

Fate's Edge

The Amaranthine Core

Three Voices of the Road

(with apologies to the sea)

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For the GM – The Spider, the Snake, the Raven

The three Omens (**Inaea**, **Isoka**, **Ikasha**) are not gods. They are forces that appear in whispers, dreams, and the spaces between counted things. Do not introduce them directly. Instead, let players encounter their echoes:

- A rope that never frays (Inaea)
- A judgment that cuts clean (Isoka)
- A dream that feels too real (Ikasha)

By the time players learn the names, they should have already felt their presence for many sessions.

The full truth of the Omens – the Clockwork Demon, the scouring of civilisations, Ikasha’s imprisonment in Obishaal – is **endgame content**. Use the fragments in this book as breadcrumbs:

- If players ask a Pereshi fire-keeper about the “serpent judge,” they will receive a riddle.
- If they ask a Tulkani about the “dreamer,” they will receive a story.
- If they ask a Sidhi about the “spider,” they will receive a knot and a warning:
“Do not pull it unless you are ready to see what it holds.”

The Hollow is the interest on the Omens’ oldest debt. The players are never meant to pay it off – only to decide whose name goes on the next line of the ledger.

Preface: Three Voices

This book is not a travel guide. It is a collection of thresholds: bridges that remember every toll, fog-bells that count your breaths, stones that warm when you speak a true name. Three travellers have walked these roads before you. They have agreed to lend their voices to the pages that follow. Listen to each; they will disagree, and that is the point.

Lady Isolde of the Scar, Fifth of Her Name

“The sun shattered at Lence. The pieces are still falling. Which shadow will catch you?”

I am Isolde, and I have worn a gorget to three tournaments, buried two brothers, and learned that chivalry is not a code – it is a weight. You carry it or it crushes you. There is no third option. My family has held the valley north of Rouen since before the Fenwoods burned Lence. In the high season we joust; in the low season we scheme. The Belworth River is our border and our wound. I speak for Vhasia, for Viterra, for the hedge-law courts and the fractured sun. When I tell you a bridge will hold, I have counted its stones. When I warn you a lord cannot be trusted, I have seen the crack in his seal.

The Bravo of Silkstrand (no other name, no other need)

“Every bridge is a promise. Every canal carries a secret. But the best secrets are the ones you share over wine.”

I am nobody – or I was, once. The canals of Silkstrand do not care about your bloodline. They care about your stroke with an oar and your aim with a dagger. I started as a dock-rat, became a duelist, and now I am something else: a witness to the city that never sleeps. The Exchange closes at midnight, but the bargains never end. I have won purses and lost friends, and I still smile. Why? Because the sun rises over the laguna every morning, and there is always another bridge to cross. I speak for Silkstrand, for the Brass Coast, for the Sidhi freedmen who taught me that freedom is a story you tell yourself until it becomes true.

The Edgewalker (Aeler, name forgotten by design)

“The mountain breathes. The stone remembers. I am the crack in both.”

I am an Aeler Edgewalker. You call us mountain-dwellers who measure breath in silver bells and seal our agreements in keystone. How quaint. We don’t just measure breath – we know the load each lung can bear. When a Tulkani chieftain swears an oath on his firstborn? That’s not honour – it’s a keystone I’ve already wedged into three different seals. The first crack was his. The second was mine. When a Veiled Sister binds a demon? That’s not terror – it’s a fault line I’ve traced in the bedrock. The first tremor was hers. The second is coming. You see the surface as “full of problems.” I see the weight in the stone, the strain in the beam. Problems are not obstacles – they are the pressure that shapes the mountain.

I speak for the Aeler, for the Mistlands, for the deep vaults where the Hollow is not a myth but a flaw in the foundation. When I tell you a tunnel is sound, I have walked its stress lines. When I tell you to flee, trust the stone's memory.

The three of us have walked these roads. We have paid our tolls – in blood, in silver, in silence. Use the cards to find your own. When you are lost, ask: *What does this place witness? And what does it ask in return?*

Then listen. The road is patient. The Hollow is patient. We are not. But we have left the lamp lit for you.

The Cartomancer's Compass

The Memory of the Deck

The world does not speak in words. It speaks in suits, ranks, and the spaces between. Every bridge, every bribe, every broken oath can be laid out on a table of felt and dealt from a worn deck. This is not superstition. It is method.

The regional generators in this book – from the fog-choked levees of the Mistlands to the walking cities of Ngomebe – all speak the same language: the language of the fifty-two-card deck. Learn to read it, and you can generate a campaign, a crossroads, or a crisis in the time it takes to shuffle.

This chapter is your key. It explains how to interpret any card drawn from any regional generator, and how to weave those interpretations into the fiction at your table. Consider it the threshold between the abstract mechanics of the draw and the living, breathing world of Fate's Edge.

The Four Suits: A Universal Grammar

Every card in every generator carries the same four suit-meanings. They are the alphabet of the world's witness.

0.0.1 ♠ *Spades : PlaceTheStage*

Where does the scene happen? ♠ *isthethreshold,thelandmark,thegroundbeneaththeaction.Itanswers : Where are we?*

- **High rank (10–A):** A major landmark – a fortress, a capital, a haunted ruin. The place has a name that echoes in local songs.
- **Mid rank (6–9):** A functional location – a ford, a market, a shrine. The place has a purpose and a keeper.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A liminal or neglected place – a crossroads, a collapsed bridge, a smuggler's cove. The place is defined by what it lacks.

In the regional chapters, ♠ *entriesarealwaysplaces.See, forexample, thebridgesandcanalsofSilkstran*

0.0.2 ♡ *Hearts : ActorTheFace*

Who drives the scene? ♡ *istheperson, thefaction, thevoicethatspeaks.Itanswers : Who is here?*

- **High rank (J–A):** An elite, a ruler, a power-broker. The actor has authority and reach beyond the immediate scene.
- **Mid rank (6–10):** A professional, a functionary, a skilled operator. The actor has a trade and a price.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A commoner, an outcast, a victim. The actor needs something or has been failed by someone.

In the regional chapters, ♡ *entriesarealwayspeopleor factions.SeethemerchantsandspiesoftheBrassC*
wardensoftheMistlands.

0.0.3 ♣ *Clubs : PressureTheComplication*

What pushes back? ♣ *isthestorm, theburden, theknifeinthedark.Itanswers : What goes wrong?*

- **High rank (10–A):** A catastrophe, a betrayal, an invasion. The complication changes the shape of the journey.
- **Mid rank (6–9):** A serious obstacle – a feud, a quarantine, a broken bridge. The complication costs time, resources, or reputation.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A minor hazard – a sudden squall, a lost token, a raised toll. The complication is a nuisance, not a disaster.

In the regional chapters, ♣ *entriesarealwayscomplicationsorthreats.Seetheriverfloodsandwitness–*
cordcutsofAyokhaorthemarketriotsofSilkstrand.

0.0.4 ♦ *Diamonds : LeverageTheReward*

What opens the door? ♦ *isthetoken, thewrit, thesecretthatchangesPosition.Itanswers : What do you gain?*

- **High rank (J–A):** A major asset – a noble title, a keystone charter, a general pardon. The reward reshapes the party’s standing.
- **Mid rank (6–10):** A significant tool – a pass-stone, a witness cord, a lighthouse charter. The reward solves a specific class of problem.
- **Low rank (2–5):** A minor advantage – a bridge token, a guest-cup, a rumour. The reward grants a single use of improved Position.

In the regional chapters, ♦ *entriesarealwaysrewardsorleverage.SeethekeystonechartersofNgomebeon*
sharetabletsofFhara.

Rank and Severity: The Weight of the Card

The rank of a card – from Ace (high) to 2 (low) – sets the scale of its suit’s meaning. Use this ladder:

Rank	Narrative Weight
Ace	Legendary, campaign-altering, mythic
King/Queen/Jack	Major, faction-level, lasting consequences
10–7	Significant, scene-defining, costly
6–4	Moderate, manageable, a real cost
3–2	Minor, a complication but not a crisis

When a generator instructs you to set a timer by the highest rank, use this conversion:

- **2–5:** 4-segment timer (short, local problem)
- **6–10:** 6-segment timer (standard, journey-length)
- **J, Q, K:** 8-segment timer (extended, regional problem)
- **A:** 10-segment timer (epic, campaign-length)

Card Faces: The Court as Character

Face cards (Jack, Queen, King) are not merely high ranks. They are *persons* with agency, personality, and often a name.

- **Jack:** An agent, a functionary, a messenger. The Jack acts on someone else’s authority. They are competent but replaceable.
- **Queen:** A power in their own right. The Queen has influence, resources, and a network. They are not easily replaced.
- **King:** The ultimate authority in their domain. The King is the source of law, the peak of the hierarchy. To challenge a King is to challenge the order itself.

When a face card appears in a ♡ (actor) draw, give the NPC a name, a motive, and a quirk. When it appears as a King of Clubs, it might be a feud that has lasted generations; a Queen of Spades might be a bridge that remembers

Aces and the Ninth: The Hollow’s Attention

An Ace is not merely the highest rank. It is a *threshold*. When an Ace appears in any draw, the Hollow takes notice. The GM gains 1 extra Story Beat (beyond any generated by 1s) to spend on a supernatural complication: a ghostly procession, a bell that rings without a clapper, a shadow that walks independently.

In regions where the Ninth Taboo is strong (Theona, Aelinnel, Ways Between), an Ace may also trigger a specific regional omen. For example:

- In Theona, an Ace of ♠ *might add a missing step to a bridge.*
- In the Ways Between, an Ace of ♥ *might cause a reflection to speak.*
- In the Mistlands, an Ace of ♣ *might cause a bell – line to fail.*

The GM should always read an Ace as a signal to escalate the uncanny.

By the Numbers: Procedure for Any Generator

When you sit down to generate a scene, a journey leg, or a settlement, follow this procedure:

1. **Name the destination.** Which region? Which route? Which authority controls the gate?
2. **Shuffle and draw.** Draw cards face-up, one for each suit you need. Most generators require all four suits; some (like travel legs) may use only three.
3. **Read the ♠.** *This is your place. Describe it first. Set the stage.*
3. **Read the ♥.** *This is your actor. Introduce them. What do they want? Why are they here?*
3. **Read the ♣.** *This is your pressure. Complicate the scene. What just went wrong, or what is about to?*
3. **Read the ♦.** *This is your leverage. What can the players gain if they succeed? Be specific.*
3. **Set the timer.** Use the highest rank among the four cards to determine the size of the scene's primary timer (see above).
4. **Interpret faces and Aces.** Give names to face cards. Apply regional Ace effects.
5. **Play to find out.** Use the generated elements as prompts, not scripts. The cards are seeds, not fences.

Regional Flavours: How Suits Shift Meaning

While the core suit meanings remain constant, each region inflects them with its own texture.

A ♠ *in Ektoria* is a forum or a coin – house; a ♠ *in the Vale* is a phasing ruin or a star – road. A ♥ *in the Black* singer.

Use the regional chapters as your lexicon. When you draw a card, consult the relevant table. The tables are designed to evoke the specific flavour of the region.

Example: A Draw in Acasia

You are running a journey through the Broken Marches. You draw:

♠ 7, ♡ J, ♣ 4, ♦ Q

1. ♠ 7 : *Hill – Motte* ~ *Freshpalisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.*
1. ♡ J : *Bride with No Dowry but a Claim* ~ *Daggers in the wedding chest.*
1. ♣ 4 : *Wedding Turns Ambush* ~ *You are caught between two bloodlines.*
1. ♦ Q : *Marriage Proxy* ~ *From the Margravine; bind a hill – king to your cause.*
1. **Highest rank: Queen** (equivalent to 8). The scene's primary timer is 8 segments: *The Feud Escalates [8]*.
2. **Interpretation:** The party arrives at a hill-fort on the eve of a wedding. The bride is caught between two feuding bloodlines. The wedding turns to violence. If the party can survive the ambush and broker peace, the Margravine will grant them a Marriage Proxy – a powerful tool to bind a hill-king to their cause. The 8-segment timer tracks how quickly the feud spirals into open war.

This is the generator at work: four cards, one scene, immediate fiction.

The Unwritten Suit: When a Draw is Incomplete

Sometimes, a generator does not require all four suits. A travel leg may only need ♠, ♡, ♣. *A social encounter*

- **No ♠** : *The place is ambiguous, shifting, or hidden. The scene occurs in a liminal space ~ across roads, a fork in the road, a threshold.*
- **No ♡** : *The actor is absent, silent, or dead. The pressure and place act without a face. This can be more frightful.*
- **No ♣** : *The scene is calm, peaceful, or mercifully straight forward. This is rare in Fate's Edge. Treasures are hidden.*
- **No ♦** : *The reward is not a token but an outcome. The players gain Position, information, or a cleared time.*

Interpreting Any Draw, Any Region

When you need a prompt in a hurry – a random encounter, a rumour at a tavern, a discovery in a ruin – draw a single card. Use this quick-reference:

♠	A place or landmark. What is its name? What happened here?
♥	A person or faction. What do they want? What do they fear?
♣	A complication or threat. Who or what is the obstacle?
♦	A reward, token, or secret. What can be gained?

The rank tells you the scale. A low rank is local and personal; a high rank is regional and political. A face card demands a name; an Ace demands the Hollow's attention.

Final Guidance: The Cards Are Oracles, Not Scripts

The generators in this book are tools, not tyrants. If a draw gives you an entry that contradicts established fiction, or if you simply prefer a different interpretation, overrule it. The deck is a prompt, not a prison.

But trust it, too. The most memorable sessions often come from the card you did not expect. The Ace that arrives at the wrong moment. The Jack who speaks a name no one wanted to hear. The diamond that glows with a secret.

Shuffle. Draw. Interpret. And let the road unfold.

“The road is never closed. It is only passed to the next walker.” — Dusana of the Raven Road

Part I

The Amaranthine Sea & Northern
Shores

“The sea keeps a better memory than any scribe. The reef remembers every secret whispered above its depths. Do not ask which flag flies highest – ask which hull leaks slowest.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

Kahfagia

The Flag of Storms.

“Kahfagia runs on lantern-light and rust, where the lies are as polite as the lanterns that never go out. Every beacon is a promise – and every reef remembers the ships that broke theirs. Come for the salt fish, stay for the gossip, but never trust a calm tide: the commodores know the lanterns fear the dark, and I’ve seen a Mirror-Keeper weep when her reflection showed her a daughter she’d sold for a pilot’s license.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish porridge – dried cod soaked overnight, boiled with hardtack and a splash of lamp oil. Every Kahfagian child learns to taste the salt and know which coast their grandmother came from.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count ships by their lanterns. Three lanterns means a Kahfagian merchant – safe. Four means an Oshiiran grain barge – neutral. One, low in the water, means a privateer. Run.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their hands. Dock-workers have rope-burned palms. Merchants have ink-stained fingers. Privateers have no fingernails – they bite them off in storms.

What is the most common crime? False manifests. Every third ship carries cargo that doesn’t appear on its papers. The Admiralty knows. The Admiralty takes a cut. The Admiralty calls it a “tariff surcharge.”

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Mirror-Keepers are not born – they are made. And the making requires a death. A sister, a daughter, a lover. Someone who drowned so the keeper could see through the fog.

Where do people go when they die? The tide takes them. Kahfagia has no cemeteries above ground. The drowned are weighted with chain and dropped in the deep channel. Their families light candles in paper boats and float them out at dusk.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer your bell. Every Kahfagian carries a small brass bell – the sound of their name. Offering it means “I give you my voice.” Refusing to return it is a declaration of blood feud.

What is the most important festival? The Beacon Lighting (midwinter). Every lighthouse keeper lights a new lamp from the Admiral’s flame. If your beacon catches first, your year will be lucky. If it sputters, you will owe a death to the sea.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Admiral’s lantern code has a ninth signal – never used, never spoken, burned into every keeper’s memory. It means “Kill the witnesses. Sink the evidence. The sea will hide the rest.”

0.1 Kahfagia — “The Creole Thalassocracy”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — but the spiders weave in the mirror-towers.*

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — and woe to the fool who rows against them. Yet I have seen the reflection move before the hand that holds it. The tides are not the only ones with secrets.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your lamps trimmed and your signals clear. And if a gray-robed stranger offers to adjust your mirror for free — say no. The Lethai-ar have long memories, and longer webs.”

Genre / Mood: Creole thalassocracy, signal-and-lane politics, eldritch tide, secret infiltration.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A sea-notary unlocks a salt-stained reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise — or the harbor names you accomplices. And watch for silk threads on the bollards. The Spider’s children are everywhere.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Kahfagia is the Creole child of the Vilikari and the deep-sea traders — a thalassocracy where reckonings meet tide-law. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law rules not by armies but by light, yet the real power flows through a tangled web of oligarchic families, each with their own spies, their own private navies, and their own seat on the Shadow Council. Above them all floats a central Admiralty fleet, charged with protecting the beacon monopoly — and with watching the watchers.

But the oligarchs are not the only players. Unseen, the Lethai-ar of Inaea have been infiltrating the mirror-towers for decades. A factor's trusted secretary, a harbor master's silent wife, a pilot's apprentice with too-still eyes — they weave their webs not for coin, but for *control*. They do not seek to destroy Kahfagia. They seek to *own* it, strand by strand, until the entire thalassocracy hums to the rhythm of the Spider's mercy.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone — admiral to dockhand — glances at the tide timer before speaking. And the faint, almost invisible silk threads tied around the bollards of the wealthiest piers.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a Mirror-Keeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling. And if the Mirror-Keeper smiles too widely, check the back of their neck for a spider's brand.

Regional Mood: The Lantern's Vigil & The Spider's Web

Power is visible here — literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to cede ground. To move a beacon is to declare war. Commodores sit in their mirror-towers, watching reflections, while tide-timers tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet burial of a reputation.

But beneath the visible power, another war is fought in whispers. The Lethai-ar agents of Inaea have spent a generation infiltrating the oligarchic families. A young heir who suddenly displays uncanny negotiating skill may not be talented — they may be *woven*. A Mirror-Keeper whose beacons never fail may be receiving guidance from a source that does not appear on any chart. The Spider's web is patient. It does not break the thalassocracy; it *guides* it.

Prominent NPCs of Kahfagia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Zafira	Commander of Lantern-Law	Keep the beacon monopoly intact	She has never lost a ship to the reefs. Her charts are said to be drawn in water.
Mirza al-Qasr	Mirror-Keeper of the Pointe	Control the tides through light	Her face is never seen—only reflected. Some say she has no shadow.
Ximena	Dockside Factor (commoner exemplar)	Profit from every cargo, legal or not	She keeps a hidden record in lemon juice; heat reveals the truth.
Captain Rodrigo	Privateer with a crooked letter of marque	Raid the corsair fleet and keep his crew loyal	His ship flies three flags; the one he lowers last is the one that matters.
Sister Anabel	Healer of the Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (Temple of Light)	Tend the sick without asking for coin	Her gray robes are said to be woven from old promises. They never stain.
Notary Farid	Admiralty magistrate	Resolve disputes before they reach the harbor master	He carries a water-timer in his sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.
The Veiled Harpist	Lethai-ar infiltrator (secret)	Weaving through the oligarchs, strand by strand	No one knows her face. She plays only in mirror-lit rooms, and her mu-

The Oligarchic Houses (Shadow Council)

The true rulers of Kahfagia are not the Admiralty alone, but the **Shadow Council** of seven oligarchic families. Each controls a monopoly (spice, salt, silk, timber, pitch, shipbuilding, or intelligence). Each maintains its own private navy and network of spies. Each vies for the empty seat left by the family that the Lethai-ar have already *woven* into silence.

- **House al-Kassam (Spice):** Oldest, proudest, most vulnerable. The Lethai-ar have already replaced the family steward.
- **House Carrasco (Salt):** Ruthless pragmatists; they suspect infiltration but cannot prove it.
- **House Mirat (Silk):** Secret allies of the Lethai-ar — they trade webs for influence.
- **House del Puerto (Shipbuilding):** Neutral; they build for anyone who pays.
- **House Henares (Timber):** Deeply weighed down by Admiralty claims; the Lethai-ar are slowly gathering leverage.
- **House de la Vela (Intelligence):** The Admiralty's own spy network — and already compromised.
- **The Empty Chair:** Once held by House Morat, now vacant. The other houses whisper that the Morats were not destroyed — they were *rewoven*.

Secret Faction: The Silk Vigil (Lethai-ar Infiltrators)

Agents of Inaea, the Spider's children have spent a generation worming into Kahfagia's elite. They do not steal or sabotage — they *guide*. A decision that benefits House Carrasco is subtly nudged toward the Lethai-ar's long-term goal: a unified thalassocracy that answers not to the Admiralty, but to the Web.

Signs of Infiltration:

- A factor's handwriting becomes unnaturally precise, the loops forming faint eight-shapes.
- A Mirror-Keeper's reflections show the same face in every tower — a woman with chestnut-brown skin and eyes like polished jet.
- A ship that should have foundered instead limps to port, its crew speaking of a gray-robed passenger who vanished before docking.

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a PC may roll Wits + Lore (DV 4) to notice a silken thread in an official's collar or a spider's brand on a dockhand's wrist. On success, they identify a Lethai-ar agent. On failure, the agent becomes aware of their scrutiny — and the Web tightens.

Names of Kahfagia

Inspired by the sea-faring republics of the western coast, blended with Vilikari influences: liquid consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that denote a port, a ship, or a founding ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Safir	Zafira	al-Kassam	<i>the Lantern</i>
Idris	Ximena	del Puerto	<i>Tide-Keeper</i>
Farid	Layla	de la Vela	<i>the Unlit</i>
Jabir	Aisha	Carrasco	<i>Mirror-Eye</i>
Rodrigo	Salma	Mirat	<i>Bell-Born</i>
Tarik	Nura	Henares	<i>Ash-Sails</i>



Places (Littoral/Lane/Law)

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plank-way at low water; smugglers' shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.* [STEALTH]
3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Inspectors check the salt-scars — white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.* [TRADE]
4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won't follow. *A hanged man's boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.* [STEALTH]
5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.* [TRAVEL]
6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow's safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow — the color of "maybe."* [TRAVEL]
7. **River Sluice** — Tide-gate and boom-chain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver's ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.* [AUTHORITY]
8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrow-keel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs — the kind that skip the ninth beat.* [LABOR]
9. **Lantern Alley** — Fog-lane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you're expected. Three? You're prey.* [WEATHER]
10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it's a serpent eating its tail.* [AUTHORITY]
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.* [SOCIAL]

- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water — today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.* [JUSTICE]
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer's gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a voided manifest.* [TRADE]
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of storm-lights and wreckers' tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who bear heavy burdens.* [DEATH]



People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tide-table by heart. *"The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope."* [TRAVEL]
 3. **Pilot's Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow's navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.* [TRAVEL]
 4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a manifest that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for "recent adjustments."* [AUTHORITY]
 5. **Vilikari Factor** — Two sets of books; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left column records bribes as "conciliation fees." The right one is never shown.* [TRADE]
 6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbor master listens anyway.* [SOCIAL]
 7. **Lantern Advocate** — "Jurisdiction moves like tide"; law in flux. *She carries a water-timer in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.* [JUSTICE]
 8. **Privateer Captain** — "Crooked" letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.* [COMBAT]
 9. **Thalassoi Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife's name.* [COMBAT]
 10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.* [JUSTICE]
- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are ex-criminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.* [LABOR]
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore's confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen — only reflected. Some say they have none.* [AUTHORITY]

K Kahfagian Commodore — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.* [AUTHORITY]

A Admiral of Red Shoal — Offers wine, figs — once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you've already agreed.* [LEGEND]



Complications/Threats

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. [WEATHER] *Someone bribed the tide-clerk — or the moon is angry.*
 3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. [WEATHER] *You hear oars. Then you don't. Then they're behind you.*
 4. **Boom Slam** — Harbor chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. [AUTHORITY] *The chain's links are inscribed with names of those who defied the Admiralty. Each one rattles differently.*
 5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change mid-approach; your lane just moved. [TRAVEL] *Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who — or drift into the reefs.*
 6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; wages unpaid, risk assumed. [LABOR] *The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.*
 7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. [AUTHORITY] *The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.*
 8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. [COMBAT] *Their leader wears a Mirror-Keeper's badge — stolen or earned, you cannot tell.*
 9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lantern-law shifts; your writ no longer bites. [JUSTICE] *The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safe-conduct is now kindling.*
 10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. [DISASTER] *A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.*
- J Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tide-tables sold to rival; route compromised. [SOCIAL] *The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.*
- Q Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. [DEATH] *The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else — something that smells sweet.*
- K Fleet Redeploy** — “Safe” corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. [AUTHORITY] *Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.*

- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. [WEATHER] [DEATH]
This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.
- + **Web Unravelled** — A Lethai-ar agent is exposed. The oligarchs turn on each other, accusing every rival of being a spider. [POLITICS] [FEAR] *Silk threads appear on every doorknob. No one trusts their shadow.*



Rewards/Leverage

2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbor favors you. [TRAVEL] *The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.*
 3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. [TRAVEL] *The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.*
 4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; no questions asked. [TRADE] *The clerk stamps it twice — once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
 5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beaconed lane; law walks with you. [TRAVEL] *The commodore's seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.*
 6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. [TRADE] *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
 7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. [TRADE] *The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock — and breaks after use.*
 8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight's signals revealed; navigation advantage. [TRAVEL] *Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.*
 9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. [AUTHORITY] *The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favor.*
 10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. [COMBAT] *The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.*
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. [JUSTICE] *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tie it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. [AUTHORITY] *The Mirror-Keeper's seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law — until challenged.*
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. [TRADE] *The share is a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.*

A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. [AUTHORITY] *The harbor master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely — or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs — beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water. If a King or Ace of Spades appears, also echo **web motifs** — silk threads on a bollard, a reflection that holds too long, the faint smell of spiced tea (the Lethai-ar are near).

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Pilot's Mirror:** Kahfagia's strength is not its fleet but its monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map. Any character with a Mirror Warrant may permanently move a beacon or buoy (GM sets a 4-segment timer). For the duration of that timer, all navigation rolls on that lane are at +1 Position for the party and –1 Position for rivals.
- **Lantern-Law Privilege:** While flying an Admiralty flag or carrying a valid Lantern License, your ship may pass through chain-booms and customs points at +1 Position. The first time in a session you invoke this privilege, the GM gains 1 SB (the Admiralty is watching).
- **Oligarchic Standing (Leverage Track):** Instead of tracking coin weights, track *Standing* with the great families (al-Kassam, Carrasco, Mirat, etc.). Standing 1–3 gives you access to private docks, early auction warnings, and off-the-books pilots. Standing 4+ lets you call in a family to block a rival's safe-conduct or raise a false alarm on their ship.
- **The Web's Patience (Secret Timer [6]):** Tracks the Lethai-ar infiltration of the Shadow Council. The timer ticks when the party helps a Lethai-ar agent, exposes a rival house's secrets, or ignores a silken thread. At 3, the Harpist's name appears on a dockmaster's manifest. At 6, the Empty Chair is filled — and the new house head bows to a gray-robed stranger. The party may reduce the timer by exposing an agent or by warning an oligarch (requires spending 2 Standing).
- **Western Reach Rumours:** Once per port visit, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to hear a rumour from a captain returned from beyond the mirror. On success, the GM reveals one of the six rumours (see below) as a foreshadowing hook or a clue for an ongoing arc.

- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *A light that never goes out; a promise that never sinks.*
- **The Mirror-King** — The Witness. *Reflections that remember every lie, every promise, every cargo.*
- **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the weight that the sea holds at ebb.*
- **The Spider's Daughter** — Inaea (secret). *The web that binds the oligarchs, strand by patient strand.*
- **The Unlit** — Ikasha. *The ninth lamp that is never lit; the safe harbor that exists only in rumour.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Alvaro of the Lantern (The Traveler):** The Admiralty's mirror-towers double as wayshrines for the Saint of Lost Channels. Sailors who light a candle before a voyage and whisper a destination to the mirror claim the tide will not turn against them before they reach it. The Mirror-Keepers charge a fee for this service — payable in salt, not silver.
- **The Silken Coup (Inaea):** The Lethai-ar call their infiltration the *Genteel Harvest*. They do not conquer; they adopt. An oligarch who accepts a gray-robed advisor finds that their children are betrothed to shadow-kin, their records are copied in disappearing ink, and their mirror-tower shows only the face they wish to see — not the one that watches them sleep.
- **The Tide-Sworn Compact (The Admiral of Sealed Tides):** A small but influential order of notaries based in Kassamira Port. They adjudicate disputes over beacon rights, cargo claims, and pilotage fees. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes — only sworn promises. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three voyages are plagued by contrary winds.
- **The Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (The Bitter Root):** A hospice on Deadman's Quay is run by gray-robed healers of the Order. They ask no payment, but they never forget a face. It is said that if you accept their care, the sea remembers your name — and the sea never forgets. Smugglers leave small offerings of fresh water on the pier to stay in the Order's good graces.
- **The Ninth:** In any lantern-lit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who light the ninth are said to see a figure standing on the water outside the window — waiting.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counter-timerwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take -1 die on your next pilot check (your choice). [SUPERSTITION]
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark a *Burden* from the Tide Court. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Cut the Thread:** If you find a silk thread on your bollard, cut it with a silver knife. Negate the next *Web's Patience* tick. [SUPERSTITION]

Thematic SB Spend Table

- **1 SB:** A lantern flickers; a signal is misread. Minor navigation error.
- **2 SB:** A rival ship appears on the horizon; a customs inspector boards.
- **3 SB:** The tide turns early; a beacon goes dark; a silk thread is found on your rigging.
- **4+ SB:** The Web tightens (Timer ticks); The Admiralty revokes a license; A storm breaks without warning.

Western Reach Rumours (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbor where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding — until moonrise.
3. A mirror-reef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.
5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs promises in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal / Web & Silk)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira (signal tyrant)** — *Phases*: Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. *Cracks*: rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe (relic raider)** — *Phases*: Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. *Cracks*: sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned-saint tithe.
- **The Veiled Harpist (Spider’s Daughter)** — *Phases*: Whisper → Weave → Harvest. *Cracks*: speak a true name of a Lethai-ar agent, cut a strand of the Web with silver, or remind an oligarch of a promise older than the Spider’s memory.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves — and through the silken threads that bind the oligarchs to the Spider’s will. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation and the quiet manipulation of loyalty. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirror-light is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. But behind every mirror, a gray-robed woman watches. And she is very, very patient.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access — to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safe-conducts, or salvage rights. But the secret war of the Lethai-ar adds a new layer: players may be hired to expose an agent, to protect an oligarch from being “woven,” or even to ally with the Spider’s children for a share of the Harvest. Use the **Web’s Patience** timer to track the infiltration; let players decide whether to slow it, accelerate it, or ride it to power.

Amaria — The Iron Shore

A small peninsula squeezed between Kahfagia’s Akilan holdings and the Vilikari border, Amaria is a land of iron mines, coastal fog, and hybrid law. Ecktoria once claimed it; now it pays tribute to both Kahfagia and the Vilikari to stay independent. Its people speak a creole of Kahfagian maritime slang and Vilikari bureaucratic precision, and its courts rule by a blend of Admiralty tariff law and Vermilion Corps writ-law.

What you notice first: The smell of rust and brine. The way every official carries two seals — one for Kahfagia, one for the Vilikari. The constant ticking of water-timers that never agree on the hour.

The rule that kills newcomers: Never carry only one flag. Amarian vessels fly both the lantern and the grain sheaf. A single flag is a declaration of allegiance — and an invitation to be sunk by the other side.

Quick Generators for Amaria (d6 each)



Places (d6)

1. **Iron Quay** – A pier built from salvaged warship timbers. The nails are iron from the inland mines; they rust red, staining the water like blood. [INDUSTRY]
2. **Coin-House of Twin Books** – A counting-house where every transaction is recorded twice — once for the Kahfagian tariff, once for the Vilikari grain tithe. The third book is the smuggler's. [TRADE]
3. **Fog Lighthouse (Disputed)** – A stone tower with two lamps: one green for Kahfagia, one white for the Vilikari. Only one is lit at a time. The keeper changes them with the tide. [AUTHORITY]
4. **Smuggler's Rope-Walk** – A hidden cove where boats land at low tide. The rope-walk is a series of knotted lines that lead to a cave full of untaxed cargo. [STEALTH]
5. **Mine Shaft of the Ninth Vein** – An iron mine that goes deeper than the surveyors mapped. The miners whisper of a sealed door at the bottom — Aeler work, they say. [MYSTERY]
6. **Dual Customs Post** – A wooden shack with two windows: one for Kahfagian stamps, one for Vilikari seals. The line snakes between them. Smugglers pay both clerks and skip the line. [AUTHORITY]



People (d6)

1. **Twin-Book Clerk** – Sits at a split desk, writing with two hands. Her left hand files Kahfagian tariffs; her right, Vilikari grain receipts. Her third hand — the one no one sees — writes the real numbers. [TRADE]
2. **Iron Miner (Free)** – A former indentured laborer who bought his freedom with a year's ore. His hands are stained red with rust. He knows the sealed door's location but will not speak of it. [LABOR]
3. **Smuggler Captain** – Flies no flag. His ship's name changes with each port. He speaks four languages badly and navigates by the taste of salt on the wind. [STEALTH]
4. **Kahfagian Customs Agent** – A one-eyed woman with a brass hook for a hand. She stamps cargo with a bell-shaped seal. The seal rings when the declared value is a lie. [AUTHORITY]
5. **Vilikari Grain Auditor** – Thin, spectacled, carries a grain balance. He measures every sack against the Widow's standard. He has found nine thieves this year. The tenth was his own clerk. [JUSTICE]
6. **Fog Keeper (Lighthouse)** – An old sailor who lost his sight to a Kahfagian mirror flash. He tends the lamps by touch. He knows which flag flies by the heat of the glass — green is cool, white is warm. [WEATHER]



Complications (d6)

1. **Tariff Double-Cross** – Both Kahfagia and the Vilikari claim the same customs fee. Pay one, and the other impounds your cargo. Pay both, and you are ruined. Smuggle, and you are a patriot. [WEIGHT]
2. **Mine Collapse (Sealed Door)** – A cave-in opens a passage to the sealed Aeler door. The miners are afraid. Something is breathing on the other side. The party is asked to investigate — or to seal it again. [DISASTER]
3. **Lighthouse Outage** – Both lamps go dark. Ships founder on the reef. The keeper is found dead, one hand on each lamp. The cause of death: old age — or old promises broken. [DEATH]
4. **Census Dispute** – The Vilikari claims Amaria's population for grain tithes; Kahfagia claims it for port taxes. The same people are counted twice — or not at all. The party is asked to review the records. The records are on fire. [POLITICS]
5. **Iron Embargo** – A rival faction sinks an ore barge. Both powers blame each other. The price of iron spikes. The party's cargo is now worth a fortune — and a target. [COMBAT]
6. **The Ninth Vein Opens** – The sealed door cracks. A cold wind blows from the deep. The miners flee. A voice whispers a name — the name of the party member who casts the longest shadow. [MYSTERY]



Rewards (d6)

1. **Dual Customs Stamp** – One stamp, two seals. Passes both Kahfagian and Vilikari checkpoints without inspection. Use once per journey. [TRAVEL]
2. **Iron Ingot (Ninth Vein)** – A bar of ore from the sealed door's chamber. It is warm to the touch. Aeler runes glow on its surface. Trade it to the True Masons for a favor. [TRADE]
3. **Fog Keeper's Log** – A journal of tide and lamp schedules. Decode it to predict when the disputed lighthouse will be unguarded. Gain +1 Position on smuggling attempts. [WEATHER]
4. **Twin-Entry Receipt** – A document that proves you paid both tariffs. It is written in disappearing ink. The ink vanishes after one use — but the paper remembers. [JUSTICE]
5. **Miner's Compass** – A brass needle that points to the sealed door. It also points to the nearest iron vein — and to the nearest heart that beats with greed. [TRAVEL]

6. **Smuggler's Flag (Neutral)** – A plain gray banner. Fly it to pass between Kahfagian and Vilikari patrols unmolested. The patrols will not salute. They will not shoot. They will pretend they did not see you. [STEALTH]

Ecktoria

Marble & Fire.

“Ecktoria is a marble coffin for a king who never was. The Everflame burns not for light but for weight – it measures the lie in every breath. The statues are not watchers – they are the pressure points in the stone. The undertakers know the body is cold, but the pressure remains. The mountain does not forget what the marble tries to hide.”

— Aeler Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? *Spiced flatbread dipped in olive oil and honey – but only if you can afford the honey. The poor eat millet porridge with a single dried fig. The fig is counted as part of the household’s grain allowance.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To count coins by touch. Every Ecktorian child has a box of worn sesterces; by age five, they can tell a debased copper from pure silver by the weight alone.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their signature. Ecktorians judge by handwriting before face. A clerk with a steady hand is trustworthy. A noble with a flourish is hiding something. A merchant who signs with an X is not worth doing business with.*

What is the most common crime? *Tax evasion – but it is not a crime, it is a sport. Every household keeps two ledgers: the white one for the Censor, the red one for the family. The art is in keeping the red ledger from looking like a confession.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Censor’s clerks are paid to find discrepancies. They are also paid to lose them. The price of a lost discrepancy is exactly 5% of the tax owed. This is not corruption. It is “administrative flexibility.”*

Where do people go when they die? *The family crypt, beneath the basilica floor. The wealthy are burned, their ashes mixed with marble dust and pressed into the floor tiles. The poor are buried in unmarked graves outside the walls. The Everflame’s light does not reach that far.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You petition the Censor to have the wrong stricken from the public record. The petition costs a tenth of your annual income. If accepted, the wrong is erased – legally, it never happened. If rejected, the wrong is published, and you lose your civic standing.*

What is the most important festival? *The Triumph of the Flame (autumn equinox). The basilica’s central flame is carried in procession through every district. To touch the flame is to be absolved of petty debts. To be burned by it is a sign that your debts are not petty.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Grand Magistrate's seal is a forgery. The original cracked in 783 AR. The current seal was carved by a prison engraver who was executed to keep the secret. The engraver's apprentice is still alive. They live in Silkstrand. They have the original sketches.

0.2 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The flame remembers. The marble cracks. The law forgets — but the statues watch.*

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law is written in marble and witnessed by the flame. Every judgment echoes in the stones — but the stones have grown quiet. The patricians do not listen. They have forgotten what the flame tastes like. They seal their windows with silk and call it governance.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times. The marble remembers the heat. The flame remembers the lies. The rich have stopped looking at the flames. They only look at each other — and at the cracks in their own mirrors. The fire isn’t burning anymore, friend. It’s *smiling*.”

Genre / Mood: Imperial decay, bureaucratic horror, memory as weight, Renaissance decadence — a city walled off from its own rot, where the wealthy dance while the poor cough ash.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles gutter beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-stained fingers offers a folded note. “The Lame King moves tonight. The Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace hasn’t answered a summons in a month. Find out who lit the fire — or the Vigil will audit your soul at dawn. And stay away from the Arena. The statues have been *whispering*.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses — but each day, more of its weight slips into the hands of mercenaries and whispers. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with a grief that refuses to name itself.

Yet the true sickness is not in the streets. It is in the **Amber Palace**, where the old patrician families have walled themselves away. They sit on laurels preserved from the empire, drinking wine that costs a village's harvest, whispering deals with merchants who have never seen a loom. **Maelstraeus**, the demon of commerce, has threaded their accounts with invisible tolls; every contract they sign forgets a clause. **Livaea**, the demon of desire, has wrapped their hearts in silk; they marry for influence, divorce for scandal, and love only the reflection of themselves in gilded mirrors — reflections that no longer blink. The common folk call them the *Unburdened* — not because they carry no weight, but because they have forgotten what weight *feels* like.

The **Vigil** — once the empire's secret police, now a fractured ghost of an institution — fights a silent war over the dream of restoration. One faction, the **Censer-Knights**, serves the Everflame and the Synod, hunting heresy and latent magic with brass censers and bells that ring at dawn. Another, the **Unburnt**, answers only to the old patrician houses, ensuring that no whisper of rebellion reaches the Amber Palace. A third, the **Red Vigil**, has sold itself to Maelstraeus, auditing not coin but *memory* — they collect the names of those who have forgotten what they owe. They do not fight each other openly. They meet in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. The statues are not decorative. They are the city's *witnesses*.

Beyond the capital's walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges. And in the sewers, the Vigil's informers listen for the name of the next person to vanish — not into death, but into the margins of a record no one will ever read.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread — and beneath it, the faint sweetness of rot. The way crowds part for a procession — and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners. The way the wealthy never step on the cracks. The cracks are where the petitions of the poor are wedged. The cracks are where the Hollow reads.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The tallies are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined trust. You will not borrow again. But more than that: never accept a gift from a patrician without naming its price aloud. Maelstraeus and Livaea both listen, and a gift accepted in silence is a contract written in water — it will drown you eventually.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers — And The Dancers Who Forgot

Here, the past does not fade — it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. But precedent is not justice. Precedent is *memory*, and memory is a weight that the city carries like a cracked keel. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians (where the Unburdened hold masques that last for weeks, their faces painted with ash from the Everflame), the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps (where Black Banner captains drink with Vigil informers), and the basilicas where the Everflame's priests balance piety against profit (and sometimes sell indulgences for the sin of being born poor). The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain rolls, and the whispered judgments of the Censor's Hall — and in the *dreams* of patricians who no longer remember the scent of rain.

The **Vigil** does not patrol the streets. It *permeates* them. Every tavern has an informer; every bathhouse has a spy; every marriage is witnessed by someone who reports to a faction of the Vigil. The **Censer-Knights** hunt unlicensed magic; the **Unburnt** hunt sedition; the **Red Vigil** hunts *what was forgotten*. They are not allies. They are not enemies. They are three creditors fighting over the same soul — and the soul is the city's.

The **patricians** — the Old Blood — no longer govern. They *perform* governance. A session of the Parlement might see two senators debate the price of grain while their slaves hold silver trays of honeyed figs. A decree might be passed that doubles the salt tax, then rescinded an hour later because a duchess sneezed. They are not cruel. They are *distracted*. Livaea has taught them to crave the next pleasure before they have finished the current one. Maelstraeus has taught them that every transaction is a game, and every game is winnable if you have enough coin — but they have forgotten that the house always wins. The house is the Hollow.

The **Everflame** still burns in the basilicas, but its light has grown dim. The High Priest speaks of unity, but his sermons are interrupted by coughing from the pews — not from illness, but from the ash that falls like snow. The common folk whisper that the flame no longer judges truth; it only *records* it, filing confessions in a vault that no one ever opens. The Vigil has a key. The patricians have a copy. The poor have nothing but their names, which the Censor's Hall writes in ink that fades when you look away.

The Everflame — Faith of Ash and Incense

The state religion of Ecktoria is a syncretic faith that venerates the Eternal Flame as the divine principle, but its power flows through three great Orders, each devoted to a different Patron. The Basilica of the Unquenched Flame is the heart of the city: a cavernous space of gold mosaics, weeping saints, and the perpetual smell of beeswax and myrrh. Mass is held at dawn and dusk, the congregation coughing through the ash that falls from the censers. The priests sell indulgences in the side chapels — a silver coin for the remission of a small sin, a gold coin for a large one, a horse for a murder. The choir sings in Utaran, a language most parishioners no longer understand, but the melody is beautiful enough to make them weep — and to make the statues turn their heads.

- **Order of the Oath of Flame & Light (Orthodox)** — The public face of the church. They lead processions, bless marriages, and anoint the dying. Their rites are those of vows, radiance, and protection. They are the ones who light the great candles at dawn. Many are sincere; most are tired. The tired ones are the ones the Vigil watches.
- **Order of the Inquisitor Prime (Prosecutorial)** — The **Censer-Knights**. They hunt untutored magic, root out demonic cults, and enforce the purity of the flame. Their rites are those of judgment, purification, and burning censure. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs, and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They are feared, but also respected — for they are the only ones who still take the flame *seriously*. And the flame takes them seriously in return.
- **Order of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Hospitalier)** — The healers and confessors. They run hospices, tend to the sick, and hear the confessions of the dying. Their rites are those of healing, forgiveness, and the spiral of care. They are often at odds with the Inquisitor Prime — mercy can look like leniency. The common folk love them; the patricians ignore them. The Vigil watches both.

The Everflame is both beautiful and ugly. Its gold leaf covers the same marble where petitioners once scratched their names. Its hymns are sung by choirboys whose families sold them for a loaf of bread. Its relics — a nail from the True Cross, a tear of Saint Lucia — draw pilgrims from across the empire, but the priests charge admission, and the poor sleep on the steps. The flame itself is a wonder: a pillar of blue-white fire that never gutters, tended by the High Priest alone. It is said to show the truth to any who stare into it long enough — and to show the same truth to the Vigil, who watch from the shadows. The truth is always the same: *you have forgotten something*.

At a Glance

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- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, the slow rot of imperial forms, and the cloying sweetness of a city drowning in its own nostalgia.
- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame's judgment — but beneath it all, the battle between Maelstræus (greed) and Livaea (desire) over the souls of the powerful.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, the Red List — and the Vigil's three factions, who may arrest you for unpaid weights, sedition, or simply being *remembered*.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, a Golden Edict carved in precedent — and, if you are brave, a secret from the Vigil's own files. The secret is always about a statue.

Prominent NPCs of Ecktoria

|p0.2|p0.25|p0.3|p0.15|

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
Valerius	Grand Magistrate	Preserve the forms of law while the empire crumbles	His gavel is a sundial; it only strikes at noon. He has not struck it in a year.
Flavia	High Priest of the Everflame	Balance the factions and keep the flame lit	She has never raised her voice; the flame speaks for her. Lately, it speaks in the voices of the dead.
Cassia	Duchess-Regent of the Dolmis Gate	Protect her family's trading rights	She rules from behind a silk screen; a dagger-hole is cut at eye level. The screen was a gift from Livaea. The silk is warm.
Jackson	Coin-House Factor	Survive the next trust panic	He seals deals with three ribbons: white (ask), red (now), black (never). His black ribbon is fraying. He does not know who is fraying it.
Lucius	Lanista (arena master)	Own the next champion and the secrets of the hypogeum	His fighters' brands are his signature; he never repeats a mark. One brand is a spiral — the mark of the Red Vigil. The fighter does not know.
The Red Clerk	Censor's Hall scribe	Control which names are remembered	His inkwell is a skull; the skull belonged to a name he erased. He has forgotten his own name. The skull remembers.
Censer-Knight	Commander Vorenius	Prefect of the Order of the Inquisitor Prime	Hunt untutored magic before it wakes the Ninth. His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads — one for each faction he has betrayed. He does not notice the third.
Lady Aelia	Patrician heiress, Livaea's favorite	Outshine every rival before the next masque	She has not left the Amber Palace in seven years. She does not know the price of bread. She dreams of bread.

Names of Ecktoria

Inspired by late Latin and early Romance: strong vowels (ae, i, o), soft endings, and the weight of imperial bureaucracy. Surnames often denote a place of origin, a trade, or a notable ancestor.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valerius	Flavia	de Urbe	<i>the Iron</i>	
Jackson	Cassia	Aquilinus	<i>the Coin-Wise</i>	

Lucius Aelia Honoratus *Flame-Touched*

Tiberius Cornelia Lateranus *the Unburned*

Gaius Livia Silvanus *Bread-Counter*

Decimus Valeria Portinari *Ash-Finger*

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes. Superimposed on them are the whispers of Maelstraeus and Livaea, who have no faction — only those who owe.

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- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Timers: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD PRICE [6]. Patron whispers:* Livaea — they marry for influence, betray for pleasure, and mistake cruelty for wit. They mistake silence for consent.
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the tally — but the tally has no god. *Timers: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]. Patron whispers:* Maelstraeus — they measure profit in margins, margins in suffering, and suffering in silver. They do not measure the weight of marble.
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays the tithe — and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Timers: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6]. Patron whispers:* Neither — the Everflame remembers, but the Vigil has learned to filter its truths. The flame’s truth is ash; the Vigil’s truth is silence.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s weight like a leash), the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease), and the **Vigil** (who hold its secrets like a knife — and sometimes use it). A wise politician learns to balance all three — and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

The Vigil — Three Faces of the Secret Police

The Vigil is not one order but three, each claiming the mantle of the old imperial secret police. They do not cooperate. They do not war. They *audit* each other. They also audit the dead.

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- **The Censer-Knights (Orthodox, Everflame)** — Hunters of untutored magic. They carry brass censers that smoke with bitter herbs and bells that ring once for a warning, thrice for a raid. They answer to the Synod and the High Priest, but their true loyalty is to the *precedent* — the law that magic must be licensed, indexed, and taxed. A Censer-Knight raid is heralded by a single, low bell. They are the most feared and the most public. They are also the most forgetful. *Timers: CANDLE-SMOKE SWEEP [4], HERETIC INDEX [6]*.
- **The Unburnt (Patrician)** — Bodyguards and spies of the Amber Palace. They wear red sashes and carry no visible weapons. Their job is to ensure that no whisper of rebellion, no bread riot, no unpaid toll ever reaches a patrician's ear. They are experts at *redaction* — not killing witnesses, but making them forget. They have forgotten their own names. *Timers: PALACE SECRETS [4], REDACTED MEMORY [6]*.
- **The Red Vigil (Maelstraeus's Own)** — Collectors and enforcers. They serve no noble, no church, no magistrate — only the record. They audit the wealthy for the wealthy, finding hidden obligations, unpaid tithes, and compound tolls that have grown teeth. A Red Vigil agent never demands coin. They demand *names*. They also demand silence — the silence of the forgotten. *Timers: TOLL DUE [4], ROLL OF NAMES [6]*.

The Vigil's three commanders meet once a month in the hypogeum of the Arena, under the gaze of statues that weep marble tears. No record is kept of these meetings. No one admits they happen. The common folk say that if you see a Vigil agent, it is already too late — but they cannot agree on *which* Vigil. The statues know. The statues do not tell.

Spades — Places (revised tone)

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone worn smooth by a thousand hopeful knees. The petitions are written in ink and wax. The steps answer in silence, and the silence is a verdict: “Your claim is under review.” A clerk sweeps the steps at dawn. He never reads the petitions. He weighs them. The heaviest goes to the bottom of the pile. The pile is the city's memory.
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late — and the names of those who forgot they owed. The ferrymaster has a brother in the Red Vigil. They do not speak.
4. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels. The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it. Lately, it speaks in a whisper. The whisper is

always the same: “*I remember. I remember. I remember.*” Those who listen too long forget their own names and start reciting the names of the city’s forgotten dead.

5. **Triumph Stairs** — Marble worn smooth by ambition. The stairs have a name: “The Rise of the Forgotten.” No one remembers why. The patricians still climb them at noon, their retainers counting the steps aloud. They never count to nine. The ninth step is a gap. The gap is where a senator fell — or was pushed — or simply forgot to step. His ghost is still climbing. He has been climbing for a century.
6. **Censor’s Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath. The Vigil has the reagent. The reagent is made from the tears of the last censor who told the truth. He is still crying.

Heads — People & Factions (revised tone)

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands, knowing every shortcut through the ruins. The ruins are not old. They are last year’s fashionable quarter, abandoned when the mortgage was “reclassified.” She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in the language of eviction notices. She reads them aloud to the rats. The rats pay her in stolen bread.
3. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who “moves” stones. His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued. He does not rewrite the map. He rewrites the *memory* of the map. “This street was always a cul-de-sac. You simply forgot.” The Vigil pays him in forgotten names.
4. **Censer-Knight Commander Vorenius** — His lantern burns green. He says it shows the truth. His shadow has two heads — one for each faction he has betrayed. He does not see the third head. The third head is his own, from a timeline where he kept his oath. It is weeping.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (revised tone)

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A funeral procession for a pauper who died in debt. The law says the corpse cannot cross until the toll is paid. The family has no coin. The law does not accept stories. The corpse is beginning to smell, and the Hollow is beginning to notice a weight that cannot be buried. The Vigil is taking notes on who stops to help.
3. **Border Dispute** — A surveyor has moved a boundary stone three feet east. The new map shows your warehouse now stands on a public thoroughfare. The old map is in the archive. The archive wing collapsed last spring. The memory of the boundary now exists only in the cracked floor of the basilica, and the basilica is accepting sealed bids for “reparative memory.” The Vigil has already bid.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (revised tone)

2. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part — or burn. The Vigil will follow. The flame will flicker when you lie. The permit is signed by a clerk who died three years ago. His ghost still signs.
3. **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening. The Vigil is already inside. They will leave a note. The note will say: *“We remember. Do you?”*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs — statues that turn their heads, flames that burn blue, law that remembers every name — and also echo the **Vigil’s presence**: a cough in the crowd, a seal on a document you did not stamp, a mirror that shows a different face. The different face is always older. It is always watching.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Imperial Ruins:** Every district bears half-collapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies. The Vigil knows every hidden passage.
- **Competing Factions:** Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy. The Vigil collects bets on the outcome.
- **Monuments as Weapons:** Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols — they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots. The Vigil has a map of which statues can be toppled.
- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following. The Vigil decodes every sermon.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin. The Vigil audits their pay.
- **The Amber Palace Quarantine:** The patricians have not left the palace in a decade. No one is certain if they are prisoners or patrons. The Vigil maintains the perimeter — and delivers the wine.

- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Saints & Cults):**

- **St. Marcellus of the Gilded Scale (Mykkiel)** — *The Justiciar*. His order enforces unwritten laws; reading a sealed precedent binds the reader to enforce it. His shrine is the Censor’s Hall. The Vigil keeps a copy of every precedent.
- **St. Valeria of the Serpent (Isoka)** — *The Shedding Saint*. Pilgrims who confess at her chapel forget one sin — and one kindness. Her mosaic shows a snake eating its tail. The Vigil uses her chapel to erase memories.
- **St. Lucia of the Undying Flame (Oath of Flame & Light)** — *The Witness of Embers*. Any oath sworn over her shrine’s flame cannot be broken; the breaker sees their own face in every wave until they drown. The Vigil swears oaths there — and never breaks them.
- **The Reckoner (Maelstraeus)** — *The Tally Keeper*. A mystery cult of coin-house factors. They offer credit at the cost of a hidden toll that compounds in blood. The Red Vigil are their collectors.
- **The Ember Prefect (Heretic Cult)** — A schism that believes the flame should not be contained. They meet in the arena hypogeum, chanting the *Unspoken Ninth Citation*. The Grand Magistrate has outlawed them three times. The Vigil has infiltrated them twice.
- **The Velvet Mask (Livaea)** — A secret society of patricians who worship pleasure as the only truth. Their rites are said to last nine days. No one has ever left a rite unchanged. The Vigil watches their parties — and reports to the Unburnt.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment — but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the arena slaves, trying to untie her cord from a coin-house weight. The Vigil has her file.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the grain-prefects. Take it, and your store never runs dry — but the coin will reappear in the mouth of a starving child. The Red Vigil uses it to mark those who owe.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called “Flame-Readers.” They see the future in the Everflame’s flicker. The High Priest employs three — and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t smell of smoke. The Vigil employs their apprentices.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Imperial Arena is a Class IV Poltergeist site — the collective rage of every gladiator who died for the crowd. Saikou Ira would ring a bell eight times and leave a wreath of laurel. The Vigil rings the bell nine times. The Arena answers.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth hear a faint laughter from

the marble walls — and their cases are never heard again. The Vigil cites the ninth often. The laughter does not bother them.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coin-house credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take -1 die on your next trust roll (your choice). [SUPERSTITION]
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor's name into a statue's ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Spit on the Seal:** Before signing any contract, spit on the wax seal. If it sizzles, the Vigil has a copy. [SUPERSTITION]

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.
- **Ecktoria (The Vigil):** A seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp. A cough from the crowd sounds like your name. Your reflection in a polished shield has a red sash.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**

- *Aeler True Masons bid* to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *Aftershock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward. The Vigil audits the contract.
- *Aelinnel Green-Market broker* offers “truth-credit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names. The Vigil pays in silence.
- *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley. The Vigil arrests the ringleader.

- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**

- If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains re-routed).
- Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy). The Vigil notes your pass.
- Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple. The Vigil compares tags.

- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**

- *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1. The Vigil collects the weapons.
- *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*. The Vigil inspects the relic.
- **Survey Rights** → boundary re-plat → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival’s. The Vigil updates the map.

- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**

- Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, Coin-House).
- Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
- Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons. The Vigil adds your name.

- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**

- *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer. The Vigil watches how the mob loves you.
- *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity. The Vigil audits your credit.
- *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*. The Vigil has a copy of your voucher.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry:** When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect or -1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances. The Vigil stands at the top of the stairs, watching.
- **Aqueduct Leverage:** Securing an aqueduct span grants a one-scene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*. The Vigil knows where the aqueduct leaks.
- **Forum Acoustics:** Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1. The Vigil counts the witnesses.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene's terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Weight* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a roll of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds. The Vigil has the key.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanus-masters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city. The Vigil owns the rod.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge. The Vigil lit the purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coin-house founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups. The Red Vigil administers the fund.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet). The Vigil reads the index nightly.
6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats. The Vigil buys the confessions.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators' mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office. The Vigil chooses the champions.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections. The Vigil has the third set.

9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – survey-cult that believes Mile-Zero is *wrong* and can re-found the city with one stone. The Vigil has the stone.
10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes. The Vigil uses their couriers.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors' sweat was bottled for augury. The Vigil broke the seal.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns. The Vigil decodes the theses — and sometimes agrees.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ash-marks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 Coin-House Credit; start a *Green Weight* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint's chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as tally*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate's Postponement*; add *Karmic Weight* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers:** Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints:** Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from bread-lines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers:** Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) auto-triggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags:** locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (mini-procedure, 3 beats):**
 1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
 2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
 3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the Coin-House floor, a factor with smoke-singed rolls offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. The Amber Palace has not answered a summons in a month. The Vigil is asking questions. I suggest you find the answers before they find you.”

Regional Motifs Coin-oaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke, Vigil seals.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor,” “The Vigil’s informer sits in the corner.”

External Timers Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4]; Vigil: *Red List* [6].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot; a seal appears on your documents that you did not stamp.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account; a Vigil informer who owes you a favor.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears. The Vigil hears it too.

Relief Return the shard; pay a city-toll in blood or Boons; route the procession elsewhere; give the Vigil a name.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowd-favor, rival sermon. *Vigil twist*: The Prefect was once a Vigil informer. The Vigil knows where he hides.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Re-plat → Dispossess → Erase. Lair: Mile-Zero. Counters: Aeler measure-rods, witness line, broken rod. *Vigil twist*: The Primus has a Red Vigil agent as a protégé.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Re-birth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test. *Vigil twist*: The Phoenix is a Vigil experiment. The Unburnt want to contain it. The Red Vigil wants to sell tickets.
- **The Velvet Mask** (Livaea’s cult): *Phase* [8] Invitation → Masque → Price of Pleasure. Lair: The Amber Palace. Counters: an unbroken oath, a mirror with no reflection, a name spoken without desire. *Vigil twist*: The Vigil’s Unburnt faction attends every masque. They are not there to stop it.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §??)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Counter-coup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).
17. **Vigil Seal (Red)** – For one scene, the Red Vigil treats you as a contractor. The price will be collected later.

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons:** backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bell-codes now gate temple entries. The Vigil has the bell-codes.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts:** hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*. The Vigil watches both.
- **Black Banners:** war-chaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*. The Vigil takes a cut.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor. And everywhere, the Vigil watches — not to stop the rot, but to take notes.

Yet beneath the decay, two demons whisper. **Maelstraeus** teaches that every contract is a weapon, every obligation a leash. **Livaea** teaches that every desire is a chain, every pleasure a payment. The patricians who once ruled the world now rule only the Amber Palace, and the Amber Palace is a gilded cage. They do not see the bread riots. They do not hear the Vigil’s footsteps. They dance. They drink. They forget that the flame remembers everything.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. The Vigil offers a different kind of patronage: *protection* in exchange for *information*. A party that pays the Vigil in secrets may find doors opening — and other doors closing behind them. To emphasize the decadence and dread:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns, Vigil marks) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting "safe-conducts," forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage weights surface and shift allegiances.
- Introduce the **Vigil’s Faction Timer [6]** to track which Vigil faction (Censer-Knights, Unburnt, Red Vigil) has the most leverage over the party. When it fills, that faction makes a demand.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background — it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival. And beneath it all, Maelstraeus and Livaea are writing a contract. The city is the collateral. The poor are the interest. The patricians are the signature — and they signed in blood long ago.

Acasia

The Broken Marches.

“Acasia was the first province the Utaran Empire swallowed and the last it spat out. Now it is a wound that will not close – a place where roads loop back on themselves and bridges lead to the same shore. The Curse is not a spell. It is a memory, and the land has a very long memory. In these marches, memory is the only currency that does not devalue.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Hardtack soaked in broth – if you have broth. If not, hardtack and hope. The granaries have been empty for three winters. The merchants sell grain at famine prices. The duke says the roads are too dangerous for caravans. The farmers say the duke owns the caravans.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To name the dead. Every Acasian child has a list of ancestors they repeat at bedtime. The list gets shorter each generation. Not because children forget. Because the dead are forgetting themselves.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they have a shadow. The Curse takes shadows first. A man without a shadow is not cursed – he is already gone. His body just hasn’t stopped moving yet.

What is the most common crime? Bridge-toll evasion. The roads are unsafe, the ferries are unreliable, but the barons still demand payment for crossings no one can make. The crime is not in refusing to pay. The crime is in being caught trying.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Curse began with a promise broken on the Blackwood Bridge. A baron promised his daughter to a lord of the old forest. He married her to a lowland knight instead. The forest remembered. The forest is still waiting for the wedding.

Where do people go when they die? Into the Blackwood. Burial is forbidden – the ground rejects the dead. Bodies are carried to the tree-line and left. The wood takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking between the trunks. They do not look back.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You walk the Broken Mile – a stretch of road that collapsed into the river a decade ago. If you reach the far side, you are forgiven. If you fall, you were not sorry enough. No one has reached the far side in seven years.

What is the most important festival? The Counting of the Names (midwinter). Every village lists its dead aloud, from oldest to newest. If a name is forgotten, the

ghost walks until someone remembers. The list grows longer each year. The memory grows shorter.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The duke's son is a ghoul. He was lost in the Blackwood as a child. They found him three days later, pale and smiling. He does not age. He does not eat. He only watches. The servants know. The servants do not speak.*

0.3 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Region Diagnostic Summary

Current Hook The Empire conquered it first. The Empire left it last. Now neither remembers why.

Core Conflict Players are caught between the **Margravine’s** iron law, the **Lame King’s** desperate legitimacy, and the **Curse** that devours broken promises.

The One Thing Only This Region Does **Geometric Haunting:** Roads loop, bridges demand tolls in memory, and contracts signed on bridges become physically binding curses.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth. The ninth toll is collected by a child with no name. The child is the Curse’s accountant.

The Price Players sacrifice **memory, identity, or future labor** to gain power. Every reward requires a gamble: memory loss, Hollow attention, Obligation, or Corruption.

Faction Triad	Faction	Goal	Method	Why players care
	Margravine of the Broken March	Keep the province from fracturing completely	Iron law, feud tallies, blood-oaths	She holds the only valid Imperial seals
	The Lame King	Be recognized as a true sovereign	Traveling throne, debtor armies, decrees	He controls the roads the Margravine cannot
	Free Companies	Find a permanent contract before winter	Selling loyalty, swapping colors mid-march	They are the only law between the claimants

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The Empire conquered it first. The Empire left it last. Now neither remembers why.*

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind. The Empire is dead. Its weight is not.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road has a

memory. The question is who pays the toll. The Empire forgot. That's why it fell."

Genre / Mood: Low-fantasy wasteland, mercenary realism, cursed borderlands.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway's last inn, walls soot-blackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a half-empty hearth. The innkeeper is a one-eyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine's feast day. "The chest contains a claim, not coin," the stranger whispers. "But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop. The Empire's surveyors marked it. Then they died."

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia was the first province the Utaran Empire swallowed when it turned its eyes east. The legions marched through the Pale Causeway, crushed the hill-kings, and planted their eagles in the Blackwood. For centuries, Acasia was the empire's eastern breadbasket and its first line of defense. Grain flowed west; coin flowed east. The roads were straight, the bridges paid, and the Curse was just a farmer's whisper. Then the empire rotted from within. When the last Utaran emperor died and the provinces broke away, Acasia lingered for another hundred years — a ghost province whose governors still stamped Utaran seals, whose courts still cited Utaran law, whose coins still bore the emperor's face. No one came from the west to collect the taxes. No one sent legions to enforce the peace. The Acasians kept the forms, because they had never learned to keep anything else. They had no native king, no unifying faith, no common tongue beyond the legionary's Latin. They were the empire's children, and when the empire died, they became orphans.

For a century they clung to the ruins. Then the plagues came. Then the famines. Then the Curse — a slow rot of roads that led nowhere, bridges that looped back on themselves, villages that woke to find their neighbors' houses standing empty. The old imperial surveys became maps of places that no longer existed. The grain blights turned the storehouses to dust. The free companies, once hired to keep the peace, became the only law.

That was two hundred years ago.

Now Acasia is a wound that will not close. It sits between Ecktoria to the west and Vhasia to the east, claimed by both, ruled by neither. Petty kings raise their banners in burned keeps. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors mid-march. The Margravine of the Broken March keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. The Lamé King travels on a throne carried by debtors, making law by pointing. And the Curse — the nameless thing that makes crossroads turn back on themselves — is not a myth. It is the weight of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

South, on the marshy islands of the Amaranthine coast, the city of Silkstrand squats on reclaimed silt, trading in silk, silver, and secrets. The Acasians call it "the Sink" — a place where the Curse thins, but where law is measured in coin, not custom. Few Acasians go there. Fewer return unchanged.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved — first in Utaran, then in a half-dozen failed scripts. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature. The Empire's last governor signed a treaty on the Pont-du-Tithe. No one knows what it said. The bridge remembers.

Regional Mood: Famine, Ambition, and the Ghost of Empire

Here, the past is not a memory — it is a geometry. The Utaran Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia's petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors mid-march. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a wrong turn: the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the milestone that faces the wrong direction, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a broken promise, and the fine print is written in mildew.

The Curse is not ancient. It is a legacy. Some say it began with the last Imperial Survey, when the surveyors tried to map every bridge, every ford, every toll—and in the measuring, broke something. Others say it was the plagues, when the dead were buried in unmarked pits and the priests forgot the proper rites. The hedge-witches say it was the empire's own fault: they ruled Acasia for centuries but never taught the Acasians to rule themselves. When the empire left, the land had no king, no law, no memory. The Curse filled the gap.

Now the Margravine and the Lame King fight over the scraps, while free companies sell their swords to whichever claimant pays first. The hedge-witches tie red thread around bridges and leave offerings of salt at crossroads, hoping to keep the Curse from spreading. The villagers pray to saints the Empire forgot. And the roads — the old imperial roads — still march west toward a capital that no longer exists. The capital does not answer. But the roads keep marching.

The Curse of Acasia (Campaign Timer)

The Curse is a slow accumulation of broken promises and unpaid tolls. Track it with a visible timer:

Curse Awakening [10] – Advances when:

- A contract is broken on a bridge (+1)
- A character speaks the ninth word in a negotiation (+1)
- The party ignores a road omen (GM spends 1 SB to tick +1)
- A free company flips allegiance mid-contract (+2)

At 4 segments: Navigation rolls in Acasia gain +1 DV (roads shift). At 8 segments: The Curse Stirrs complication triggers once per session (roll on the table below). At 10 segments: The Curse manifests as a physical threat — a bridge eats a village, a road swallows a patrol, or the ghost of the last emperor rides.

Curse Stirrs (d6) When the timer reaches 8, roll 1d6 for an immediate complication:

1. A milestone points the wrong way. Navigation DV +2 for the scene.
2. A bridge you crossed earlier now loops back to where you started. Lose 1 segment of progress.

3. A toll collector's ghost demands payment in a currency that no longer exists. Pay 1 Boon or mark 1 Fatigue.
4. A child with no shadow offers directions. If you follow, you arrive at your destination — but you forget why you came.
5. The Margravine's seal cracks. One of your Diamonds (writ, charter, token) becomes a forgery until you re-witness it.
6. The Hollow's breath freezes the ford. Crossing requires a Desperate roll; on a Miss, you lose 1 Supply (drowned).

Prominent NPCs of Acasia

|p0.2|p0.25|p0.3|p0.15|

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
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Zara	<i>"the Ledger"</i>	Margravine of the Broken March	Keep the province from fracturing completely. She has never lost a feud; her sword is also a counting rod. She claims descent from the last Utaran governor.
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Oren	<i>"Tin Crown"</i>	The Lame King	Be recognized as a true sovereign. His traveling throne is carried by debtors; he pays them in promises. His grandfather was a free company captain who declared himself king.
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Ysabeau	Hedge-Witch of the Blackwood Charcoalers	Survive the Curse and keep her kin from the rope.	She knows which bridges eat travelers, and her price is a story that ends badly. Her grandmother witnessed the last imperial survey.
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The Bride	Dowry chest claimant (Blackwood matriarch's heir)	Recover the chest before the Margravine's feast day.	She carries a dagger in her wedding veil. The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bridge was built by the Utaran legions.
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Vladan	Free Company Captain ("The Rusted Banner")	Find a permanent contract before winter.	He has served three kings this year. He cannot remember their names. His company's banner is an Utaran eagle, torn and stitched.
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Sister Ash	Ex-Imperial surveyor	Finish the old map of Acasia.	She visits villages that no longer exist. The map shows them anyway. She carries a sealed chest of the last governor's papers.
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Names of Acasia

Inspired by the martial duchies of a fallen southern empire: clipped Latin, war-names, and the hard consonants of mountain keeps. Many families still bear Utaranized surnames, though they have not spoken the language in generations.

|p0.25|p0.25|p0.2|p0.2|

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Alboin	Theodelinda	da Ponte	<i>the Stiff</i>
Authari	Rosamund	del Ferro	<i>the Toll-Fist</i>
Liutprand	Gundiberga	di Rocca	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
Desiderius	Anspranda	Longobardus	<i>Blackwood</i>
Ratchis	Veleda	Saxo	<i>the Unremembered</i>
Aistulf	Gisela	Capoferro	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(**Pass/Ruin/Toll-Town**) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vine-terrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.



— Places

2. Broken Milestone



[RUIN] [OMEN]

On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight.

The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet. The first was cut by Utaran legionaries.

Mechanical hook: If you camp here, roll Spirit + Lore (DV 4). On success, you learn the true border line (+1 die on navigation for this leg). On failure, the milestone moves while you sleep — start a **Lost Ways [4]** timer.

3. Vine-Terrace Hillside



[RUIN] [HARVEST]

Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup. The vintage was the year the last governor left.

Mechanical hook: Foraging here gives 1 Supply, but the ivy is possessive. On a Miss, you are entangled (Body+Athletics DV 3 to break free) and tick **Curse Awakening +1**.

4. Toll-Bridge Town



[TOLL] [BOUNDARY]

Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts.

The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak. The bridge was built by the legions. It remembers their footsteps.

Mechanical hook: Crossing costs 1 Boon or 1 Supply. If you refuse, the child writes your name in chalk. The bridge will demand double next time.

5. Wolfstairs Pass



[MOUNTAIN] [AMBUSH]

Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff.

The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name. The pass was the empire's eastern gate. No army has crossed it in a century.

Mechanical hook: Navigation DV +2. On a Partial, you are spotted by a free company scout — start **Rival Hunt** [4].

6. Sootfall Abbey Ruins



[RUIN] [DEATH]

Bell tower intact; crypts breathing.

The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there. They have been praying for the empire's soul for two hundred years.

Mechanical hook: A character who prays with the monks (Spirit+Lore DV 3) clears 1 Fatigue, but the monks ask for a story about a broken promise. Refusal ticks **Curse Awakening** +1.

7. Hill-Motte



[FORTIFICATION] [WAR]

Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops.

The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting. The siege was over a bridge toll. The bridge has not collected in fifty years.

Mechanical hook: The lord of the motte will hire the party as mercenaries (1 Supply). If they refuse, he accuses them of being spies — start **Feud Spark** [4].

8. Border-Stone Ring



[BOUNDARY] [OMEN]

Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong.

The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway. The eighth crown was the empire's. It is not carved. It is implied.

Mechanical hook: A character who touches the eighth (empty) crown must test Resolve (DV 4). On failure, they gain the Condition *Marked by the Curse* (GM may spend 1 SB to worsen Position in any negotiation).

9. Blackwood Charcoalers' Hollow

*[FOREST] [WITCHCRAFT]*

Witch-posts at every path.

The witch-posts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing. They were collecting for the empire. They have not stopped.

Mechanical hook: A hedge-witch offers to read your fortune (1 Boon). On a success, she warns of the next Curse Stirrs trigger. On a failure, she demands a memory (erase a minor fact).

10. Salt-Road Ford

*[RIVER] [DEATH]*

Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks.

The bones are from three wars. They are not all human. The ford was the empire's salt route. The salt is still in the water.

Mechanical hook: Crossing costs 1 Fatigue (cold). If you drink the water, test Endurance DV 3. On failure, you see the ghosts of the drowned for the next scene (–1 die on all actions).

11. Iron Mine Adits

*[UNDERGROUND] [WHISPERS]*

Held by a miners' commune; the air is full of whispers.

The whispers are the mine's memory. It remembers every collapse. The last collapse was the year the empire fell. The miners are still digging.

Mechanical hook: The commune will trade 1 Supply for a miner's story. If the story is true, they also reveal a hidden exit — treat the next travel timer as 2 segments shorter.

12. Margravine's Hunting Lodge

*[NOBLE] [SECRETS]*

Tapestries of victories that never were.

The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair. The victories are Uтарan. The weaver was Acasian.

Mechanical hook: A character who studies the tapestries (Wits+Lore DV 4) learns a noble's secret (a String). On a failure, the blind weaver's ghost asks for a favor — start **Weaver's Debt** [4].

13. War-Camp City



[WAR] [REFUGE]

Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne.

The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat. The lord was the last imperial governor. He died in the fire.

Mechanical hook: To enter the camp, you must swear a temporary oath to a claimant. Breaking it ticks **Curse Awakening** +2.

14. The Pale Causeway



[ROAD] [CURSE]

The last high road that survives the spring thaws.

The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it. The workers were Acasian. The empire paid them in promises.

Mechanical hook: Crossing the Causeway at dusk forces a Resolve test (DV 4). On failure, you gain the Condition *Debtor to the Dead* (any spirit can demand one service from you). On a critical failure, the Curse Awakening timer ticks +2 immediately.

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithe-collector's runner with a tally-rod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.



— People & Factions

2. Tithe-Collector's Runner



[AUTHORITY] [HUNGER]

Tally-rod, empty stomach, and a list of names.

His tally-rod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty. He collects for the Margravine. She does not ask where the grain goes.

Debt they owe: He owes his soul to the Margravine's ledger. If you give him a name

from the list, he will mark it paid — but the ghost of that name will haunt you.

Price of aid: 1 Supply or a story about a tax collector who died hungry.

3. Roadside Prior

♥ 3

[FAITH] [RELIC]

Three lay brothers guarding a relic.

The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death.

The saint was an Utaran missionary. The Acasians ate his offerings.

Debt they owe: The prior's order swore to feed the poor. They have failed. He will help anyone who shares a meal.

Price of aid: A crust of bread and a prayer. If you refuse, the relic's ghost will follow you (−1 die on all stealth rolls for one scene).

4. Hedge-Witch

♥ 4

[WITCHCRAFT] [KNOWLEDGE]

Knows which bridges eat travelers.

Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending. She has heard all the good ones. The bridges listen when she speaks.

Debt they owe: She once cursed a tax collector. The curse still echoes. If you help her lift it, she will teach you a route that ignores the Curse once.

Price of aid: A story that ends with a death. If the story is true, she gives you a Salt Ward (Diamond). If false, the bridges will remember you.

5. Free Company Captain

♥ 5

[MERCENARY] [FATIGUE]

Pike and shot between contracts.

He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names. His first contract was with a man who called himself emperor. The man is dead. The contract is not.

Debt they owe: He owes back pay to his company. If you pay 1 Supply, he will fight for you for one scene.

Price of aid: A contract signed in blood. If you break it, the Curse Awakening ticks +2.

6. River Reeve

♥ 6

[LAW] [CORRUPTION]

Rents every boat twice.

His paper is a single page folded into a boat. The other half is elsewhere. The other half is in the Margravine's counting house. She does not know.

Debt they owe: He stole the half-page from the Margravine. If you return it, he will waive all tolls for a season.

Price of aid: A bribe of 1 Boon or a secret about the river. He will also betray you for a better offer.

7. Salt-Baron



[TRADE] [VIOLENCE]

Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable.

His salt is gray. It was cut with ashes from a burned village. The village refused to pay the imperial salt tax. The empire is dead. The salt is not.

Debt they owe: He took a loan from the Margravine's counting house. If you pay it (2 Supply), he will give you a Salt Charter (pass any ford free).

Price of aid: A wagon of gray salt. Using it in a bargain gives +1 die to intimidation, but the ghost of the burned village will haunt the transaction.

8. Blackwood Matriarch



[NOBLE] [VENGEANCE]

Tends the feud like a garden.

Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies'. Her grandmother was the last Acasian to hold an imperial title. The empire took it back. She has not forgotten.

Debt they owe: The empire stole her grandmother's title. If you recover the original charter (in the Sealed Dowry Chest), she will name you her heir.

Price of aid: A lock of hair from a blood enemy. She will not say whose.

9. Ex-Imperial Surveyor



[KNOWLEDGE] [LONELINESS]

Has the last accurate map.

The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway. She leaves offerings of bread and ink. The ghosts do not eat. They watch.

Debt they owe: She lost the map's key — a brass compass. Find it, and she will draw you a route that ignores the Curse for one journey.

Price of aid: A true name of a dead village. She will trade a secret for it.

10. "King" of Three Villages



[CLAIMANT] [IRON]

Iron-nail crown, iron-will taxes.

His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse. The curse reversed back. He does not know.

Debt they owe: He borrowed the plowshare from a hedge-witch. The witch wants it back. Return it, and he will grant you a tax waiver.

Price of aid: A day's labor in his fields. If you refuse, he accuses you of oath-breaking — start a **Feud Spark** [4].

11. Bride with No Dowry but a Claim



[CLAIM] [DESPERATION]

Daggers in the wedding chest.

The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect. The bridge was built by the legions. The legions are gone. The bridge is not.

Debt they owe: Her dowry was the bridge's toll. The Margravine seized it. If you help her collect, she will give you a **Bridge Token** (Diamond).

Price of aid: A dagger from her chest. Using it in a duel gives +1 die, but the bridge's ghost will claim the loser.

12. Margravine of the Broken March



[AUTHORITY] [FEUD]

Half saint, half tax roll.

She has never lost a feud. Her tally stick is her sword. Her great-great-grandfather was the last imperial governor's clerk. He stole the seal. She still has it.

Debt they owe: She is losing her grip on the province. If you settle a feud for her, she will give you a **Blood-Peace Charter** (Diamond).

Price of aid: A signature on her tally stick. Signing binds you to her service until the feud is settled.

13. The Lame King



[CLAIMANT] [FATIGUE]

Traveling throne; makes law by pointing.

His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything. He owes the Margravine a bridge toll. He has not paid. The bridge remembers.

Debt they owe: He cannot pay the toll. If you pay it for him (2 Supply), he will name you his heir for a day — you may issue one royal decree.

Price of aid: A ride on his throne. The debtors will carry you, but you will owe them a favor in return.

14. The Cursed Child of Silkstrand



[MYTH] [OMEN]

A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges.

She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century. She was born on the day the last imperial governor died. She does not age. She does not forget.

Debt they owe: She is the Curse's accountant. If you find her, she will tell you how many bridges you owe.

Price of aid: A name you have never spoken. She will write it in her ledger. The Curse will remember it forever.

(**Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse**) Peat-fog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day's service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.



— Complications/Threats

2. Peat-Fog



[WEATHER] [FEAR]

All horns sound like someone calling your name.

The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you. The fog is the empire's last breath.

Mechanical hook: Navigation rolls are Desperate for the scene. On a Miss, a ghostly tax collector appears. It demands a story or a memory. Refusal ticks **Curse Awakening** +1.

3. Sudden Levy



[AUTHORITY] [TIME]

Every traveler is pressed for a day's service.

The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink. The list was copied from an imperial tax roll. The roll is two hundred years old.

Mechanical hook: Pay 1 Supply or serve. Serving forces a Resolve test (DV 4). On failure, you gain the Condition *Impressed* (−1 die to all actions until you escape). Start a **Levy Escape** [4] timer.

4. Bridge Feud



[BOUNDARY] [VIOLENCE]

Rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach. The oath was sworn to the emperor. The emperor is dead. The chain does not care.

Mechanical hook: The chain will only lift if you swear an oath to one of the feuding parties. Swearing ticks **Curse Awakening** +1 (oaths made on bridges always compound). Refusing forces a fight — treat as a Cap 2 adversary.

5. Grain Blight



[HARVEST] [FEAR]

Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night.

The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry. The collector worked for the empire. The empire did not pay him.

Mechanical hook: You may pay double (2 Supply) or refuse. Refusing starts a **Village Hunt** [4] timer. When full, the villagers attack at night (Cap 3 mob).

6. Scree Slide



[MOUNTAIN] [BLOCKED]

Seals the pass; the “safe” detour is owned by your enemy.

The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you. The pass was the empire’s eastern gate. It still remembers the legions.

Mechanical hook: Pay 2 Supply to the enemy or find another way. Searching for another way forces a Wits+Survival roll (DV 5). On a failure, you lose 1 segment of progress and gain a **Black Mark** with the enemy.

7. Wedding Turns Ambush



[SOCIAL] [TRAP]

You are caught between two bloodlines.

The bride’s veil is a shroud. The groom’s ring is a knife. The feud began when the empire divided the valley. The valley has not healed.

Mechanical hook: You must choose a side or flee. Choosing a side gives you an ally (Cap 2) but starts a **Feud Spiral** [6] timer with the other. Fleeing costs 1 Fatigue and ticks **Curse Awakening** +1.

8. Witch’s Tithe Night



[WITCHCRAFT] [DEBT]

Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else.

The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect. They are the ghosts of imperial tax collectors. They have not stopped working.

Mechanical hook: The ghosts demand a story. If you cannot tell one, they take 1 of your Boons (or 1 Supply). If you have nothing, they take a memory — lose 1 XP (refundable by a quest).

9. Pox Sign

 9

[DISEASE] [ISOLATION]

On a village gate; your escorts desert you.

The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real. The pox came with the last imperial supply train. The supply train never arrived.

Mechanical hook: You must travel alone for the next leg (no assists). Start a **Disease Timer** [4]. When full, each PC gains 1 Fatigue.

10. Condotta Breaks

 10

[MERCENARY] [BETRAYAL]

The Free Company flips colors mid-march.

The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale. He was hired by the Margravine. He was also hired by the Lame King. He is collecting both salaries.

Mechanical hook: The company now fights for your enemy. You may bribe them back (2 Supply) or fight them (Cap 3). Bribing ticks **Curse Awakening** +1 (broken loyalty compounds).

11. Heretic Preacher

 J

[FAITH] [RIOT]

Sparks a march; toll-gates come down in splinters.

The preacher's text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture. The receipt was issued by the empire. It is still valid. No one knows to whom.

Mechanical hook: The preacher will grant you safe passage through the riot if you give him a relic (any Diamond). If you refuse, the mob attacks (Cap 2, and you are separated from allies).

12. Imperial Pretender

 Q

[CLAIMANT] [POLITICS]

Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards.

The pretender's seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked. The seal was stolen from the last governor's tomb. The governor's ghost is following him.

Mechanical hook: The pretender offers you a charter (Diamond) if you swear loyalty. Swearing ticks **Curse Awakening** +2 (the ghost of the governor will remember). Refusing makes him a permanent enemy (start a **Pretender's Hunt** [6] timer).

13. River Overruns the Levee



[WEATHER] [DESTRUCTION]

The pontoon goes; your rivals don't.

The river's name is "Debt." It remembers every unpaid crossing. The empire's engineers built the levees. They calculated the flood levels. They did not calculate the Curse.

Mechanical hook: You lose 1 Supply (washed away). If you have no Supply, you lose 1 Boon instead. The GM may also tick **Curse Awakening** +1 (the river demands interest).

14. The Curse Stirrs



[CURSE] [TRAP]

No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads.

The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled "Regret," "Hunger," "The Same." The post was planted by the last imperial surveyor. She is still walking.

Mechanical hook: Roll on the **Curse Stirrs** table (see Regional Mood section). The party cannot leave until they pay a toll — a story, a memory, or a name.

(**Papers/Claims/Safe-Conduct**) Toll-exemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.



— Rewards/Leverage

2. Toll-Exemption Plaque



[TRAVEL] [ONCE]

For one bridge (once).

The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the toll-keeper will spit—but step aside. The leaf was minted by the empire. The empire's mines are closed. The metal is still

good.

Curse cost: Using the plaque ticks **Curse Awakening** +1 (the bridge will remember your face). If you use it on a bridge that has already taken a toll, the plaque crumbles and the bridge's ghost follows you for a day.

3. Monastery Letter



[HOSPITALITY] [ONCE]

For bed and bread on a named road.

The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not. The abbot was an imperial clerk. He still follows the old forms.

Curse cost: The monks will ask you to pray for the dead. If you refuse, the letter burns and you gain a **Black Mark** with the monastery. If you pray, clear 1 Fatigue but tick **Curse Awakening** +1 (the dead listen).

4. Wine-Right



[TRADE] [ONGOING]

On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares.

The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron. The grave holds the last imperial garrison. They were paid in promises.

Curse cost: Drinking the wine gives +1 die to your next social roll, but the garrison's ghosts will appear in your dreams. The GM gains 1 SB to use on a nightmare complication.

5. Condotta Contract



[MERCENARY] [ONCE]

A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms).

The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain's own finger. The contract was copied from an imperial legionary oath. The words have changed. The weight has not.

Curse cost: If the contract is broken, tick **Curse Awakening** +2. The captain's ghost will demand a new contract — signed in your own blood.

6. Tithe-Remission Writ



[AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

For a village; they owe you a season's labor.

The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell's clapper is a finger bone. The bell was cast from melted imperial coinage. The coinage was debased. The bell rings true.

Curse cost: Using the writ forces the village to work for you, but the bell's ghost will follow you. Every season, you must offer it a story or lose 1 Boon.

7. Border-Stone Adjustment



[BOUNDARY] [ONCE]

Move a line two fields over.

The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there. The line was surveyed by the empire's best geometers. They are all dead. Their measurements are not.

Curse cost: The ghost of the surveyor will appear and demand you measure the new line with your own feet. Walk it exactly (8 steps) or lose 1 Fatigue and tick **Curse Awakening** +1.

8. Pass-Key Charm



[TRAVEL] [ONGOING]

Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen.

The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay. The cord was tied by an imperial courier. The courier's route was swallowed by the Curse. The cord remembers the way.

Curse cost: The charm works for one season. After that, the courier's ghost will visit you. He will ask for a message to deliver. If you refuse, the charm becomes a curse — all roads lead back to the same crossing.

9. Sealed Dowry Chest



[CLAIM] [MYSTERY]

Of claims, not coin; certain doors open.

The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know. The name is the last imperial governor's. He wrote it on the inside. He is the only one who has seen it.

Curse cost: Opening the chest ticks **Curse Awakening** +3. The governor's ghost will appear and offer a bargain: the name in exchange for a service. Refusing means the chest locks forever.

10. Mine-Share



[RESOURCE] [ALLIANCE]

In the commune; they fight like they mean it.

The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave. The mine was

opened by the empire's first surveyors. They found iron. They also found something else. They did not name it.

Curse cost: The miner will work for you, but the mine's whispers will follow. Once per session, the GM may ask you to name something you found in the dark. If you lie, the miner dies.

11. Blood-Peace Charter



[SOCIAL] [TRUCE]

Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons.

The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember. The ribbon was woven by a hedge-witch. She used thread from a tax collector's uniform. The collector is dead. The thread is not.

Curse cost: The truce lasts one scene. After that, the feud returns with interest — both sides will demand a wergild from you. Pay 2 Supply or start a **Double Feud** [6].

12. Marriage Proxy



[SOCIAL] [ALLIANCE]

From the Margravine; bind a hill-king to your cause.

The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost. The ghost was the Margravine's grandmother. She married an imperial legate. The legate never came home.

Curse cost: Using the proxy binds the hill-king to you — but the ghost will appear at your own wedding (or any celebration). She will ask for a dance. Refusing costs 1 Boon and ticks **Curse Awakening** +1.

13. The Lame King's Traveling Writ



[AUTHORITY] [ONCE]

Troops must make way (for now).

The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King's seal is a footprint. The footprint was pressed into wax by his grandfather. The grandfather was a free company captain. He could not write. He used his boot.

Curse cost: The writ works only once. After that, the Lame King will send debtors to collect the scepter. If you refuse, start a **King's Hunt** [6].

14. Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary)



[RITUAL] [ONCE]

For one night, no crossroads can hold you.

The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken. The name is the Curse's. It does not want to be spoken. It does not want to be silent. It wants to be paid.

Curse cost: Using the rite clears all **Curse Awakening** segments for one night. The next morning, the Curse returns with double the segments. You cannot use the rite again in the same province.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safe-conducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew, the ghost of the empire in every milestone.
- Track the **Curse Awakening [10]** timer as a campaign-wide pressure. Use the **Curse Stirrs** table when it reaches 8.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feud-token tied to a petty lord or house. Feud-tokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feud-token to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.
- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil stored supplies.
- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.
- **Empire's Ghost:** Any ancient imperial structure (milestone, bridge, fortress) may still be haunted by the echo of its original purpose. A character who makes an offering (a coin, a salute, a whispered oath) may gain +1 die on a single roll within sight of that structure. The offering must be sincere. The empire does not accept bribes. It accepts memory.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant. She says the empire’s last weight is still unpaid.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack. The workers do not spend the coins. They stack them. They are building something.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the toll-collectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods. The coin was minted in the empire’s last year. The emperor’s face is worn smooth.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “Feud-Readers.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted a settlement they didn’t whisper. They say the Curse is not a thing. It is a conversation. The empire is still talking.
- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth. The ninth toll is collected by a child with no name. The child is the Curse’s accountant.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.
- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ’s ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector’s name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like promises. The Margravine keeps a tally of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari's iron teeth, a Free Company's purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel. The empire is dead. Its weight is not. And the Curse is patient.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company patrols or village watchmen**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers or hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **River reeve or Free Company captain** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival bloodline or toll-lord's enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feud-kin**, **Free Company** deserters, or **Margravine's** guards arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Margravine**, **Lame King**, or **Cursed Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as “payment.”
- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.
- **Acasia (Empire's Ghost):** A phantom legionary marches past, an imperial seal glows on a broken stone, a tax collector's ghost demands arrears.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.

- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedge-witch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases*: Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks*: a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.
- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucrat-priest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases*: Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Reckoning. *Cracks*: a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** buys off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia's plague of false crossroads. *Phases*: Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks*: a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.
- **The Imperial Ghost (Undead/Precedent)** — The shade of the last imperial governor, still trying to collect the taxes. *Phases*: Audit of the Damned → Summon the Debtors → The Emperor's Peace. *Cracks*: produce the original imperial charter (in the Sealed Dowry Chest), pay a wergild in the empire's own debased coinage, or convince the ghost that the empire is truly dead.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch's dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants broken. The chest was last seen in the hands of a free company captain who claims he is the heir to the empire.
- **The Lame King's Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies. The king wants to know who killed the last imperial surveyor. The surveyor is sitting at the table.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge. The bridge wants more. The bridge remembers the empire's last toll.

Vhasia

The Fractured Sun.

“The sun shattered at Lence. The pieces are still falling. Which shadow will catch you? The Fenwoods burned the capital a decade ago, but the fire never went out – it just moved indoors, into every court, every negotiation, every marriage bed. Chivalry is the mask; the knife is the truth.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Dark bread and watered wine – the wine cuts the dust from the road. The nobility eat spiced eggs and fresh cheese, but they eat behind closed doors. To eat well in public is to invite envy. Envy is a dagger.

What does a child learn before they can walk? Which colours not to wear. Black and gold are the Northern Crown’s colours. Red and silver are the Southern Parlement’s. A child who wears the wrong colour to the wrong village may not return home.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they walk on. The north side is the Crown’s. The south side is the Parlement’s. The middle is no man’s land – literally. Bandits, spies, and messengers use the middle. So do ghosts.

What is the most common crime? Raiding across the Belworth. The river is the border, the border is a suggestion, and the suggestion is enforced by armed men on both sides. The crime is not in raiding. The crime is in being caught on the wrong bank at dawn.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sun-court was not burned. It was bankrupted. The Fenwoods did not sack Lence – they bought it. Every judge, every clerk, every guard captain had a price. The Fenwoods paid it. The Vhasians are still paying interest.

Where do people go when they die? To the crypts beneath the Sun-court – if they can afford a plaque. The poor are buried in unmarked graves along the Belworth floodplain. The river floods every spring. The dead wash downstream, into the land of the other crown. Neither side claims them.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a chevauchée – a raiding party that burns a village in your name. The apology is not in the burning. The apology is in the promise that the village will be rebuilt with your own hands.

What is the most important festival? The Sun-return (spring equinox). Both crowns claim the sun as their symbol. On this day, both hold processions. The proces-

sions are identical. The participants do not acknowledge each other. The sun does not care.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Queen-Mother has no claim to the regency. Her son is not the Dauphin. The real Dauphin died in childbirth. The child on the throne is a foundling, bought from a Tulkani caravan. The Tulkani know. The Tulkani are still waiting to be paid.*

0.4 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The sun shattered at Lence. The pieces are still falling. Which shadow will catch you?*

Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (Elite): “The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains. Every coin minted here carries our blessing, and every law written bears our seal—the rest is just politics. The rest is also ash. Ask the Fenwoods. They made the ash, and they left us to choke on it. But remember: the first crack came not from their swords, but from the marriage beds where a Vhasian queen bore sons to two Viterran kings—and the sons who wondered whose blood truly ran in their veins. Chivalry? A thin veneer. Scratch it, and you find the iron beneath.”

Road Warden (Commoner): “I’ve served under three banners on this same road. The only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls, oaths, the dead. The Fenwoods burned Lence ten years ago, marching from the Belworth like storm-clouds. Now every duke with a purse thinks he’s king. The Queen-Mother weaves in the west, Valdais sharpens his lance in Adria, and the Two Crowns count their silver. Me? I just want to get home before the snows bury the graves. And if you hear a cantor singing the *Planctus Armatus*, stop and listen. That’s the only honest history left—especially the verse about the queen who married twice, bore sons to both kings, and left the realm wondering which throne was hers by right, and which by rumor.”

Genre / Mood: Courtly intrigue, chevauchée warfare, fractured legitimacy, the tragedy of chivalry—a kingdom that cannot mourn because mourning would mean admitting the old world is dead. Beneath the gilt and the heraldry, chivalry is a thin veneer; the iron of siege and sack shows through at every edge.

Starting Location: The Pont-du-Tithe, its golden arches catching fire in the sunset as pilgrims chant from both banks. A Duchy Constable in splendid armour guards the toll gate. “The chevauchée burns to the east,” he says, gesturing toward the Belworth. “Two Crowns march to meet it. Whose seal do you carry? Speak quickly—the levy waits for no one. And keep your hand away from your sword. The bridge remembers the last blood spilled here. It remembers the Fenwood horses crossing from the east. It remembers the screams.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Vhasia is a realm of broken coronations and split loyalties, still bleeding from a wound a decade old. Once a proud province of the Utaran empire, the unified Sun Court shattered like its heraldic sunburst when the Fenwoods of Viterra and their allies crossed the Belworth, sacked the capital of Lence, and cast down the old Blood line. Duke Braedyn Fenwood—uncle of Veralyn, now the Warrior Queen of Viterra—led the assault, his ironshod cavalry grinding the Sun King’s army into the mud of the Ford of Ashes. They burned Lence until the mirrors melted and the very stones wept. They left the throne empty—not destroyed, but open. And they left a wound that has not healed.

But the wound runs deeper than smoke and stone. Forty years ago, during the Province Wars, King Wymund of Viterra sought alliance with Vhasia through marriage—taking Elianor Everblood (née Longblood) as his queen. She bore him two daughters, his heir Valdaïs Longblood, and a second son, Wyllmot, who was made heir to the Viterran throne. When Wymund died, Elianor married his son Baldvyn II, becoming queen of Viterra again and binding the two realms in blood—but also in rumor. The jealousies between these unions ignited the provincial wars that weakened both realms, culminating in Wyllmot’s clash with Valdaïs at Adria—a victory stained by the suspicion that brother had fought brother for a throne built on doubtful bloodlines.

When the Fenwoods came, Elianor was in her western duchy of Ethor, having married into the Vhasian royal Bloods line—a final attempt to stitch the realm back together. Her nephew had been made heir to the Sun Court on condition of that marriage, a settlement that the sack of Lence tore apart utterly. Now, Elianor rules from Ethor, her alliances woven from the threads of three marriages and the quiet terror that none of her sons may be truly “hers” by the blood that matters. She is not mourning. She is waiting—for proof, for a sign, for the moment when the fractured sun might finally cast a single shadow.

The memory of the sack haunts every negotiation. The Queen-Mother, Elianor Everblood, lost her third husband—the old Sun King—and her cousins and sisters in the flames. Her second son, Wyllmot, King of Viterra and Duke of Aberiel, died fighting rebels in Viterra, leaving his crown to his daughter, Veralyn—who is now the Warrior Queen, who was the Fenwoods’ ward, and who was *there* when they burned Lence. Elianor rules from a riverside keep, weaving alliances and hiding a secret—a Dauphin, perhaps her grand-nephew, perhaps a changeling, who may be the key to restoring the Sun Court. Her eldest son, Valdaïs Longblood, Duke of Adria in the west, claims the throne by blood and steel, but Elianor does not trust him. She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning. She is waiting.

The Fenwood sack was not just a military defeat; it was a betrayal of chivalry itself. The knights of Vhasia had sworn to protect the realm with the **Round of Five Virtues**: Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth. At Lence, the Fenwoods showed no mercy. The knights still argue about whether chivalry died there or whether it was already a corpse, dressed in armour, a thin veneer over the cruelty of the world. The Cantor Alain sings the *Planctus Armatus* each spring, and the congregation weeps for Sir Corin, who unbuckled his gorget to hear a thief’s voice and was undone by the mercy he offered. Sir Corin died at Lence. He was trying to save a child. The child is now the Dauphin—or so the Queen-Mother claims—and perhaps the living proof that Elianor’s bloodline, however tangled, still holds the true sun.

What you notice first: The smell of old smoke and fresh ink. The way every noble’s seal has a hairline crack—like the fault lines in old marriage alliances. The constant.

Regional Mood: Crowns, Courts, and the Weight of Lence

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a weight—not of silver, but of memory. The Fenwoods came from Viterra across the Belworth with fire and iron, broke the Sun King’s army at the Ford of Ashes, and burned Lence until the mirrors melted. Duke Braedyn Fenwood led them; his daughter Veralyn—now the Warrior Queen of Viterra—was her father’s attendant and witness to the sack, a fact that complicates every border negotiation. The Vhasian nobility has not forgotten. They cannot forgive. But they cannot afford a war with Viterra, either.

So they fight each other instead.

Now every duke with a long purse and a short conscience backs a claimant. The Queen-Mother weaves alliances from her riverside keep in the west, holding a Dauphin—perhaps her grand-nephew, perhaps a commoner with a convincing birthmark—as a bargaining chip. The Two Crowns—Valdais Longblood of Adria in the west, and a rival claimant backed by the southern parlements—march their levies. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and the memory of Lence is ground into every negotiation. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace. And ten years later, the smoke from Lence still hasn’t cleared—and neither has the doubt about whose blood truly flows in the veins of those who claim the throne.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

The Ninth Taboo

In any Vhasian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear a faint laughter from the marble walls—and their cases are never heard again. The laughter is the dead king’s. He was the ninth king of his line. He died at Lence. He is still laughing—because the ninth citation is the only one that names the Fenwoods as the true heirs. No one has ever cited it. No one dares.

Also, the ninth cup poured at a feast is for the Hollow. The wise pour eight and leave the ninth empty. Those who pour the ninth see a pale figure standing at the high table—waiting to collect a weight. The figure is the dead king, checking his oath-stick.

The Province Wars (Forty Years Ago)

Before the Fenwood sack, there was the **Province Wars**—a generation of low-intensity raiding between the cantons that left the old crown weakened and the knights bitter. The peace that ended the Province Wars was a treaty of exhaustion, not reconciliation. It was during those wars that the dynastic tangles began: King Wymund of Viterra married Elianor Everblood to seal the peace, only for her to later wed his son Baldvyn II after Wymund’s death—a union that sparked the very conflicts it was meant to prevent. The veterans of the Province Wars are now the old men who watch the new claimants with weary eyes. They remember when mercy meant something. They also remember when it cost everything—and they whisper that the first casualty of those wars was trust in the marriage beds of queens.

The Players of the Great Game

The succession crisis has four major factions, each with a claim, a secret, and a price—each shadowed by the legacy of dual marriages and uncertain parentage.

- **Queen-Mother Elianor Everblood (née Longblood):** Widow of three kings—Wymund of Viterra, his son Baldvyn II, and the last Sun King. Mother of Valdaïs and the late Wyllmot. She rules the western canton of Ethor. Her price is a guarantee that her grand-nephew (the Dauphin) will not be killed. Her secret: she is not sure if Valdaïs is truly her son by Wymund—or if he was conceived during the turbulent shift between husbands. She acts as if he is of the Blood, because certainty would destroy what remains of the Longblood line—and because the Dauphin may be her only hope for an heir without doubt.
- **Duke Valdaïs Longblood of Adria:** The western claimant. Nephew—or half-brother, depending on the rumour—to the last Sun King. A tournament champion with a flawless record and a suspicious habit of opponents falling ill before jousts. His claim rests on blood and steel. His secret: his mother, Elianor, does not trust him—and he suspects why. He was not at Lence. He wishes he had been—so he could have died with honour instead of living with the question: “Whose son am I, truly?”
- **The Two Crowns (Rival Dukes of the South and East):** Backed by the southern parlements and the eastern march lords who face the Belworth. Their claim rests on election and expediency. Their secret: they have been known to accept Viterran gold—but never the Fenwood seal. They whisper that Veralyn is not her father’s daughter. They are wrong. They are also afraid—afraid that if the Viterran line is false, then the Vhasian claim via Elianor’s marriages is equally doubtful, and the realm has no true sun left to claim.
- **The Last Dauphin (The False/Real Heir):** A child of nine years, hidden in the Queen-Mother’s keep. His legitimacy is a matter of faith. His existence is the only thing keeping Valdaïs from marching on his mother’s castle. His secret: even Elianor does not know if he is truly her grand-nephew—but she has dreamed of Sir Corin, who died saving a child at Lence. The child in the dream has the Dauphin’s face—and perhaps, just perhaps, the unbroken line of Elianor’s blood, however it flowed.

The Cantor Alain and the *Planctus Armatus*

No figure embodies Vhasia’s tragedy more than **Alain, the Iron Bard**. A cantor who survived the sack of Lence as a boy—rescued by Sir Corin himself—Alain carries a cracked ring and a voice that carries the weight of the dead. Each dusk, he sings the *Planctus Armatus* (the Lament for the Armoured), a song that recounts Corin’s unbuckling and the mercy that killed him. The song has eight verses. The ninth is silence—the space where the Hollow listens. The fourth verse, oft-whispered, speaks of “the queen who wore two crowns, and the son who knew not which father’s blood he carried.”

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a character who hears Alain sing (or who recites a verse of the *Planctus Armatus*) may gain +1 die on a roll involving mercy or witness.

On a failure, they mark 1 Fatigue—the weight of remembering. If they recite the fourth verse specifically, they may instead gain +1 Effect on a roll involving inheritance or legitimacy—but mark 1 Corruption, as the doubt it stirs is a poison to certainty.

Prominent NPCs of Vhasia

p0.2	p0.25	p0.3	p0.15	
Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured	Quirk
	Elianor Everblood	Queen-Mother of Ethor	Restore her grand-nephew (real or false) to the throne—and prove, at last, whose blood truly flows in Valdais’s veins. She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning—she is planning, and waiting for the moment the doubt ends. Her shadow has begun to drift independently—sometimes toward Ethor, sometimes toward the memory of Wymund’s court, sometimes toward the empty space where Baldvyn II’s queen should stand.	
	Valdais Longblood	Duke of Adria, western claimant	Unite Vhasia under a strong western crown—and silence the whispers about his parentage once and for all. He has never lost a joust. His opponents have a habit of falling ill before the tilt. He does not poison them. His mother’s spies do. He carries a shard of Wymund’s coronation sword in his boot—a reminder that the first throne he ever knew may not have been his by right.	
	The Red Marshal	Exiled commander of the Sun Court’s army	Win back Lence—or die trying. He lost the Battle of Ashes; he still sees it in his dreams and his nightmares. He was the last man to see the old king alive. The king’s last words were a curse on the Fenwood name. He wonders, in the quiet hours, if the curse was meant for the Fenwoods—or for the queens who married twice and left the realm questioning whose sons were truly theirs.	
	Seint Michel’s Justiciar	Magistrate of the Order of the Gilded Scale	Enforce the chivalric code without mercy. He carries a scale with one pan empty; the empty pan is for lies. He has never been able to balance it. The empty pan holds the ghost of Sir Corin—and sometimes, he swears, the whisper of Elianor’s doubt as she watched the sack from Ethor.	
	Sister Oria	Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House on the Belworth	Keep the rites of hospitality and witness. She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to. The Queen-Mother’s enemies who cross her threshold have a habit of forgetting why they came. Her scroll records every name and every death of those who fell at Lence.	
	The Cantor Alain	Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring	Sing the truth of Corin’s mercy before the armour closes again—and sing the truth of the queens who bore sons to two kings, and the sons who never knew which father’s blood they carried. Feathers grow from his temples; his shadow moves a half-step behind him. His songs are the only honest history left in Vhasia. He sings the names of the dead every dusk. The dead listen—and sometimes, they answer.	
	The Dauphin (Child)	A child of nine, hidden in the Queen-Mother’s keep	Survive—and perhaps, one day, answer the question that has haunted Elianor since Valdais was in swaddling clothes. He has never seen the sun. He knows three languages, the lineage of every	

noble house, and the taste of every poison. He does not know if he is a prince or a puppet. He dreams every night of a knight with an unbuckled gorget—and of a queen who wore two crowns, wondering which throne was truly hers.

Names of Vhasia

Inspired by the fractured duchies: Francien, Norman, and Brittonic influences. Soft vowels, silent consonants, and surnames that recall a bridge, a ford, or a stained banner. Many names echo the Province Wars era, when marriage alliances were made and broken.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Valdais	Elianor	de la Marche	<i>the Iron</i>
Wymund	Baldvyn	l'Ever	<i>the Unwed</i>
Renaud	Isabeau	de Lence	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Corin	Oria	d'Ethor	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Touénot	Mael	du Pont	<i>the Silver</i>
Alain	Giselle	de la Croix	<i>Ash-Banner</i>
Ghiro	Celandine	l'Argent	<i>the Unpaid</i>

(Château/Cathedral/Forest) Wayside shrine with pilgrims tacking petitions to a scorched sun disc; vine-terrace clos above a millstream with napping watchmen. The oldest vintners whisper that the “Crownbreaker” vintage was blessed by Elianor herself—once as Viterran queen, once as Vhasian queen—before the province wars turned the gift to ash.

Spades — Places

- Wayside Shrine** – Pilgrims tack petitions to a scorched sun disc; each parchment curls in different winds. *The petitions are never answered. The shrine is a mailbox for the dead—especially those who fell at Lence. The dead do not write back. They wait.*
- Vine-Terrace** – Clos above a millstream; watchmen nap, halberds traded for bottles. *The best vintage is called “Crownbreaker.” It tastes like smoke and regret. The year of the sack was a particularly good harvest. The wine remembers.*
- Bastide Square** – Neat as a checkerboard; merchants pay homage to different “hours” of the Sun. *The square has a gallows. It rotates to face whichever claimant lost the last duel. The wood is still green—from the forest where the Fenwoods camped before Lence.*

5. **Royal Forest** – Antler posts mark laws no king remembers; poachers still hang. *The forest's deer have grown bold. They wear crowns of shed antlers. Some say they are the ghosts of the old nobility—or the knights who unbuckled their gorgets too late.*
 6. **Pont-du-Tithe** – Tollbridge flanked by chapels and crossbows; chains blessed by rival bishops. *The chains were forged from melted sunbursts. They ring in different keys. The Fenwood army crossed here from the east. The bridge still groans when Viterrans approach. The groans are prayers.*
 7. **Great Fair** – Outside a chartered town; counting sheds ring like bells, rumours louder still. *The fair has a Court of Miracles where counterfeiterers sell to informers. The best forgery is a sunburst coin that rings true until you test its weight. The weight of a lie is memory.*
 8. **Salt Pans** – Windpumps on an estuary; gulls own the law, smugglers own the night. *The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older weights. The smugglers carry more than salt—they carry the Queen-Mother's letters. The letters smell of Lence.*
 9. **Siege-Château** – Hoardings patched, cistern low, banners cut into ragged suns. *The banner's ragged edges are from a Fenwood sword. The owner still limps. He lost his son at Lence. He fights for Valdaïs but he does not love him. He loves the ghost of his son.*
 10. **Cathedral Yard** – Cranes creak, stones fly, scaffolds bristle with rival masons' marks. *The mason's marks are clan signs. A scratched-out mark means a dead foreman. One mason's mark is a sunburst with a crack—the mark of the Queen-Mother's architect. He was at Lence. He built the pyres.*
- J **Parlement Hall** – Hung with faded tapestries; sunbursts spliced and restitched by claimants. *The tapestries show battles that never happened—and some that shouldn't have. One tapestry shows the sack of Lence from the Fenwood perspective. The Queen-Mother has ordered it burned three times. It keeps reappearing. The thread is from the shrouds of the dead.*
- Q **Queen's Causeway** – Mile-long oath paved in quarried stone; half-sunk each spring. *The sunken half is a graveyard for vows. The stones are slippery with old lies. The Queen-Mother walks here at dawn. She speaks to the dead. The dead answer in the voice of the Dauphin.*
- K **Sun Palace (Lence)** – Shuttered mirrors, brambled gardens; courtiers playing at kingship. *The mirrors were covered after the sack. No one wants to see what they show now—a reflection of a kingdom that no longer exists. The courtiers pretend the king still lives. The servants know better. The mirrors know best.*
- A **King's High Road** – Milestones chipped of crowns; yet every army still marches it. *The road is paved with the bones of tax collectors. They are not missed. The Fenwood army marched here from the Belworth. Their footprints are still visible—in the stone and in the memory of every orphan.*

(**Lord/Court/Company**) Road warden with dented badge and honest horn; vintner-guild syndic counting saints' days as grace periods.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Road Warden** – Dented badge, honest horn; ignored by both crowns but knows the roads. *His horn is cracked. It still sounds—but the note is always half a step flat. He was at Lence. He does not speak of it. The horn does.*
3. **Vintner Syndic** – Counts saints' days as grace periods, vintages as treaties; wine as diplomacy. *He keeps a bottle of Crownbreaker in every cellar. He knows which vintage each duke prefers. He also knows which duke's wine is poisoned. He does not ask. The poison is memory.*
4. **Abbess-Chatelaine** – Rules a fortress-convent with iron rule and sharper scripture. *She has never drawn a blade. The scaffold has, on her orders. She sheltered refugees after the sack. The Queen-Mother owes her a weight. The Queen-Mother does not forget weights—or the smell of burning wool.*
5. **Routier Captain** – Scarred and mercenary; prefers ransoms to loyalty; coin as conscience. *He switches banners as often as his shirt. His loyalty is to the paychest—and to his mother. He fought for the Fenwoods at Lence. He still has nightmares. He pays for them in silver.*
6. **Duchy Constable** – Splendid armour, empty coffers, pride swollen as a banner; glory over gold. *His armour was his grandfather's. It still has the dent from a Fenwood axe. He serves Valdais because Valdais pays—but he served the old king first. He cannot forgive himself for surviving Lence. The dent weeps rust.*
7. **Cantor Alain** – The Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring; his songs are the only honest history. *Feathers grow from his temples. His shadow moves a half-step behind him. He sings the names of the dead every dusk. The dead listen. And sometimes, they sing back.*
8. **Salt-Farmer** – Gabelle lessee with cudgels, writs, and a river-chart no crown has; tax as tyranny. *His tally is written in salt. One drop of water and the obligations vanish—along with the evidence. He is the Queen-Mother's man. He does not say so aloud. His salt tastes of ash.*
9. **Trouvère** – A scandalous lay about the last Sun King brings knives to tavern doors. *He sings the truth. That is why he sleeps in a different inn every night. He knows who really ordered the burning of Lence. He will not say. He values his tongue. The truth is a currency he spends in silence.*
10. **Marshal-Exile** – The Sun Court's hammer; now wielded by whoever pays in silver. *He lost the Battle of Ashes. He still sees it in his dreams and his nightmares. He*

was the last man to see the old king alive. The king's last words were a curse on the Fenwood name. The curse is still unpaid.

J Heretic Perfect – Preaches peace while tucking hidden daggers into parchment margins. *His sermon is a code. The psalms tell you which bridge to cross and which to burn. He is the Queen-Mother's spy. He is also Valdais's spy. He is also his own spy. His sermons are the only honest prayers left.*

Q Queen-Mother – Riverside keep in the west; weaves alliances as if they were dowries. *She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning. She is waiting. Her grand-nephew—real or false—will sit on the Sun Court. She will not live to see it. She has made her peace with that. The peace tastes of Lence.*

K Two Crowns – Rival dukes, each “crowned” in rival cathedrals, neither whole. *One wears a crown of iron. The other wears a crown of words. Both rust. Neither was at Lence. Neither speaks of it. They pay others to speak for them. And sometimes, they whisper that if the Viterran line is false, then the Vhasian claim via Elianor's marriages is equally doubtful.*

A Last Dauphin – A rumour with a birthmark; armies march for whispers alone. *He may be a baker's son. The armies don't care. They need a sun to follow. He has never seen the sun. He knows three languages, the lineage of every noble house, and the taste of every poison. He does not know if he is a prince or a puppet. He does not ask. He dreams every night of a knight with an unbuckled gorget.*

(Chevauchée/Law/Church) Chevauchée burning loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. Interdict falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Chevauchée** – Raiders burn loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. *The raiders wear no colours. Their horses answer to whistles and grudges. They were at Lence. They remember. The smoke smells of old wool. '[WAR]'*

3. **Interdict** – Falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls, heretics prosper. *The bells were melted for shot three wars ago. The silence is old. The interdict was ordered by the Cardinal-Regent—but no one knows which claimant he serves. The silence is a prayer for the dead of Lence. '[FAITH]'*

4. **Forest Law** – Venison becomes treason; poachers hang from antler posts. *The antler posts are carved with the names of the hanged. They whisper at dusk. The names include survivors of Lence who could not find work. '[DEATH]'*

5. **River Spate** – Ferries chained, bridges drowned, pilgrims stranded mid-prayer. *The water is the colour of old gold. It washed away a mint last spring. The mint belonged to a claimant who could not pay his routiers. The routiers now raid for the other side. '[WEATHER]'*

6. **Coin Debasement** – Three mints, three suns, no trust; soldiers demand silver alone. *The silver is from the same mine—but the stamp is a prayer, not a promise. The Queen-Mother controls two mints. Valdais controls one. The Cardinal-Regent holds the dies. The dies were made from melted Fenwood spurs.* ‘[WEIGHT]’
 7. **Parlement Divided** – A siege laid on parchment before walls; war by paperwork. *The clerks duel with citations. The loser pays the winner’s ink bill. The winner gets to draft the next round of tax levies. The peasants pay both. The ink is mixed with ash from Lence.* ‘[LAW]’
 8. **Company Mutiny** – Unless arrears are paid in blood or coin; mercenaries as a time bomb. *The mutineers have a list. Your name is on it—or will be by nightfall. The list was leaked by the Queen-Mother’s spy. She wants the routiers to switch sides. The list is written on a page torn from the Chivalric Roll.* ‘[MERCENARY]’
 9. **Relic Dispute** – Two abbeys claim the same saint’s bones; mobs answer with stones. *The bones are actually from a cow. The saints don’t mind. They like the attention. The abbeys are backed by rival claimants. The cow was from a farm that burned at Lence.* ‘[FAITH]’
 10. **Harvest Blight** – Bread locked behind pikes; bakers guarded as lords. *The blight has a name. It is the name of a duke who raised the levy too late. His fields fed the Fenwood army. His people starved. He still rules. The blight is his guilt made visible.* ‘[DISASTER]’
 11. **Tournament “Accident”** – Hides an assassination; your favour is now evidence. *The lance was filed with a prayer. The prayer was answered—but not for the target. The victim was a claimant’s champion. The killer was never found. The Queen-Mother smiled. The lance was from Lence.* ‘[COMBAT]’
- J **Royalist Restoration** – Sunburst badges painted overnight on doors and graves. *The paint is the colour of dried blood. The badges face the wrong direction. The Queen-Mother’s agents paint them. She wants the people to remember that the Sun Court once existed. The badges glow in moonlight.* ‘[OMEN]’
- Q **Feudal Levy** – Lords demand levies in days, not months, with three days’ bread. *The bread is hardtack from the last Fenwood siege. It still smells of smoke. The levy was called by Valdais. The lords are his cousins. They do not want to march. They owe him.* ‘[WAR]’
- K **Winter Campaign** – Roads turn to mud, hooves to ice, armies to ruin. *The snow is grey with ash. The Pass of Ashes has a sister pass now. The Fenwood army marched through the Pass of Ashes from the Belworth. The ghosts still march there—in both passes.* ‘[WEATHER]’
- A **Lence’s Echo** – Smoke rises from the ruins. The Fenwood banners appear on the horizon. It is a false alarm—or is it? *The party must test Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1d4 Fatigue from remembered terror. If they fail, they also gain the*

Haunted condition—the dead of Lence will follow them for one session. The question they whisper is always the same: “Why did you survive?” ‘[FEAR]’ ‘[DEATH]’

(Charter/Patent/Right) Safe-conduct sealed by a duke or abbey; honoured only once, on one road; burgess charter for a market ward.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Safe-Conduct** – The seal is cracked. The road is watched. Use it before the seal breaks. *The seal was cracked at Lence—by a Fenwood axe.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Burgess Charter** – The charter is a bell. Ring it, and the town answers—or it doesn’t. *The bell was cast from a melted sunburst. It rings true—but only for those who remember. The bell’s clapper is a finger bone from a knight who died at Lence.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
4. **Bridge Farm** – Tolls at Pont-du-Tithe for a season, if you can hold it. *The toll-keepers are loyal to the last coin. Yours—or theirs. The bridge was rebuilt after Lence. The stone is new. The ghosts are old. The ghosts do not pay tolls.* ‘[TRADE]’
5. **Pareage Charter** – Shared rule with a monastery; half justice, half rent, no peace. *The monks pray for you. They also pray for your enemies. Balance. The monastery sheltered refugees after the sack. The Queen-Mother has not forgotten.* ‘[LAW]’
6. **Wardship** – Over a minor heir; lands obey you “for now.” *The heir has a knife. He knows how to use it. He learned from watching you. His father died at Lence. He does not know which side his father fought for. He does not care. The knife was his father’s.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
7. **Gabelle Lease** – Salt-tax rights; lucrative, hated, and dangerous. *The lease is a death warrant written in profit. Cash it wisely. The salt pans are near the Belworth. The Viterran border is close. The Fenwood raids come at dawn from the east. The salt is grey with ash.* ‘[TRADE]’
8. **Letters Patent** – Raise a free company under your banner; an army as a business. *The letters are signed in blood—yours or the notary’s. Both are valid. The notary lost a hand at Lence. He signs with his left. His right is buried in Lence.* ‘[MERCENARY]’
9. **Remission** – Of feudal dues for a village; they’ll march when called. *The village has a long memory. They remember the last lord who promised mercy. He was a Fenwood. They do not forgive. The remission is written on a page torn from the Chivalric Roll.* ‘[COMMUNITY]’
10. **Low-Justice Grant** – Stocks, fines, gallows in a troublesome hamlet. *The gallows rope is new. The notches are from the last hamlet. The hamlet was burned by routiers. The routiers were paid by a claimant. The claimant denies it.* ‘[LAW]’

J Confiscation Writ – Against a royalist estate—if you can seize it first. *The writ is a race. The other claimant rides a faster horse. The estate belonged to a lord who died at Lence. His widow still lives there. She has a knife. The knife is for the horse.* ‘[WEIGHT]’

Q Queen’s Audience – Private with the Queen-Mother; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is a chess game. She always wins—but she lets you take a pawn. The pawn is the Dauphin. Do not touch him. His shadow is not his own.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’

K Sunburst Warrant – Of the fallen court; most still bow if shown boldly. *The warrant is a ghost. It has no power—only the power of belief. The ghost was signed by a dead king. The dead king’s seal was stolen from his tomb. The Queen-Mother has the original. The original weeps wax.* ‘[LEGEND]’

A General Pardon (Temporary) – Rebels absolved if they bend the knee. *The pardon is a spring. It will close when the season turns. The rebels were at Lence. They fought for the old king. They fled when the Fenwoods broke the line. They are still running. The pardon smells of ash.* ‘[JUSTICE]’

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/patents/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **fractured sun motifs**—light that splinters, oaths that crack like glass, smoke that smells of Lence, and a child who may be a prince or a puppet. Also echo the weight of memory: a ghost knight, a mirror that shows the sack, a bell that rings for the dead.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Fractured Seals:** When brandishing a writ, badge, or charter tied to a Sun Court claimant, step Position up one step for the scene’s next interaction at a gate, court, or checkpoint. Each use advances a **Legitimacy [4]** timer linked to the claimant; when it fills, rivals challenge the authority on sight. The seal’s crack widens with each challenge. Eventually, it will break—and the broken seal will smell of Lence.
- **Parlement Games:** If a scene touches petitions, guild disputes, or feudal appeals, the first Diamond played becomes a policy lever: treat it as two Diamonds toward swaying a decision or rewriting a custom. Afterward, start or advance a **Whispered Precedent** timer; when it fills, backlash spreads as other courts cite the case against you. The Queen-Mother’s clerks are masters of this. They have never lost—because they have never forgotten the price of losing. The price is Lence.

- **Gabelle Knife-Edge:** At bridges, fairs, or salt depots, convert Diamonds tied to tolls, leases, or safe-conducts into immediate passage or tariff relief for the company (no roll). Each conversion ticks a **Resentment [4]** timer for the locale; when it completes, expect boycotts, ambush rumours, or an audit by rival officials. The salt farmers remember Lence. They do not forget. The salt in their tears is grey.
- **Vhasian Chivalry & the Round of Five Virtues:** The knights of the western cantons (Ethor, Adria) follow the **Round of Five Virtues:** Courage, Courtesy, Mercy, Prowess, Truth. In a formal joust or a legal duel, the GM may award **Victory by Virtue** rather than by blood: the combatant with the higher Virtue score wins the dispute, even if they lost the physical exchange. This is the law of the tilt and the law of the court. But at Lence, the Fenwoods showed no mercy. The knights still argue about whether chivalry died there—or whether it was already a corpse, dressed in armour, a thin veneer over savagery. And sometimes, they whisper that the first crack in the sun came not from the Fenwoods' swords, but from the marriage beds where queens bore sons to two kings—and the sons who never knew which father's blood they carried.
- **The Armor Closes / The Song Escapes (Chivalric Timers):** The Cantor Alain, bearer of the Cracked Ring, sings a warning at every tourney:
 - **Armor Closes [6]** advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars. The Fenwoods taught Vhasia that mercy is a weakness. The knights have not forgotten. They wear their gorgets to bed.
 - **Song Escapes [8]** advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal. The Cantor Alain has been trying to fill this timer for ten years. He is still trying. He sings every dusk. The dead listen—and sometimes they answer.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The law that does not bend; the judge who cannot be bought. His shrines are at tourney fields and courtrooms. Knights swear oaths on his scale before the joust.
 - **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** The dream of setting aside the crown; the mercy of forgetting duty. Her groves demand that armour be unbuckled at the threshold.
 - **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor'iraath):** The oath that outlasts the oath-taker; the blood-price paid in stone. The barrow-kings demand tribute in stories, not gold.
 - **The Cantor's Road (The Traveler):** The road that belongs to no lord; the path that finds its own way. Cantors are immune to chivalric protection—but subject to its violence.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Seint Michel, the Judge of the Scar (Mykkiel):** The Order of the Gilded Scale maintains the **Chivalric Roll**—a record of every oath sworn and broken in the cantons. A page torn from this roll can serve as a single-use Claim String (gain +1 Position in any court). The Order’s justiciars are feared and respected; they never unbuckle their gorgets, and they have never lost a case. The Queen-Mother keeps a copy in her riverside keep, wrapped in a grey shroud. The page that records the Fenwood oath of safe passage—broken at Lence—is still blank. The Order will not write it. They are afraid of what will happen if they do. The blank page smells of smoke.
- **Seint Isabeau, Who Slumbers Amongst the Lilies (Ikasha):** In the Ethorian marches, knights whisper prayers to Seint Isabeau when they long to set aside their steel. Her shrine is a hawthorn grove where armour must be left at the gate. Pilgrims who enter bare-skinned and speak a true regret find that their next wound heals in a single night—but they dream of a woman in white who asks, “Will you remember how to be touched?” Those who return to the grove a second time are never seen again. The knights who survived Lence do not go near the grove. They are afraid of what they might forget—or what they might remember.
- **Seint Evroul of the Cairn (Mor’iraath):** In the high passes of the Ethorian marches, a rusted knight in an unopened helm haunts the old barrows. He is the patron of those who carry a blood-weight and cannot rest. To call upon him, one must pour a cup of salt water at a cairn and name the wrong done to your house. He will witness one blow; if it lands, the foe is **Marked by the Cairn**—any spirit may locate them for a year. If it misses, the blow turns inward. The Marshal-Exile carries a scar from such a bargain; he does not speak of it. He named the Fenwoods. The blow missed. He still does not understand why. The Cairn weeps rust.
- **The Order of the Sunken Cup (The Hospice of the Broken Blade):** A grey-robed hospice in the ruins of Lence treats the wounded of both crowns. They ask no payment, but they record every name in a scroll that never dries. The Restorationists suspect they are spies for the Queen-Mother; the Two Crowns accuse them of erasing obligations. Sister Oria, the hospice’s custodian, is also the keeper of the Lantern-Rites House on the Belworth—neutral ground where even claimants must leave their blades at the door. The scroll has a page for every person who died at Lence. The page is still being written. The ink is still wet. The ink is made from ash and tears.
- **The Ninth:** (See the Ninth Taboo Manifestation box above.)

Vhasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Sun:** Crumble a crust onto a cracked sun disc. Ignore the first *Chevauchée* penalty. [SUPERSTITION] *The sun disc should be from Lence. The older the crack, the better. The bread should be stale—like the memory of the old king.*

- **Knot the Seal:** Tie a single knot in a charter's ribbon. Cancel *Parlement Divided* or take -1 die on your next legal argument (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]' *The ribbon should be black. Black is for mourning. The knot should be tied while facing east—toward Lence and the Belworth.*
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead claimant's name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their faction this scene, but mark Obligation to the Queen-Mother. '[SUPERSTITION]' *The salt pan should be on the Belworth. The dead claimant's name should be spoken only once. The Queen-Mother will know. The salt will taste of ash.*
- **The Lence Candle:** Light a candle in the ruins of Lence. For the next scene, any oath sworn by candlelight is binding—but the candle will gutter if the oath is false. The dead will witness. They do not forgive. '[SUPERSTITION]' *The candle should be made from the fat of a knight who died with his gorget buckled. There are many.*

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Rival officials or court guards take notice.
- **Noise:** Parlement clerks or routier patrols are alerted.
- **Trace:** Trackers or tax collectors mark your route.
- **Delay:** A setback costs time or a favourable legal window.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource timer.
- **Lence Echo:** A flash of smoke, a distant scream, a child's face in a window. The memory of the sack surfaces. The GM gains 1 SB to spend on a fear effect. The fear is always the same: that it will happen again.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A duchy constable or abbess-chatelaine begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** Legal challenge or road closure costs you advantage.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival claimant or free company arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes Compromised/Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test.
- **Claimant's Agent:** A spy working for Valdais, the Queen-Mother, or the Two Crowns reveals themselves. They demand a favour or a bribe. The bribe must be a memory of Lence. If you have none, they will take a finger.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional routiers, parlement guards, or ducal forces arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool or weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** A writ is voided, an interdict declared, or a levy called.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark Fatigue 1/Harm 1 or an appropriate Condition.
- **The Dauphin's Name:** Someone speaks the child's name aloud. The Queen-Mother's spies are everywhere. The party is now on her radar. The child will dream of them.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates fully.
- **Authority Arrival:** The Two Crowns, Queen-Mother, or Marshal-Exile intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A chevauchée hits, the river floods, or the parlement erupts.
- **Patron Omen:** An omen appears, a blessing is lost, or a curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **The Sack Relived:** Smoke rises from Lence. The Fenwood banners appear on the horizon. It is a false alarm—or is it? The party must test Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1d4 Fatigue from remembered terror. If they fail, they also gain the **Haunted** condition—the dead of Lence will follow them for one session.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Fractured Authority:** Seals break mid-signing, legal papers rewrite themselves, badges refuse honour.
- **Legal Warfare:** Court decisions reverse, precedents are cited against you, writs expire prematurely.
- **Sun Symbolism:** Sun discs crack underfoot, light splits into contradictory shadows, oaths shatter like glass.
- **Lence's Shadow:** A ghost appears—a soldier, a child, a king. It asks a question. Answering costs a memory. Refusing costs a curse. The question is always: *“Why did you survive?”*

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Survival):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Charter (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a Safe-Conduct is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Sack (Resolve + Spirit):** On a hit in *Lence's Echo*, you pick who keeps their memories; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Red Marshal (Exiled Sun Court hammer) – Phases:** Chevauchee Call → Banner Turn → Lists to War. *Cracks:* Letters Patent buys one round of obedience; General Pardon lets a unit stand down. He was at Lence. He ran. He has not forgiven himself. He wears his gorget unbuckled.
- **Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (scarlet gloves) – Phases:** Interdict Blade → Seal Both Ways → Confessional Leak. *Cracks:* Queen's Audience cancels Interdict Blade once; a Synod Indulgence treats a church check as controlled for one scene. He was not at Lence. He blessed the Fenwood banners before they marched. He does not speak of it. His gloves are scarlet for a reason.
- **The Parlement Spider (chief clerk; quills like daggers) – Phases:** Motion to Delay → Counter-Citation → Filed at Dawn. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant opens a “royal window”; a Burgess Charter lets a town court overrule once locally. He keeps the lists. He knows which nobles voted for the Fenwood peace. He does not show the list to anyone. The list is written on his own skin.
- **The Two Crowns (rival dukes) – Phases:** Contradictory Edicts → Levy in Hours → Coin Trial. *Cracks:* Sunburst Warrant → public mass unites them for one scene; General Pardon calms levy unrest once. They were not at Lence. They sent levies. The levies never returned. They pay the widows' pensions. They do not visit the graves. The graves visit them.
- **The Queen-Mother (Elianor Everblood) – Phases:** Weave the Web → Unveil the Dauphin → The Sun Rises Again. *Cracks:* produce proof of the Dauphin's illegitimacy, convince Valdais to kneel, or find the old king's true heir (a child hidden in the Mistlands). She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She will outlive you. Her webs are woven from the hair of the dead.
- **The Cantor Alain (Iron Bard, bearer of the Cracked Ring) – Phases:** The Planctus → The Witness → The Silence. *Cracks:* unbuckle a gorget in his presence, speak a true regret aloud, or sing the ninth verse—the one that names the Hollow. He is not an enemy. He is a mirror. Do not break the mirror.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Tournament Ordeal (Bastide Square)** – Declare Purse, Patent, or Pardon as stakes. Win to cash a matching $\diamond$; lose and spawn *Tournament “Accident”*. The square was built on the site of a mass grave from Lence. The dead watch. They are not impartial. They vote with the wind.
- **Cathedral Scaffold Assize** – Argue law atop creaking beams; each good point moves Position up; each slip marks Exposure. A Paréage Charter lets you call a recess once. The cathedral was rebuilt after the sack. The old stones are in the foundation. They still remember the fire. They also remember the screams.
- **Pont-du-Tithe Vigil** – Keep the bridge peaceful through dusk: clear 3 segments on Bridge Peace by feeding pilgrims, quieting relic zeal, and paying one tithe from your purse. The bridge was the first structure the Fenwoods burned. The replacement stone was brought from Viterra across the Belworth. It still smells of smoke—and of Veralyn’s perfume. She was there.

Patronage & Power

In Vhasia, power flows through the remnants of imperial authority, fractured legitimacy, and the careful manipulation of memory and mercy. Former Utaran provincial structures still provide a framework for governance, but competing claimants to the Sun Court have created a complex web of overlapping jurisdictions and conflicting loyalties. The true power lies with those who can navigate this legal maze—and who understand that the only currency that matters is the memory of Lence.

But beneath the charters and the writs runs a deeper current: the wound that will not close. The Fenwood sack was not just a military defeat; it was a wound to the soul of Vhasia, proof that chivalry was only ever a thin veneer. Every negotiation, every duel, every sealed document carries the weight of that loss. The Queen-Mother plays a long game, her Dauphin a card she may never play. Valdais wants the throne his father could not hold. The Two Crowns will accept any solution that leaves them richer. And the common folk—the farmers, the salt-panners, the road wardens—just want the raiding to stop.

They will wait. They have waited ten years. They can wait longer.

For the GM: Patronage in Vhasia revolves around legitimacy, legal documents, and the ability to command respect from institutions that no longer have a clear central authority. Rewards often take the form of charters, writs, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasise the post-sack grief and the fragile peace:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, badges, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided—especially if they bear the old king’s seal or the Fenwood mark.
- Let rival claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more—and whose memory of Lence they are willing to invoke.
- Use the parlements, cathedrals, and châteaux as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success—and where the mere mention of the Fenwood name can shift the tide.
- Introduce the **Lence’s Shadow** mechanic: whenever a scene involves a legal dispute, a military manoeuvre, or a negotiation with a noble who lost family in the sack, the GM may spend 1 SB to invoke the memory of the burning. The Position worsens by one step, and the losing party may gain the **Haunted** condition.
- Use the **Armor Closes** and **Song Escapes** timers as a visible campaign front. The party’s actions—acts of mercy or cruelty—tick one or the other. When the Armor Closes, the cantons become fortresses; when the Song Escapes, a moment of genuine connection may change everything—or kill everyone.

In Vhasia, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled. But your memory of Lence—and how you use it—determines whether anyone will follow you.

The Vacant Throne & Campaign Timers (For longform political campaigns)

- **Vacant Throne Timer [10]:** Advances when a claimant gains a major advantage (battle, noble defection, foreign alliance). Retreats when the party brokers a truce or exposes a weakness. When full, a claimant takes Lence and declares themselves king. The Queen-Mother will not live to see it. She will die the day the sun rises whole again.
- **Armor Closes [6]:** Advances when knights choose protection over mercy, when gorgets are buckled tight, when chivalry becomes siege mentality. When full, the cantons close their borders and the raids become wars. The Fenwoods taught Vhasia that mercy is a weakness. The knights have not forgotten. They sharpen their gorgets.
- **Song Escapes [8]:** Advances when a Cantor sings the truth, when mercy is shown, when armour is unbuckled. When full, a moment of genuine connection occurs—though it may be fatal. The Cantor Alain has been trying to fill this timer for ten years. He is still trying. He sings every dusk. The dead listen—and sometimes they answer.
- **Claimant's Coup (per claimant):** A 6-timer that advances when that claimant wins a Parlement vote, a joust, or a skirmish. When full, they march on Lence. The Dauphin—real or false—watches from the Queen-Mother's keep. He does not know if he should cheer or weep.
- **Lence's Reckoning [8]:** Tracks the party's engagement with the memory of the sack. Advances when they aid a survivor, recover a relic, or speak the truth about what happened. When full, a survivor reveals a secret: the old king's last words, the location of a hidden treasure, or the true parentage of the Dauphin. The secret will change the succession. It will also change the party. Some secrets are heavier than crowns.

Viterra

The Hedge-Law Realm.

“Viterra hums with the quiet hum of old promises kept. The Queen’s Peace is not a word – it is a wax seal warm from the press, and every seal tells a story. The hedge-courts don’t keep the peace with swords – they keep it with second chances. And in Viterra, a second chance is always worth the price of a smile.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Barley porridge with a drizzle of honey – if you own bees. If not, porridge with salt. Salt is the currency of the poor. Honey is the currency of the hopeful.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To recite their lineage back three generations. Every Viterran child knows their grandparents’ names, trades, and debts. A child who cannot recite is a child without standing. Standing is everything.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Whether they carry a seal ring. A seal ring means they have the right to make contracts in their own name. A stranger without a seal ring is either a servant or a criminal. In Viterra, the difference is a matter of paperwork.

What is the most common crime? Boundary disputes. A hedge moved three feet east. A milestone replaced under cover of darkness. A ford declared “private” when it has been public for two centuries. The courts are clogged. The lawyers are rich. The hedges are patient.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Queen is not a warrior. She has never drawn a sword. Her reputation was forged by a propaganda campaign run by her spymaster. The spymaster is dead. His successor is more discreet.

Where do people go when they die? To the family plot – if they have a family. The landless poor are buried in parish cemeteries, their headstones marked with a single word: “Anonymous.” The ghosts wander the hedgerows at dusk. They do not remember their names. They remember their debts.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You petition the hedge-court for a “writ of contrition.” You state your wrong aloud while holding a handful of earth from the wronged party’s land. If the earth crumbles, you are forgiven. If it holds, you are not.

What is the most important festival? The Opening of the Rolls (autumn). Every county sends its tax records to the capital. The documents are carried by children, so the next generation learns the weight of obligation.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Codex of Precedents has a missing page. It was torn out during a trial for treason. The page contained the precedent for executing a monarch. The Queen knows. The Justiciars know. The page is hidden in a lead-lined box beneath the hedge-court at Thornwood.

0.5 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every hedge is a boundary. Every boundary is a claim. Every claim is a blade.*

Queen Veralyn Everblood (Elite): “I was Fenwood’s ward when I was sixteen. I took Lence’s walls for him. I made the Vhasian Sun-court run red. Now I sit on a throne built of precedents—and I keep a dagger under my pillow. The hedge that is not defended is only a suggestion. The law that is not enforced is only a memory. I will have both remembered. But sometimes I wonder which hand shakes more when I seal a charter: the queen’s, or the enforcer’s.”

Fen Reeve Cuthbert (Commoner): “The dikes hold back more than water—they hold back the scream of Lence still echoing in the reeds. Every rod measured, every stone placed, keeps the flood from washing away not just our fields but the memory of what we were before the Fenwoods came. Across the Belworth, the Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try. We have lawyers who quote old charters. We have swords that remember Lence. The Queen’s peace is a contract; she signs it each morning with a blade in her hand. I just hope the ink holds—and that it’s not mine.”

Genre / Mood: Post-imperial consolidation, legal warfare as blood sport, border adventurism, fragile crown haunted by fratricide.

Starting Location: The Hall of Dawning tilt-yard at first light. Dawn-knights drill in armor polished like mirrors—each dent a story from last week’s legal duel. Beside them, advocates rehearse arguments with the same intensity, palms slick on pommels. A Queen’s Justiciar slides a parchment across an oaken rail, her seal ring catching the dawn. “Three charters, one road across the Belworth. The Vhasian claimant says the bridge is theirs. The local reeve says it’s crown land. The abbey says it’s a pilgrimage, not a toll. Carry the Queen’s writ, break the Quiet Tolls, and make them agree—by clause or by cut. The Earls are watching, and the Queen has only just secured the throne. Fail, and you’ll give her enemies the excuse they need: that she is still Fenwood’s bloody handmaiden, not Viterra’s queen.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Viterra is a kingdom learning to stand alone after throwing off the Utaran yoke. Once a proud realm before the legions came, it never forgave the empire. Its hedge-laws and parish courts preserved a stubborn identity that parchment and wax could never erase. Now, under the young Warrior Queen Veralyn Everblood—ward of the Fenwood dukes, veteran of the sack of Lence, and still Duchess of Aberiel in Vhasia—Viterra is trying to remember what it means to rule itself.

But the crown is not secure. Veralyn took the throne only after the sudden death of her brother, King Baldwyn Brightside, whose two-year reign ended in a swift, mysterious illness. Rumors whisper it was Fenwood's doing, to clear the path for *their* claim. His death was a wound the kingdom has not healed. The northern earls, descendants of old hill-kings, watched for a misstep that proved she was still Fenwood's instrument. Some of them secretly funded the fanatics who killed her father, Wyllmot, five years earlier—a betrayal she has just finished rooting out with steel and statute. The eastern barons, who expected greater spoils from the Lence campaign because she was the Fenwood duke's ward, now grumble that she has rewarded loyalty to the crown, not to the sword. Every spring, the Queen's justiciars ride west with warrants. Every autumn, Vhasian routiers raid the grain convoys. The border is not a line on a map. It is an argument. And the Queen intends to win it—even if she must become the thing she swore to leave behind.

The realm's true sinews lie in writs, charters, and ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, church to common. Yet there is no single, unified law. The Queen's law competes with the earls' law, the barons' law, the custom of the fens, the Ubral clan law of the high passes, and the Vhasian claims that bleed across the Belworth. A deed valid in Valora may be worthless in the Marches. A crown-court judgment may be overturned by a hedge-moot at dusk. The very question *which law is law* is settled not in courts, but in the mud of the Belworth, where writs are brandished like blades and blood soaks into the parchment.

What you notice first: The smell of damp parchment laced with old iron. The clatter of writ-runners' boots on blood-soaked cobblestones. The way every noble's hand rests on a seal ring worn thin from constant gripping—and every commoner's hand rests on a hatchet notched with Vhasian blood.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers—sometimes still clutching a forged writ to their chest.

Regional Mood: The Queen's Long Shadow

Here, the law is a weapon and the past is a ledger still open. Veralyn's throne is a fortress she built with borrowed steel and her own blood. The northern earls have been humbled—their levies disbanded, their charters rewritten—but they watch from their keeps, waiting for a misstep. The eastern barons, who expected land and tariffs from the Lence campaign, now find themselves audited and outmaneuvered. They whisper that she fights like a Vhasian,

rules like a Fenwood, and trusts no one. They are correct. Across the Belworth, the Vhasian claimants still style themselves the rightful kings of Vhasia, and they remember that Veralyn once rode with Braedyn Fenwood. The Queen’s peace is a contract written in ink and witnessed by steel. Every spring, she rides west with her justiciars. Every autumn, the routiers test the borders. The hedge-law holds—barely.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

The Ninth Taboo

In any Viterran court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous citations. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who cite the ninth are said to hear faint laughter from the marble walls—and their cases are never heard again. Some say the laughter is Baldwyn Brightstide’s, still judging from the shadow of the throne.

0.5.1 Prominent NPCs of Viterra

p0.2 p0.24 p0.38 p0.14 Name	Role/Title	Motivation & Manner	Rumoured Quirk
Queen Veralyn Everblood	Warrior Queen of Viterra	Securing a contested throne through law and blade; haunted by her dead brother’s shadow, her Fenwood upbringing, and the knowledge that northern gold paid for her father’s murder.	Sleeps with a dagger under her pillow. Her crown has no jewels—only seals from conquered claims, each one cold to the touch. Still signs some charters as Duchess of Aberiel, a Vhasian title she refuses to surrender.
Justiciar Elodie Venn	Queen’s Justiciar	Raised from the fen marshes; defeats opponents legally and socially, leaving them ashamed.	Carries a writ signed in Baldwyn Brightstide’s blood as a lucky charm; has never lost a duel.
Baron Aldric	Disgraced turncloak	Stripped for oath-breaking during the succession crisis; patrols the northern marches to prove he still bleeds Viterran.	Wears his stripped baron’s belt as a sash; speaks only in legal precedent when agitated.
Ser Roran	Knight of the Queen’s household	A Vhasian prisoner ransomed by the Queen; serves out of loyalty, not obligation.	Never takes ransom. His left gauntlet is silver, etched with the Vhasian sun he once served.
Fen Reeve Cuthbert	Keeper of the dike guilds	Measures floods to atone for Fenwood sins and to ensure the Queen’s tax men do not drown in the same waters that took Lence.	Tally-rod notches from three floods; the next may be from a Vhasian raid he let pass to test the Queen’s resolve.
Master Advocate Halric	Legal duelist	Believes law is the only true weapon left; refuses succession sides, making everyone suspect him of playing both ends.	Has argued cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgos, and Ubral courts—and won all three using their own precedents against

them.

Sister Oria Custodian of the Lantern-Rites House Keeps the old ways alive on the border; her threshold confuses ill intent. Has never drawn a blade; keeps a bowl of Vhasian tears by her door.

Earl Morcar of the North Leader of the northern earls Recently forced to kneel after his levy was shattered at the Fenmoor; now watches for any sign that the Queen's resolve is softening. Carries a shard of Lence's cathedral glass in his pommel; whispers to it before every moot. Secretly funded the fanatics who killed King Wyllmot.

0.5.2 Names of Viterra

|p0.25|p0.25|p0.2|p0.2|

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Baldwyn	Veralyn	Everblood	<i>the Law-Giver</i>
Cuthbert	Elodie	Fenwood	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Roran	Oria	of the Scar	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Morcar	Aelfwyn	de la Marche	<i>the Hedge-Wise</i>
Leofric	Celandine	l'Argent	<i>the Silent</i>
Ghiro	Svanhild	Riven	<i>Ash-Banner</i>

(Reeve/Guild/Knight/Legal Advocate) Fen reeve with tally-rod speaking for dike guilds; river-carter syndic moving grain faster than rumor; justices of the peace settling disputes with careful pen—and a wary eye for Vhasian poison in the ink.

0.5.3 Using the Viterra Deck

Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer : 2–5 → 4 segments, 6–10 → 6 segments, J/Q/K → 8 segments, A → 10 segments.

Diamonds are codified outcomes (writs, charters, priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.

If any **Ace** appears, echo **hedge-law** motifs—boundaries blur like old scars, charters contradict like guilty consciences, precedent splinters like shaky oaths, and the careful web of legal authority shows its living cracks. Legal warfare escalates to physical conflict not as failure, but as the only language left when words run dry.

0.5.4 Spades — Places

Reeve, Guild, Knight, Legal Advocate

2. **Fen Causeway** — Stile with toll-rod and eel carts queueing; each reeve claims right under a different charter. Dueling advocates argue on platforms slick with river-mist. '[LAW]' '[TRADE]' *The causeway sinks an inch each year. The lawyers argue over whose fault it is—and whether the sinking is a sign from Lence's drowned kings.*
3. **Hedgerow Green** — In the Dales; bows strung under apple trees where justices of the peace hold court beneath makeshift arbors. Court duels permitted for matters of honor and old scores. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *The apple tree is called "the Hanging Judge." Its fruit tastes of iron—not from the soil, but from the Vhasian claimant hanged from its branches for poaching Queen's deer.*
4. **Beacon Hill** — Above the Highlands; fire-grate still warm from last winter's levy call, signal tower with semaphore arms for legal dispatches and military alerts. '[AUTHORITY]' '[TRAVEL]' *The hill has three beacons. One for Ubral raids. One for Vhasian incursions. One for paperwork—lit when the Queen's justiciars are lying.*
5. **Belworth Stairs** — Ferry ledgers gone damp with river-mist; three manors claim toll rights, writs in three different hands. '[LAW]' '[TRAVEL]' *The stairs were repaired last year. The Vhasian side uses a different measurement—and a different kind of truth.*
6. **Bloom Quarry** — Old iron-bloom turned drill yard; hammer echoes carry like war drums. Military contracts awarded through legal bidding wars. '[CRAFT]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The forge-reeve has never lost a contract. His opponents have a habit of vanishing the night before the bid—leaving only their seals behind, still warm.*
7. **Parish Maze** — Stone maze where three maps disagree; hedge-priest's vote decides tithe and freehold. Legal disputes settled by navigating correctly—or accepting the priest's blessing. '[LAW]' '[RIDDLE]' *The maze changes at night. The hedge-priest says that's God's will—and the lawyers say that's when the Vhasian smugglers move their goods.*
8. **Fairport Works** — Tideworks at the Dolmis mouth; customs writs in three languages flutter like wounded birds. Maritime law enforcement includes boarding actions where the Queen's men find Vhasian coins stamped with Viterran seals. '[TRADE]' '[AUTHORITY]' *One language is Utaran. One is Linn. One is for the smugglers—written in salt and silence.*
9. **Law Quarter** — Valora archives, oath-rooms, Hall of Dawning where precedent is birthed in ink and sealed with wax. Adjacent training grounds for legal advocates who practice strikes on pells wrapped in old charters. '[LAW]' '[KNOWLEDGE]' *The archives have a locked wing. The key is a legal argument no one has won—and no one dares to lose.*
10. **Counting Fields** — Tarlington beside muster ground; wagons load, ledgers mis-sum—sometimes from Vhasian poison slipped into the ink by desperate clerks. Auditors with quill-pens sharp as daggers. '[AUTHORITY]' '[LABOR]' *The auditors carry swords.*

They say it's for counting cattle. No one asks further—but they watch the hands that hold the pens.

J Dike Crown — Ring of turf and timber; brotherhood bells warn of flood and spies who move like water through the fen. Legal sanctuary for those fleeing court judgments—if they can outrun the reeve's wrath. '[COMMUNITY]' '[LAW]' *The sanctuary lasts for one tide. After that, the reeves can come—if they can find you before the Vhasian raiders do.*

Q Progress Camp — Queen's canvas palisade, banners stiff. Old courtiers plot advancement through legal maneuver and sanctioned duels—each bout a test of whether the throne is steel or silk. '[AUTHORITY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The camp moves every week. The lawsuits follow at a measured pace—each one a step closer to the Queen proving she is more than Fenwood's shadow.*

K Tilt-Yard — Hall of Dawning at first light; Dawn-knights drill clean, loyalties in contracts signed with careful pen. Legal challenges often end in trial by combat. '[COMBAT]' '[LAW]' *The sand is raked between duels. Sometimes the rake turns up old blood—or old oaths sworn on dying breath.*

A Highway Stone — Queen's milestone above the Dolmis road; three sheriffs post seals over hers, each claiming different jurisdiction. Territory disputes resolved through armed arbitration. '[AUTHORITY]' '[TRAVEL]' *The stone has been broken and reglued seven times. Each crack holds a forgotten compromise.*

0.5.5 Hearts — People & Factions

Federate, Mixed Court, Diaspora

2. **Fen Reeve** — Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds, remembers every flood-year's debts. Authorized to call local levies and levy blood-price if the papers do not add up. '[AUTHORITY]' '[COMMUNITY]' *His tally-rod has notches from three floods. The next notch may be from a Vhasian raid he let happen to test the Queen's resolve.*
3. **River Syndic** — Moves grain faster than rumor; knows which writs matter and which customs officials can be persuaded. Maintains armed merchant guards. '[TRADE]' '[STEALTH]' *His ledger has a watermark—a crown on one side, a sunburst on the other. He shows the right side to the right audience.*
4. **Parish Surveyor** — Three maps, one opinion—but the opinion changes with the wind and the weight of a Vhasian coin. Hedge-walks settle more disputes than courts. '[KNOWLEDGE]' '[LAW]' *His chain is exactly one rod long—but the rod changes length depending on who is paying.*
5. **Dawn Quartermaster** — Ledgers sharper than tongue; counts every farthing spent in the Queen's name. Legal authority over military supplies—and over the Queen's hesitation when the books do not balance. '[AUTHORITY]' '[LABOR]' *He once*

tracked a missing farthing to a Vhasian counting house. It was returned with interest, and a note in Vhasian script: "Next time, we take the whole sack."

6. **Levy Serjeant** — Dales bow calm, cider breath, memory keen for every loophole in the mustering laws. Commands armed civilians in legal enforcement actions. '[COMBAT]' '[LAW]' *His bowstring is made from a cancelled writ—one that promised peace and delivered only war. He says it shoots truer now.*
 7. **Cleric-Pair** — Light preacher versus Everflame canon lawyer; debates decide tithe law. Religious law carries weight in secular courts—because even kings fear a god who keeps score. '[SOCIAL]' '[LAW]' *They share a room at the inn. They have not spoken outside court in seven years—but they still pass the salt with care.*
 8. **Fairport Shipwright** — Dolmis cousins; skiff carries more secrets than cargo. Expert in maritime law and naval combat—where the truth is in the hold and the lie in the manifest. '[CRAFT]' '[STEALTH]' *Her skiff has no name. The customs clerks have given it three—and each one is a different kind of truth.*
 9. **Fenwood Comptroller** — Conjures wagons with a signature, silence with a seal. Tracks every debt owed to the crown. Legal authority over taxation—and over the Queen's guilt when the books do not balance. '[AUTHORITY]' '[TRADE]' *His quill is a dagger. He has used it as both—to write, and to remind himself what happens when the ink runs dry.*
 10. **Queen's Justiciar** — Law on the road, polite as a noose. Bearing three kings' judgments and a purse full of pardons. Authorized to conduct trial by combat. '[LAW]' '[AUTHORITY]' *She has never lost a legal duel. Her opponents have a tendency to fall down stairs—and then lie very still.*
- J **Border Routier** — Reads ledgers as ambushes and writes them as tribute. Serves two crowns, collects from both. Expert in frontier law enforcement—where the ledger is often the first thing to burn. '[STEALTH]' '[TRADE]' *His loyalty is to the highest bidder. The Queen and the Vhasian claimant are currently in a bidding war—and the currency is lives.*
- Q **Warrior Queen** — Crown on helm, sword at side; the weight is familiar. Final arbiter in legal duels—where she wins not by being right, but by being willing to go further. '[AUTHORITY]' '[LAW]' *Her crown has no jewels—only seals. Each seal is a conquered claim, still warm from the hand that took it. Still signs some charters as Duchess of Aberiel, a reminder that she has not forgotten her Vhasian title.*
- K **Crown Council** — Fenwood dukes, guild envoys, abbots; weighing grain against glory and the shadow of Baldwyn Brightside against them all. Legal battles fought through proxy advocates. '[POLITICS]' '[LAW]' *The council has a standing rule: no weapons within the chamber. The advocates have found seventeen loopholes—and eighteen reasons to break it.*

- A **Master Advocate Halric** — Silver-tongued legal warrior who settles disputes through verbal duels that can end in physical combat. Keeper of legal combat traditions. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *He has won cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgos, and Ubral courts using their own precedents—and their own blades when the words ran out.*

0.5.6 Clubs — Complications/Threats

Hedge, Crown, and Claim

2. **Dike Breach** — Black-rain; the wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown. The water carries peat and the ghost of Lence's last stand. Legal liability demands armed enforcement. '[DISASTER]' '[LAW]' *The river argues back, carrying old deeds and screams downstream.*
3. **Feast Clash** — Light versus Everflame processions collide; shutters slam, writs fly. Justices of the peace called to settle which holy day takes precedence. Honor disputes may require legal duels. '[SOCIAL]' '[LAW]' *The processions take different routes now. The clash was not an accident—it was an invitation.*
4. **Quiet Tolls** — Sprout on the Queen's Highway. Escorts sniff traps laid by smugglers and the Queen's own doubts. Sheriffs argue rights; customs officials demand duties no one knew existed. '[AUTHORITY]' '[TRAVEL]' *The toll posts have fresh paint from a Vhasian claimant's keep—and it's still wet.*
5. **Audit Freeze** — Counting-house freezes cargo. The ink was slipped with Vhasian poison by desperate clerks. Queen's seal versus old writs; auditors with quill-pens sharp as daggers. '[AUTHORITY]' '[DEBT]' *The auditors work by candlelight. The shadows on the walls look like gallows.*
6. **Border Snarl** — Three courts arrest the same hay-cart. It's not about the hay; it's about whose charter was signed with cleaner hands. Bribes flow like wine—and Vhasian silver. Frontier justice involves armed standoffs. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *The hay is from a field that was Vhasian last spring. Now it's Viterran. The field hasn't moved—but the souls working it have.*
7. **Isle Refusal** — Theona withholds levy. The quays choke on rumor and the old curses the Three Greens mutter when Viterran boots touch their soil. Ships idle while lawyers debate maritime law. '[POLITICS]' '[LAW]' *Theona's envoy carries a hawthorn branch—not of peace, but of warning.*
8. **Delta Spat** — Fairport versus Marcott customs. Barges stack three deep; merchants pick sides for old scores. Inspectors examine every manifest for truth or the Vhasian tell. '[TRADE]' '[LAW]' *The magnifying glasses reveal truth—and also start fires. Both are useful.*
9. **Routier Arrears** — A free-company flips unless someone pays. It's about the name on the ledger and whether it's written in Vhasian silver or Queen's trust. Legal debts

enforced through hired swords. '[DEBT]' '[COMBAT]' *The routiers have a list. Your name is on it—or will be by sunset.*

10. **Salt Pinch** — Import spikes. Bakers barricade for old scores, not just profit. The Queen's promise tastes like thin gruel because of ash from the burned Vhasian customs post. Riots brew. '[WEATHER]' '[SOCIAL]' *The salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned Vhasian customs post—and it still smells like smoke.*
- J **Dawn Recall** — Escort pulled to a flood-struck parish. The writ argues with the river, and the river argues back, carrying the Queen's doubts. Justices demand inquiry into who neglected the dikes. '[AUTHORITY]' '[TRAVEL]' *The escorts are back in a week. They bring new writs—and fewer men.*
- Q **Aberielist Intrigue** — Royalist seals in wrong hands. Conspirators plot in quiet places where the law feels thin. Treason charges carry death penalty in legal duels. '[POLITICS]' '[LAW]' *The seals are from a dead duke—and the duke's ghost is said to approve. Or to weep.*
- K **Levy Call-Up** — Dalesmen mustered. Wagons seized “for the realm,” conscription writs signed with careful pen. Families left to tend fields alone. Legal authority backed by armed force. '[AUTHORITY]' '[COMBAT]' *The conscription writs have a clause: “void if Belworth freezes.” The river is still warm.*
- A **Legal Duel Challenge** — Master Advocate Halric issues a formal challenge. Refuse and lose legal standing; accept and risk life and fortune in court-yard combat. The winner takes all legally. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *The challenge is written on both sides of the parchment—and there is no blank space to refuse.*

0.5.7 Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

Charter, Right, Escort

2. **Ferry Priority** — Belworth crossing (once); a horn blown by a Vhasian defector now serving the Queen. Legal right of way backed by armed escort. '[TRAVEL]' *The priority token is a writ signed by both banks. One side's ink is newer; the other still smells of Vhasian smoke.*
3. **Dike Allotment** — Brotherhood labor granted, if three clerks can look past old scores. Work performed under legal contract with military oversight. '[LABOR]' *The allotment includes a clause: “as tides permit.” The reeve decides what the tides permit.*
4. **Market License** — Valora's square, if a guild nod is enough. Legal protection from merchant guild enforcement. '[TRADE]' *The license is written on vellum from a Vhasian abbey. The irony is noted.*
5. **Dawn Escort** — Four lances at dawn. Their presence keeps lesser men from troubling you. Legal authority to enforce your writs. '[AUTHORITY]' *The lances are from the Fenwood armory—and the Fenwood dukes have their own plans.*

6. **River Charter** — Guaranteed haul on a grain artery, if the weather permits. Legal right protected by river patrol. '[TRAVEL]' *The charter is stamped with a seal that looks like a crown—or a sunburst. No one can agree.*
 7. **Map Correction** — A hedge moves; the border shifts with the truth. Lawsuits bloom. A new survey can make or break a fortune overnight. '[LAW]' *The surveyors carry chains and swords. The swords are for when the chains disagree.*
 8. **Customs Seal** — Fairport for Dolmis cargo. Legal immunity from customs enforcement. '[TRADE]' *The seal is a wax crab. It pinches when pressed—and it remembers the hand that shaped it.*
 9. **Thing Ruling** — Sharp local bite; appeals run swifter than oaths. Court decisions enforceable by local levy. '[LAW]' *The ruling is carved on an oar. Break the oar, and the ruling breaks with it.*
 10. **Salt Allotment** — Winter depot; the Queen's writ opens doors. The right connections ensure the best salt reaches the right tables. '[TRADE]' *The salt is from a pan worked by Ubral exiles. They still count in clan measure.*
- J **Wardship** — A minor fen-keep. Legal guardianship with military authority—and the quiet hope that the child is worth the trust. '[AUTHORITY]' *The ward is a child with a seal ring older than the kingdom.*
- Q **Queen's Audience** — Private; her questions strike like thrusts. Royal decree carries immediate enforcement power. '[AUTHORITY]' *The audience lasts one hour. The paperwork lasts a generation.*
- K **Ducal Warrant** — Fenwood to enforce customs. The parchment carries weight in any court—and old power bows before new. '[AUTHORITY]' *The warrant is signed in blood—or ink that looks like blood. The difference matters at trial.*
- A **Duel Sanction** — Right to challenge in legal combat; the Queen's seal makes it official. The winner takes all legally; the loser learns the cost of doubting the Queen's peace. '[LAW]' '[COMBAT]' *The sanction is a coin. Heads you duel, tails your opponent chooses the weapon.*

0.5.8 Viterra Mechanics

Core Timers

Border-Lace [4] Tracks competing legal claims in a locale. Starts when contradictory papers are invoked. **Ticks when:**

[nosep]

- A second (or third) valid writ is presented for the same right (+1).
- A player steps up Position using Hedge-Law Momentum (+1).

- A Vhasian or local authority disputes a crown document (+1).

At 4: The dispute escalates immediately to a riot, duel, or jurisdictional void. All social rolls in the locale suffer +1 DV until a ruling is imposed by force or decree.

Succession's Shadow [6] Tracks the erosion of Queen Veralyn's legitimacy from the ghosts of Baldwyn Brightside's death and the lingering resentment of the northern earls and eastern barons. **Ticks when:**

[nosep]

- A document bearing Baldwyn's seal surfaces (+1).
- A northern earl or eastern baron publicly defies the crown (+1).
- A legal duel is lost by the Queen's champion (+1).
- The GM spends 2 SB to introduce a witness, forgery, or rumor tied to the crisis (+1).

At 3: Viterran officials and allies suffer −1 die to social rolls (they doubt the throne's stability). **At 6:** A serious claimant emerges—perhaps a northern earl with a forged charter, or a Vhasian pretender promising to restore the old border. The Queen must win a legal duel or face a general levy against her authority.

Queen's Peace [Front] Once per session, if the party resolves a cross-border dispute in the Queen's favor without bloodshed, advance this front. If they escalate violence or validate a Vhasian claim, tick **Succession's Shadow** instead.

Status & Environment

Hedge-Law Momentum When a valid *writ*, *charter*, or *warrant* is presented in the proper parish with dry ink and unbroken seal, step **Position** up one category on social or logistical actions in that locale for the scene. The first contradiction starts the **Border-Lace [4]** timer.

Beacon & Bell Chain If two adjacent *beacons* or *brotherhood bells* are under your influence and lit for the correct reason, convert one **Club** draw into a travel delay for *others* while the party proceeds with improved **Effect** for movement and logistics. The signal draws scrutiny; the GM may bank 1 SB tied to local authority.

River-Right Window At a ferry, tidework, or customs stair, play any **Diamond** tied to crossings or seals to open a short *window of lawful passage*: one convoy passes uninspected, or one cargo clears at priority. The window closes immediately if a storm, audit, or levy card is revealed.

Legal Duel Protocol When legal disputes cannot be resolved through argument, parties may challenge each other to a duel. The winner's position becomes legally binding. Requires proper sanction and seconds (see **Duel Sanction** Diamond). If either party lacks a sanction, the duel is treated as assault under crown law.

Vhasian Claims Any Viterran noble with land across the Belworth may invoke a *Ducal Warrant* to attempt to collect rents or enforce judgments in Vhasia. Doing so starts a **Border Snarl** complication (or ticks **Border-Lace**), as Vhasian claimants are unlikely to cooperate. The Queen's own Vhasian title (Duchess of Aberiel) adds a layer of irony—and suspicion.

Theona Contest The Warrior Queen's authority over the Three Greens is nominal. Any attempt to enforce Viterran law in Theona triggers an **Isle Refusal** complication; local taboos may twist the law into knots.

The Succession's Shadow Any legal dispute touching on inheritance, legitimacy, or royal authority is automatically one step more volatile. The GM may spend 1 SB to introduce a witness, document, or rumor related to Baldwyn Brightstide's death or the northern earls' secret funding of King Wyllmot's murderers.

Procedures

Courtroom Mini-Game (Fast Trial)

[nosep]

1. Lay three stones: **Precedent**, **Equity**, **Force**.
2. Argue a point (roll Wits + Sway vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one stone to your side. On a miss, the opposing advocate gains *Citation Edge*.
3. Win two stones to secure a temporary **Court Ruling** (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
4. *Halric's Interjection* (2 SB): flip **Precedent**, but start **Whispered Precedent** [2] with the losing side.

Cross-Border Tensions (Fast Pressure)

[nosep]

- Two opposed timers: *Queen's Peace* vs. *Border Fire* (size by highest rank in the seed).
- Each leg, choose *Viterran Road* (safe, slow), *Vhasian Claim* (fast, risky), or **Ubral Pass** (hidden, costly).
- Advantage: Vhasian Claim → Viterran Road (shortcuts), Ubral Pass → Vhasian Claim (concealment), Viterran Road → Ubral Pass (supplies).
- Spend a **Ducal Warrant** to shift one segment from *Border Fire* to *Queen's Peace*.

Start-of-Scene Rumors Roll **1d6** at the start of a Viterran scene:

[nosep]

1. **Wrong Wax:** A rival's seals softened; +1d to forgeries this scene.
2. **Empty Beacon:** Tower unmanned; travel faster, scrutiny harsher.
3. **Dawn-Lane Cleared:** First convoy action gains +1 Position.
4. **Clerk's Wedding:** Filings delayed; first petition ignores *Audit Freeze*.
5. **Fen High Water:** Ferries slow; river-charters count double value today.
6. **Mask at Progress:** Someone uses your name at court; +1d to social opens, +1 SB banked by GM.

Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

[nosep]

- **Bread to the Hedge:** Crumble a crust at a parish boundary stone. Ignore the first *Border Snarl* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Writ:** Tie a single knot in a charter's ribbon. Cancel *Audit Freeze* or take -1 die on your next legal argument (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the River:** Whisper a dead claimant's name into the Belworth. Gain +1 Effect when arguing against their heir's claim this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen's Justiciar. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **The Brightstide Candle:** Light a candle in memory of King Baldwyn before a difficult legal proceeding. On a roll that includes a 1, you may reroll that die once. If you still fail, the GM banks 1 SB. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Strain Budget (SB) Spends

Minor (1 SB)

[nosep]

- **Exposure:** Crown officials or rival advocates take notice.
- **Noise:** Writ-runners or levy guards are alerted.
- **Trace:** Trackers or customs inspectors mark your route.
- **Delay:** Lose a favorable court date or legal window.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource timer.

Moderate (2 SB)

[nosep]

- **Alarm Raised:** The Queen's Justiciar or a fen reeve responds.
- **Position Lost:** Legal challenge or river closure costs you advantage.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival claimant or border routier arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A key item becomes Compromised or Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious (3 SB)

[nosep]

- **Reinforcements:** Dawn-knights, levy forces, or Vhasian routiers arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool or weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** Writ voided, duel declared, or levy called.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark Fatigue 1, Harm 1, or an appropriate Condition.

Major (4+ SB)

[nosep]

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** The Warrior Queen, Crown Council, or Master Advocate Halric intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** Dike breaks, river floods, or court erupts.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine or arcane forces manifest—an omen appears, a blessing is lost, or a curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story reframes your objectives unexpectedly.

Region-Specific SB Conversions

[nosep]

- **Hedge Shift (1 SB):** A boundary stone shifts; increase DV by 1 for navigation or legal rolls this scene.
- **Citation War (2 SB):** Increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a *◊orrecallapastruling*).
- **Seal Crack (3+ SB):** A writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
- **Succession's Whisper (2 SB, Viterra only):** A document or rumor tied to Baldwyn Brightstide's death surfaces. The GM must answer one yes/no question about royal legitimacy or introduce a related complication. Earl Morcar's involvement may also be hinted.

Boss Seeds (Three-Phase Foes)

The Violet Clerk (Master of Counter-Seals) *Phases:* Produce Earlier Patent → Split the Writ → Seal Fast.

Cracks: A **Queen's Audience** overrules his seal; a **Duel Sanction** forces personal combat; a **Map Correction** voids his boundary claim.

The Thorn Captain (Queen's Quiet Hand) *Phases:* Queenspeace Zone → Duel Warrant → Swap the Field.

Cracks: A **Map Correction** reveals a loophole; a **Dike Allotment** lets you claim the field as "flood zone"; a **Border Routier** testifies to the Queen's favor.

The Saffron Abbess (Keeper of Bell-Law) *Phases:* Wrong Hour → Bless or Damn → Mixed Tribunal.

Cracks: A **Queen's Justiciar** invokes crown supremacy; a **Border Routier** bribes her bell-ringer; a **Thing Ruling** from Theona forces her to recuse.

The Brightstide Claimant (Pretender) *Phases:* Produce the Lost Charter → Rally the Northern Earls → March on Valora.

Cracks: Find proof the charter is a forgery; convince Earl Morcar to stand with the Queen (or expose his role in Wyllmot's death); survive a legal duel with the claimant's champion.

Legendary Sites & Trials

Belworth Stairs Ordeal Cross the river without a charter. On success, you prove possession is nine-tenths of the law. On failure, the river takes your name and cargo. (Wits + Survival vs. DV 5.)

Hall of Dawning Vigil Spend a night in the tilt-yard. At dawn, recall a forgotten precedent; gain a one-use *Precedent Edge* (+1 die in any court). The ghost of a dead duelist may challenge you to a legal dream-duel. (Spirit + Lore vs. DV 4.)

Hedge-Moot at Dusk Settle a boundary dispute by walking the hedge. Each successful navigation test (Wits + Survival) clears 1 segment from a **Border Snarl** timer. A miss plants the thorn of a future feud (advance **Border-Lace** by 1).

0.5.9 Lore Echoes

[nosep]

- **The Hedge-Seal (The Dike Covenant):** Covenant judges in the eastern parishes adjudicate river tolls and inheritance. They carry iron scales and a copy of the *Hedge-Law Tables*—each page stained by a different flood. A ruling is binding in both Viterra and the Vhasian marches, but any party who lies before them forfeits their right to appeal. The Warrior Queen has granted them a charter; the Fenwood dukes consider them spies.
- **Saint Cuthbert of the Fen (The Traveler):** A legendary reeve who walked the flooded dikes during the Great Storm, lighting every beacon by hand. His shrines are stiles and bridge posts; travellers who touch the iron ring and speak a destination find the road holds firm. The fen folk leave offerings of eels at his cairns.
- **The Cog-Cults of the Northern Hills (The Clockwork Monad):** Secret fraternities of millers and surveyors near the Ubral border believe law is a machine that can be perfected. They meet in abandoned watermills, measuring boundaries with brass chains and reciting the *Canons of Proportion*. The Everflame calls them heretics; the Queen's justiciars ignore them.
- **The Salt Sworn of the Eastern Coast (The Pale Shepherd):** Along the Dolmis shore, a syncretic cult tends to the drowned. They build cairns of salt stone and leave no offerings—only the names of the lost, carved into driftwood. Temple of Light missions sent to suppress them have been found adrift with no crew and a single name carved into the mast: *Oblivion*.

0.5.10 Cross-Region Hooks

[nosep]

- **Ubral (Stone & Oath):** A **Ducal Warrant** acts as a *Guest-Token* once at a clan hearth. Starts a **Feud Rekindled** tick if you collect tolls twice in a tenday.
- **Thepyrgos (Synod Law):** A **Queen's Audience** can suspend a synod interdict. Starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.

- **Vhasia (Fractured Sun): A Duel Sanction** is recognized on the Pont-du-Tithe. A rival abbey can turn it into *Parlement Divided* on a Club draw. The Queen’s own Vhasian title (Duchess of Aberiel) may be used as leverage—or as a weapon against her.
- **Theona (No Ninth): Ferry Priority** overrides a local taboo once. If the Ninth custom is in play, the writ “forgets” one clause on use (GM banks 1 SB).

0.5.11 Conspiracy Flourishes

[nosep]

- **Hedge-Moots at Dusk:** Parish elders “trim hedges” while trading sealed whispers.
- **Cipher Roses:** Folded writs stamped with thorn-petals; one petal missing marks a false clause.
- **Mirror Hours:** Beacons flash lawful signals—reversed for those who know the counter-code.
- **Eel-Letters:** Oiled parchment smuggled in eel-baskets; ink runs in water, truth does not.
- **Quiet Steel, Quieter Quills:** Dawn-knights duel at first light; advocates settle three duels before breakfast with ink alone.
- **Progress Masks:** Courtiers wear legal devices as masque motifs (seal, chain, beacon) to signal faction at a glance.
- **Bell Penance:** A single off-hour peal grants amnesty to those who confess a clause before the twelfth echo.
- **The Brightside Prayer:** Whispering the dead king’s name before a legal proceeding is said to turn the judge’s heart—or curse the speaker. Some say Earl Morcar still whispers it each night.

Patronage & Power

In Viterra, power flows through the careful application of law—but beneath every charter runs the threat of steel. The Warrior Queen maintains authority through a combination of military might and legal precision, but the throne is fragile. The old duchies and local officials wield influence through knowledge of hedge-law and ancient custom. The true power lies not in the documents alone, but in the will to enforce them when the parchment fails.

For the GM: Patronage in Viterra revolves around legal documents, local rights, and the ability to command respect from institutions still finding their post-imperial identity. Rewards often take the form of writs, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence—but they can be challenged, stolen, or voided, especially if they bear the dead king's seal.

[nosep]

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, charters) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival duchies and Vhasian claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the courts, parishes, and muster grounds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.
- When legal conflicts escalate beyond words, transition naturally to physical confrontation with appropriate stakes.
- Introduce the **Succession's Shadow** as a recurring complication: old loyalties, forged documents, the ghost of Baldwyn Brightstide, and the secret funding of King Wyllmot's murder can upend any legal certainty.

In Viterra, your papers are your power. And your power determines whether you rule or are ruled. But when words fail, steel speaks—and the law says both are valid. The Queen's Peace is a contract. She has signed it in blood. Will you?

Thepyrgos

City of a Thousand Stairs.

“Thepyrgos is a vertical labyrinth of stair-rights, rope-guilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. The Synod rules with the delicacy of a brick wrapped in velvet – they hate unsanctioned magic, but they adore infrastructure. Beneath the city, the Unfinished Stair waits for those who ask a question the Synod cannot answer.”

— The Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? Flatbread with olive oil and a boiled egg – if you are a clerk. If you are a student, bread and water. If you are a professor, bread, water, and a single fig. The fig is a status symbol. The status is “I have not been audited.”

What does a child learn before they can walk? To read a bell schedule. Thepyrgos runs on bells – dawn bells, market bells, curfew bells, trial bells. A child who cannot read the bells cannot cross the city without a guardian. A child without a guardian is a child who will be sold to the university for dissection.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their step count. Thepyrgos has a thousand stairs. A stranger who counts them aloud is either a pilgrim or a spy. A stranger who climbs them in silence is either a native or a ghost.

What is the most common crime? Unsanctioned magic. The Synod licenses every spell cast within the walls. An unlicensed cantrip is a misdemeanour. An unlicensed healing is a felony. An unlicensed summoning is a death sentence – not for the caster, who will be executed, but for the summoned, who will be bound to the city’s foundation as a “structural consultant.”

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Silent Stair is not silent. It whispers the confessions of dead scholars – their secrets recorded in the stone. The Chain-Lanterns listen. They do not share.

Where do people go when they die? To the catacombs beneath the university. The catacombs are a library of bones. Each skeleton is labelled with the scholar’s name, their thesis, and the date of their death. The unlabelled bones are the ones who died before they could finish. They are still writing.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You submit a “retraction” to the Synod’s Committee on Ethical Correction. The retraction is published in the public square, read aloud by a herald, and witnessed by three notaries. The fee is 50 silver. The shame is free.

What is the most important festival? The Convocation of the Steps (summer solstice). Every citizen climbs the thousand stairs to the upper citadel. The Archon

reads the names of the dead from the past year. The names are carved into the steps as they are read. The steps are getting crowded.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Archon is a fraud. He never passed the Synod's examination. His degree was purchased from a disgraced dean whose signature is forged on every document. The forger is still alive. They live in the catacombs. They have the original quill.*

0.6 Thepyrgos — “The City of Unfinished Proofs”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every stair is a question. Every answer is a proof. The Ninth and the Witness argue over whose record holds the truth.*

The Archon (Elite): “Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built—it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom. But the stairs remember more than the living. They remember the ones who never came down.”

Bell-Runner (Commoner): “I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city’s mood better than any lord—three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming. But on the ninth bell, the stairs themselves answer.”

Genre / Mood: Scholarly vertical city, labyrinthine imperial bureaucracy, coastal peninsular folk horror in the hinterlands, metaphysical war between memory and forgetting.

Starting Location: The Synod Hall at dusk. Gold-glass mosaics glitter as a Matriarch reads a scroll aloud. “The Beacon Crown sees traitors in the smoke. A child’s talent was surrendered to the Commissary last night. Find the informer—or the next stair seized will be yours. And if you hear a stair creak where none exists, do not turn around. The Ninth is counting.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Thepyrgos is both realm and city, built on the bones of the drowned **Astroegro Empire**. The capital rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs above the Dolmis shore—but the stairs are not stone. They are *fossilized vertebrae*, the spine of a leviathan that Khemesh dragged under when the last emperor broke a covenant older than the sea. Once a Utaran province, now a nation unto itself, Thepyrgos is famed for its universities, libraries, and debating synods, where precedent and philosophy weigh as much as pikes or coin.

The Astroegro were a human civilization of formidable magic, the ancient rivals of the **Valewood's Empire of Leaves**. Their ruins litter the hills and swamps south of the city, and their legacy haunts every threshold. When the Empire of Leaves fell, **Lethai-thora** refugees—high elves who had served as archivists and lore-keepers—fled across the Black River and were granted sanctuary in Thepyrgos. Generations later, their descendants still walk the city's tiers, their silver hair and ink-stained fingers a quiet reminder of a pact older than the synod. Many now hold chairs at the university, tend the forbidden archives, or secretly serve the Witness or the Ninth.

Outside the city, the countryside is a rugged coastal landscape of limestone hills, olive groves, and whitewashed villages—but the weather is warmer, wetter, and the valleys are choked with reed-filled marshes. This is the land of the **Hyro** people, the surviving descendants of the Astroegro. The Hyro carry the fracture of their ancestors in their blood. A child born in the hills might dream in geometries that do not exist. A farmer might hear the stones whispering in a language no living throat can shape. The **Chain-Lanterns** and other Witch-Hunter Commissariats ruthlessly patrol these villages, using posted warrants, candle-smoke tests, and stair-seizures to identify and kidnap children with arcane talent. The Hyro have learned to offer *substitutes*—a memory, a false name, a lock of hair—at crossroads, hoping the Hollow accepts the tribute.

In the university's forbidden tiers, the **Witness** and the **Ninth** fight a proxy war via fraternal orders and occult mystery cults. The Witness wants the **Astroegro Vaults** *remembered* but sealed; the Ninth wants them *opened*, to trigger a Great Unlearning that would erase the concept of record from the world. No provenance would remain. The Hollow would go unanswered. The Witness would have nothing to inscribe. The Ninth would become the only law: *forgetting*. No one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks—gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

What you notice first: The endless chime of bells from different tiers, never quite in sync. The smell of brine, olive oil, and candle wax. The way locals glance at the sky when a child coughs—and then at the nearest crossroads. The quiet grace of the Lethai-thora archivists, who never seem to blink.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns offer safe conduct to those who give names that ring false on the test stairs. But worse: never ask a question of a stair that has no end. The Ninth is listening, and it will answer.

Regional Mood: Stairs, Bells, and the Argument of Patrons

Here, every ascent is a plea and every descent a confession. Thepyrgos the city is a vertical labyrinth of stair-rights, rope-guilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. Thepyrgos the province is a haunted countryside of hidden talent and state-sanctioned abduction. The Hyro keep their arcane children in root cellars and haylofts, praying the hunters take the neighbor’s instead. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university’s forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors. The Lethai-thora maintain the great archives, but they are divided—some serve the Witness as faithful recorders, others whisper to the Ninth in darkened scriptoria. And in the ruins of the Astroegro, something still ticks—gears of black glass, locked doors that hum, and the occasional survivor with eyes like burning tar who speaks of a pressure from below.

Geographic Integration

Thepyrgos is landlocked on three sides by Viterra, separated by the Black River and the Belmont Marshes. The marshy lowlands breed strange fogs and rarer creatures, and the border is porous—Viterran hedge-courts and Thepyrgos synods argue jurisdiction over every flooded farmstead. To the northeast, a short boat ride from Fairport (Viterra) across the Belworth estuary brings travelers to Marcott in Vhasia, making Thepyrgos a quiet but crucial link in the riverine trade between the fractured sun-kingdom and the imperial remnant. The city itself controls the **Astroegro Straits**—the narrow sea passage between the Dolmis and the Amaranthine—and maintains a few small colonies on the western coast of Hyaar, where olive oil and wine are exchanged for eastern silks and spices. Those colonies are run by exiled scholars and retired Chain-Lanterns, and they are said to be even more paranoid than the mother city.

Prominent NPCs of Thepyrgos

p0.2p0.25p0.3p0.15	Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
	Archon Konstantinos	Ruler of the city, elected by the wards	Balance the synod, the guilds, and the Commissariat	He wears a key around his neck; no one knows what it opens—or that it opens the Ninth’s Vault.
	Matriarch Eleni	Synod primate, head of the Temple of Light’s synod	Keep the Everflame from reclaiming the province	She speaks once a session; when she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.
	Commissary Kyrillos	Chain-Lantern commander	Purge all untutored magic from the province	His lantern shows not only latent talent but also the bearer’s greatest fear. He refuses to look into it himself.

Sofia Bell-Runner (commoner exemplar) Outrun the hunters and protect the hidden gifted She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white—a hunter she could not outrun.

Nomophylax Zoe Law-scholar, master of citations Reform the synod from within She has never lost a case; her opponents have a habit of vanishing into the Unfinished Stair.

The Lighthouse-Patriarch Reclusive seer of the Beacon Crown Steer the city through the coming storm He has no eyes—only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the faces of those whose names the Ninth holds.

Keeper Lian (Lethai-thora) High Archivist of the Library of Keys Preserve the Astroegro records and keep the Ninth's cult from the deepest vaults She has not spoken aloud in twenty years. She writes on water. The water never freezes.

Names of Thepyrgos

Inspired by the southern peninsulas and the Aegean coast: clear vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a stair, a tower, or a village. Lethai-thora names are longer, more flowing, often ending in -iel, -ael, -ir.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Konstantinos	Eleni	Skalas	<i>the Stair-Wise</i>
Dimitris	Zoe	Platanos	<i>the Unseen</i>
Kyrillos	Sofia	Raptis	<i>Bell-Sworn</i>
Nikolas	Anastasia	Laskaris	<i>the Accursed</i>
Leonidas	Irini	Makris	<i>Ash-Finger</i>
Stephanos	Fotini	Koutroulis	<i>the Silent</i>
Aerendil	Lian	Thoraen	<i>Archivist</i>

(Tower/Stair/Sea-wall) Pilgrim's Stair zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; Tower Quarter with family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges.

Spades — Places

- Pilgrim's Stair** — Zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; ascent as devotion. '[TRAVEL]' '[RITUAL]' *Every hundredth step has a bell. Pilgrims ring once for mercy, twice for memory. The ninth bell has no clapper.*

3. **Tower Quarter** — Family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges; vertical neighborhoods. '[SOCIAL]' *The lowest rung of each ladder is painted red—a mark of the rope-guild's claim. The rope-guild's scroll is written in disappearing ink.*
 4. **Chain-Barbican** — Harbor gate; capstans ready to raise the boom at horn's call. '[AUTHORITY]' *The capstan pins are carved from the thighbones of executed smugglers. The bones still warm in your hand.*
 5. **Blue Cistern** — Under the forum; cool echo, strict tally; water as law. '[MAGIC]' '[PROOF]' *The water tastes of copper and old prayers. Drink deep, and you may forget a formula—but the water will remember your face.*
 6. **Ropeyard Terrace** — Cranes walk cargo up slope by treadwheel; muscle and machinery. '[LABOR]' *The treadwheel operators sing in eights. The ninth beat is always silent—that is when the Stair moves.*
 7. **Storm-Wall Arcades** — Wind shrieks through arched galleries; defense as architecture. '[WEATHER]' *The wind carries voices from the last siege. Some say they're warnings. Others say they're the Ninth rehearsing.*
 8. **Beacon Crown** — Ring of watchtowers signaling along the Dolmis; eyes of the city. '[TRAVEL]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The beacons burn juniper and saltpeter. Black smoke means fire; white smoke means hunters. Green smoke means the Stair is hungry.*
 9. **Library of Keys** — Archive vaults; shelves locked by rung and rite; knowledge as power. '[MAGIC]' '[SECRET]' *The keys are graded by the import of what they lock. The ninth key opens nothing—and everything. It is kept in a box that has no lid.*
 10. **Siege Court** — Test ramp and scarred stones; war never far from peace. '[COMBAT]' *The ramp's stones are stained with lamp oil and regret. Practice charges end in the cistern—or the Unfinished Stair.*
- J **Ladder Monastery** — Perched on a needle of rock; monks climb toward truth. '[RITUAL]' *The monks never speak. They write commandments in chalk on the rungs. The ninth rung has no chalk—only a smear of ash.*
- Q **Synod Hall** — Gold-glass mosaics; judgment audible at a whisper's distance. '[LAW]' *The acoustics are enchanted. A lie told here echoes twice—once in the liar's voice, once in truth's. The Ninth's lies echo only once.*
- K **Archon's Citadel** — Acropolis peak; mirror tiles glare like noon's justice. '[AUTHORITY]' *The mirrors were a gift from Kahfagia. They show not the sea, but the faces of those who bear the archive's mark—and sometimes a stair that was not there before.*
- A **The Unfinished Stair** — A hidden flight that appears only to those who have asked a question the Synod cannot answer. '[THRESHOLD]' '[MYSTERY]' *The stairs have no end. Each step is a different year. At the top, the Ninth and the Witness are playing knucklebones with forgotten names.*

(**Archon/Synod/Guild**) Bell-runner child whose feet know every stair by heart; Master of Ropes with palms like oak, voice like a whistle.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bell-Runner** — Child whose feet know every stair by heart; speed as currency. ‘[STEALTH]’ *She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she has outrun; her hair is a thicket. One knot is white—a hunter she could not outrun.*
3. **Master of Ropes** — Palms like oak, voice like a whistle; guild head of lifters. ‘[LABOR]’ *He lost two fingers to a frayed line. He keeps them in a jar as a warning. The jar is on the ninth shelf.*
4. **Icon-Smith** — Portable shrine, temper about pigment; faith in detail. ‘[CRAFT]’ *His pigments are ground from stolen icons. He calls it recycling the divine. The Ninth calls it preparation.*
5. **Wall Strategos** — Drills levies on the test ramp; defense as daily ritual. ‘[COMBAT]’ *She lost a son to a Linn raid. She trains orphans now—and keeps a list. The list has nine names.*
6. **Chain-Keeper** — Harbor boom; hates “surprises” at dusk; order as obsession. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *His bell never rings the same note twice. He says the tide changes its mind. The Ninth changes its tone.*
7. **Oath-Examiner** — Weighs words like iron; notary of truth and consequence. ‘[LAW]’ *She carries a scale with one pan empty. The empty pan is for lies. When the Ninth speaks, both pans tip.*
8. **Archive Sister (Lethai-thora)** — Key to the “forbidden rung”; keeper of dangerous knowledge. ‘[SECRET]’ *Her left eye is milk-white—a cost for reading a cursed shelf. The shelf was a stair in a past life.*
9. **Salt-Fish Syndic** — Warehouse queen of the quays; profit in preservation. ‘[TRADE]’ *Her salt is cut with ground bone meal. The fish stay fresh—and quiet. The bones were from a stair.*
10. **Nomophylax** — Law-scholar whose citations close mouths; precedent as weapon. ‘[LAW]’ *He has never lost a case. His opponents have a habit of vanishing. The Unfinished Stair has a new step.*
- J **Palikar Captain** — Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy; strength in motion. ‘[COMBAT]’ *His shield is painted with a ladder—each rung a battle he survived. The ninth rung is blank.*
- Q **Matriarch of the Ladder** — Synod primate; calm as stone, wisdom in height. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *She speaks once a session. When she does, the bells listen. She has never spoken the ninth word.*

K **The Archon** — Elected, entrenched, counting bells; ruler of the ascent. '[AUTHORITY]' *He wears a key around his neck. No one knows what it opens. The key is a stair.*

A **Lighthouse-Patriarch** — Reclusive seer; said to steer beacons in storms. '[MYSTERY]' *He has no eyes—only mirrors where his eyes should be. In the mirrors you see the Unfinished Stair.*

(**Edict/Quake/Chain**) Tremor with hairline cracks racing down a stair; crowds freeze; iconoclast riot in the Tower Quarter.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tremor** — Hairline cracks race down a stair; crowds freeze, dust speaks. '[DISASTER]' *The dust spells names. Yours appears if you've broken a stair-right—or if the Ninth is curious.*
3. **Iconoclast Riot** — In the Tower Quarter; pigments and teeth fly through the air. '[SOCIAL]' '[COMBAT]' *The riot started over a missing icon's eye. The eye was a hunter's informer. The icon was a stair.*
4. **Chain Jam** — At the barbican; capstan pins shear at the worst moment. '[TRAVEL]' *The pins were filed by a saboteur. The chain will hold—or not. The Ninth is keeping score.*
5. **Black Northerly** — Pins cranes; cargo hangs between tiers, prayers below. '[WEATHER]' *The wind smells of iron and ice. Someone is using weather magic. The Witness disapproves.*
6. **Cistern Taint** — Sour water; inspectors padlock spouts, thirst rises. '[PROOF]' *The taint is sweet—too sweet. Someone poisoned the cistern to flush out a talent. The talent is a stair.*
7. **Synod Summons** — A chant or badge is suddenly proscribed; law shifts like wind. '[LAW]' *The summons is written on a bell-clapper. Read it, and you are a witness. The Ninth writes the margin.*
8. **Rope Guild Interdict** — No lifts until a grievance is heard; the city stops climbing. '[LABOR]' *The guild's grievance is a single name. The name is yours. The name is also a stair.*
9. **Siege Drill Panic** — Practice horns mistaken for real; chaos in the ranks. '[FEAR]' *The horns were blown by a child who didn't know the difference. Or did they? The child is a step.*
10. **Smuggler's Ladder** — Discovered; the whole stair sealed, routes rerouted. '[STEALTH]' '[PROOF]' *The ladder was built by a Hyro family. Now they are all "guests" of the Commissariat. Their house is a stair.*

- J Ropeyard Fire** — Sparks leap uphill faster than boots; smoke chokes the ascent. ‘[DISASTER]’ *The fire was set to cover a kidnapping. The victim’s name is on the proscription list. The board is a stair.*
- Q Exarch’s Claim** — “Thepyrgos under my protection”; arrests follow the papers. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Exarch is a puppet of the Chain-Lanterns. His seal is a bell without a clapper. The Ninth has the clapper.*
- K General Watch** — All towers manned; levies seize carts “for the walls.” ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The levies are looking for one thing: children who flinch at candle-smoke. The children are stairs.*
- A The Unfinished Stair Awakens** — A hidden flight appears in the middle of a crowded tier. The Ninth’s attention falls. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ ‘[BOSS]’ *The stairs have no end. The Witness is writing. The Ninth is counting. You are already on the third step.*

(Key/Rite/Paper) Stair token passes a barricaded stair without delay; harbor pass lowers the boom for your vessel on command.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

- 2. Stair Token** — Pass a barricaded stair without delay (once); height as right. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The token is a bronze step. It fits into a missing rung. The missing rung is a secret.*
- 3. Harbor Pass** — Boom lowers for your vessel on command; sea as ally. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pass is a note written on a fish scale. The gate-keeper will not ask why. The fish was a witness.*
- 4. Cistern Draw-Right** — A named ward during scarcity; water as favor. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The right is a clay cup. Break it to claim your share. The cup was a stair.*
- 5. Crane Allotment** — One guaranteed lift on the Ropeyard Terrace; height as service. ‘[LABOR]’ *The allotment is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each use. The ninth knot is a lie.*
- 6. Icon License** — Display a disputed image without penalty; faith as leverage. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The license is stamped with the Archon’s ring. The ring is warm—the Archon is watching. The ring is a stair.*
- 7. Archive Hour** — Library of Keys; one shelf opened to you; knowledge as power. ‘[SECRET]’ *The shelf is sealed with a riddle. Solve it, or the key will break. The riddle is about the ninth step.*
- 8. Bellmark** — Lawful ring at a fog-wick summons the watchers; law travels on sound. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The bellmark is a brand on your palm. Show it, and the watch bleeds for you—once. The blood is a witness.*

9. **Watchlight Code** — Today's beacon and mirror signals; navigation as paper. '[TRAVEL]'
The code is written in lemon juice. Heat it to read, then hide it again. The heat is a confession.
10. **Synod Indulgence** — One proscribed chant or rite permitted (for you). '[MAGIC]'
The indulgence is a bell-note held in a jar. Break the jar to release it. The bell-note is a name.
- J **Pronoia Grant** — Temporary stewardship of a terrace hamlet; land as standing.
 '[TRADE]' *The grant is a wooden token. Present it to the village elder—if she is still alive. The elder is a stair.*
- Q **Synod Audience** — Private with the Matriarch and clerks; whispers become policy.
 '[SOCIAL]' *The audience is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written. The fog is a witness.*
- K **Archon's Writ** — Palikars escort you between towers; authority as escort. '[AUTHORITY]'
The writ is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt, and the guards will know your voice. The rope was a stair.
- A **Golden Key** — Open or seal any city gate once; access as power. '[MAGIC]' *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist. It will work—once. The fist is the Ninth's.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (keys/rites/papers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **height and sound** motifs—bells that carry, wind that remembers, stairs that echo with purpose.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Bell-Law:** Bells are law made sound. Once per session, a Bellmark or tower bell summons the watch, a levy, or a decree. False rings stain a reputation; the Synod may inquire. The ninth ring is never false—it is always the Ninth.
- **Stair-Rights:** Every stair is claimed, chartered, or under review. A token bypasses barricades and checkpoints; climbing the wrong stair without leave sparks a riot or a duel. The Unfinished Stair has no owner—only one who bears its mark.

- **The Unfinished Stair Timer [6]:** Tracks the party's entanglement with the hidden architecture of Thepyrgos. Tick it when you use a hidden stair, ask a question the Synod cannot answer, or speak a true name of an Astroegro ruin. At 6 segments, the party discovers a *new* hidden stair—one that leads to an Astroegro Vault—but they are also *marked*. The Witness's attention falls on them. Their reflections in mirrors begin to lag by a heartbeat. The Chain-Lanterns receive a vision of their faces. Reduce the timer by feeding a memory to the Ninth's Coterie (lose a fact, a skill point, or a Bond) or by recording a truth in the Synod's archives (gain the Witness's Annotation).
- **The Offering at the Crossroads (Hedge Gift):** Once per session, a Hyro character (or someone who has learned their customs) may leave a *substitute* at a crossroads—a written name, a lock of hair, a childhood memory. For the next scene, they are *invisible to the Chain-Lanterns* (cannot be tracked or identified by candle-smoke). The substitute becomes an *Unfinished Proof* that the GM may call in later (the Hollow accepted it; the Hollow will ask for more).
- **The Candle-Smoke Test (GM Tool):** When the Chain-Lanterns test a village, the GM rolls 1d6. On a 1-2, they find a gifted child (the party must intervene or witness a tragedy). On a 3-4, they find a substitute (a false name, a hidden memory) and leave. On a 5-6, the village has already paid in silence—no raid occurs. The party can influence the roll by offering their own substitute (use a Boon to shift the result by 1).
- **The Astroegro Singing (Player Tool):** A Hyro character can hum a fragment of an old empire song. The song has no words—only pressure. When hummed at a ruin, it may open a hidden door. When hummed at a Chain-Lantern, it may cause their lantern to flicker. Each use advances the *Unfinished Stair* timer by 1 (the past is waking).
- **Lethai-thora Archivists:** The high elf refugees have integrated into the city's scholarly elite. They are the keepers of the deepest archives and the most secret keys. A character with Lethai-thora heritage (or who earns their trust) may gain access to the *Archivists' Mark*—a brass key that opens one restricted door in the Library of Keys per session. However, the Archivists are not monolithic; some serve the Witness, others the Ninth. Choosing a side may alienate the other faction.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Unwritten Citation** — The Witness. *A precedent that exists only in the margin.*
 - **The Bell-Founder** — Mykkiel. *The law that rings true, even when it hurts.*
 - **The Abyssal Pressure** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the city; the pressure that the deep remembers.*
 - **The Silent Stair** — The Ninth. *The step that is never counted, the threshold that opens only once.*

The Astroegro Vaults

Beneath the city, nine vaults. The Synod knows of three and has sealed them with Witness-branded wax. The Ninth's Coterie has found a fourth. The other five are still buried, waiting for the right key—a true name, a specific death, a memory that has never been spoken.

Each vault contains:

- A weapon (a bell that rings the target's true name, a lens that shows the death of anyone you name, a stone that erases a page from the world's record).
- A guardian (a spirit of an Astroegro archivist, bound to defend the vault with its last calculation).
- A cost (to open the vault, you must sacrifice something the empire valued—a memory of salt water, a dream of drowning, a confession of hubris).

The Ninth's Goal: Open all nine vaults simultaneously. The resulting “unlearning” would erase the concept of record from the world. No provenance would remain. The Hollow would go unanswered. The Witness would have nothing to inscribe. The Ninth would become the only law: *forgetting*.

The Witness's Goal: Keep the vaults sealed, but *remembered* perfectly. Every weapon, every secret, every crime of the Astroegro must be recorded in the Synod's archives—not to use, but to witness. The Witness does not want to prevent the Ninth's plan; it wants to be *the one who writes down what happened*.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Astroegro Remnant (Khemesh):** Deep beneath the Beacon Crown, a sealed chamber contains a working Astroegro orrery. Its gears are carved from abyssal glass, and it still ticks. Those who listen too long hear a voice whispering the true names of drowned emperors. The Chain-Lanterns have posted a perpetual guard; they say the orrery is a beacon for something that should not surface.
- **Saint Methodia of the Silent Stair (The Witness):** A legendary archivist who climbed the Ninth Stair of the Library of Keys and never came down. Her ghost is said to appear to those who speak a truth the Synod has buried, offering a single citation that can overturn any edict. The cost is a secret of equal measure, and the ghost never forgets.
- **The Cog-Cults of the Clockwork Monad:** Underground fraternities of gear-smiths and logicians who believe the Astroegro Empire fell because its geometry was imperfect. They meet in the basements of the Ropeyard Terrace, trying to reconstruct the lost orrery. The Chain-Lanterns tolerate them because their calculations sometimes predict talent blooms. Heretics from the Everflame call them timer-worshippers; the Cog-Cults call themselves the True Iterators.
- **The Daughters of the Cord (The Bitter Root):** A hospice in the lower tiers is run by gray-robed women who ask no payment, but they take names. They are

tolerated because they treat the poor for free, but the Commissariat suspects they also hide gifted children. A renegade Sister hides among the bell-runners, trying to unbind her Hollowed from the Chain-Lanterns' record.

- **The Savage Heart (Red Maw):** In the highland villages west of the city, a bear cult has arisen. They believe the only way to escape the Commissariat's hunts is to become the hunter. They wear cured skins and speak in growls, and they have begun hunting Chain-Lantern patrols. The Archon has declared them outlaws, but the villagers leave offerings of raw meat at their shrines.
- **Zakov's Astroegro Foundation:** The pirate city of Zakov is built on top of a sunken Astroegro port. Smugglers occasionally pull up black glass artifacts from the deep channels, which find their way to Thepyrgos' black market. The Ninth's Coterie offers high standing for such relics; the Witness's archivists try to secure them first.
- **The Ninth:** In any Thepyrgos scene, the ninth bell rung in an hour opens a threshold. The wise stop at eight and cover their ears. Those who ring the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing on the Beacon Crown's mirror tiles—waiting to receive a name.

Thepyrgos Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stair:** Toss a crust onto a rung before climbing. Ignore the first *Tremor* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a crane line. Cancel *Rope Guild Interdict* or take -1 die on your next lift (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Name to the Smoke:** Whisper a hunter's name into the Beacon Crown's fire. Gain +1 Effect when evading the Chain-Lanterns this scene, but gain the Synod's Notice. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Offer the Substitute:** Leave a written false name at a crossroads. The next Candle-Smoke Test against you automatically fails—but the Hollow gains an Unfinished Proof on you. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tower guards or guild masters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-runners or civic patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or archive keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable ascent**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wall Strategos** or **guild head** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **quake damage** or **stair closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction** or **civic enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **palikars**, **guild enforcers**, **synod guards**, or **crown militia** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**taboo broken/green host rides/feud declared/crown warrant issued**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **King**, **Matron**, **Lady Beneath**, or **Viterran Governor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**fog rises/bells ring/causeway shifts/crown forces arrive**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Thepyrgos (Height & Law):** Stairs shift position, bells ring with the wrong tone, legal papers rewrite themselves.
- **Thepyrgos (Synod Power):** Edicts change mid-speech, citations appear in the air, wisdom comes unbidden.
- **Thepyrgos (Vertical City):** Ropes fray without warning, cranes swing cargo unexpectedly, tower windows show wrong views.
- **Thepyrgos (The Unfinished Stair):** A hidden stair appears behind the party. The Ninth is counting. The Witness is writing. The stairs have no end.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Stair (Presence + Lore):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a stair token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Quake (Body + Athletics):** On a hit in *Tremor*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Inquisition)

- **The Bell-Exarch (Nine Bans)** — *Phases:* Candle-Smoke Sweep → Orchestrated Silence → Synod Coup. *Cracks:* ring a forgotten bell, expose a false bounty, survive a night in the Beacon Crown.
- **The Astroegro Engine (Pressure from Below)** — *Phases:* Gears Turn → Whispers Become Names → Seiche. *Cracks:* abyssal glass shard, survivor testimony, the Lighthouse-Patriarch's mirror turning clear.
- **The Ninth's Advocate (Living Stair)** — *Phases:* Count → Omit → Forget. *Cracks:* speak a true name that the Ninth does not know, offer a memory the Witness has not recorded, climb the Unfinished Stair and refuse to answer the Ninth's question.

Patronage & Power

In Thepyrgos, power flows through elevation, education, and the precise application of law—but also through the hidden architecture of the Unfinished Stair. The Archon maintains authority through a complex web of guilds, synods, and civic institutions, but the real power lies with whoever can climb the stairs that should not exist. Social mobility is literally upward mobility, with stair-rights, bellmarks, and archive access serving as both currency and status symbols. But the highest status belongs to those who have seen the top of the Unfinished Stair—and remembered how to return.

The Lethai-thora, as the city's most respected archivists, hold a special kind of power: they know which shelves are watched, which keys are false, and which doors lead to the Ninth's vaults. Some whisper that the Archon is secretly a Lethai-thora puppet; others say the real ruler is the ghost of an Astroegro emperor, still counting stairs in the deep.

For the GM: Patronage in Thepyrgos revolves around access—to towers, to knowledge, to the right to climb, and to the hidden stairs. Rewards often take the form of keys, passes, or legal exemptions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the metaphysical war:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, keys, papers) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided by crown officials.
- Let rival guilds and the two Patrons (Witness and Ninth) issue conflicting exemptions—players must choose whose favor matters more, and whose curse is worse.
- Use the synods, towers, and staircases as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success against Viterran common law—but where the Ninth's silence and the Witness's memory can tip the scales.
- Introduce the Unfinished Stair timer as a campaign tension; every time the party uses a hidden stair, they advance the timer and bring the Ninth's attention closer.

In Thepyrgos, your ascent is your standing, and your standing determines whether you rise or fall—or whether you are simply *forgotten*.

The Magic Colleges (University Extensions)

- **College of Ladders & Lines** — geomancy, architecture, constraint; stairs as sigils, capstans as circles.
- **College of Bells & Beacons** — acoustics, omen-fire, signal calculus; law made audible, augury made measurable.
- **College of Waters & Weights** — alchemy, cistern rites, dyes; solutions, precipitates, and lawful flow.

- **College of Names & Oaths** — nomikon theurgy; citations that bind, clauses that compel.
- **College of Mirrors & Haze** — illusion, scrutiny; seeing, being seen, un-being seen.
- **College of Quiet** — ethics of death, memory rites; permitted remembrances—anything more is heresy.

The Witch-Hunter Province (Commissariat Extensions)

Thepyrgos-the-Province funds Witch-Hunter Commissariats—ministries with notices posted per ward. Citations hang on stair-landings; bells announce *hunts lawful and hunts less so*. The Chain-Lantern order is the most feared, but others compete for quotas.

Hunter Hearts (faces of the persecution)

- **Commissary-Exarch** — Writs in triplicate; quotas in private.
- **Index-Reader** — Calibrates children by the bell; “verification” by smoke.
- **Pardoner-Chaplain** — Sells absolution to informers; keeps a careful record.
- **Stair-Runner Informant** — Knows which doors open to the right knock.
- **Chain-Lantern Captain** — Commands the most feared order; his lantern reveals truth through flesh.

Hunter Clubs (pressures and sweeps)

- **Notice Posting** — New warrant on “untutored talent”; crowds turn into nets.
- **Candle-Smoke Test** — Lines at the Blue Cistern; smoke curls toward the Gifted.
- **Commissary Sweep** — Ladders chained; a whole tier searched under horn.
- **Quieted Child** — An “accident” near the Exam Stair; evidence goes missing.
- **Chain-Lantern Raid** — Dawn assault on a hamlet; children taken before the rooster crows.

Hunter Diamonds (leverage and reprieve)

- **Witness Pardon** — Informer absolved and commended; cancels one legal fallout *once*.
- **Archon’s Clemency** — Suspends a bounty timer for one named; bell-marked and public.
- **Hidden Stair Token** — Through a maintenance run unseen; good for one group escape.

Detection & Denial (Fast Procedures)

Scry & Deny (evading the tests)

1. **Mask the Trace:** dye, salt, bell-oil; pick *one* (each grants +1 die to one approach).
2. **Pick the Test:** *Smoke, Sound, Mirror*. State how you spoof it (alchemical veil, bell overtones, angle games).
3. **On a hit:** cancel a **Candle-Smoke Test** or **Proctors' Gate** tag for this scene.
Consequence: start *Bell Mark* [2] or *Rector's Notice* [2].

Examination Economy (quick table, GM picks or 1d6)

1. *Whisperer* (faint talent): 1 notation; informers abundant.
2. *Spark-Hand* (cantrip): 2 notations; “rehabilitation” promised.
3. *Mirror-Bent* (glamour): 3 notations; seized at once.
4. *Bell-Singer* (acoustic): 4 notations; Synod claims jurisdiction.
5. *Oath-Breaker* (binding): 5 notations; Exarch insists on custody.
6. *Quiet-Worker* (death-ethic): 6 notations; College of Quiet petitions for trial.

Scenario Starters (Plug-and-Play)

The Bright Child on the Exam Stair *Hook:* A Bell-Runner begs you to get a latent child to campus before the dawn sweep. *Complications:* **Candle-Smoke Test, Commissary Sweep**, a jealous **Street Thaum**. *Relief:* Trade a *Latency Seal* for testimony; or ring a lawful *Bellmark* to create a corridor—accept *Censure Murmurs* [2].

The Black Index of Accusations *Hook:* The College of Quiet wants proof that a Commissary inflates rolls to fill quotas. *Complications:* **Synod Summons, Smuggler's Ladder, Chain Jam**. *Relief:* Publish via a *Nomikon* colloquy (gain *Synod Indulgence*); or submit it to the Archon (gain *Archon's Clemency* but start *Faculty Feud* [4]).

The Golden Key and the Silent Stair *Hook:* A dying Archivist gives you a Golden Key. “It opens the stair the hunters fear.” *Truth:* The stair leads to the Beacon Crown's secret basement—a prison for children who passed the smoke test. *Relief:* Free the children and expose the Commissariat (gain *Archon's Clemency* for the whole party, but start *Exarch's Claim* at full); or seal the stair forever (gain *Golden Key* to use elsewhere, but the children are lost to memory).

The Ninth Vault *Hook:* A fragment of an Astroegro weapon has been unearthed in a hill village. The Ninth's Coterie and the Synod both want it. The village elder offers it to the party—if they can offer a substitute that satisfies the Hollow. *Truth:* The weapon is a bell that rings the true name of anyone you name. Its guardian is the ghost of the Astroegro archivist who sealed it. The ghost will not speak to anyone who has not climbed the Unfinished Stair. *Relief:* Climb the stair, speak the archivist's true name, and take the bell—but the stair adds a segment to the Unfinished Stair Timer. Or destroy the bell with a memory of the Astroegro's fall (lose a cherished memory permanently). Or give the bell to the Synod (gain a Synod Indulgence) or to the Ninth's Coterie (gain the Ninth's Annotation).

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Part II

The Northern Reaches

“The mountain counts your breaths. The frost writes your name in ice. In the north, the dead do not wait – they walk, and they remember every promise you made to keep warm.”

— The Edgewalker

Aeler

Crowns & Under-Vaults.

“The Aeler hold the mountains by breath, bell, and load-bearing stone. Air is measured, water is bartered, light is rationed – and every tunnel has a breaking point. I’ve mapped most of them. The ones I haven’t are still settling.”

— The Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? *Stone-bread and cave cheese – the bread is baked on heated stone slabs, the cheese is aged in sealed galleries. The cheese has been aging for three generations. It is an heirloom. It is also barely edible.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To count their breaths. Aeler children wear breath-counters – small brass bells. Eight breaths, ring the bell. Nine breaths, run. A child who cannot count will not survive the winter.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their bell. Every Aeler carries a bell tuned to their breath. A stranger’s bell rings at a different pitch. A mismatched bell is a warning. A silent bell is a threat.*

What is the most common crime? *Air theft. In the deep vaults, ventilation is shared. A sealed door, a blocked vent – these are thefts of breath, punishable by breath-debt. The guilty party donates their own air ration to the victim. The donation is measured in days. The days are counted by bells.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The True Masons are not neutral. They are the Vault-Queen’s eyes. Every “independent” repair, every “neutral” inspection – the True Masons are watching. They do not report to the Queen. They are the Queen.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the Deep Vaults. The dead are sealed in niches carved into the walls, their names chiselled above their heads. The niches are reused every century. The names are never erased. The dead share walls with strangers. The strangers are patient.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a keystone – a load-bearing stone from your own holding. It is installed in the wronged party’s wall. If it holds, you are forgiven. If it cracks, the claim stands. If it crumbles, your holding collapses. Apology is architecture. Architecture is law.*

What is the most important festival? *The Ringing of the Underways (deep winter). Every bell in every hold is rung eight times. The sound travels through the stone, a heartbeat that reminds the mountain that the living are still here. The dead listen. The dead do not ring back.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Vault-Queen is a construct. Assembled after the real queen died in a cave-in. Her heart is a keystone. Her breath is a bellows. The True Masons have the schematics. The schematics are missing three pages – the pages that describe how to turn her off.

0.7 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone. The deep remembers every breath we owe.*

Vault-Queen of a Crownland (Elite): “The mountain remembers every seal pressed into its walls, every oath whispered in the dark. To govern here is not to command — it is to listen. The stone sings of what we owe. The deep listens for what we forget.”

Under-Mason (Commoner): “When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all’s well. Three knocks at night means something’s coming through the walls that wasn’t meant to walk. My grandfather called it the pressure that thinks. He walked into the deep one day and never came back. The mountain answered his knock. It always does.”

Genre / Mood: Survival horror underground, infrastructure as soft power, collectivist mercantilism, the weight of every breath.

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tally-marks from a dozen forgotten crowns. A Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown — or be buried by one. The lowland grain barges are late again. If the holds don’t eat, the pressure wakes. And if you hear a knock in threes, pretend you did not. The deep is listening tonight.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Aeler Kingdoms hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Dozens of sovereign holds — some sealed for centuries, others trading openly with lowland markets — share only the deep roots of stone and the supremacy of the High King Beneath the Peaks. Their halls run like arteries, their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone and cisterns shine like night skies turned inward. *Survival* is the first law: air is counted, water is bartered, light is rationed by wick and prayer. *Tradition* is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living. Between the two, a people learn to argue quietly and build loudly.

Collectives — clans, guild-kin, lamp-companies — own what the mountain allows; individuals are custodians by oath. Trade runs under and over the range through under-ways and pass-forts, stitching protectorates and lowland markets to vaultmouth gates. Aeler prosperity depends entirely on surface grain. The holds cannot grow enough food in the dark; each winter, caravans from Acasia, Vhasia, and Viterra bring barley and rye through the high passes. In exchange, the Aeler send iron, copper, and engineered stonework — bridge keystones, mill gears, breath-counter mechanisms. It is a fragile bargain. When the grain is late, the holds ration. When the holds ration, the pressure whispers louder.

But beneath the order, beneath the breath-counters and the record-stones, something older stirs. The Aeler do not speak of it directly. They call it *the pressure that thinks* — a presence that lives in the deepest galleries, in the spaces between sealed holds, in the darkness where bells have not rung for centuries. It does not attack. It *invites*. Miners who wander too deep return with no memory of why they went. Others do not return at all. The pressure does not hate. It is patient. And it is always, always listening.

What you notice first: The smell of stale air and hot metal. The constant drip of condensation in the distance — or is it footsteps? The way every Aeler touches a small brass bell at their belt before speaking of the deep. The way they never, ever count to nine aloud.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never count your breaths aloud in a mine. The mountain listens, and if it hears you reach the ninth, it will take one — a breath, a memory, a shadow. The deep does not forgive miscounts.

Regional Mood: Infrastructure, Famine, and the Pressure Below

Here, power is not measured in gold but in *capacity*: how many lamp-hours your holding can afford, how many mouths your air-recyclers can support, how many tons of ore you can raise before the grain runs out. The Aeler do not conquer; they *engineer*. A bridge built to their standards binds a valley to their trade network. A breath-counter installed in a foreign counting house gives them leverage over every contract signed beneath it. Their soft power is written in brass and stone.

Yet the holds are always one bad harvest away from collapse. The Deep Vaults cannot

feed themselves. Every season, Edgewalkers — outcasts, rogues, and those too restless for the counting-chamber — are sent to the surface to “find opportunities.” They start feuds between lowland lords, sell weapons to both sides, and return with grain contracts signed in blood. The holds do not ask where the grain came from. They ask only that the wagons arrive before the ninth bell.

The holds endure because they are willing to spend lives as carefully as they spend lamp oil. A collapsed gallery is a line item. A village that starves because its grain was diverted to the Deep Vaults is a footnote in an audit that no one reads aloud. The Aeler are not cruel. They are *efficient*. And efficiency, in the dark, is the only mercy.

The Pressure That Thinks — The Deep Drake

Deep beneath the oldest mountains, beyond the Ninth Seal and past the last lamplighter’s mile, there is a presence. The Aeler do not name it. Among themselves, in whispers, some call it the Deep Drake — an ancient worm, a child of Nidhoggr, hatched in the dark between worlds. But that is speculation, and the Aeler are not a people given to speculation about things they cannot measure.

What they know is this: there is a *weight* in the deepest stone. It feels like curiosity. It sounds like your own name spoken with concern. It is not a god, not a demon, not a dragon in any sense the surface-dwellers would recognize. It is a *proto-patron* — a being whose hold on the world is tenuous, whose attention slips like water through fingers. It cannot command. It cannot bless. It can only *invite*.

The Deep Drake has no lair that any living Aeler has seen, though rumor persists of a vast chamber of black glass and fossilized bone, where the heat of the earth meets the cold of the void. In that chamber, the worm coils around a hoard that is not gold but *attention*: the still, silent figures of those who walked too far and never walked back. They sit in the dark, eyes open, mouths moving silently as they repeat the last promise they ever made. The Drake does not kill. It *collects*. And what it collects, it forgets — because its memory is as fragile as its grip on reality. That is why it is always hungry. That is why it is always listening.

The Aeler refuse to think of it as anything other than *the pressure that thinks*. To name it would be to invite it. To acknowledge it as a being would be to admit that the deep is not merely stone and silence but *occupied*. So they call it a superstition, a miner’s fancy, the kind of story told to frighten apprentices. And for the most part, they believe their own dismissal. But the old miners know. The Edgewalkers who have heard the three knocks and turned back just in time — they know. They do not speak of it. They only count their breaths more carefully.

The Deep Drake draws the living toward it not through force, but through a gentle, irresistible lure: a half-remembered tune, a forgotten oath, a face you thought you had left behind. You walk toward it because you believe you have business there. You have no business there. Its pull is strongest when you are tired, when your attention wanders, when you have stopped counting your breaths. The Aeler have learned to live with this. They seal off tunnels that grow too warm. They never answer a knock that comes in three. They count their breaths not out of habit, but out of a deep, unspoken fear that the ninth breath might be the one the Drake answers.

What the elders do not say, but what the Edgewalkers whisper: The Deep Drake is not the only thing down there. It is a child of something older — Nidhoggr, the corpse-tearer, the one who gnaws at the root of the world. That older thing does not invite. It *demands*. And it has been patient for a very long time.

The Edgewalker's Bargain

Outcasts from the holds, Edgewalkers are those who could not abide the counting — or who were too useful to execute and too dangerous to keep. They trade in secrets, in weapons, in the subtle art of making two lowland lords need each other's destruction. An Edgewalker's greatest skill is not swordplay but *leverage*: knowing which noble's grain debt is overdue, which free company captain will flip for a better contract, which bridge toll can be raised to start a war. The holds disavow them publicly and fund them privately. When a war breaks out in the lowlands, Aeler iron flows to both sides. When the war ends, the holds send grain inspectors to collect the tab.

Mechanical hook for Edgewalker characters: Once per arc, an Edgewalker may declare that they have a *line* on a lowland conflict. The GM creates a 4-segment *Opportunity* timer. Each tick represents the Edgewalker applying pressure (spreading rumors, selling a weapon, forging a letter). When the timer fills, a war, a feud, or a trade embargo ignites — and the Aeler holds gain +2 Supply from arms sales. The Edgewalker gains 1 Corruption (the Hollow notices their work) and a permanent String on a lowland faction.

The Fractured Crowns: Aeler Faction Spectrum

Aeler society is not monolithic. Beneath the High King's nominal authority, each crownland follows its own star. Attitudes toward the surface range from open partnership to militant isolation, and even the most reclusive holds maintain **Edgewalker** contacts to monitor the world above.

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- **Traditionalist / “The Old Ways”** – These holds idealize the ancient mountain-empire: closed gates, iron tariffs, and the certain knowledge that surface-dwellers cannot be trusted. They resemble the dwarves of fireside tales: stubborn, insular, and quick to reach for an axe when a human mentions “progress.” Their kings speak of the days when no foreigner stepped past the vaultmouth. They also speak of the pressure in whispers, and they seal any tunnel that shows signs of warmth. *Timers:* *FOREIGNER SUSPICION* [4], *HOLD SEALED* [6].
- **Cooperative / “Open Hand”** – These holds trade freely with Aelaerem, Kahfagia, and even the Vilikari. They staff the under-markets, send engineers to repair bridges in Viterra, and treat the surface as a resource to be managed, not a threat to be shunned. They prefer soft power: standardized measures, certified weights, and bell-code protocols that make others *want* to trade on Aeler terms. They are also the most likely to send expeditions into the deep, seeking lost holds — and the most likely to lose miners to the pressure. *Timers:* *TRADE ROUTE PROSPERITY* [6], *CULTURAL FRICTION* [4].

- **Isolationist / “Silent Stone”** – Deep holds that have not answered a Kingsmoot call in living memory. Their gates are lost, their peoples rumored to have turned inward, worshipping forgotten depths — or to have become part of the pressure’s hoard. They neither help nor harm the surface — but when a White Flood or a gas flare occurs, their silence becomes a hazard of its own. The Deep Drake is said to lair somewhere beneath the Silent Stone holds. *Timers: SILENT HOLD AWAKENS [8], ANCIENT GRUDGE [6].*

Most Aeler characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same hold might shift its stance over a season, depending on grain prices, a new Vault-Queen, or a disaster that forces its hand.

The Breath Count — Habit, Not Function

Among the Aeler, counting breaths is not merely a safety measure — it is a cultural reflex, as automatic as a human’s heartbeat. Aeler children learn to count in eights before they learn to speak. They tap their fingers, their bells, their spoons in rhythms of eight. They never, ever count to nine aloud. The ninth breath is not a number; it is a *gap* — the space where the pressure listens. Aeler who forget to count in eights are considered unreliable, possibly touched by the deep. Those who deliberately count to nine are shunned; they are thought to have invited the pressure to notice them.

Mechanical note: Breath-counting is not a skill roll or a resource to track. It is a narrative and cultural tic. The GM may use a character’s failure to observe the count as a trigger for a complication (e.g., the mountain shifts, a bell rings falsely, a character feels watched). Conversely, an Aeler who scrupulously counts their breaths in eights may gain a small boon (e.g., +1 die to resist fear in confined spaces) as the mountain’s attention slides past them.

Prominent NPCs of Aeler

[p0.2][p0.25][p0.3][p0.15]

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
Valthor Aezelbron	High King Beneath the Peaks	Keep the ancient concord and balance the crownlands	He has not spoken above a whisper in seven years. The court reads his will by bell-code.
Grunhelda Thrainsdottir	Vault-Queen of Irondeep	Expand trade routes while keeping the Old Ways satisfied	She keeps a pet geode that hums when a contract is fair — and goes silent when the pressure is near.
Maeva Emery	Legate of the Under-Seal	Negotiate passage rights and standard measures with lowland realms	Her seal-rod is carved from a fossilized root. She has never lost a tariff dispute.
Thromm Stone-Tongue	Under-Mason (Commoner exemplar)	Hear the mountain’s warnings and keep the tunnels safe	He can identify a false weight by tapping it once with his

hammer. He has never counted to nine.

Orthen White-Ribbon Tunnel Courier Deliver sealed writs across hostile jurisdictions
He has run the Spine Underway in darkness without a lamp. Twice. He says the dark has a voice, but it only asks questions.

Lumenor Saela Keeper of the Under-Altars Maintain the breath-rites and the old flame
She speaks only in bell tones during services. Her mundane voice is never heard.

Emery “*the Unbound*” Edgewalker (exiled fixer) Create lowland chaos to secure grain contracts for the holds She has three false names and a real one she no longer remembers. She never sleeps in the same room twice.

Names of Aeler

Aeler names blend flowing vowels and soft diphthongs (ae, ei, ou, ui) with harsh consonants (k, th, z, r, g). Surnames are carved from mountain-roots: a hold, a forge, a seam, or a trade.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2				
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets	
Thrain	Grunhelda	Aezenbron	<i>the Iron</i>	
Emery	Maeva	Thrainkhar	<i>Breath-Steady</i>	
Orthen	Saela	Valdurg	<i>Seal-Keeper</i>	
Rurik	Aeldis	Lucasthane	<i>Bell-Tongue</i>	
Bromm	Helka	Zarkul	<i>the Under-Mason</i>	
Zelgur	Thorunn	Dornvael	<i>White-Ribbon</i>	

Spades — Places (vaultmouths, descents, underways, crown seats)

2. 1

(Security/Gatekeeping) Vaultmouth Gate in a hillslope: bronze lungs for breath-tests, tally-niches for lamps.

3. 2

(Tradition/Oaths) Crown-Crypt Porch where oaths are sworn to sleeping kings.

4. 3

(Commerce/Underground) Under-Market: lantern alleys between cistern pillars; damp coin, dry wit.

5.  (Labor/Danger) Smoke-Shaft Stair spiraling up to a soot hatch; handprints black as seals.
6.  (Mystery/Whispers) Gloam Cistern — black water, lead scales, whispers carry too far.
7.  (Maintenance/Travel) Lamplighter's Mile on the Under-Road; niches sting with spent wicks.
8.  (Precision/Authority) Measure Vault: standard rods and weights chained under glass and oath.
9.  (Sacred/Knowledge) Reliquary Arcade: bell-chimes answer drafts; saints keep their own tallies.
10.  (Military/Strategic) Twin-Throne Gate — surface fortress straddling a chasm bridge.
11.  (Knowledge/Secrecy) Deep Archive Stacks behind grillwork; scriptoria cells breathe ink and dust.
12.  (Royalty/Privilege) Queen's Descent: private stair from palace to royal vault-house.
13.  (Politics/Power) Kingsmoot Cavern — crownstones in a ring around a bottomless dark.
14.  (Infrastructure/Majesty) The Spine Underway, a great tunnel linking crownlands beneath the peaks.

Hearts — People & Factions (crowns, keepers, guilds, legates)

2.  (Apprenticeship/Dedication) Lamplighter apprentice with a jingling key-ring and soot in the lungs.

3.  **2**
(Craft/Knowledge) Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away.
4.  **3**
(Authority/Duty) Vault Warden with breath-tally and seal-rods; patient as granite.
5.  **4**
(Protection/Faith) Censer-Knight of the Dawn – fights miasma and men with equal zeal.
6.  **5**
(Sacred/Craft) Key-Sister (monastic locksmith) who names wards like prayers.
7.  **6**
(Commerce/Authority) Under-Market assessor whose stamp can starve or save a stall.
8.  **7**
(Engineering/Expertise) Engineer of Underways (geometer) with rod, hammer, and the right maps.
9.  **8**
(Tradition/Law) Oath-Keeper of the Crown Crypt – memory like iron, smile like law.
10.  **9**
(Diplomacy/Authority) Legate of the Under-Seal, royal commissioner between kingdoms.
11.  **J**
(Communication/Loyalty) White-Ribbon tunnel courier; runs blind, rings true.
12.  **Q**
(Royalty/Authority) Vault-Queen of a crownland, sovereign above and below.
13.  **K**
(Supreme Authority/Tradition) High King Beneath the Peaks, first among crowns by ancient concord.
14.  **A**
(Spiritual Power/Resolution) Lumenor of the Under-Altars, one sentence opens doors and closes debates.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (air, water, stone, rite, jurisdiction)

2.  1
(Danger/Disorientation) Bad air pocket — candles gutter blue; lungs complain, schedules fail.
3.  2
(Disruption/Flood) Drip-flood from a burst cistern reroutes corridors without asking.
4.  3
(Accident/Destruction) Gas flare kisses a lamp; eyebrows and evidence vanish.
5.  4
(Error/Security) Seal misread — the wrong door opens, the right one will not.
6.  5
(Quarantine/Delay) Under-mold quarantine shuts the market just as your crate arrives.
7.  6
(Danger/Warning) Settling crack — dust snow warns the roof wants down.
8.  7
(Accusation/Suspicion) Stolen key turns up in your kit; accusations ring like bells.
9.  8
(Conflict/Jurisdiction) Bell-code conflict — two authorities claim the same chime.
10.  9
(Political Conflict/Violence) Vault-right feud: crown guards face basilica wardens on a stair.
11.  J
(Disaster/Trapped) Cave-in behind — proof, friends, and retreat on the far side.
12.  Q
(Religious Conflict/Inquisition) Heresy inquest in the under-chapel; arrests in whispers.
13.  K
(Authority/Restriction) General Under-Seal — all vault traffic halted by royal decree.

14. 

(Natural Disaster/Destruction) White Flood — mountain thaw becomes a river through your route.

Diamonds — Treasures & Discoveries (keys, passes, breath, priority, precedent)

2. 

(Utility/Time) Lamp-priority tally — skip one lamplighter queue.

3. 

(Safety/Access) Breath-measure allotment — lawful time in a sealed chamber (once).

4. 

(Security/Authority) Key-Writ — operate a named lock one time, witnessed.

5. 

(Travel/Security) Underway Pass — escorted travel between two vaultmouths.

6. 

(Commerce/Rights) Stall-Right in the under-market for a season.

7. 

(Engineering/Safety) Engineer Shoring — a crew stabilizes your chosen corridor on your timetable.

8. 

(Commerce/Trust) Assay Mark — your coin/metal accepted sight unseen below.

9. 

(Protection/Law) Crypt Asylum — temporary sanctuary under crown law.

10. 

(Authority/Access) Vault Inventory License — remove a named cache under witness.

11. 

(Military/Authority) Under-Guard Commission — command a vault detachment for a day.

12.  (Royalty/Privilege) Private Descent with the Vault-Queen or High King's chancellor.
13.  (Supreme Authority/Access) High King's Sealed Writ — doors open, mouths close across crownlands.
14.  (Exception/Power) The Under-Seal Clause — temporary exception to any lock, levy, or rite below.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = treasure. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Treasures (Diamonds) are codified outcomes (keys/passes/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo stone & breath motifs — keys click, bells answer, and the mountain listens (and remembers). Also, the pressure that thinks may manifest as a whisper, a warmth, or a knock in the dark.
- Track **Grain Reserves** as a campaign timer. When it empties, the holds begin to starve — and the Edgewalkers are sent to light a fire somewhere on the surface.

Additional Features

- **Count the Air:** When a scene establishes scarce air, a character who actively paces their breathing (counted steps, measured rests) may shift *Position* one step safer on their next physical action in a confined space. This is habit, not a resource; Aeler characters may do this reflexively.
- **Bell-Code Courtesy:** If the party adopts local bell etiquette (asking a warden which chime applies and heeding it), gain +1 assist die on negotiations or passage requests within a vault or under-market. Ignoring the bells invites the mountain's attention.
- **Measure is Mercy:** Presenting a certified measure (rod, weight, sealed tally) calms a dispute: cancel the first SB generated by commerce or jurisdictional friction in the scene. A false measure, however, may draw the pressure's curiosity.
- **The Ninth Breath (Cultural Tic):** An Aeler character never counts to nine aloud. If forced to do so (or if they deliberately break the taboo), they must test Resolve (3) or gain the *Marked by the Pressure* condition (the next environmental hazard

automatically triggers a complication). This is not a mechanical resource; it is a narrative and cultural constraint.

- **Grain Reserves Timer [8]:** Represents the holds' food supply. Ticks when a surface caravan is delayed, a contract is broken, or an Edgewalker's scheme fails. At 4 segments: rationing begins — all physical actions in the holds suffer −1 die. At 8 segments: famine. The Deep Drake's attention sharpens. The party must find new grain — or feed the pressure something else.

Stone & Sovereignty

In the deep places, survival depends on precision and tradition. The Aeler understand that stone does not forgive error — a misread seal can mean death, a miscalculated air measure can doom an expedition, and a broken bell-code can spark jurisdictional war. But beneath the law, beneath the tallies, there is the pressure. It does not hate. It does not judge. It simply *thinks*. And when it thinks of you, you will feel a warmth in the stone, a whisper in the dark, a knock that comes in threes. The wise pretend not to notice. The foolish walk toward it.

The holds endure because they are willing to spend lives as carefully as they spend lamp oil. A collapsed gallery is a line item. A village that starves because its grain was diverted to the Deep Vaults is a footnote in an audit that no one reads aloud. The Aeler are not cruel. They are *efficient*. And efficiency, in the dark, is the only mercy.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **vault wardens** or **lamp-lighter companies**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **under-guards** or **echo bats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **assessors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable air**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Breath warden** or **vault warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **air shift** or **seal change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival crown's **guard** or **gas wraith** arrives on scene.

- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **crown guards, true masons, or lamp companies** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **seal misread/cave-in/flare ignites**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.
- **Pressure Whispers:** A character hears their name spoken from a crack in the stone. They must test Resolve (3) or be compelled to move toward the sound.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Vault-Queen, High King's Legate, or Lumenor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **gas floods/water breaks/floor collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.
- **The Deep Drake's Attention:** The pressure that thinks focuses on a character. They gain a *Marked by the Deep* condition. The GM gains 2 SB to spend on environmental or psychic complications in future scenes.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aeler (Stone & Breath):** Keys click in the wrong locks, bells answer without being rung, mountain air grows thin without warning.
- **Aeler (Authority & Tradition):** A seal is misread, bell-codes conflict between jurisdictions, a vault warden demands proper credentials.
- **Aeler (Underground Hazards):** Bad air pockets form, settling cracks warn of collapse, gas flares ignite unexpectedly.

- **Aeler (The Pressure That Thinks):** A distant knock in threes, a warmth from a cold wall, a whisper that sounds like a dead relative, a shadow that moves independently.

Aeler — Under-Vault Tensions

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tally-marks from a dozen forgotten crowns.

“Among the Aeler, stone remembers the weight of oaths, and every echo calls a reckoning. But some echoes call from the deep, where the pressure thinks. Do not answer.”

In... An Underway junction, a Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown — or be buried by one. And if you hear a knock in threes, pretend you did not. The pressure is listening tonight.”

Regional Motifs Load-bearing oaths, fault-prayers, crown-rights, catacomb guilds.

Whispers to Offer “Cut a supporting tie,” “Sign for another’s weight,” “Take a shortcut through the sealed tunnel,” “Answer the knock — it might be a friend.”

External Timers Threat: “The Spine Slips”; Fracture: “Maps Reorder”; Community: “Surface Panic”; Deep: “The Pressure Wakes [8]”; Grain: “Reserves Empty [8]”.

Complications Load-lights dim; echoes reply in politics; crown agents arrive early; a miner goes missing in the deep.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s workshop; a shared refuge tunnel; a relative who works in the deep galleries.

Escalation Beat The tally-rod points to the most guilty PC. Then a knock sounds from the darkness — three times.

Relief Shore a vault with sacrifice (1 anchor), or complete a truce between crowns; Spirit + Resolve (5) to hold a cave-in long enough to evacuate. Or offer a memory to the pressure — it will accept, but it will remember.

Faction Entanglements

- **Edgewalkers (Prospectors):** If you accept their escort or intel, start a 4-segment *Opportunity* timer you can cash for +1 Effect on one venture. If you refuse a posted hazard, they post *your* route as “open” (first stealth or smuggling roll this leg suffers –1 die). Edgewalkers are the most likely to have heard the pressure’s whisper and survived.

- **True Masons (Infrastructure Orders):** Pledge tools or labor to earn a *Mason's Stamp* (treat as papers to traverse construction zones). Cross a marked barrier without their leave and gain the *Tampered Work* tag — first structural mishap SB against you is free. True Masons are the ones who seal the tunnels that grow warm.
- **Lamplighter Companies:** Donate wick, oil, or time on the Mile to bank a *Lamp Credit*; spend to ignore darkness penalties once on the Under-Road. Skip a service bell and all under-market buys that scene cost +1 timer tick (queues & suspicion). Lamplighters are the first to notice when a light goes out for no reason.
- **Under-Market Assessors:** Submit to measure/weigh and reduce Commerce by 1 this scene. Try to pass unassayed goods — on a Miss, lose the load *or* accept a *Caveat Stamp* that poisons your price two markets downstream. Assessors have a sixth sense for false weights; they claim the pressure tells them.
- **Breath Wardens:** Register bodies & flames before sealed work; compliance cancels the first air-hazard SB. Skipping registry adds a *Thin Air* tick to the leg (applies −1 die to the first exertion test in confinement). Breath Wardens are the ones who count every exhalation. They never speak of what they hear in the silence between breaths.

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Agrarian Reliance (Human Breadbelts):** Grain, timber, tallow, and fleece convoys from Acasia/Vhasia/Viterra sustain vault populations. Famine or levy spikes uprange impose night rationing: Under-Road checks +1 and food trades add +1 SB pressure until relief.
- **Standards Diplomacy:** Aeler *Measure Vault* rods adopted abroad grant +1 die to settle disputes in foreign markets; rejecting Aeler standards increases toll and inspection frequency (first border scene gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB).
- **True Mason Missions Abroad:** Accept a Mason cadre to “stabilize” bridges, ports, or sluices: reduce Travel by 1 on that route for the arc, but the route now respects Aeler closure bells (authorities can halt traffic with one writ).
- **Edgewalker Concessions:** Prospect notes traded to frontier lords exchange for wayleaves and salvage rights; cash once for an *Under-Seal Clause (local)* or accept a rival claimant timer that will mature if you delay.
- **Kahfagian Interface (Sea Monopoly):** Aeler export hard-goods via Kahfagian factors; storm seasons or privateer scares add a *Harbor Quarantine* tick to any surface leg feeding those ports (customs +1).
- **Aelerem/Aelinnel Fallout:** When *Valewood Weather* is signaled, Aeler works creak; all bell-codes in mixed settlements (Aelerem/Aelinnel) are one step easier to misread (first bell-etiquette scene: add a free “Error/Security” SB unless you consult a local).

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Airworks & Wick (Oil, Char, Filters):** Donate to a vault — bank a *Breath Favor* to cancel the next bad-air complication. Hoard in a shortage and your lot is flagged; all purchases beneath that crown suffer –1 die until you settle a fine or tithe.
- **Stonework & Ironwork (Beams, Keys, Rods):** Selling to foreign keeps spreads Aeler codes: once per arc, treat a foreign gate as if it used Aeler warding (gain +1 die with Key-Sisters/warders there). Counterfeit measure rods trigger a cross-border inquest timer.
- **Foodflows (Grain, Fleece, Tallow):** Move relief trains to clear one *Rationing* tag for a settlement (–1 for social checks there). Divert a relief train and gain an *Audit* timer that follows you three markets hence.
- **Cistern-Right & Water Engineering:** Fund a sluice or cistern abroad to gain *Water Priority* (skip one queue during drought). Neglect maintenance and the keeper may invoke *Aeler Liability* — pay or lose access to the route for a season.

Patron Networks (Below and Beyond)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Consecrated door-nails from True Mason kits act as single-use *stay* writs (negate one forced entry this scene).
- **The Traveler:** Spine milestones double as wayshrines; leave a brass chit to reroll one failed travel test on that segment this arc.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** Breath-pure censers sanction “clean rooms”; once per delve, dispel one ambient miasma or ward-rot effect at cost of +1 Obligation to local abbey-knights.
- **Maelstraeus:** Under-Market stalls tithe to the Great Ledger; cash a *Market Dominance* tick to flip one price band in your favor for a scene, then mark a 4-segment *Karmic Weight* with assessors.

Survival-Horror Procedures (Use Often)

- **Headcount & Flamecount:** At scene start in confinement, ask “Who breathes, what burns?” If headcount+flamecount exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start a 4-segment *Stale Air* timer.
- **Two Bells to Safety:** Any time the fiction stalls underground, ring two nearby bells (authority vs. sanctum). PCs must pick one to heed; ignoring both increases the next hazard’s Cap by +1 (stone holds grudges).
- **Measure or Mistrust:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB this scene; failing to present one imposes –1 die on haggling or passage until appeased.

- **The Knock in Threes:** If a character hears three knocks from the darkness, they must test Resolve (3) or be compelled to walk toward the sound. The knock may be the pressure — or it may be a lost miner. The difference is not always clear.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Breath Favor (minor resource):** Earned by donating wick/oil or assisting air wardens. Spend to downgrade one underground hazard outcome or to bypass a lamplighter queue.
- **Stamps & Seals:**
 - *Mason-Marked:* Doors to worksites open; smugglers avoid you (harder to buy contraband, easier to cross safely).
 - *Edge-Trusted:* Prospectors share fresh maps — first detour per leg is free; officials eye you as opportunists (first civic audience +1).
 - *Assessor-Clean:* Under-markets honor your assay; rivals spread rumors — add a trailing *Audit* timer if you score a windfall.

Boss Archetypes in Aeler

Systemic / Economic / Conspiracy

- **Under-Market Syndic (Cartel/Measure Fraud):** Price-fixes breath, wick, and water; wields corrupt assay marks to starve rivals. *Win by exposing forged measures or seizing the Assay Chain.*
- **True Mason Provost (Infrastructure Coup):** Locks cities behind “safety closures,” weaponizes detours and permits. *Win by forcing a public bell-code audit or breaking the Permit Timer .*
- **Edgewalker Concessionaire (Route Monopolist):** Controls salvage and shortcuts, posts hazards to strangle traffic. *Win by proving route tampering or opening a sanctioned bypass.*
- **Bell-Code Inquisitor (Silent Coup):** Rewrites chimes to shift jurisdiction; arrests arrive as echoes. *Win by restoring canonical bell charts or capturing the Chime Key.*

Survival Horror (Environment as Boss)

- **White Flood (Water/Pressure):** Thaw-swollen river through the halls; phases at trickle → surge → roar. *Win by sluicework, sacrificial breach, or riding the flood.*
- **Bad Air (Miasma/Invisible):** Candles gutter blue; thoughts slow; corridors choose the slowest. *Win by air discipline, filter rites, or opening a lung-shaft.*
- **Hungry Stone (Creep/Collapse):** Settling cracks hunt noise and heat; shudders on every miss. *Win by shoring, silence, and rerouting stress through old ribs.*

- **Lamp Famine (Darkness/Isolation):** Wicks fail in sequence; last lights lure you deeper. *Win by restoring the Lamplighter’s Mile or kindling a saint-wick.*

Undead / Fallen Kingdom / Eldritch / Demonic

- **Crown-Lich of the Crypt (Undead Sovereign):** Keeps ancient offices; binds petitioners with oaths to the dead. *Win by repealing a mortmain writ or severing the Oath-Chain.*
- **Echo-King in the Deep (Eldritch Memory):** A throne of voices; answers every argument you will ever make. *Win by changing the Measure (new precedent) or striking the Silent Note.*
- **Seal-Devil (Demonic Contract):** Lives in locks and signatures; eats exceptions. *Win by offering a flawless counter-seal or starving it of loopholes.*
- **The Hollow Architect (Fallen Works):** A ghost-guilder rebuilding the empire wrong on purpose. *Win by unkeying the master plan or collapsing the false load paths.*
- **The Deep Drake (The Pressure That Thinks):** Not a boss to be fought, but a presence to be negotiated with — or escaped. *Phases: Whisper → Knock → Invitation → Collection. Cracks:* offer a memory of sunlight, speak a true regret, or allow a willing sacrifice to walk into the deep in your place.

Boss Mechanics Notes

- **Air & Light Tracks:** In confined scenes, track *Headcount*, *Flamecount*. If *Headcount* + *Flamecount* exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start **Stale Air** [4]. Each tick imposes −1 die to exertion until vented.
- **Jurisdiction Timers:** Many bosses run a **Bell-Code Conflict** [4] or **Seal Dispute** [6]. On fill, the boss gains *Authority Surge*: increase their social by +1 and seize initiative once.
- **Lair Actions (choose 2–3):**
 - *Collapse Probe:* Mark “Settling Crack”; nearest noisy PC tests PROWESS or risk *Pin/Separate*.
 - *Breath Tax:* Reduce *Flamecount* by 1; next exertion in zone costs Fatigue 1 on a miss.
 - *Blackout/Glare:* Snuff or flare lamps; impose Disorient (−1 die) until a *Lamp-lighter Action* restores balance.
 - *Bell Overrule:* Swap which faction’s law applies; social actions vs. boss gain +1 this round.
 - *White Flood Surge:* Advance environment timer; force MOVE/WRECK or be *Separated*.

- *Pressure's Knock (Deep Drake only)*: A character hears three knocks. They must test Resolve (4) or be compelled to move one range band toward the sound.
- **Phase Triggers:** Environment bosses phase when *Air* hits 2/4, *Water* hits 3/6, or *Light* hits 0; Conspiracy bosses phase when *Audit* or *Permit* timers fill.
- **Truth & Measure:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB each phase; forging one gives the boss 1 SB and a free *Expose Fraud* reaction.
- **Crowd Pressure:** In under-markets, add **Panic Crowd [4]**; each tick adds +1 to precise actions (shoot, pick, ritual) unless calmed with bell-code or coin.
- **Fear Hooks (optional):** *Bad Air* inflicts FEAR vs. suffocation; *Echo-King* inflicts FEAR vs. isolation; *Seal-Devil* inflicts FEAR vs. helplessness; *Pressure's Knock* inflicts FEAR vs. the unknown. On Fail: mark *Shaken*; on Critical Fail: drop a resource (*lamp, key, breath*).

The Mistlands

Bells, Salt, and Breath.

“The Mistlands lend their name to the Aeler, but the fog is its own master. It hides not just the land, but the law that should bind us. The bell-lines ring to keep the wraiths back, and the Aeler ask for their due – but when the coin is gone, they take their bells and leave. Then the fog does not forget; it remembers every name they left behind in the damp and dark.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Salt fish and sour bread – the fish is smoked over peat fires, the bread is leavened with fog-damp yeast. The yeast is caught in cloth traps hung from bell-towers. The yeast is not alive. It is not dead either.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To ring a bell. Every Mistlands child is given a small bronze bell at birth. By age three, they can ring the eight notes of the ward-chime. The ninth note is never taught. Discovery is fatal.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their salt-pouch. A stranger without a pouch is a fool. A stranger with an empty pouch is a fool about to become a wraith.

What is the most common crime? Ward-salt theft. The Aeler control the salt pans, and the salt is the only thing that keeps the dead from rising. A stolen pouch buys a week’s protection. The price is a year’s labour in the deep galleries. The cycle is perpetual.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Bell-Wardens are not chosen – they are volunteered. The training holds are in the mountains. The mountains are cold. The ones who return do not speak of what they learned. Their bells ring at a different pitch.

Where do people go when they die? To the fog. Bodies are left at the edge of the bell-line. The mist takes them. Sometimes, at dusk, you can see them walking the lanes. They do not speak. Their presence is a question.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You ring the Bell of Atonement – a cracked bronze bell in every village square. Ring it once for each wrong confessed. If the bell rings true, you are forgiven. If it shatters, you are banished to the fog. The banished never return. Their voices still answer from the white.

What is the most important festival? The Rehanging of the Lines (autumn). Every bell-line is taken down, cleaned, and rehung. The villages are silent for three nights. The dead listen. The dead wait. The dead do not ring.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Legate of the Mists is a wraith. She died in 803 AR, during a bell-line failure. The Acler rebuilt her from fog and memory. She does not know she is dead. She signs documents. Her signature fades after sunset.

0.8 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mistlands lie north of the Aelerian mountains, where the Aberderrin Sea laps against reed-fens and drowned shores. To the west, the Direwood breathes; to the east, the salt tides of the Aberderrin. It is a Protectorate of the Aeler, but their iron passes only hold the southern roads — the land itself belongs to fog and bells. Every levee hums with ward-notes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood’s endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with patrols, garrisons, and breath-bonds, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

What you notice first: The constant, distant chime of bells — never quite in sync. The taste of salt on your lips even inland. The way everyone holds their breath when crossing a bridge. The silence when a bell fails to ring.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you.

Regional Mood: Bells and Breath

Here, breath is currency and silence a sin. Every exhalation is counted by the ward-bells, and every stolen inhalation feeds something that should not be. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with patrols and garrisons, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

The tension between the Aeler governor (Legate Halvar) and the local bell-wardens is constant. The Aeler want standardized bell-codes, the salt-tithe weighed true, and villages who keep the old pacts. The wardens want the old ways: counting in eights, never the ninth, and the right to refuse a name to the fog. Payden’s Port, the only true city, is a battleground of writs and lanterns. Grain ships leave each autumn, carrying the Protectorate’s due east and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary — who rarely stay.

Prominent NPCs of the Mistlands

p0.2p0.25p0.3p0.15 Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Legate Halvar	Aeler governor of the Protectorate	Keep the bell-lines intact and the grain flowing east	She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end

of her reign.

Mother Anja Salt-Monk of the White Pans Preserve the old wards against the Direwood
Her tongue is white with salt; she speaks only in blessings or silence.

Warden Lucas Bell-Warden of the High Line Protect his village from the mist and the
Aeler law-men He refuses to write down the ninth note; it lives only in his fading memory.

Sister Darya Healer of the Grey Hospice of the Unnamed (Temple of Light) Tend the
fog-sick and the drowned Her grey robes never stain, and she asks no payment — only a
name to carry in her keeping.

Notary Voss Covenant judge (Mykkiel) Impose Aeler law on local customs He carries
a water-timer to measure the shifting of legal moods. The mist ignores it.

The Ferryman Oath-ferryman of the Ghost Slip Gather tolls in salt and whispered
names His left hand is always gloved; underneath, the names are carved into his palm.

Names of the Mistlands

Inspired by the coastal fens and the Aeler protectorate: clipped, breathy, with soft vowels
and hard endings. Surnames often denote a marsh, a craft, or a ward.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Halvar	Anja	Foss	<i>the Bell-Sworn</i>
Lucas	Darya	Mork	<i>Fog-Born</i>
Voss	Pia	Saltvedt	<i>the Unnamed</i>
Torben	Lise	Kyst	<i>Breath-Thief</i>
Stian	Ragna	Dyrep	<i>Ward-Keeper</i>
Vidar	Signe	Tangen	<i>Ash-Finger</i>

(**Fen/Levee/Bell-line**) Reed-fen causeway with chalked ward-runes on every milestone;
Bell-Line levee with iron posts and eight bells per span.

Spades — Places

2. **Reed-Fen Causeway** — Chalked ward-runes on every milestone; safe path through
the mist.



Step only on the chalked stones. The mud between has no bottom.

3. **Bell-Line Levee** — Iron posts, eight bells per span; one bracket empty, one note forbidden.

♠ **WARD**

The empty bracket is for the bell that never rings. The rope is still there.

4. **Ghost-Ferry Slip** — Rope crosses black water; toll taken in salt and whispered names.

♠ **DEATH**

♠ **TRAVEL**

The ferryman never blinks. Some say he traded his eyelids for the right to collect.

5. **Pall Watch-Tower** — Piles above mire; mirrors face west to the Direwood's breath.

♠ **WARD**

The mirrors are silvered on both sides. The wardens watch their own reflections as much as the trees.

6. **Mist-Chapel** — Stilted planks; votive lanterns gutter under damp rafters.

♠ **RITUAL**

The icon has no face. Worshippers say it lost its features to the fog, one by one.

7. **Dead-Cut Canal** — Old imperial ditch; patrolled by eel boats and law.

♠ **TRAVEL**

The eels have eyes like men. Fishermen throw back any that blink.

8. **Drowned Copse** — Root-tangles clutch tide like old hands; bones in the bark.

♠ **DEATH**

The trees were planted on a mass grave. They grew twisted, hungry.

9. **Fogmill Ridge** — Wind vanes vanish into cloud; gears hiss like prayers to fog.

♠ **WEATHER**

The miller grinds salt, not grain. The fog claims his breath each turning.

10. **Salt-Pan Terraces** — Patched with peat; ward-salt dries under nets, watched by monks.

♠ **RESOURCE**

The monks chant without ceasing. If they stop, the salt spoils — and so does the warding.

J **Fort-Stair** — Stacked timber and stone; flags swallowed by mist, guards by routine.

♠ **AUTHORITY**

The flags are changed daily. The ones that vanish are never spoken of again.

Q **Witchlight Bridge** — Over black runnel; ninth plank “counted” but unseen.

♠ **THRESHOLD**

The missing plank is there — you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.

K **High-Mist Pass** — Through Aelerians; cairns ringed in iron nails, bells in the stones.

♠ **TRAVEL**

Each cairn holds a bell that rang once at the death of a warden. They ring again when mist takes another.

A **Weeping Gate** — Western palisade facing Direwood; bells wired to bones of trees.

♠ **WARD**

♠ **DEATH**

The gate weeps sap that smells of iron and old grief. Wardens collect it in silver cups.

(Warden/Ferryman/Aeler) Bell-warden whose ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts; oath-ferryman gathering toll in salt and names.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Reed-Cutter** — Peat-black hands, precise opinion on fog; knows every safe path.

♥ **TRAVEL**

She cuts reeds in a pattern — one snip, two snips, then a pause for the ninth.

3. **Salt-Monk** — Blesses pans, keeps ward-measure honest; salt as both shield and vow.

♥ **RITUAL**

His tongue is white with salt. He speaks only in blessings or silence.

4. **Bell-Warden** — Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay.

♥ **WARD**

She refuses to write down the ninth note. It lives only in her memory — and that memory is fading.

5. **Oath-Ferryman** — Toll taken in salt and names; remembers both, gathers both.

♡ **DEATH**

♡ **SOCIAL**

His left hand is always gloved. Underneath, the names are carved into his palm.

6. **Lantern Acolyte** — Trims wicks and arguments; light as law in the mist.

♡ **AUTHORITY**

He carries a bell on his belt. It rings once for each lie he hears.

7. **Mist-Pilot** — Linn refugee; ghosts ships through reed-lace — if the cost is breath.

♡ **TRAVEL**

She never speaks above a whisper. Her voice is currency, and she spends it carefully.

8. **Protectorate Clerk** — Aeler oilskin folios, narrow smile; law in triplicate.

♡ **AUTHORITY**

His stamp is a bell. He presses it twice — once for the crown, once for the Hollow.

9. **Shroud-Diver** — Harvests tokens from drowned fields before dawn's false light.

♡ **STEALTH**

♡ **DEATH**

He wears a bell around his ankle. If it rings, he's stayed too long.

10. **Direwood Refugee** — Cold breath, colder stories; knows what the trees whisper.

♡ **FEAR**

She carved out her own tongue. The trees still speak through her — in a voice not her own.

- J **Fog-Knight** — Cavalry rides levee crowns by bellcode; mist as their steed.

♡ **AUTHORITY**

♡ **COMBAT**

Their horses have no shadows. Some say they traded them for fog-sight.

- Q **Legate of Mists** — Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree, bells at their command.

♡ **AUTHORITY**

She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.

K Lord Warden — Local strong hand sworn to Legate's seal; law walks the fens.

♥ **AUTHORITY**

He lost an eye to a wight. He wears a bell in the socket.

A Mist-Seer — Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks.

♥ **MAGIC**

♥ **FEAR**

She has no shadow. The mist took it as a pledge.

(Undead/Weather/Law) Ground-mist lifts off fen and eats tracks by the yard; witch-lights try to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets you.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Lifts from fen; eats tracks by the yard, names by the breath.

♣ **WEATHER**

♣ **DEATH**

Your footfalls vanish behind you. The mist is following, not rising.

3. **Witchlight Count** — Trying to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets your path.

♣ **MAGIC**

♣ **FEAR**

The lights flicker in a pattern — two short, two long. They're signaling someone.

4. **Ward-Salt Short** — Pans go green; bells ring, nothing answers from the other side.

♣ **RESOURCE**

♣ **WARD**

The salt is grey, not white. Someone cut it with grave dust.

5. **Wrong Bell** — Cracked note opens a door the Legate can't close; mist takes the gap.

♣ **MAGIC**

The bell's clapper is a finger bone. The original owner wants it back.

6. **Linn Raid** — Slips reed-maze; hearths douse, horns travel on the fog.

♣ **COMBAT**

The raiders wear bells on their belts — stolen from the last village.

7. **Direwood Moan** — At dusk; Weeping Gate ropes go taut by themselves.

♣ DEATH

♣ FEAR

The moan has words. You don't want to understand them.

8. **Valewood Wind** — Crosses Aberderrin; voices sweet, landmarks false.

♣ WEATHER

♣ MAGIC

The wind smells of honey and rot. Do not follow it.

9. **Bell-Line Failure** — Levee breaks silence; wraith steps across like it owns the road.

♣ WARD

♣ DEATH

The wraith carries a lantern. The light is blue — the color of drowned breath.

10. **Marsh-Quake** — Sod heaves, dyke slumps; causeways and bodies sink together.

♣ DISASTER

The ground exhales. Your name rises from it like smoke.

- J **Protectorate Interdiction** — All ferries sealed “until review”; routes dry up.

♣ AUTHORITY

♣ TRAVEL

The seals are stamped with a bell. The wax is mixed with bone ash.

- Q **Rite-Purge** — Inspectors call local customs heresy; tempers at a boil.

♣ AUTHORITY

♣ SOCIAL

The inspectors carry blank books. They fill them with names of the accused.

- K **General Alarm** — Pall horns sound; every lantern becomes law, every shadow suspect.

♣ AUTHORITY

♣ FEAR

The horns are made from the tusks of a sea beast. The beast's ghost is angry.

A **Tide-Mist** — Rolls from Aberderrin; spirits ride the white and won't be named.

♣ **WEATHER**

♣ **DEATH**

The spirits have no faces — only the faces of the drowned.

(Pass/Seal/Token) Ward-salt allotment draws safe circle once; ferry token crosses named black runnel regardless of curfew.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ward-Salt** — Pure measure draws safe circle once; mist parts, briefly.

◇ **WARD**

The salt is warm. It knows it will be used.

3. **Ferry Token** — Cross named black runnel regardless of curfew or tide.

◇ **TRAVEL**

The token is a knuckle bone. The ferryman accepts it without comment.

4. **Bell-Key** — Unlock and set one bell on the Line to your note; change the song.

◇ **MAGIC**

The key is a tuning fork. Strike it once to claim your note.

5. **Lantern Writ** — Lawful travel at night along levee crown with escort.

◇ **TRAVEL**

◇ **AUTHORITY**

The writ is written on dried bladder. It crinkles when you lie.

6. **Exorcist's Seal** — Stamped clause downgrades "haunt" to "nuisance."

◇ **MAGIC**

The seal is a bell without a clapper. It's silent, like the wraiths it binds.

7. **Codeleaf** — Today's mirror and horn sequences; fog cannot hide what you know.

◇ **TRAVEL**

The leaf is soaked in brine. Read it before it dries.

8. **Protectorate Mark** — Priority rations and rope from Fort-Stair stores.

◇ **RESOURCE**

The mark is a brand. It smokes when you show it.

9. **Wraith-Pardon** — Pardon for desperate deeds done while spirits press near.

◇ **AUTHORITY**

The pardon is signed in salt water. It will dissolve if you misuse it.

10. **Bone-Field License** — Salvage rights at drowned hamlet (with witnesses).

◇ **RESOURCE**

The license is a map drawn on a shroud. Follow the stitch marks.

- J **Refuge-Right** — Move a named household through Gate unchallenged; breath as token.

◇ **SOCIAL**

The right is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt. Nonna will ask.

- Q **Legate's Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; bells ring your decree.

◇ **AUTHORITY**

The Legate's ear is a silver bell. Speak into it once.

- K **Warden's Commission** — Raise levee guards; local doors open, and trust follows.

◇ **AUTHORITY**

The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the fens answer.

- A **Pall Indulgence** — Temporary exception to ward law, spoken and sealed by bell.

◇ **MAGIC**

◇ **AUTHORITY**

The indulgence is a single bell-note, held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/seals/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.

- If any A appears, echo **breath and boundary** — bells answering across water, salt that won't dry, voices returning late.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Breath-Toll:** Many claim the mist remembers every breath. Travelers hold breath crossing bridges, fearing the mist will count them wrong. Mechanically, when you cross a threshold without a ward-salt or bell, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the mist learns your name — gain the MARKED condition (the next spirit encounter starts at Desperate Position).
- **Salt as Promise:** A handful of salt is more than warding — it is a vow. Spill it on plank or stone to swear safety. Once per session, a character may spend a handful of ward-salt to create a **Salt Oath** [4] timer. While the timer has segments, the oath-taker gains +1 die to resist fear or possession. If the oath is broken, the timer fills and the breaker takes Harm 1 (spiritual backlash).
- **The Ninth Bell:** Legends say a ninth bell once rang on the Line. The note is not in any ringbook; no warden speaks of it. Some nights, though, it rings — and gates open where none should be. When the GM spends 3+ SB in a scene, they may declare that the Ninth Bell rings. All characters must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or lose 1 Fatigue (the sound steals breath).
- **Payden's Port:** The only true city in the Mistlands, huddled on the western coast of the Aberderrin. Its wharves are built from salvaged longship timber, and its law is split between the Aeler Legate's seal and the old bell-wardens' traditions. Grain ships leave from its harbour each autumn, carrying the Protectorate's due east — and returning with iron, engineers, and the occasional missionary. The port's inn, the *Drowned Rat*, has a bell that rings once for every sailor lost at sea. It rings often.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Bell-Keeper** — The Sealed Gate. *A bell that never rings, yet holds the threshold closed.*
 - **The Salted One** — Oath of Mercy and Grace. *A prayer that preserves body and soul, but remembers the name of everyone it saves.*
 - **The Mist-Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the fog; the hunger that waits in still air.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and lost souls.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Lucas of the Iron Bell (The Sealed Gate):** The bell-wardens venerate a legendary warden who hammered a ninth bell into the Weeping Gate to seal a Direwood

breach. The bell cracked, but the breach closed. His chisel is kept at Payden's Port; it is said to quench the mist for an hour if struck against an iron post. The Aeler Protectorate has tried to confiscate it twice; both attempts ended with the confiscators lost in fog.

- **Saint Anja of the White Pans (Oath of Mercy and Grace):** A salt-monk who died blessing the pans during a tide-mist. Her body never decayed, and her chapel now serves as a hospice for fog-sick sailors. The Temple of Light sends offerings of fresh water each spring; the Everflame considers her a heretic. Pilgrims who pray at her shrine may ask one question of a drowned ancestor — but the answer is always a single word, and that word is never given freely.
- **The Grey Hospice of the Unnamed:** Sister Darya runs a hospice near Payden's Port. She asks no payment, but she records every patient's name in a book that never dries. The Aeler clerks suspect she is erasing names, not healing wounds. She has been investigated three times; each time, the investigator vanished into the fog and returned with no memory of why they came.
- **The Bell-Ringer's Covenant (The Keeper of the Silent Seal):** Notary Voss is the Protectorate's appointed judge, charged with imposing Aeler law on local customs. He carries a water-timer to measure the shifting of legal moods, but the mist ignores it. His rulings are always delivered in triplicate, and the bell-wardens obey them — slowly. Those who lie before him find that their next passage through the Ghost-Ferry Slip is denied; the ferryman refuses to name them.
- **The Ninth:** In any Mistlands scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the mist's attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count. Those who speak ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the foot of the bed that night — waiting to take a breath.
- **The Black Barrow Keep (Aelinnel Ruin):** Looming over Payden's Port, this ancient workshop of bell-automata and ward-forges is sealed by the Protectorate — but smugglers and treasure-hunters still enter. Locals whisper that the lowest catacombs connect to the Ways Between. The Aeler have tried to collapse the upper levels three times; each time, the rubble was found cleared by morning, with no tracks in the fog.

Mistlands Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a bridge. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.

♣ SUPERSTITION

- **Hold the Ninth Breath:** Cross a threshold while holding your breath. Cancel *Witchlight Count* or take −1 die on your next action (your choice).

♣ SUPERSTITION

- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect against undead for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Legate.

♣ SUPERSTITION

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fog-knights**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirits or patrol boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Protectorate forces or local warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or bell failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **wraith, raiding party, or inspector** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fog-knights, spirits, or Aeler forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **bell-line fails/ward broken/mist claims name**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Legate, Lord Warden, or Mist-Seer** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **mist thickens/bells ring/forest breathes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Mistlands (Bells & Breath):** Bells ring without cause, breath forms visible words, mirrors reflect wrong faces.
- **Mistlands (Salt & Warding):** Salt refuses to dry, ward-runes bleed color, protection tokens crack.
- **Mistlands (Direwood Threat):** Trees whisper your name, roots shift position, forest breath grows stronger.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Silence the Bell (Presence + Stealth):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a ward-salt pouch is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Tide (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Tide-Mist*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Bell & Breath)

- **The Ninth Bell Ringer (Direwood herald)** — *Phases:* Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate. *Cracks:* restore a ringbook; trade a breath; rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails.
- **Queen of Counting Lights (fae arbiter)** — *Phases:* Courtesies → Geas-Market → Counting of Leaves. *Cracks:* return stolen way-marks; speak said and meant; gild the iron.
- **Reed-Wolf Captain (Linn raider)** — *Phases:* Smoke Signals → Night Oars → Thing Verdict. *Cracks:* name a feud-token; win a skald-duel; force harbour-truce under bell and banner.

Patronage & Power

In the Mistlands, power flows through ritual, warding, and the careful balance between the living and the dead. The Aeler Protectorate maintains nominal control through military presence and legal frameworks, but true authority lies with those who understand the bells, the salt, and the breath of the land itself. Local wardens, salt-monks, and bell-keepers hold sway over daily life, while the Legate of the Mists mediates between imperial law and ancient custom.

For the GM: Patronage in the Mistlands revolves around protection — from mist, from spirits, from the encroaching forest. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage that can be turned into greater shelter. To emphasize the folk-horror feel:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (salt, bells, lanterns) that can be challenged, depleted, or voided by the mist itself.
- Let rival factions (Protectorate vs. bell-wardens vs. Direwood refugees) issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the levees, ferries, and watchtowers as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of the old ways (counting breaths, naming spirits, offering salt) determines success.

In the Mistlands, your safety is your standing, and your standing depends on who remembers your name.

Black Barrow Keep — The Ruin Above Payden's Port

Looming over the eastern edge of Payden's Port, Black Barrow Keep is a jagged wound in the skyline. Its basalt walls weep salt, and its broken towers lean into the fog like old men listening for a bell that never rings. The Aelinnel built it in a forgotten age—not as a fortress, but as a *workshop*. Here, they forged bell-automata, copper sentinels, and the first ward-lines that still keep the Direwood at bay. When the Mistlands became a Protectorate, the Aelinnel sealed the deep forges and retreated. The locals say the keep is haunted. The truth is worse: it is not haunted—it is *occupied*.

Below the keep, the catacombs stretch down through nine known levels. Each level was sealed by a different generation of wrights: Aeler engineers, Aelinnel bell-smiths, Linn shipwrights, and older crafts whose names are scrubbed from the records. The lowest level is said to contain a working that has been ticking since before the Hollow learned to count.

Accessing the Keep: The main gate is chained with a bell-lock that requires a copper key and the correct sequence of rings (eight, never nine). Side entrances include a collapsed ropeway from the salt pans, a flooded stair from the Ghost-Ferry Slip, and a smugglers' tunnel that exits near the Grey Hospice. The Protectorate has officially sealed the keep, but wardens look the other way for a share of salvage—or a story about what moves in the deep.

Generator — Black Barrow Keep: Rooms & Encounters

|c|p0.75|

d12 Area / Encounter**d12 Area / Encounter**

1 The Hanging Bell-Garden. A collapsed floor reveals a chamber where bells grow from the ceiling like stalactites. Each bell has a clapper shaped like a finger bone. *Effect: A bell that rings once for each secret spoken beneath it. The ringing can be heard throughout the keep.*

2 The Copper Forge. Still warm, though the fire went out centuries ago. A half-completed automaton sits on the anvil. Its brass skull is hinged open; inside, a nest of salt-eels writhes. *Effect: The forge can be reactivated with a bell-key, producing a single ward-salt token per scene.*

3 The Oublette of the Unnamed. A pit lined with counting marks — eight scratches, a gap, eight scratches. At the bottom, a wright's skeleton still holds a hammer. The hammer rings when you touch it. *Effect: The hammer can drive a copper nail into any surface, sealing a threshold for one scene.*

4 The Echo Scriptorium. Shelves of slate tablets, each inscribed with a single number. The numbers are not in sequence. A ghost wright sits at a desk, writing the same number over and over. *Effect: The ghost will answer one question about the keep's history, but will then ask for a number you have never written.*

5 The Drowned Armoury. Sealed by a slow leak from the salt pans. Weapons float in brine. One of them — a bell-hilted sword — hums when you near it. *Effect: The sword counts your heartbeats. If you draw it in combat, you gain +1 die, but the sword will demand a name at the end of the scene.*

6 The Weeping Cistern. A stone basin filled with black water. The water rises when you speak. A voice from below asks, "What is the ninth number?" *Effect: Answer with silence, and the water recedes, revealing a sealed door. Answer incorrectly, and the cistern floods the room.*

7 The Cogwheel Choir. A chamber of interlocking copper gears, each tooth stamped with a rune. When the wind blows through the broken wall, the gears turn and the runes sing a cracked hymn. *Effect: A character who learns the tune may reroll one failed navigation test while in the Mistlands (once).*

8 The Salt-Liche's Studio. A wright who refused to die. Its flesh is replaced by salt-cured leather and copper wire. It still tries to finish a bell that has no clapper. *Effect: The salt-liche is not hostile, but will trade a bell-key for a memory of fresh water.*

9 The Unstable Lift. A chain-hoist that descends into darkness. The chains are warm. The lift stops at every eighth floor, never the ninth. *Effect: Riding the lift skips*

two levels of the catacombs, but ticks the FOG ATTENTION timer by 1.

10 The Bone Gallery. A corridor lined with the remains of wrights from every generation. Each skeleton wears a different style of bell-maker's apron. The newest apron is still damp. *Effect: A PC may spend a scene searching; on a Wits+Lore roll (DV 4), they find a key, a token, or a warning.*

11 The Ticking Heart. A sealed chamber behind a copper door. Something inside ticks at a steady rhythm. The rhythm changes when you lie. *Effect: The door requires a blood offering and a true confession to open. Inside is a working that can reset one broken bell-line — but it will ask for a year of your life.*

12 The Ninth Gate. A door that appears only when the keep's bells have rung eight times in sequence. Beyond it, a spiral stair descends into absolute silence. No echo returns. *Effect: This leads to the lowest catacomb, where the first wright's original bell-line generator still turns. Activating it would drive the Direwood back a mile — but the noise would wake the Ninth Bell Ringer.*

To use: Roll once for the room, then optionally roll again for a resident, hazard, or treasure from the appropriate tables in §0.8, §0.8, or §0.8. For the deeper catacombs, increase the DV of all spirit-related rolls by 1 and add a STALE AIR timer [4] at the start of each scene.

Factions in the Keep

- **The Bell-Wrights' Ghosts:** Ancient Aelinnel spirits who still maintain the lower forges. They ignore the living unless the forges are disturbed. Offerings of copper nails or a correctly rung bell will buy safe passage.
- **The Protectorate Salvage Team:** Aeler engineers and a squad of fog-knights, ostensibly "surveying" the keep for hazards. They will confiscate any working bell they find and arrest anyone without a Protectorate writ. Their captain has a brass hand that is also a tuning fork.
- **The Hollow's Anticipators:** A cult that believes the keep was built to contain the Hollow's attention. They leave offerings of salt and silence. They are not dangerous — but they will follow you, writing down every bell you ring and every name you speak.

Catacombs Depth Timer For expeditions that descend below the first sub-level, track a **Depth Timer [6]**. Each time the party descends a stair, uses the unstable lift, or passes a sealed door, tick the timer. At 3 segments: all navigation rolls gain +1 DV (the walls shift). At 6 segments: the party reaches a sealed level that requires a bell-key, a blood offering, or a true name to open. The deepest level (Depth 6 or more) connects to the Ways Between — a mistake may drop the party into the Hollow's own threshold.

Ykrul

Wolf Standards, Winter Camps.

“The Ykrul ride the Violet Steppe, where the sky is a cup and the horizon its lip. Their Kon’reh is not a code but a compass – it reads the land in steps, in stops, in the weight of a breath. Every crossing has its cost, every ford its toll, every feud its balance in the space between hoof and earth. But the Steppe does not deal in coin; it deals in the weight of a promise and the length of a life.”

— Aeler Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? *Fermented mare’s milk and dried meat – the milk is drunk warm from the skin, the meat is sliced thin and dried on saddle-pommels. The meat carries the taste of horse sweat. The milk carries the taste of the steppe.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To sit a horse. Ykrul children are placed on a horse before they can stand. A child who falls learns to hold tighter. A child who cannot ride cannot eat.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their braids. Red for the Wolf Clan, black for the Iron Horse, grey for the Salt Steppe. A stranger whose braids are cut has been shamed. A stranger with no braids has no clan. A stranger with no clan is prey.*

What is the most common crime? *Horse theft. A stolen horse is a stolen relative. The price is blood – the thief’s or the owner’s. The evidence is the horse’s memory. Horses do not lie.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Khagan is not chosen by blood. He is chosen by the horse. Every five years, the clan chiefs lead their best stallions to the sacred ring. The horse that steps forward first chooses the next Khagan. The horse has not stepped forward in twenty years.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the sky. Bodies are placed on open platforms, left for the wind and birds. The bones are ground into powder, mixed with clay, fired into beads. The beads are worn by the dead’s descendants. The beads are warm. The warmth is memory.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a hostage string – a braided cord that ties your wrist to the wronged party’s. The cord is cut when the apology is accepted. If the cord is never cut, you are bound. The binding is lifelong. The binding is called “friend.”*

What is the most important festival? *The First Grass (spring equinox). The herds are released onto new pasture. The riders race to the horizon and back. The winner*

names the summer camps. The loser tends the sick animals. The loser always wins next year.

***What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person?** The Sky-Speaker is a fraud. She cannot call storms. She cannot read omens. She is a horse-witch who learned to read the clouds. The clouds are reliable. The Khagan does not want to know.*

0.9 Ykrul — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The steppe owes nothing. The wolf pays no debts. Only the fool plays for beauty; the wise play for the exit.*

Khatun Bortai of the Ring (Elite): “We do not dream on the steppe. We count. We measure breath, grain, and the length of a blade. My grandfather taught me Kon’reh before I could hunt: the board is dirt, the pieces are sheep-bones, and the lesson is always the same—the game ends when one side has no roads left. Politics is merely the same game played with living pieces. To lead here is to know when to trade, when to raid, and when to ride away. Sentiment is a luxury of farmers. We are the children of the horse, the wind, and the knife.”

Herd-Scout Sogata (Commoner): “Kon’reh teaches that the straight road is a lie. The wise shepherd knows the river bends not from weakness, but from wisdom. We are practical folk. A horse that cannot carry you is meat. An oath that cannot be kept is smoke. Speak true, ride steady, and always count your exits before you enter. The steppe does not forgive the beautiful mistake—only the useful truth.”

Genre / Mood: Nomadic epic, pragmatic cunning, wind-scoured honour, Scythian steppe.
Starting Location: A winter camp on the steppe edge, banners snapping in frost-bright wind as the Khagan’s fires burn low in the east. A Khatun of the Ring offers a clay cup of salted tea. “The Khagan’s kin ride from the salt pan. The old sayings say the straight road is a lie. You came by the bent path—the wolf knows you. Speak your errand before the wind changes. Trade is welcome; lies are tallied.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ykrul ride the endless Violet Steppe, where the horizon drinks the sky and survival is a game played without mercy. They are a pragmatic people—harder and more practical than the settled folk of the south. Sentiment is a waste of breath; beauty is a fool’s consolation. Their philosophy is not written in books but scratched in the dirt boards of *Kon’reh*, a game of encirclement, escape, and blockade played with pebbles and sheep-bones. Every child learns before they can hunt: count your exits before you enter, never commit to a single path, and an ally untested is a blade without a sheath. This is not mysticism. It is arithmetic. The steppe is a hard teacher, and the Ykrul are its starkest students.

What outsiders call “geometry” the Ykrul call *the Count*—the simple, bone-deep understanding that every route has a price, every camp has a weakness, and every alliance is only as strong as the remounts that sustain it. Their law lives in saddlebags. Every crossing has its toll, every ford its depth, every feud a reckoning measured in horse-lengths and heartbeats. Hosts gather by the thousand, then scatter at a word; one night you share their fires, the next they test your bonds. Their banners are wolves’ teeth, their treaties braided cords, their memory longer than the rivers that cut the grass. The old folk still recite the Thirty-Six Sayings of the Road, but the wisest know the thirty-seventh is the one you learn alone, on a night when the stars blink out and the wolf does not howl.

What you notice first: The smell of horse sweat and woodsmoke. The way every rider counts hoofbeats under their breath. The silence when a stranger approaches the fire. The cold assessment in every eye—not hostile, merely reckoning value.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ride between two wolves at dusk. The space between them is a snare with no exit. In *Kon’reh* it is called the Closed Circle; in life it is called death.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

In any Ykrul camp, the ninth cup poured at a feast is for the ancestors. The wise pour eight and leave the ninth as a pause. Those who pour the ninth cup find that the ancestors drink—and the ancestors are always thirsty. The next morning, the pourer’s shadow is one inch shorter. If the same person pours the ninth cup nine times, their shadow vanishes entirely, and they become a ghost rider, forever counting cups at the edge of the firelight.

0.9.1 Regional Mood: The Pragmatism of the Steppe

Here, the horizon is not a line—it is a reckoning. The Ykrul measure distance in oaths and remounts, not miles. A camp is a weave of debts owed and honour satisfied, audited by the Camp-Mother’s sharp eyes. A feud is a slow equation: blood in, blood out, with interest compounded by winter. The Khagan rules not by force alone but by keeping the old calculations—the unwritten rules that govern every crossing, every treaty, every duel. Break the pattern, and the steppe itself may turn against you. Keep it, and even enemies will share

their salt, though they will count the grains. The Ykrul build no monuments. They build relationships, each one a stone in an invisible cairn that stretches from the Dolmis to the Aberderrin, and each one valued only so long as it holds weight.

0.9.2 Prominent NPCs of the Ykrul

p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2
Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Khatun Bortai	Keeper of the Ring	Keep the clans fed and mounted; let poets starve	Her hostage strings are braided from the hair of oath-breakers.
Noyan Temur	Banner-lord of the Red Reeds	Win a winter pasture without losing a single man to talk	He has never lost a negotiation. He has never needed to speak.
Sogata	Herd-Scout (commoner exemplar)	Read the weather before the storm because a wet horse is a dead horse	He can read a trail by the way the grass bends—and a liar by the way a rider checks his exits.
Elder Saruul	Bone-Singer	Keep the names of the dead so debts are not forgotten	She sings the names of the departed each dawn; the dead sing back.
The Dust Prince	Raider who rides the wind's lee	Amass enough salt to buy a clan because gold is too heavy to run with	He offers escort braids for secrets, never seen from the front.
Storm-Singer Urum	Sky-Speaker	Sell weather on credit because even the sky is a resource	His bills come due during the Wolf Moon.

0.9.3 Names of the Ykrul

Inspired by the open steppe and the deep east: guttural stops, flowing vowels, and suffixes that mark lineage or deed.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Bortai	Temur	Sogata	<i>the Grey</i>
Urum	Saruul	Khorch	<i>Red-String</i>
Khasar	Altan	Noyan	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
Mongke	Checheg	Borjigin	<i>Storm-Born</i>
Edil	Borte	Uriankhai	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
Toghrul	Orghana	Qasar	<i>the Silent</i>

(**Steppe Road/Winter Ring/Ford**) Wolf Road milepost of stacked stones with wind whining through eye-holes; winter camp ring with felt tents in horseshoe facing wind.

0.9.4 Using the Ykrul Deck

Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).

Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/remounts/truces) that change position rather than call for a roll.

If any **Ace** appears, echo **steppe and sky** motifs—wind that speaks, horses that remember, treaties that bind across generations, and the cold arithmetic of Kon'reh made manifest.

0.9.5 Spades — Places

Steppe Road, Winter Ring, Ford

2 Wolf Milepost

[Travel]Stacked stones; wind whines through eye-holes. Each stone is a tally. Remove one, and the wind names you debtor.

3 Remount Station

[Travel]Low corral with stamped snow and tether-posts. The tether-posts are carved with the names of dead horses. The living ones remember.

4 Birch Windbreak

[Ritual]Above black-earth tracks; old offerings in the bark. The offerings are strips of wool. Each strip is a prayer for safe crossing.

5 Salt Pan

[Weight]Crusted white; hoof-prints like stars across the void. The pan has a name: “The Khagan’s Mirror.” Look into it, and you see what you owe.

6 Reed Ford

[Travel]River braids; poles mark yesterday’s safe line. The poles shift in the night. The river’s path changes with the moon.

7 Trading Palisade

[Trade]Way-post with wolf-skull pennons snapping. The skulls face outward. They watch for liars and bad weights.

8 Winter Camp

[Social]Felt tents in a horseshoe facing the wind. The open end is for guests. The closed end is for the ancestors.

9 Kurgan Field

[Death]Low barrows; horse-bones bead the grass like prayer beads. The bones were placed by a bone-singer. Each bead is a name.

10 Watch Kopje

[Weather]Lonely tor with signal fire-scar; the eye of the steppe. The fire-scar is from a signal that saved a host. The smoke still smells of hope.

J Pontoon Crossing

[Travel]Laced hides creak; the current speaks fast and hungry. The hides are from horses that died crossing. Their ghosts still pull.

Q Council Hollow

[Social]Standards planted; the ground tamped like a war-drum. The standards have ears. Speak a treason here, and every clan will know by dawn.

K Khagan's Station

[Authority]Broad ger on a timber platform; guards in silence. The guards never blink. They are paid in salt and secrets.

A Sky Steppe

[Mystery]Open, wind like a voice; tracks keep pace beside you. The tracks are not yours. They belong to the ancestors who ride with you.

0.9.6 Hearts — People & Factions

Host, Envoy, Rider

2 Herd-Scout

[Travel]Three ponies and six opinions; the horizon as a map. He can read a trail by the way the grass bends. He can read a liar by the way a rider checks his exits.

3 Camp-Mother

[Social]Chooses where fires live; hospitality is law. She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.

4 Banner Youth

[Combat]Minding the wolves' tooth standard; pride as duty. The standard is older than his grandmother's grandmother. He will die before it falls.

5 Salt-Broker

[Trade]Weighs promises like grain; trade as precision. Her scales are honest—because a dishonest scale is a broken tool, and tools are expensive.

6 Remount Keeper

[Travel]String-master with a book of brands; horses as currency. His book is written in hoof-prints. He can read a horse's soul.

7 Bone-Singer

[Death]Knows the kurgans' proper names; death as memory. She sings the names of the dead each dawn. The dead sing back.

8 Road-Judge

[Law]Tümen scribe with seals and a patient ear. His seals are from three empires. He uses whichever one is still valid.

9 Noyan Envoy

[Social]Silver paiza, iron smile; diplomacy as a blade. His paiza was a gift from a Khagan who is now dead. He does not mention that.

10 Host Captain

[Combat]The tent-wall is a map; strategy in every fold. He can see a battle in the way smoke rises. He is usually right.

J Falcon Courier

[Travel]Leather gauntlets, answers sooner than asked. The falcon is a sleeper agent. It belongs to a different clan. The courier doesn't know.

Q Khatun of Ring

[Law]Keeper of camp-law and hostage strings. Her strings are braided from the hair of hostages. She knows each strand's owner.

K Khagan's Kin

[Social]A nephew or niece sent to bind a foedus with a look. They have never lost a negotiation. They have never needed to speak.

A Sky-Speaker

[Magic]Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them a price. They can call lightning—or call it off. The price is always a story.

0.9.7 Clubs — Complications/Threats

Law, Weather, Feud

2 White Squall

[Weather]Dry snow, lost horizons; navigation by gut and horse sense. The snow tastes of iron. Someone is bleeding nearby.

3 Rasputitsa

[Weather]The road becomes porridge; wheels are lies on the earth. The mud has a smell—old blood and older lies.

4 Remount Sickness

[Death]A cough in the string; swaps get awkward, trust thinner. The cough is a curse. The horses know who cast it.

5 Salt Shortage

[Weight]Meat spoils; tempers thin like winter air. The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.

6 Hostage Call

[Social]Protocol invoked; someone must sit in the tent. The tent has no floor. The hostage can see the earth beneath—and the bones.

7 Feud Spark

[Weight]A name spoken wrong reopens an old debt; blood is the only coin that pays. The name was spelled correctly. The insult was in the pause before it.

8 Grassfire

[Disaster]Runs with the wind faster than horses; escape as a prayer. The fire has a face. It is the face of a Khagan who burned a village.

9 Foedus Recall

[Law]Treaty terms re-read; your papers disagree. The treaty was written on both sides. The other side used a different ink.

10 River Break

[Travel]Ice goes; ferries don't; crossing becomes a gamble. The ice is still thick in the middle. The edges are lying.

J Raid Shadow

[Combat]Another banner follows at a patient distance. They are not attacking. They are waiting for you to make a mistake.

Q Kurultai Call

[Social]Camps converge; travel becomes politics. The kurultai has a list of grievances. Your name is near the top.

K Wolf Muster

[Authority]A levy raised; every road a checkpoint, every rider a judge. The muster horn is a wolf's skull. It sounds like a scream.

A Sky Omen

[Omen]Three suns, or none; routes rewrite themselves. The omen is a wedge of cranes flying north in winter. The sky is wrong.

0.9.8 Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

Pass, Remount, Truce

2 Camp Token

[Social]One night's lawful fire and fodder; hospitality as a right. The token is a horsehair braid. Burn it to claim your fire.

3 Salt Allotment

[Trade]Draw from a named store without quarrel. The allotment is a salt-cake. Break it in half to share.

4 Ford-Right

[Travel]Cross a named braid at lawful depth. The right is a pole. Plant it in the river, and the ford will hold—once.

5 Remount Chit

[Travel]Swap two tired mounts for fresh. The chit is a horse's tooth. The remount keeper will not smile when you present it.

6 Escort Braid

[Travel]Two riders see you through a bad stretch. The braid is woven from the riders' own hair. They will die before they cut it.

7 Safe-Hostage

[Social]Place or take token-kin for a truce. The hostage is a child. The child is patient.

8 Paiza Tablet

[Authority]Priority on the Wolf Road and at posts. The tablet is bronze. It is warm when your reputation is good.

9 Foedus Seal

[Law]A treaty clause that trumps petty order. The seal is a wolf's head. Press it into wax, and the steppe listens.

10 Market-Green

[Trade]Trade under a banner; weapons sheathed. The banner is a green field. No blood may be spilled beneath it.

J Standard Guard

[Combat]Travel under wolf-tooth; raiders defer. The standard is a wolf's tooth on a pole. Raiders will bow—or die.

Q Ring Audience

[Social]The Khatun hears you alone; precedent sticks. The audience is held at midnight. The fire is the only witness.

K Khagan's Writ

[Authority]Doors open, mouths close across the steppe. The writ is a sheet of hammered silver. It bends, but it does not break.

A Sky's Exception

[Weather]Once, the weather ignores you (storm, whiteout, dust). The exception is a single breath. Use it well.

0.9.9 Ykrul Mechanics

Core Rules

Kon'reh — The Game of the Steppe The Ykrul do not speak of “geometry.” They speak of *Kon'reh*, a dirt-board game of encirclement, escape, and blockade played with pebbles and bone. Every Ykrul child learns its lessons: count your exits before you enter; never commit to a single path; a screen of light pieces can trap a heavy king; the best move is the one your opponent thinks you have forgotten. In Ykrul culture, Kon'reh is not recreation—it is education. A war-council may be fought out on a Kon'reh board before a single arrow is nocked. A treaty may be argued as a series of moves and counter-moves. When a Ykrul says “the Count,” they mean the cold reckoning of advantage: remounts, routes, grain-days, and the price of a blade in winter.

In play: When a Ykrul NPC evaluates an offer or a threat, they are playing Kon'reh in their head. Social rolls against Ykrul suffer +1 DV unless the player can demonstrate a “route of escape” (an exit, a concession, or a hostage) that makes the deal survivable for both sides.

Hostage Strings [4] Every oath is secured with a **hostage string**—a token kin, retainer, or sworn ally left in the other camp. If the deal is broken, the hostage's fate becomes the story's next beat. Mechanically: create a 4-segment *Hostage* timer for any major treaty. On breach, the timer becomes a countdown to vengeance. Ykrul take hostages as a matter of course; refusing to give one is treated as a declaration of bad faith.

Steppe Law Travelers are bound by **steppe law**: hospitality lasts three nights, insults last three generations. The Keeper may demand 1 SB when either law is broken. The three nights are measured by the Camp-Mother's fire; the three generations are measured by the Bone-Singer's memory.

Sky Omens When the sky shows strange signs—mock-suns, green fire, thunder without storm—the steppe itself speaks. Once per scene, players may treat an omen as a *Diamond*, shifting Position without a roll. The GM may bank 1 SB for future weather complications. Pragmatic Ykrul treat omens as weather-data misread by the fearful; even so, they do not ride against them.

Bowl and Board Ykrul elders settle disputes not by shouting but by drawing two circles in the dirt: the **Bowl** for fairness, then the **Board** for routes and concessions. A successful *Wits + Lore* (or relevant skill) roll creates a *Seasonal Concession String* at a ford, harbor, or pass. On a miss, the **Market Moot** [4] timer advances as factions argue.

Local Patrons

[nosep]

- **The Hoof** — The Traveler. *The path that never ends, the remount that never tires.*
- **The Wolf's Tooth** — The Witness. *Every oath is counted. Every broken promise is a scar.*
- **The Salt Throat** — Maelstraeus. *The weight that salts your tongue; the interest that blinds your horses.*
- **The Sky Father** — Kuva. *The wind that carries names; the storm that erases them.*

The Thirty-Seven Sayings of the Road (Excerpts)

The Ykrul teach strategy not in manuals but in proverbs—each a line of play from Kon'reh. A few of the most quoted:

Let the river freeze before you cross. — Do not rush. Let the opponent make the first move; your opening will be built on their impatience.

Borrow a corridor to trap a king. — When the enemy carves a path toward you, let it deepen. Then seal the mouth behind them.

Loot a burning house. — Strike only when the enemy is committed elsewhere.

Hide your dagger behind a smile. — Threaten one flank; strike the other.

The reed bends, the oak breaks. — Yield to overwhelming force, but do not break; preserve your core.

A distant banner casts no shadow. — A threat far away is no threat at all; control the centre.

The guest who outstays his welcome steals the host's peace. — Allow no force, however small, to remain within your lines uncontrolled.

Count exits, not victims. — Before you move, count the ways your foe can flee. If the number is greater than zero, you have not yet won.

Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

[nosep]

- **Salt to the Wind:** Toss a pinch into the air before a long ride. Ignore the first *White Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the String:** Tie a single knot in a hostage cord. Cancel *Feud Spark* or take -1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Kurgan:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into a horse's ear. Gain +1 Effect when raiding their clan this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bone-Singer.

Strain Budget (SB) Spends

Minor (1 SB)

[nosep]

- **Exposure:** Road-judges or border riders take notice.
- **Noise:** A nearby camp or raiding party is alerted.
- **Trace:** Hoofprints or broken grass mark your route for feud-kin.
- **Delay:** A horse throws a shoe, a rope breaks—lose time.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on fodder or water timer.

Moderate (2 SB)

[nosep]

- **Alarm Raised:** A watch kopje signals; riders are coming.
- **Position Lost:** Rasputitsa or white squall hides the trail.
- **Foe Appears:** A raid shadow or hostage taker arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A saddle snaps, a bowstring frays.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A river breaks, a ford becomes impassable.

Serious (3 SB)

[nosep]

- **Reinforcements:** A wolf muster or kurultai war party arrives.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A horse goes lame, a paiza cracks.
- **Major Twist:** A grassfire cuts off retreat, or a feud spark escalates.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a campaign timer (e.g. **Hostage Crisis**).
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Exhausted** or **Marked by Feud**.

Major (4+ SB)

[nosep]

- **Trap Springs:** A hidden kurgan collapses, a pontoon sinks.
- **Authority Arrival:** Khatun of the Ring, Khagan's Kin, or Sky-Speaker intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A sky omen rewrites the terrain; paths appear or vanish.
- **Patron Omen:** A wolf watches, a horse speaks, the wind carries a name.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The feud is not what it seemed; the hostage was a willing sacrifice.

Region-Specific SB Options

[nosep]

- **Steppe Law:** Hospitality fails, insults echo, treaties shift mid-parley.
- **Horse Culture:** Mounts refuse to move, remount posts are empty, riding rolls suffer -1 die.
- **Sky Omens:** Weather changes instantly, stars point the wrong way, a raven shadows the party.

0.9.10 Extensions (Plug-in)**Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)**

[nosep]

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Ride):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud*.
- **Cut the Herd (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a *remount chit* is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *White Squall*, you pick who keeps their bearings; on a miss, the GM does.

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex of the Violet Steppe.

1. Wolf milepost with fresh red thread; someone retied the law.
2. Reed ford poles lying on bank; current whispers a different depth.
3. Fallen standard tooth used as a chopping block; grooves still warm.
4. Circle of pony skulls facing east; one blinks when the wind shifts.
5. Snow trench with cudgel steps; no prints leave it.
6. Copper salt-scale hung from a birch; pans balance only under oath.
7. Hoof-bells threaded on hair; ringing calls riders—or storms.
8. Abandoned paiza shard wedged in a milestone; edges bite skin.
9. Kurgan capstone chalked with a name misspelled; feud waiting.
10. Flint knapper's tarp half-buried; a perfect arrowhead points north.
11. Blue-fledged signal arrow stuck in frost; message in the vane.
12. Camp-sweep marks: three rings—last night was a council.
13. Wheel rut frozen like glass; a face looks up from inside.
14. Salt-brined jerky hanging from a tripod; untouched by birds.
15. River ice singing in thirds; ferryman's pole wedged under.
16. Pony hobble-rope knotted in hostage-string pattern.
17. Cold forge dug into loess; tools wrapped in wolfskin.
18. Child's braid-bead dropped in snow; still warm to the tongue.
19. Thorn-tether scratched with clan brands; two over-scratched.
20. Bone flute lodged in a cairn; playing it summons a road-judge.

Lair Seeds (One-Page Rides)

1. **Ger of Echoes** — Empty felt walls repeat anything uttered in the Khagan's voice once per night.
2. **Salt-Pit Shrine** — Rope winch to brine caverns; offerings are tears and horsehair.
3. **Remount Vault** — Subterranean stables under reed mats; mounts won't leave without a tale.
4. **Kite-Maker's Bluff** — Bone kites pinned on racks; their shadows scout for raiders.
5. **Storm-Rider's Stone** — Pillar that hums to hooves; racing round it sets weather wagers.
6. **Frozen Court** — Ice dais in a dry riverbed; law held here counts triple until thaw.
7. **Banner Grave** — Flags planted like trees; each knows the battle it died in.
8. **String-Mother's Yard** — Web of hostage cords; cutting one opens a secret but starts a feud.
9. **Fire-Under-Snow** — Warm vent where foals winter; spirits ask for salt-song.
10. **Quiet Palisade** — Trading post where voices fail; deals done in gesture and cut meat.
11. **Ashen Trident** — Three lightning-split birches; tie a braid to choose a road's luck.
12. **Grey Ger** — Moves at night; inside, a camp-mother tests your hospitality the other way around.

Steppe Bestiary (Palette)

[nosep]

- **Steppe Manticores** — Lionine torsos, porcupine tails of bone quills. *Signs:* quills in fence-posts; ponies refuse to drink. *Hook:* play a raid-song backward; they circle to listen.
- **Dust Hulks** — Wind-packed silhouettes that rise from dunes. *Signs:* dunes "breathe"; grit sifts upward. *Hook:* spill water on their shadow; they settle for a watch.
- **Bone Kites** — Carrion birds with rune-etched pinions. *Signs:* spiral flights over kurgans. *Hook:* offer a name-stake (twig with hair) to barter silence.
- **Frost Wargs** — Blue-pelt wolves that steam cold. *Signs:* rime on tracks; breath that crackles. *Hook:* warm milk poured on ice buys one unchallenged crossing.
- **Reed Stalkers** — Long-necked marsh hunters, gait like stilts. *Signs:* pole-pocks where no ferryman walks. *Hook:* carry reeds in your mouth; they read it as truce.
- **Salt Screamers** — Pale eels in dry pans; voices like flutes. *Signs:* fissures crusted with salt frost. *Hook:* scatter ash; they coil to sing and forget to bite.

Relic & Find (d10)

When you uncover a kurgan cache or a lost hoard, roll or pick:

1. Wolf-tooth standard tip; planted, it demands silence for parley.
2. Bronze paiza half; merchants honour it as full once—then talk.
3. Salt-needle that points to the nearest brine store.
4. Frost-bitten stirrup; mount that wears it ignores ice once.
5. Braid-bead of hostage glass; melts when a string is cut nearby.
6. River-depth rod carved with safe counts for three fords.
7. Iron hoof-bell that rings for liars at council.
8. Bone-lot cup; roll it to name which feud clause applies.
9. Wind-wrung scarf; pass it round to share breath in a white squall.
10. Wolf-road tablet scrap; reads as a *Foedus Seal* to one clerk.

Complication Twists (d8)

When a travel complication arises, roll or choose a twist that deepens the story.

1. *White Squall* reveals a remount vault's smoke hole; entering angers reed stalkers.
2. *Rasputitsa* exposes kurgan stones; riding around them starts a name-claim.
3. *Feud Spark* was staged by a salt-broker; paying in *Salt Allotment* unmasks them.
4. *Hostage Call* is for a *Safe-Hostage* you already carry—by another name.
5. *Grassfire* runs uphill toward a council hollow; smoke votes before riders do.
6. *Foedus Recall* cites a river you crossed yesterday—now it flows the other way.
7. *Raid Shadow* is your own tracks, mirrored by sky omens; choose which you admit.
8. *Kurultai Call* stacks councils; words spoken in one bind you in the other.

Boss Seeds (Three-Phase Foes)

[nosep]

- **The String-Mother (Nine Hostages)** — *Phases*: Knot → Tighten → Sever. *Cracks*: return a hostage string, win a Bowl and Board arbitration, cut the right knot.
- **The Dust Prince (Rider of the Red Wind)** — *Phases*: Raid Shadow → Salt Tithe → Kurultai Coup. *Cracks*: spill a salt allotment in his path, unmask his face before the council, outride him through a white squall.

0.9.11 Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

[nosep]

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice near the salt pans. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the herders, trying to untie her cord from a Ykrul blood-weight.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The kurgans are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of old Khagans bound by unfinished wergild. Saikou Ira would carry a bag of salt in each hand here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the salt-brokers. Take it, and your store never runs dry—but the coin will reappear in the salt pan at every new moon.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ykrul psions are called “Weather-Readers.” They taste the future in the wind. Road-judges employ two—and have never trusted a verdict they didn’t hear from the sky.

0.9.12 Ykrul of the Eastern Steppe — The Iron Grass Clans

The wind is colder here, and so are the hearts. We do not forget an insult because we cannot afford to. The grass is thinner, the wolves are bolder, and the sky speaks only in threats. The western Ykrul trade in stories. We trade in teeth.

Eastern Khatun (Elite): “The westerners count their weights in silk and verses. We count ours in frost and iron. A broken oath here is not a story for the skald—it is a hole in the winter larder. We do not forgive because we cannot. The Hollow rides with us every night. We have no room for mercy, and even less for poetry. Kon’reh is still our teacher, but the board is frozen, and the pieces are bones.”

The Eastern Ykrul share blood with their Violet Steppe cousins, but generations on the harsher eastern ranges—where the Kuvani horse clans also roam—have carved them into a different shape. They are more isolationist, more pragmatic, and their honour code has less room for talk. They live among the Kuvani but do not intermarry; they trade when the snows allow, raid when the grass is thin, and speak a dialect that grinds like stones in a riverbed. Outsiders call them the *Iron Grass Clans*. They call themselves *Those Who Remember Winter*.

Eastern Variations (Use with Ykrul Core)

When generating an Eastern Ykrul camp, clan, or encounter, roll on the tables below instead of (or in addition to) the standard Ykrul generators.

Eastern Clan Trait (d6)

1. **Frost-Bitten:** The clan survives on the edge of the permafrost. +1 die to Survival in cold weather, but –1 die to all social rolls with lowlanders (they stink of frozen horse).
2. **Kuvani-Kin:** This clan has traded with the Kuvani for generations. They speak the Kuvani tongue and may call on one Kuvani remount station per journey. Rivals whisper they have forgotten the old ways.
3. **Wolf-Pacted:** The clan has a standing truce with a local wolf pack. Wolves do not attack their herds. In exchange, the clan leaves every ninth calf unbranded—for the wolves. The pack sometimes fights beside them in battle (Cap 2, appears once per arc).
4. **Salt-Misers:** This clan controls a small, bitter salt pan. They trade salt for iron with the Kuvani. They are wealthy but paranoid; any visitor is assumed to be a spy. +1 die to detect deception, but starting Position in parley is Desperate.
5. **Curse-Bearers:** A broken oath from three generations ago still hangs over the clan. Their horses are prone to sickness, and their children are born with grey eyes. They seek a way to lift the curse—and will do almost anything to find it.
6. **Road-Breakers:** This clan claims the right to open or close the high passes east. They carry a brass key (actually a bronze paiza) that Kuvani caravans recognise. They are isolationist, proud, and quick to draw steel over matters of passage.

Eastern Steppe Hazards (d6) When travelling through Eastern Ykrul territory, roll for a hazard (or replace a standard Clubs draw).

1. **Frost-Rime Grass:** The grass is coated in a crystalline frost that cuts horse legs. Travel speed halved for one leg. On a failed Survival roll, one mount goes lame (mark 1 Fatigue or lose 1 Supply).
2. **Wolf Howl at Dusk:** A pack shadows the party for a day and a night. They will not attack unless the party is weak or separated. If a character sleeps alone, roll Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or be found by wolves at midnight.
3. **Ice Lens Mirage:** The flat steppe plays tricks. Navigation rolls suffer –1 die for the leg. On a miss, the party wanders into a kurgan field—the dead are restless. Start a **Spirit Attention** [4] timer.
4. **Salt Pan Crack:** A dried salt pan has a hidden fissure. A horse or wagon breaks through. Lose 1 Supply (salt pork ruined) and mark 1 Fatigue for the party as they pull the animal free.
5. **Kuvani Border Markers:** The party has crossed into a Kuvani grazing ground without permission. Kuvani riders appear (Cap 2, non-hostile unless provoked). They demand a story or a small offering of salt. Refusal starts a **Border Dispute** [4] timer.

6. **Silent Sky:** No birds, no wind, no insect sounds. The Hollow is near. For the next scene, any roll that shows a 1 also summons a **Oath-Keeper**—it will appear at the end of the scene to ask one question. Answer poorly, and it takes a memory.

Eastern Ykrul Encounter (d8) When meeting an Eastern Ykrul camp or patrol, roll for their initial disposition and a twist.

1. **Hungry Hosts:** The camp is low on supplies. They will trade—at ruinous prices. But they will also remember a fair deal. If you overpay (give 1 extra Supply), gain a **String** (Eastern Ykrul favour).
2. **Grieving Clan:** A child died last night. The camp is in mourning. They will not trade or talk. If you offer a true story about a lost loved one, they will share a meal.
3. **Feud-Watch:** The clan is on alert for raiders from a rival banner. They mistake the party for scouts. The first social roll is at Desperate Position. A successful Deception or Bribe (cost 1 Boon or 1 Supply) clears the misunderstanding.
4. **Salt-Broker's Caravan:** A small caravan of salt traders, heavily armed. They are willing to trade salt for news of the west. They ask pointed questions about the Violet Steppe—they are planning a raid.
5. **Kurgan Pilgrims:** A group of bone-singers and their guards are travelling to a sacred kurgan. They will allow the party to accompany them if the party helps perform a ritual: each member must whisper a forgotten name into a horse skull. Afterwards, the party gains +1 die to resist fear for one day, but the Hollow knows one of your names.
6. **Storm-Singer's Challenge:** A sky-speaker challenges the party to a weather-calling contest. Roll Spirit+Lore vs. DV 4. On a success, the storm-singer is impressed and grants a **Sky's Exception** (ignore one weather hazard). On a failure, the party is drenched and loses 1 Fatigue.
7. **Hollow-Touched Camp:** The camp is silent. Everyone is sitting still, staring at a single point. A Oath-Keeper has passed through. If the party can speak the name of the broken oath, the camp will wake. Otherwise, they must leave an offering of salt and retreat.
8. **Iron Grass Market:** A rare gathering of three clans at a neutral ford. The market lasts only one day. Goods for sale: remounts (cost 1 Supply each), salt (1 Supply per 2 portions), iron arrowheads (1 Boon for 1 die bonus on next ranged attack), and one cursed paiza (half price, but the previous owner's ghost follows).

Eastern Ykrul Customs (d6) When interacting with an Eastern Ykrul camp, roll for a local custom that may affect social rolls.

1. **No Left Hand:** Offering anything with the left hand is an insult. All social rolls using Presence+Sway suffer -1 die unless you explicitly use your right hand.

2. **Fire First, Talk Later:** Guests must warm their hands at the central fire before speaking. If you refuse, the host will be offended—the first request you make is automatically refused.
3. **The Empty Saddle:** One saddle in the camp is always empty. It belongs to a rider who died last winter. If you sit in it, you must tell a story about a death you witnessed. If the story is true, the ghost may give you a warning (GM reveals one future hazard). If false, the ghost haunts you for a day (you gain the **Haunted** condition).
4. **No Naming the Dead:** Eastern Ykrul do not speak the names of the deceased for one year after death. If you accidentally name a dead person, the clan demands a blood-price: 1 Supply or a lock of your hair.
5. **Salt Before Meat:** A meal is not blessed until the host throws a pinch of salt into the fire. If you eat before the salt, you are considered an oath-breaker. The meal will not nourish you (you do not recover Fatigue from that rest).
6. **The Ninth Breath:** When drinking fermented mare's milk, you must pause after the eighth sip. If you take a ninth, you must immediately name an enemy. The clan will consider that enemy as their own for one season. The enemy may not appreciate this.

Eastern Ykrul Superstitions (burn for +1 die once) Add these to the standard Ykrul superstitions when in the eastern steppe.

[nosep]

- **Iron to the Frost:** Press a cold iron nail into the ground before a white squall. Ignore the first *Frost-Rime Grass* penalty.
- **Braid the Tail:** Tie a single knot in a horse's tail hair. Cancel *Wolf Howl at Dusk* or take -1 die on your next survival roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Hollow:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into a salt pan at midnight. Gain +1 Effect when evading Oath-Keepers this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Eastern Khatun.

Eastern Ykrul Boss Seed (d6) When the party faces a major antagonist from the Eastern Ykrul, roll for a unique foe.

1. **The Frost-Khagan (Undying):** A chieftain who froze to death but did not stop riding. *Phases:* Blizzard's Call → Frozen Host → The Long Night. *Cracks:* burn a horse tooth in a fire, speak his true name (carved on his saddle), or offer a living rider to take his place.
2. **The Salt-Throat (Cursed Broker):** A salt merchant who sold his clan's future for wealth. *Phases:* Weigh the Debt → Salt Tithe → The Scales Close. *Cracks:* pay a wergild in untainted salt, expose his false paiza, or cut his hostage string with a silver knife.

3. **The Hollow's Rider (Oath-Keeper in Flesh):** A warrior who made a pact with the Hollow to survive a winter famine. *Phases:* Count the Breath → Ride the White → Claim the Ninth. *Cracks:* feed him a memory of warmth, show him a red thread tied in eight knots, or outride him to the horizon—the Hollow cannot cross moving water.
4. **The Iron Grandmother (Bone-Singer Revenant):** An ancient bone-singer who refused to die. *Phases:* Song of Names → Kurgan Rising → The Dead Vote. *Cracks:* sing a true name she does not know, return a stolen kurgan stone, or answer her riddle: “What weight is never paid?”
5. **The Wolf-Banner (Pack-Leader):** A clan chief who has fused with a wolf spirit. *Phases:* Stalk → Circle → Feast. *Cracks:* break his banner, offer a raw heart to his pack, or survive a night without fire.
6. **The Sky-Weeping Child (Curse Bearer):** A child born during a white squall, marked by the Hollow. *Phases:* Winter Dreams → Frost-Fever → The Ninth Day. *Cracks:* warm her hands with your own breath, speak her true name (her mother is still alive—she will tell you), or find the horse that was born at the same moment—it carries the other half of the curse.

Eastern Steppe Names (d8 each) For quick NPC generation, roll or choose:

Male first names (d8): 1. Bortei, 2. Temurjin, 3. Khorchi, 4. Edil, 5. Sogata, 6. Toghrul, 7. Ogedei, 8. Chagatai.

Female first names (d8): 1. Orghana, 2. Borte, 3. Altan, 4. Saruul, 5. Checheg, 6. Nergui, 7. Tolui, 8. Hulan.

Clan epithets (d8): 1. Iron-Heart, 2. Frost-Mane, 3. Salt-Tongue, 4. Wolf-Brood, 5. Hollow-Sight, 6. Curse-Bearer, 7. Red-Hoof, 8. Silent-Banner.

Eastern Ykrul at a Glance

Core Traits: Isolationist, pragmatic, harsher honour code, live among Kuvani but do not intermarry. **Key Resources:** Salt, iron, remounts, wolf truces, kurgan spirits. **Common Conflicts:** Feuds over salt pans, disputes with Kuvani over grazing, Hollow incursions in winter, curse-lifting quests. **Tone:** Bleaker than western Ykrul. Fewer stories, more teeth. Hospitality is still sacred—but the guest is expected to earn it. **Ritual Objects:** Frost-bitten stirrups, bronze paizas, horse-tooth chits, salt-cakes, wolf skull standards.

Patronage & Power

In Ykrul society, power flows through the careful management of hospitality, the binding of oaths with hostages, and the ability to navigate the complex web of tribal relationships. The Khagan maintains authority through the loyalty of noyans and the respect of khatuns, while local leaders wield influence through their control of resources like salt, remounts, and safe passage. The true power lies with those who understand the old calculations—the pragmatic reckonings of Kon'reh—and can maintain the delicate balance between hospitality and honour.

For the GM: Patronage in Ykrul society revolves around hospitality, hostage exchanges, and the ability to command respect from hosts and courts. Rewards often take the form of tokens, treaties, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the old ways:

[nosep]

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, braids, standards) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Use the *Bowl and Board* procedure for disputes—first fairness (Bowl), then routes and concessions (Board), then a seasonal right.
- Let rival hosts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more.
- Remember that Ykrul pragmatism is colder than southern sentiment. An ally is an asset; a debtor is a liability. Mercy is a luxury, not a virtue. The game of Kon'reh teaches that a trapped piece is dead weight—free it or sacrifice it, but never weep for it.

In Ykrul society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you ride as guest or ghost.

Vilikari

Laurels & Longhouses.

“The Vilikari live in the space between marble and felt, where treaties are not written in law but woven in need. The emperors gave us their chisel, the chieftains gave us their knot – and where they meet, we find a strength that is not in the stone or the string, but in the space between. We do not forget the argument; we remember that the space between is where we build.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatmeal with dried berries – the berries are harvested from the border scrub, where the empire’s orchards meet the steppe’s wild brambles. The berries taste of both. The oatmeal tastes of neither.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To speak both languages – Imperial Utaran and the steppe cant. A child who speaks only one will never cross the border. A child who crosses the border comes back with stories. Listening is power.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Which side of the road they ride on. The empire’s roads are measured from the centre. The steppe’s paths are measured from the edge. A stranger who rides in the ditch is a spy.

What is the most common crime? Treaty-splitting – selling the same rights to both sides. The crime is not in the selling. It is in getting caught before you cross the border.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Foedus Stone is a copy. The original was stolen by a Vilikari trader who owed favours on both sides. She melted it down and sold the marble dust as “treaty-strengthening powder.” The treaties are still holding.

Where do people go when they die? To the border. Buried at the edge – close enough for imperial priests to pray, close enough for steppe shamans to chant. The dead are planted face-up, so they can see both skies. The skies are different colours. The dead do not complain.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You invoke the mallus – the oak-ring court. The wrongdoer circles the ring three times, speaking their apology. On the third circuit, the elders judge. If rejected, the ring closes. Outside is the lawless land. The lawless land is where the wolves are.

What is the most important festival? The Renewal of the Foedus (summer solstice). The stone is washed with milk and honey. The milk is from a Ykrul mare. The honey is from an imperial apiary. The ceremony takes all day.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Foedus Stone has a crack. It was repaired with clay and prayer. The clay is drying. The prayer is fading. When the stone splits, the treaty splits with it. No one knows what happens then.

0.10 Vilikari — “Laurels & Longhouses”

The Vilikari are mercantile: traders and smugglers, but not accountants.

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Two laws, one people. The oak remembers; the marble writes. The stone is cracking.*

Federate King Aldric (Elite): “We are the bridge between empire and wilderness, the marriage of law and custom. Our strength lies not in choosing one path but in walking both with equal surety. But the bridge is rotting, and no one sends hostages anymore. The stone cracks, and the cracks have no witnesses.”

Hearth-Mother Vesna (Commoner): “The old ways and new laws both have their place at our table. Serve the right mead to the right guest, honor the proper customs, and you’ll find we’re better hosts than most kings. The trouble is, the guests are forgetting why they came. The stone is forgetting their names.”

Genre / Mood: Early Holy Roman Empire on the steppe — legal dualism, hybrid identity, frontier pragmatism, forgotten treaties.

Starting Location: A longhouse quarter tucked into an old forum. Laurel garlands hang from broken columns. Smoke from a dozen hearths curls under cracked marble arches. A Hearth-Mother offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Foedus Stone cracks,” she says. “The steppe listens. Which law will you speak when the Ykrul envoy arrives — oak or marble? The stone has a new crack. No one knows which promise it represents. Speak carefully. The stone is listening too.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Vilikari are *forgotten*. They do not choose between empire and steppe; they marry them, awkwardly, imperfectly, and with frequent arguments. Their halls are longhouses raised over ruined forums; their laws carved on both oak and marble; their loyalties braided like the war-maidens' hair. They read the geometry of *jurisdiction*. They are the bulk of the non-elite population in Ecktoria—the legionaries' descendants who never went home. A Vilikari blacksmith in Ecktoria might swear by the marble bench; his cousin two valleys over in Acasia still ties knots for the oak. This is not contradiction. It is survival.

But survival requires witnesses, and the witnesses are dying. The Foedus Stone, ancient guarantor of their autonomy, is *cracking*. Every season, another shard falls. The Ecktorian clerks have stopped renewing the oath; the Ykrul no longer send hostages. The Vilikari are becoming invisible to both sides. Their law still holds, but the witnesses are fading. The Elder of Elders speaks once a year, but fewer and fewer listen. The newest crack appeared last winter. It has no date. No one knows which promise it represents.

On the coast, fishing villages double as smugglers' coves, running fugitives, forbidden goods, and whispered messages. Their boats are fast, their pilots know every reef and patrol route, and their loyalty is to the cargo's survival. They are the last people in the Amaranthine who still remember the old treaty's third clause. They are not sure why it matters. They keep it anyway.

What you notice first: Woodsmoke and old parchment. The way everyone speaks two languages at once—switching mid-sentence. Longhouse roofs that use broken imperial tiles as shingles. The silence where there used to be oaths.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never invoke only one law. The *mallus* (oak-ring) and the *basilica* (marble bench) must both be honored. Choose one, and the other will find you. But now, neither may answer. The stone has forgotten which law applies—so it applies neither.

Regional Mood: The Weight of the Crack

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a weight — the weight of a stone that remembers every oath and every betrayal. The Vilikari live in the shadow of two legal systems that no longer trust each other, and in the growing silence of a witness that is slowly forgetting. Every negotiation is a tightrope between oak and marble; every handshake is a gamble that the other party will remember which law they swore by. The Foedus Stone is not a monument; it is a timer, and its cracks mark the hours until the Vilikari cease to exist as a recognized people. On the coast, the smugglers laugh at treaties and live by the tide; in the hill forts, the old legionaries drill with ghosts; in the longhouses, hearth-mothers pour beer for guests who no longer know why they came. The stone listens. The stone waits.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

In Vilikari courts, the ninth witness called to a *mallus* (oak-ring) is always a ghost. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court. Those who call a ninth witness find that the ghost speaks the truth — but the truth is always the worst possible version, and the living witnesses remember it as their own. The stone’s cracks are full of these truths.

Names of the Vilikari

Vilikari names blend Utaran (Latin) roots with steppe influences: hard consonants, fluid vowels, and surnames that recall a ford, a bridge, or a longhouse.

	p0.25	p0.25	p0.2	p0.2
	First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
	Aldric	Vesna	de la Marche	<i>the Two-Law</i>
	Rurik	Theodora	Longwood	<i>the Fox</i>
	Drago	Gisela	Kalderash	<i>Bridge-Born</i>
	Oswin	Mira	Oakenshield	<i>the Unbuckled</i>
	Vidar	Svanhild	Tregard	<i>Ash-Prow</i>
	Elijah	Ragna	Foedus	<i>the Grey</i>

Quick use notes

Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer : 2–5 → 4 segments, 6–10 → 6 segments, J/Q/K → 8 segments, A → 10 segments.

Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters, rights, escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.

If any **Ace** appears, echo **law and bond** motifs—oaths that bind, stones that witness, treaties that remember every hand—but also **cracks and forgetting**. The stone’s newest crack widens; the Hollow listens.

0.10.1 Spades — Places

March Town, Villa-Fort, Old Road

2 Longhouse Quarter

[Community]The forum’s marble floor is worn smooth by dancing feet, not sandals. The ghosts of tax collectors weep in the corners.

3 Milefort XVII

[Military]Earth bank, stone gate; faded eagle over fresh knotwork. The eagle's stone wings were reglued after a lightning strike. It still leans left — toward the steppe.

4 Stone Ford

[Trade]Plank-palings and a customs table at knee-height; border as bureaucracy. The ford changes hands every season. The customs table never moves. The wood is stained with ink and blood.

5 Villa Granary

[Military]Barracks with a tile roof; spear racks where olives once slept. The olive press still works. The pressers are now armorers. The oil is for lamps, not cooking.

6 Twin Court

[Law]Mallus ring beneath an oak, basilica bench across the lane. The oak and the bench are the same distance from the well. The well is neutral ground. The well has a chain.

7 Blackwood Road

[Travel]Milestones re-carved in runes and Latin both. The runes say “safe passage.” The Latin says “toll payable twice.” The third line is scratched out.

8 Staple Market

[Trade] [Social]Frontier where Ykrul horses meet Vilikari iron. The horse-traders and smiths speak a pidgin of gestures and grudges. The scales are honest — mostly.

9 Burial Field

[Death]Ship-ridge mounds beside tiled mausolea, both garlanded. The mausolea have fresh offerings. The ancestors are not picky. The ship-mounds whisper at dawn.

10 Repaired Bridge

[Travel] [Law]An arch of stone, a Vilikari trestle stitched on; past and present joined. The trestle creaks in Vilikari, the stone groans in Utaran. They argue at midnight. The toll-keeper listens.

J Hill Amphitheater

[Authority]A lord's hall raised in an old arena's curve; power in architecture. The lord's throne is a gladiator's chair. He does not know who last sat in it. The sand beneath is still dark.

Q New Raivon

[Urban]March capital; grid-streets colliding with wandering lanes. The grid was laid by a surveyor who never came back. The lanes are older. They move at night.

K Dux's Palace

[Authority]Purple awnings, wolf-hides, law tablets on the wall. The tablets list every treaty broken. The wolf-hides are from the treaty-breakers. They still growl.

A Foedus Stone

[Law] [Legend]At a crossroads; every treaty carved, every hand weighed. The stone has grown. Each new treaty adds a finger of granite. The oldest fingers are worn smooth. The newest crack has no date.

0.10.2 Hearts — People & Factions

Federate, Mixed Court, Diaspora

2 Hearth-Mother Vesna

[Social]Keeper of guest-right. She has never lost a quarrel; her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone. She remembers obligations that are not yet owed—and the stone is forgetting, shrinking.

3 Shield-Brother Rurik

[Military] [Oath]Comitatus oath-bearer. His braids are his record; each knot is an oath kept — or broken. He has started tying knots in his sleep, hoping the stone will remember.

4 March Notary Theodora

[Law]Utaran-trained legalist. Her left hand writes Latin, her right writes runes. She signs with her foot. A “third hand” writes in ink that no one can read—not even her. The document is always binding—until the stone forgets.

5 Horse-Reeve

[Trade]Rations pasture between plows and warbands. He measures grass in fistfuls. The Ykrul respect his arithmetic. The Ecktorians pretend not to notice. He is saving fistfuls to patch the stone.

6 Ykrul Envoy

[Social]Riding under safe-conduct; speaks obligations in proverbs. He never carries a weapon. His tongue is sharp enough. His hostage string has nine knots. He is running out of space—and the stone is running out of memory.

7 Old Legionary

[Military]Drill-master for Vilikari levies; Utar in muscle memory. He still marks time in paces. The recruits call him “Grandfather Eagle.” The eagle on his shield is chipped. He says the stone’s cracks are just more places to put his thumb.

8 Ecktorial Factor

[Trade]Vilikari blood, Ecktorial coin; flows where the market points. His coat has two collars—one for each loyalty. He wears whichever is warmer. His tally has three columns. The third column is labelled “crack width.”

9 Kahfagian Pilot

[Travel]Lantern-law chit and clan tattoo; sea-law on land. He navigates by stars and tariffs. Both change with the season. He has never been lost—only delayed. The stone’s cracks are good for smuggling.

10 Marcher-Lord

[Authority]Iron-nail crown, Vilikari law in pocket; a frontier king. His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse. His hands are still calloused. He does not sit on his throne. He spends his days pressing his ear to the stone.

J War-Maiden

[Combat] [Oath]Oath-braid names the dead and the owed; vengeance as memory. Her braid is longer than her sword. Both have drawn blood. She never cuts the braid. The dead would forget her. The stone is forgetting everyone else.

Q Queen of Marches

[Politics]Consort-regent; smiles like precedent. She married the Federate King for peace. She kept the kingdom for herself. Her seal is a broken arrow. She keeps a piece of the stone in her pocket—it gets smaller every year.

K Federate King Aldric

[Authority]Rex-Dux sworn to forms, sung by his own. He has three thrones—oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over. Lately, all three are dusty. He has stopped arguing. He just listens to the stone.

A Elder of Elders

[Law]Thing-council speaker; a nod can unmake a clan. He speaks once a year. The rest of the time he listens—and remembers. But his memory is cracking like the stone. He has started writing things on his own skin.

Other Prominent Figures

Smuggler Captain Drago: Vilikari fisherman and trafficker. He runs contraband and refugees past the Kahfagian patrols, knows every reef and every lantern shift, and claims the Foedus Stone’s cracks are good for business—no one checks the old treaties anymore.

0.10.3 Clubs — Complications & Threats

Two Laws, Two Fronts, Old Grudges

2 Annona Late

[Supply] [Social] Grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken like flint. The granary is full. The keys are in the wrong vault. Someone is waiting for the price to rise. The soldiers are not. The stone does not care.

3 Law Tangle

[Law] Mallus verdict vs. basilica writ — whose seal bites? The oak judge and the marble judge are cousins. They send each other holiday cards. The case has been open for three generations. The stone has forgotten who started it.

4 Raid Rumor

[Combat] [Fear] A Ykrul boyar; levies panic the plowlands. The boyar is a ghost—or a tax collector. The farmers don't wait to find out. They burn the fields themselves. The stone's cracks are good cover for ghosts.

5 Bridge Levy

[Trade] [Combat] Doubled for road-works; caravans balk, fists rise. The road-works are a ditch. The ditch fills every spring. The bridge keeper has a new sword. He sharpens it on the stone.

6 Succession Feud

[Politics] [Death] Wolf-brother claim vs. purple-charter heir. The wolf-brother has a better sword. The purple-charter has a better notary. The notary's ink is mixed with blood. The stone's crack drinks it.

7 Foedus Recall

[Law] [Social] A prefecture resettlement is "requested"; homes bristle. The prefecture's map is forty years old. It shows a village that drowned. The villagers are still there. The stone remembers their names—barely.

8 Coin Talk

[Trade] [Weight] Debasement; pay demanded in salt, hides, or hostages. The salt is from a disputed pan. The hides are from cattle that were never born. The hostages are children. The stone's cracks are full of their names.

9 Grave Offense

[Death] [Omen] A burial field disturbed; omens ride with the news. The ancestors are angry. They have a list. Your name may be on it. The list is carved on a ship's prow. The stone's new crack is shaped like a finger pointing.

10 Port Clash

[Law] [Trade] Lantern-law vs. street-law; confiscations bloom. The lanterns were moved last night. The old safe channel is now a reef. The harbor master is not answering questions.

He is listening to the stone.

J Warband Flip

[Military] [Betrayal] Colors change mid-pay; hostage protocol snaps shut. The hostages are eating well. Their captors are not. The captain's new banner is stitched with his old captain's hair. The stone's crack has grown wider.

Q Restoration Preacher

[Social] [Fear] Stirs crowds against the "barbarian king in purple." The preacher's license was signed by a dead abbot. The seal is still warm. The crowd does not know. The stone does not care.

K General Levy

[Military] [Supply] The march is closed; markets freeze into spears. The levy notice is posted in three languages. None of them are local. The tax collector has a bow. The stone has stopped listening.

A Spring Melt

[Weather] [Travel] Eats the Wolf Road; proofs, plans, and armies bog. The road is a memory. The ruts fill with water—and older things. The bridge keeper is fishing for boots. The stone's crack is now a chasm.

0.10.4 Diamonds — Rewards & Leverage

Charter, Right, Escort

2 Foedus Seal

[Law] Settlement and stipends confirmed for a season. The seal is a bronze wolf's head. It warms when the treaty holds—and cools when it doesn't. The wolf's eyes are garnets. One eye is cracked.

3 Mallus Right

[Law] Hold court under the oak and be obeyed. The oak is older than the kingdom. Its roots have seen more verdicts than the throne. The acorns are bitter. The oak's leaves are falling early.

4 Stipend Arrears

[Supply] Paid in salt and grain; portable, persuasive. The salt is grey. The grain is from last harvest. Both are worth more than coin. The soldiers will accept. The stone will not.

5 Utaran Patent

[Social]Citizenship-style privilege; doors open, bows deepen. The patent is a worn scrap of vellum. It has been folded and refolded for a century. The seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is fading.

6 Stall-Right

[Trade]Customs favor on a frontier market line. The stall is a painted plank. Plant it, and the tax man will pretend not to see you. He will remember the favour. The stone will not.

7 Hostage Treaty

[Social] [Oath]Exchange fosters; grudges trade for leverage. The hostages are children. Their parents are patient. The treaty has nine clauses. The ninth is unspoken. The stone has forgotten the first eight.

8 Remount Allotment

[Travel]Fresh horses from royal paddocks, no questions. The horses are from the king's own herd. They know the roads better than you. They also know the king's secrets. They refuse to cross the stone's shadow.

9 Wergild Table

[Law] [Weight]Recognized by both codes; vengeance priced and paid. The table is a slate slab. The prices are carved deep—and often recarved. The newest price is a year of rain. The rain is washing away the carvings.

10 Bridge Farm

[Trade]Imperial for a season; funds and friends accrue. The bridge toll is a copper a head. The bridge keeper is your new best friend. He also keeps a list of your enemies. He scratches the list on the stone.

J Purple Warrant

[Authority]Wear the stripe; officials defer on sight. The stripe is a sash. It was a curtain in a past life. The present life is yours. Do not lose it. The stone's crack has swallowed one like it.

Q Queen's Audience

[Social]Private; a whisper becomes policy. The audience is held in a garden. The flowers are listening. The gardener is a spy. The gardener is also the queen. She keeps a piece of the stone under her tongue.

K Dux Commission

[Military]Command a mixed unit with pay authority. The commission is a baton. It doubles as a mace in a pinch. It also doubles as a receipt. The receipt is overdue. The stone has a receipt for the stone.

A Great Law Day

[Law] [Legend]Proclaim a new concord; one temporary exception to old law. The proclamation is made at noon. By sunset, everyone will have an opinion. By dawn, the Foedus Stone will have a new finger—or a new crack.

0.10.5 Vilikari Mechanics

Core Timers

Witness Fading Timer [8] Tracks the erosion of Vilikari legal authority.

Ticks when:

[nosep]

- The party defies a Vilikari judgment or brings a dispute to an outside court (+1).
- The GM spends 2 SB to represent a forgotten oath (+1).
- A foreign envoy (Ykrul, Ecktorian, etc.) publicly ignores a Vilikari ruling (+1).

At 4 segments: Any Vilikari NPC the party interacts with suffers –1 die to social rolls (they doubt their own authority). The stone’s cracks are visible to all.

At 8 segments: The Foedus Stone cracks completely. The Vilikari are no longer recognized as a neutral party. The Ykrul and Ecktorians begin fighting over their land. The party can reset the timer only by **renewing the treaty**—finding a witness older than the stone itself (a Lethai-al elder, a Trow, a ghost of the original signatory) and having them speak the oath aloud.

Two-Law Tension [4] Whenever a *jurisdictional conflict* arises (mallus vs. basilica, oak vs. marble), players may step Position up by citing the Foedus Stone or an older precedent—but every use adds a tick to the Two-Law timer. When it fills, one side demands exclusive authority. The other side sharpens its knives.

If the Witness Fading Timer is at 4+, this timer ticks twice as fast.

Border Tension [Front] Once per session, if a deal is struck with a foreign envoy or mixed-blood courtier, advance or start this front.

Market Knives [4] At any *Staple Market* or *Stone Ford*, each time a player converts a held Diamond into a *Market Edge* (+1 die to all buy/sell rolls for the scene), tick this timer. When it fills, a rival factor challenges your right to trade—face a duel, a bribe demand, or a confiscation.

Feast-Bond [3] / Blood-Owed [3] Created by the Treaty-Feast Procedure. While Feast-Bond has segments, both parties are protected from betrayal in that matter. On breach, the breaker immediately takes 1–2 SB and the timer flips to Blood-Owed [3].

Status & Environment

The Two-Law Dial (Oak ↔ Marble) Track which legal tradition currently holds sway.
[nosep]

- **Oak High:** +1 Position when invoking mallus, blood-price, or tribal custom; the first basilica petition starts one step worse.
- **Marble High:** +1 Effect when citing charters, patents, or Utaran precedent; the first mallus oath starts one step worse.

Center the dial by offering a wergild recognized by both sides or hosting a joint moot. If the Witness Fading Timer is at 4+, centering requires a sacrifice (a memory, a name, or a drop of blood on the stone).

Frontier Diplomacy If a Heart card involves a foreign envoy, a federate, or a mixed-blood courtier, treat the first Diamond played in the scene as doubled leverage. If the Witness Fading Timer is at 6+, the deal also ticks the timer by 1 (the stone forgets another clause).

March Markets At any *Staple Market*, *Stone Ford*, or *Repaired Bridge*, Diamonds tied to rights or escorts may be cashed as currency in lieu of coin, one-for-one. Doing so creates a **Stone Weight** that the GM may call in later through factions or raiders. The weight is never written. It is remembered—until the stone forgets.

The Vilikari Diaspora Vilikari characters in Ecktoria gain +1 die on Streetwise checks (they know the back alleys and the bribes), but –1 die on social rolls with Old Blood patricians (who see them as upstarts). In Acasia, they gain +1 die on Survival checks (their ancestors were farmers here) but –1 die on social rolls with the Curse-touched (who remember imperial tax collectors). A Vilikari character may start with one “family tally”—a minor asset that tracks a single unpaid favour across generations. If the Witness Fading Timer ever fills, the tally turns to ash.

Procedures

Treaty-Feast Procedure (Fast Diplomacy)

[nosep]

1. **Set the Table:** Name 2–3 *terms* (what both sides want) and 1 *taboo* (off-limits).
2. **First Cup (Position):** Roll a social test; success grants +1 die to bargain, failure grants the host 1 SB.
3. **Bread & Salt (Offer):** Put one leverage on the table (Diamond or oath-promise). The host matches with an obligation (escort, market access, or hostage).

4. **Smoke (Complication):** The GM reveals a pressure tied to *Old Grudges* or *Two Laws*. Resolve it or accept a *Rider Clause*.
5. **Knot the Braid:** On success, create a Feast-Bond [3] timer. On breach, the breaker takes 1–2 SB and the timer flips to Blood-Owed [3].
6. **Stone Witness:** If the Feast-Bond is sworn at the Foedus Stone, reduce the Witness Fading Timer by 1. The stone remembers one more promise.

Frontier Market (Quick Trading) At any Staple Market or Stone Ford, players may convert a held Diamond into a Market Edge. Each conversion ticks Market Knives [4]. When the timer fills, a rival factor challenges your right to trade.

If the Witness Fading Timer is at 6+, the rival factor is a ghost—a forgotten signatory of the Foedus Stone. The duel is a legal dream-duel.

Start-of-Scene Omens Roll **1d6** at the start of a Vilikari scene:

[nosep]

1. **Laurel Wilt:** First legal action gains +1d; first boast draws **Law Tangle**.
2. **Smoke on the Steppe: Raid Rumor** advances once; shortcuts open.
3. **Twin Bells:** Both courts are in session; pick a side or start **Law Tangle**.
4. **Queen's Dove:** A message arrives; +1d on the next **Queen's Audience**.
5. **Grey Salt: Stipend Arrears** counts double value today; smugglers' ears open.
6. **Old Eagle:** An Utaran relic surfaces; **Utaran Patent** use is free this scene.

Crack Light (special): If the Witness Fading Timer is ≥ 4 , the stone also glows. The next legal argument made at the stone is automatically binding—for both sides.

Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

[nosep]

- **Bread to the Stone:** Crumble a crust at the base of the Foedus Stone. Ignore the first *Law Tangle* penalty.
- **Knot the Braid:** Tie a single knot in a horse's tail. Cancel *Annona Late* or take –1 die on your next supply roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Oak:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into the hollow of the mallus oak. Gain +1 Effect when collecting wergild from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Elder of Elders.
- **Press the Crack:** Touch the newest crack in the Foedus Stone and speak a promise you intend to break. Gain +1 die on your next deception roll, but the stone will remember your name. The Hollow will too.

Strain Budget (SB) Spends

Minor (1 SB)

[nosep]

- **Exposure:** March officials or tribal elders take notice.
- **Noise:** Levy guards or market patrols are alerted.
- **Trace:** Trackers or treaty keepers mark your route.
- **Delay:** Lose a favorable legal window or crucial time.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant resource timer.
- **Crack Whispers (Vilikari only):** A character hears the stone whispering a forgotten promise. Test Resolve (DV 3) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Moderate (2 SB)

[nosep]

- **Alarm Raised:** The Horse-Reeve or March Notary responds.
- **Position Lost:** Legal challenge or border closure costs you advantage.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival faction or warband arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A key item becomes Compromised or Neglected.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.
- **Witness Fading:** Advance the Witness Fading Timer by 1 segment.

Serious (3 SB)

[nosep]

- **Reinforcements:** Shield-brothers, levy forces, or foreign troops arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool or weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** Treaty voided, levy called, or border dispute erupts.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark Fatigue 1, Harm 1, or an appropriate Condition.
- **Stone Speaks:** The Foedus Stone whispers a forgotten clause that invalidates a character's legal protection for the scene.

Major (4+ SB)

[nosep]

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** The Federate King, Queen of Marches, or Elder of Elders intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** A raid hits, the levy is called, or a treaty breaks.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine or arcane forces manifest—an omen appears, a blessing is lost, or a curse manifests.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story reframes your objectives unexpectedly.
- **Crack Splits:** The Foedus Stone’s newest crack widens. One of the party’s active Diamonds crumbles to dust.

Region-Specific SB Conversions

[nosep]

- **Seal Crack (1 SB):** A writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
- **Citation War (2 SB):** Increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a Diamond or recall a past ruling).
- **Crown Fracture (3+ SB):** A treaty splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival’s seal on your paper (start or tick Two-Law timer).
- **Stone Whisper (2 SB, Vilikari only):** The Foedus Stone reveals a forgotten clause. The GM must answer one yes/no question about a treaty or oath in the region.

Reputation Echoes

[nosep]

- **Court-Favored:** Once per session, downgrade **Law Tangle** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- **Raid-Tested:** +1 Position when evading Ykrul or Black Banners; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
- **Neutral Broker:** +1d with both oak and marble in a treaty scene; any betrayal earns **Blood-Owed [2]** from both sides.
- **Stone-Marked:** Gained by renewing the treaty. The Foedus Stone remembers your name. Once per session, reroll a failed social roll involving a Vilikari or a treaty. The stone will ask for a memory in return.

Local Patrons

[nosep]

- **The Two-Faced King** — Mykkiel. *Justice that wears a laurel and a wolf's tail.*
- **The Hearth Judge** — The Witness. *The flame that watches both sides of the bargain.*
- **The Oak Father** — Grimmer. *The root that holds the law; the branch that signs the treaty.*
- **The Coin Saint** — Maelstraeus. *Interest on a handshake; the stone that never sleeps.*

Boss Seeds (Three-Phase Foes)

The March Notary (quills like daggers) *Phases:* Citation Tangle → Seal Swap → Precedent Trap.

Cracks: Produce a **Foedus Seal** to quiet him; a **Queen's Audience** overrules his filing. If the Witness Fading Timer is at 6+, he gains +1 die in all phases (the stone supports him).

Ykrul Storm-Rider (wolf-cloak, bone whistle) *Phases:* Raid Cry → Herd Stampede → Blood Price.

Cracks: A **Wergild Table** settles the feud without combat; a **Hostage Treaty** buys a season's peace. He fights harder if the stone is cracked (he smells weakness).

The Prefect's Auditor (Ecktorial ink on his fingers) *Phases:* Tally Seizure → Tax Levy → Fort Closure.

Cracks: An **Utaran Patent** grants immunity; a **Mallus Right** transfers jurisdiction to the oak. He carries a piece of the stone in his pocket; if the party takes it, the Witness Fading Timer resets by 2.

The Stone's Ghost (Foedus Avatar) *Phases:* Whisper of Forgotten Clauses → Crack Widens → The Hollow Steps Through.

Cracks: Speak the original treaty aloud (requires a Lethai-al witness), repair the stone with a memory of a kept promise, or sacrifice a personal oath to feed the stone instead of the Hollow.

0.10.6 Lore Echoes

[nosep]

- **The Smugglers' Covenant (The Sealed Gate):** Vilikari pilots who run the Kahfagian coast swear by a secret oath to the *Unlatched Lock*—a threshold that never fully closes. They leave a copper nail at every hidden cove. A captain who breaks the covenant finds that their boat will not cross the tide line; the sea simply refuses to carry them. The Kahfagian Admiralty has tried to bribe the covenant's keeper; he

accepted the coin and sank the next morning in calm water. The stone's newest crack appeared that same night.

- **Saint Theodora of the Dual Writ (The Witness):** A march notary who uncovered a Fenwood spy in the Federate King's court. She forced the spy to sign a confession under both oak and marble, then burned the oak copy and kept the marble one. The spy vanished, but his signature appears on every broken treaty in Vilikari history. Her quill is kept in the Dux's Palace; it writes in lemon juice, and the truth it records cannot be erased by fire or water. The stone's cracks drink the juice.
- **The Host of the Two Ledgers (The Longhouse Healers):** A hospice near the Foedus Stone is run by grey-robed healers who ask no payment. They treat wounded raiders from both sides of the steppe, and the Ykrul and Ecktorian captains have agreed to a truce around its doors. The Federate King tolerates them because they also hold the rite of the *Unbuckled Oath*—a ceremony where a knight may renounce a blood-debt without losing honour, by placing their sword on the stone and speaking a single true regret. The stone remembers these regrets. It has many.
- **The Ostrihari Cousins (The Savage Heart):** The eastern Vilikari, called Ostrihari by lowlanders, are no more savage than any frontier people. Their reputation comes from the bear cults of the upper Wolf Road, where initiates wear cured skins and speak in growls. The Ostrihari do not raid Vilikari villages; they trade furs for iron and send their young to serve as mercenaries in the Black Banners. A Vilikari proverb says: "The Ostrihari sharpen their teeth on stone, not on kin." The stone does not mind. It has no teeth left.

0.10.7 Cross-Region Hooks

[nosep]

- **Kahfagia (Lantern-Law):** A **Foedus Seal** may stand in for a *Safe-Conduct* along a beacons lane once. Doing so starts **Port Clash** [2] in the next harbor touched.
- **Ecktoria (Imperial Remnants):** An **Utaran Patent** counts as either *Archive Hour* (scholars open doors) or *Icon License* (display symbols) in Ecktorial sites—choose once per session.
- **Aelerian Mountains (Pass & Toll):** A **Pass-Ring** (from the Aeler expansion) grants priority at dwarf switchbacks; cashing it to bypass inspection spawns **Stone Notice** [3].
- **Direwood (Breath & Bells):** Spending **Stipend Arrears** for levee labor converts one Direwood **Clubs** draw into a *Ward-Salt* Diamond for a scene, then begins **Names Disputed** [3] with bell-wardens.
- **Acasia (Curse & Tithe):** A **Wergild Table** accepted by a Curse-touched village also clears one *Feud Spark* timer, but the Hollow gains +1 Attention.

- **Lethai-al Silk Bridges: A Hostage Treaty** can be witnessed by a Lethai-al silk-warden, making it binding across the Crimson Valley. The price is a strand of the treaty-bearer's hair.

Patronage & Power

In Vilikari society, power flows through the careful balance of multiple legal traditions, the management of frontier diplomacy, and the maintenance of complex oaths and treaties. The Federate King maintains authority through a combination of imperial forms and traditional customs, while local leaders wield influence through their knowledge of both Utaran law and tribal custom. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex landscape while maintaining the loyalty of their people and the respect of their neighbors.

But the stone is cracking. The witnesses are dying. The Vilikari are becoming *invisible*.

For the GM: Patronage in Vilikari society revolves around legal documents, diplomatic relationships, and the ability to command respect from institutions that operate under multiple legal systems. Rewards often take the form of treaties, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the hybrid identity and the fading authority:

[nosep]

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, treaties) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided—and that may crumble if the stone forgets.
- Let rival legal systems issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favour matters more. Neither may remember them tomorrow.
- Use the courts, markets, and frontier posts as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success—and where the stone's whispers can tip the balance.
- Remember that Vilikari characters are at home in Ecktoria's counting-houses and Acasia's hedgerow courts alike—but they are never fully trusted in either. That suspicion is their best tool. When the stone cracks fully, that suspicion becomes exile.

In Vilikari society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rule or are ruled. But a bond is only as strong as the stone that witnesses it. And the stone is forgetting.

Black Banners

Condotta & Crowns.

“Mercenary companies trade steel for coin – today’s shield, tomorrow’s spear. Ecktorian treasuries do not contain the border war; they stoke it with gold. Between them walk the Ykrul clans, the Vilikari tribes, and the legionaries who remember when a word was a bond.”
— Aeler Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? *Hardtack and camp stew – the stew is whatever was caught, killed, or traded for before dawn. The cook is called “The Alchemist.” No one asks their real name.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To count coin. Camp children tally pay shares before they can read. A child who miscounts goes hungry. A child who goes hungry learns to count faster.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their colours. Every company has its own banner – lantern, thorn, bell, fishbone, broken scale. A stranger with no colours has no company. A stranger with no company is a deserter. A deserter is a corpse.*

What is the most common crime? *Desertion – but desertion is a negotiation. A soldier who wants to leave will sell their gear, their secrets, and their silence. The price is always “one more season.”*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Black Colonel is not a person. The title is held by a wax seal in a lead-lined box. The box is carried by a mute lieutenant. The lieutenant signs documents with the Colonel’s thumb-print. The thumb-print is a forgery. The forger is the lieutenant. The lieutenant has no thumbs.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the pyre. Camp dead are burned in a bonfire of broken spears. The quartermaster charges a fee from the dead’s final pay. The final pay is never enough.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You stand a watch. The wronged party chooses the hour – midnight, dawn, the dead of winter. If you survive, you are forgiven. If you do not, the claim is paid.*

What is the most important festival? *Payday – but payday is a negotiation. The captain promises payment on the first of the month. The quartermaster promises when the supply train arrives. The soldiers promise loyalty until the payment comes. The payment never comes. The loyalty never ends.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Banner-Captain's contract is written in disappearing ink. The ink was supplied by a Sidhi forger paid in promises. The promises were not kept. The forger is now a camp follower. The forger knows where the contract is hidden.

0.11 Black Banners — Condotta & Crowns

Quick Reference

Tagline: *A contract is only as good as the next settlement — but loyalty is earned in blood, not silver.*

Banner-Captain (Elite): “A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year. But a captain who forgets the men in the mud won’t last the winter.”

Veteran Sergeant (Commoner): “I’ve seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard. The mud stays the same. The pay comes when it pleases. But the men? They remember who shared their fire and who ate alone. Keep your blade sharp and your word sharper. The camp sings? You live. They stop singing? Even the best charter bleeds.”

Genre / Mood: Mercenary realism, winter warfare, logistics-driven violence, loyalty in the mud.

System Type: Portable overlay — apply to any region (Acasia, Violet Steppe, Ecktorian borderlands). Not a fixed geography.

Condotta & Crowns

Ecktorian treasuries bankroll a perpetual border-war they claim to be *containing*. In truth, the gold keeps the fire burning. The Black Banners are mercenary leagues — ex-Utaran legionaries, second-sons, deserters, and exiles — who sell steel to the highest bidder, today’s ally becoming tomorrow’s quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans (swift, pragmatic, oath-canny) and the Vilikari hill tribes (crafty, patient, and proud). Ecktorian ministers call it “pressure management.” The companies call it a season — and a season is measured in the rhythm of pay, but also in snowdrifts, broken wheels, and the weight of a dead friend’s shield.

What you notice first: The smell of wet wool and old blood. The way every tent has a roster pinned to its flap — and beside it, a list of the fallen. The silence when the chest is opened — and the murmur when it’s light. The way veterans watch the horizon not for enemies, but for the supply train.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly — and how captains end hanging. The dead don’t forget.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

In any mercenary camp, the ninth tent in a row collapses before dawn. The ground beneath is always damp, as if something rose from below and left. Those who sleep in that tent wake with no memory of the night — but a new name carved into their belt buckle. The name is never theirs.

The Theater of Banners

Here, war is a marketplace — but also a forge, a campfire, a brotherhood of mud and steel. The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling league of freelance violence, bound by camp law, customs of compensation, and the shared knowledge that tomorrow's enemy might be today's employer. The real battles are fought in tents over agreements; the clash outside is just the review. Loyalty is a bond that shifts with circumstance — but it also lives in the sergeant who shares his last ration, the surgeon who works through the night, the captain who stands in the shield wall.

Between the rigid honour codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground. Survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one — always at dawn, with a witness, and with surety paid. But it also depends on knowing whose back to watch, whose flask to share, and whose name to call when the snow closes in.

Names of the Black Banners

Mercenary names are often aliases, nicknames from past campaigns, or the colour of a faded banner. Surnames are rare; epithets are everything.

[p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2]			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Banner Names	Epithets
Rurik	Svetlana	Blackwolf	<i>the Unpaid</i>
Dragan	Mira	Ironhand	<i>the Scarred</i>
Sebastian	Olena	Rustcloak	<i>Bell-Heart</i>
Vladan	Zoya	Ashbanner	<i>the Silent</i>
Temur	Nadezhda	Greyboar	<i>Six-Fingers</i>
Caspian	Rada	Redtally	<i>the Lame</i>

Quickstart (Two-Minute Setup)

[leftmargin=*]

1. **Condotta Crossroads:** Put two conflicting charters on the table. Ask: *Who do you disappoint first?*
2. **Company Sheet:** Name, Colors, Captain. Add timers: **Payday** [4], **Supplies** [4], **Cohesion** [6].
3. **Pressure Timers:** Pick two external threats (e.g., *Skirmish Spiral* [6], *Camp Fever* [6], *Winter Deepens* [6]).
4. **Allegiances in Flux:** At each scene start, roll 1d6 and apply the twist (see table).

5. **Honor vs. Pragmatism Dial:** Slide based on choices; affects Position, logistics, and how the men remember you.

The Four-Suit Generator

Draw until you have all four suits. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10). Any Ace echoes winter & loyalty motifs: hunger, omen, promotion-by-attribution, or a sudden blizzard that buries both sides.

Spades — Places (Camps, Battlefields, Fortresses)

p0.08 p0.2 p0.67	Rank	Name	Description & Mechanical Hook
	2	Burned Village	Field hospital; flies, tinctures, fever-prayers. '[DEATH]' <i>Start a Camp Fever [4] timer. Each failed Medicine roll ticks it. The dead whisper the names of the care-less.</i>
	3	Frozen Ford	Last month's dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice. '[DEATH]' '[WEATHER]' <i>Crossing costs +1 Fatigue. The dead whisper a name — the next Desertion check is at -1 die.</i>
	4	Latrine Row	Mud, shame, whispered mutiny; a sergeant who hears too well. '[SOCIAL]' <i>Any failed social roll here ticks Cohesion +1 (soldiers lose faith). The smell is a warning.</i>
	5	Crater Pasture	Alchemical barrage aftermath; glass flowers sprout like guilt. '[MAGIC]' <i>Scavenging here gives a Glass Shard (1 use: +1 die to intimidate), but ticks Supplies +1 (poisoned ground). Veterans avoid it.</i>
	6	Supply Road	Twelve broken wagons; oxen nose the wreckage for salt. '[TRAVEL]' <i>First scavenge roll of the scene is Controlled; on a Miss, tick Supplies +1. The crows are fat.</i>
	7	Half-Raised Siege Tower	Abandoned camp; every rung creaks with grudges. '[COMBAT]' <i>Climbing costs 2 Fatigue; on a Partial, the tower leans — next attack from it is Desperate. The ghosts of sappers still work the ropes.</i>
	8	Salt-Cured Cache	Behind the surgeon's tent; wrong kind of maggots move. '[DEATH]' <i>Opening it gives 1 Supplies but starts a Disease [4] timer (the maggots carry rot). The surgeon's face goes pale.</i>
	9	Command Tent	Maps show borders diplomacy erased. '[SOCIAL]' <i>A player who studies the map for a scene may ask one question about enemy intentions; on a Miss, the map is a decoy — start False Orders [4]. The tent smells of fear and bad wine.</i>
	10	Watch-Tower	Stacked from skulls and slate; crows know the countersign. '[WAR]' <i>The crows will warn of ambush once, but only if fed a memory (erase a minor fact). The</i>

watchman never sleeps.

J Ancient March-Keep Held by a skeleton garrison of veterans; they remember when banners were gold. '[DEATH]' *They will fight for you if you swear an oath to restore their banner — start **Oath Share [6]**. Their captain has no shadow.*

Q The Bone Fields Ykrul elders parley among cairns; reckon oaths with the dead. '[DEATH]' '[OATH]' *The dead vote on any dispute. Roll Spirit+Lore (DV 4). On success, they side with you (gain +1 Position on next parley). On failure, they demand a blood-price. The wind carries their voices.*

K Marcher's Fortress Three walls, two sieges' scars, one gate that opens inward only. '[COMBAT]' *The gate opens inward so the dead can leave. Living who enter without permission take Harm 1 (spiritual backlash). The stones weep when an agreement is broken.*

A The Singing Wastes Fallen weapons hum with voices of their last wielders. '[MAGIC]' '[DEATH]' *Each weapon can answer one question about its owner's death. After three questions, the Wastes awaken — start **Wrath of the Fallen [8]**. The song is a lament.*

Hearts — People & Factions

|p0.08|p0.2|p0.67|

Rank Name Description & Mechanical Hook

2 Young Cadet Father's sword, mother's share, hunger to prove himself. '[SOCIAL]' *If you mentor him (a downtime scene), he becomes a Cap 1 follower. If you ignore him, he joins a rival company — tick **Rival Agenda +1**. He has never seen a man die.*

3 Veteran Sergeant Counts scars like medals; spends them on whiskey and mercy. '[COMBAT]' '[SOCIAL]' *She will fight for you, but at end of scene demands a story about a battle you survived. If you cannot provide one, she takes a button from your coat — a promise.*

4 Ecktorian Banner-Captain Griffon standard, roster of noble grudges, smile like winter. '[LAW]' *He offers a **Letter of Marque** (once: ignore one legal complication). Accepting starts his **Favor Share [4]** — he will call in a favour during a critical moment. His boots are always clean.*

5 Condotta Broker Changes colours when wind turns, always lands on his feet. '[SOCIAL]' *He will flip a contract for you — but the price is a **Black Mark** (reputation stain). He has three names and uses none.*

6 Ykrul Clan Emissary Speaks in riddled proverbs; pays in copper from a cursed mine. '[SOCIAL]' '[OATH]' *He offers a **Safe-Conduct Token** (one free passage through Ykrul land). Accepting marks **Obligation [2]** — the horse you ride will remember.*

7 Vilikari War-Chief's Second Son Honour burns brighter than his father's patience. '[SOCIAL]' *He will join your next battle as a Cap 2 ally, but if he takes Harm, start a **Blood Feud [6]** with his clan. His axe has a name.*

8 Surgeon of the Red Tally Treats friend and foe; her record balances in blood. '[SHARE]' *She can heal 1 Harm — but the patient's name is added to her roll. Once per arc, she calls in the share: a dangerous mission. Her hands never shake.*

9 Quartermaster Knows where every coin went and every man will fall. '[SHARE]' *His bribe book is thicker than his roster. Spend 1 Boon to cancel one **Supplies** tick — but he now has a String on you. He never eats with the men.*

10 Tribune's Aide-de-Camp Sealed orders contradict the general's intent. '[SOCIAL]' *He will leak the real orders for a **Favor Share [4]** — but the leak may be a trap. His seal ring is warm.*

J The Black Colonel Legendary commander not seen in months, yet his banner rides. '[LEGEND]' *The banner rides alone. If you follow it, you find a cache (gain 1 **Diamond** of your choice). Following it three times summons his ghost. He never lost a battle — only his way home.*

Q Ykrul Clan-Mother Weaves war-braids from hair of oath-breakers. '[OATH]' *She can witness any oath; breaking it gives her power over you (she may demand a service). Her braids have nine knots.*

K Vilikari High Chief Trades mercenaries like game pieces; never tips the board. '[SOCIAL]' *He offers a **Trading Charter** (buy/sell anything in any camp). Using it ticks **Cohesion** +1 (soldiers suspect you of corruption). His smile is an agreement.*

A The Bannerless One Commands loyalty without rank or flag. '[LEGEND]' *She appears when the camp is darkest. She clears one segment of the pay cycle — but you incur a **Price of Mercy [4]**. When it fills, she asks for a prisoner — or a promise. Her face is never the same twice.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

|p0.08|p0.2|p0.67|

Rank Name Description & Mechanical Hook

2 Payday Delayed Supplies dwindle before coin arrives. '[SHARE]' *Tick **Payday** +1. On fill, a squad deserts — lose 1 **Supplies** and gain a **Black Mark**. The captain blames the weather.*

3 False Orders Your target is now your ally — on paper. '[SOCIAL]' *The first command this scene is misinterpreted unless countered with a **Diamond** (cipher, cantor, witness). The messenger's hands are clean.*

4 Blizzard Pins Two rival companies, one cloister; vows and knives both come out. '[WEATHER]' '[COMBAT]' *Tick **Cohesion** +1. The abbot will sell safe passage to the highest bidder — start an **Auction [4]** timer. The snow is red by dawn.*

5 Ykrul Counter-Offer Better terms than Ecktoria; your contract becomes a liability. '[SOCIAL]' '[SHARE]' *You may accept (gain +1 Effect, mark Obligation [2]) or refuse (tick the pay timer +1). The horses watch you decide.*

6 Condotta Flip Unit switches colours mid-battle; your “relief” hits your flank. '[COMBAT]' *On a Miss, the unit attacks you. On a Partial, they demand double compensation — tick **Payday** +1. Their old banner burns in your camp.*

7 Camp Fever Blooms in the surgeon’s tent; the counting-house for the dead. '[DEATH]' *Start **Camp Fever** [4]. Each failed Endurance test ticks it. At 4, a key NPC dies. The surgeon weeps in silence.*

8 Vilikari Raid Cuts your supply road; winter moves the schedule. '[COMBAT]' '[TRAVEL]' *Tick **Supplies** +1. The raiders left a recipe — cooking it gives 1 **Supplies** but starts a **Rival Hunt** [4] (they want the recipe back). The stew tastes of revenge.*

9 Honour Code Collision Ecktorian ideals vs. mercenary pragmatism; the camp splits by doctrine. '[SOCIAL]' *Choose **Honour** (tick **Supplies** +1, logistics suffer) or **Pragmatism** (gain +1 Effect now, but start **Parley Divided** [4]). The men watch which way you lean.*

10 Tribune Captured The aide must choose: the rescue or the war. '[SOCIAL]' '[SHARE]' *Rescue him: lose 1 **Supplies**. Abandon him: gain **Black Mark** but tick the pay timer -1 (his captors compensate you). His ghost will remember.*

J Black Colonel’s Banner Appears on the wrong field; confusion is a weapon. '[COMBAT]' *Roll 1d6. On 1–3, the enemy believes you have reinforcements (+1 Position). On 4–6, your own side hesitates (-1 die on first attack). The banner has no shadow.*

Q Blood-Feast Clan-Mother calls it; all contracts suspended until dawn’s judgment. '[OATH]' '[SOCIAL]' *The feast is a trial. Each PC must confess a broken oath or take **Harm** 1 (the clan judges). The meat is always fresh.*

K High Chief’s Game Plays companies against each other; “winner” takes obligations, not spoils. '[SOCIAL]' '[SHARE]' *The “winner” inherits a **Obligation Timer** [6] from the loser. Refusing the game starts a **Vendetta** [4]. The game has no rules — only winners.*

A The Singing Wastes Awaken Every fallen blade rises to seek its last hand. '[MAGIC]' '[DEATH]' *The blades attack everyone for 1 round. Afterward, any PC may claim a **Cursed Blade** (+1 die, but the blade whispers secrets — the GM gains 1 SB per scene). The song is a scream.*

Diamonds — Treasures & Discoveries

Each Diamond is a physical object with a cost and expiration.

|p0.08|p0.2|p0.67|

Rank	Name	Description & Mechanical Hook

2 **Emergency Requisition** Strip a fallen company; their ghosts watch. '[SHARE]' *Gain 1 Use of any mundane gear. After use, the quartermaster's ghost haunts you for 1d4 scenes (-1 die on stealth). He asks for his boots back.*

3 **Dual Contract** Serve two masters whose goals cannot both be met. '[SOCIAL]' '[SHARE]' *Gain +2 dice on one negotiation, but start a **Double Charter [6]** — when it fills, both masters seek recompense. The second master always cheats.*

4 **Honour Dispensation** Your acts are justified regardless of code (for now). '[SOCIAL]' *Once, ignore a **Black Mark** consequence. The dispensation is a bell — ring it, and the tribunal looks away. The bell then cracks. The sound is a lie.*

5 **Condotta Rider's Pass** Cross any camp perimeter unchallenged. '[STEALTH]' *The pass is a feather from a messenger who arrived too late. Use it once; then the feather burns. The smoke spells a name.*

6 **Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token** Pass a named clan's lands unmolested (until the moon changes). '[TRAVEL]' *The token is a horse's tooth. The horse was a gift from a dead Kha-gan. The tooth turns to dust after one use. The horse still whinnies at midnight.*

7 **Vilikari War-Mark** Their scouts guide you through hostile hills — and remember the favour. '[TRAVEL]' '[SHARE]' *Gain +1 Effect on one navigation roll. The favour will be called at dawn: they will demand a ridge or a bridge. The ridge is haunted.*

8 **Surgeon's Note** Medical care when no coin remains; the interest is names. '[SHARE]' *Heal 1 Harm now. The note is a name — the surgeon will collect it later (GM gains a String on you). She never forgets a face.*

9 **Tribune's Cipher Ring** Decode orders that do not exist yet. '[SOCIAL]' *Once, treat a **False Orders** complication as **Clean Success**. The ring is warm — it cools after use. The message was always a lie.*

10 **Banner-Captain's Seal** Commandeer resources from junior companies (and their resentment). '[AUTHORITY]' '[SHARE]' *Gain +1 **Supplies** now, but start a **Jealousy [4]** timer (junior officers scheme against you). The seal is a wolf's head. It bites.*

J **Field Promotion Warrant** Assume command of a shattered unit, inherit its timers. '[AUTHORITY]' '[SHARE]' *You gain a Cap 2 follower (the unit's sergeant), but inherit their pay timer [2/4] and **Black Mark [1]**. The sergeant has seen too much.*

Q **Clan-Mother's War-Braids** Her chosen fight beside you this battle, then judge you after. '[COMBAT]' '[SOCIAL]' *Gain a Cap 3 ally for one battle. Afterward, she judges your conduct — on a Miss, she takes a war-braid from you (lose 1 Boon). The braid is warm.*

K **High Chief's Trading Charter** Buy or sell *anything* in any camp, no questions asked aloud. '[TRADE]' *Once per arc, treat a market roll as **Clean Success**. The questions are asked in silence — the answers are compensated in silence (GM gains 1 SB). The charter is written on skin.*

A The Bannerless Word Loyalty that outruns rank, law, and coin. ‘[LEGEND]’ *Once, when all other resources are exhausted, whisper this word to rally a shattered company. They fight for one scene without tracking the pay timer or cohesion. Afterward, the word is forgotten — you cannot use it again. The men will not speak of it.*

Company Mechanics (Visible Tracks)

Every mercenary company (PC-led or NPC) tracks three timers:

- **Payday [4]** – Missed compensation, bad terms, seized chests. On fill: a squad deserts (lose 1 **Supplies**) or a veteran sells secrets (GM gains 2 SB). *The men whisper.*
- **Supplies [4]** – Weather, marches, sabotage. While Supplies ≥ 3 , all risky maneuvers start **Position** -1 unless you bring a Diamond (scavenge, requisition). *Hunger is a slow knife.*
- **Cohesion [6]** – Losses, betrayals, officer feuds. When Cohesion hits 1–2, the GM may convert the first 1 SB each scene into **Desertion, Brawl, or Refusal**. *Trust is the first casualty.*

Recovery: A successful **Payline Drill** scene clears 1 Payday. A **Quartermaster Audit** clears 1 Supplies. A **Rally & Reform** roll (Presence+Command, DV 3) clears 1 Cohesion. *Shared hardship binds faster than coin.*

Camp Event Mini-Generator (d8)

When the company makes camp or when tensions run high, roll on this table for a camp event that affects morale, cohesion, or supplies.

p0.1 p0.85
d8 Event

1 **Deserter’s Tale.** A soldier tries to flee with a payroll satchel. If caught, the company demands a public flogging. Intervening costs 1 Boon but earns a loyalty share (+1 Cohesion). If ignored, tick **Payday** +1 (the coin is gone) and **Cohesion** -1 (trust erodes). The deserter’s name is scratched from the roll.

2 **Surgeon’s Lottery.** The camp surgeon runs a lottery for medical priority. Those who pay 1 Boon jump the queue. Those who refuse may lose a wounded ally to infection (lose 1 **Supplies** or a follower). The surgeon’s ledger grows longer — and her smile thinner.

3 **Muster of the Fallen.** A ghostly formation marches through camp at midnight. Veterans take it as an omen. Each PC must test Resolve (DV 3) or gain the **Haunted** condition (-1 die on initiative for one day). On a success, they gain +1 die on the next morale check. The dead are counting.

4 **Brawl Over Bread.** A fight erupts over the last rations. The quartermaster demands the party intervene. Choose: *Break it up* (costs 1 Fatigue, no change), *Take sides* (gain a

small faction's favour but tick **Cohesion** -1), or *Let it burn* (lose 1 **Supplies** to spoilage). The loser's face stays in the mud.

5 **Pardoner's Visit.** A travelling pardoner offers absolutions for past sins. Pay 1 Boon to clear one **Black Mark** (the pardoner writes your name in his book). Refuse, and the pardoner's curse gives -1 Position on the next social roll against clergy. His book has many names.

6 **Desertion Ring.** An informant reveals a plot to desert en masse. The party can pay arrears (clear 1 Payday), execute the ringleaders (gain a **Black Mark** but tick **Cohesion** $+1$), or ignore it (tick **Payday** $+2$ as half the camp vanishes overnight). The informant wants a horse.

7 **Camp-Fever Peak.** The surgeon's tent overflows. Mark 1 **Fatigue** for each PC. A successful Medicine test (DV 4) reduces the effect by half. On a critical failure, a key NPC (the quartermaster or a sergeant) dies. The fever has a name.

8 **The Bannerless One Visits.** The mysterious figure appears at the edge of the firelight. She offers to clear 2 pay cycle segments in exchange for a **Price of Mercy** [4] timer. The timer advances each time the party shows mercy to an enemy. When full, she asks for a prisoner — or a promise. Her eyes are old.

Allegiances in Flux (Scene Start, 1d6)

At the start of every scene involving mercenaries, roll 1d6:

[leftmargin=*]

1. **Condotta Flip** – Rival charter offers better terms. Accept: gain **Black Mark** [1] with old patron. Refuse: tick **Payday** $+1$. *The ink is still wet.*
2. **Ykrul Counter-offer** – Accept an exit-rich but costly route: gain $+1$ Effect now, mark **Obligation** [2]. Refuse: tick **Payday** $+1$. *The wind shifts.*
3. **Vilikari Shortcut** – $+1$ Effect on this maneuver via night roads; GM gains 1 SB (hostile terrain later). *The path is older than the kingdom.*
4. **Ecktorian "Correction"** – March under "imperial guidance": $+1$ Position this scene or take a **Black Mark** for defiance. *The seal is heavy.*
5. **False Orders** – First command this scene suffers misinterpretation unless countered with a **Diamond** (cipher, cantor, witness). *The messenger's hands are clean.*
6. **Bannerless One** – A myth-wrapped figure clears 1 pay segment – but starts **Price of Mercy** [2]. When it fills, she asks for a prisoner you'd rather keep. *She was always there.*

Honor vs. Pragmatism Dial

Place a two-step dial. Starting position: balanced (0).

- **Honour** (left): +1 Position in parley/oathbound actions; logistics burn faster (increase **Supplies** by 1 on a Partial where you'd normally be safe). *The old songs approve.*
- **Pragmatism** (right): +1 Effect in ambush/sabotage; social rolls start one step worse Position when oaths/witnesses matter. *The men learn to watch their backs.*

Centering Actions: Settle arrears on-screen, return prisoners with witness, fulfill a broken writ at cost. Move the dial one step toward center. *The campfire remembers.*

Black Banners Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bell:** Crumble a crust at a camp's bell post. Ignore the first *Payday Delayed* penalty. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Knot the Roster:** Tie a single knot in the company roster. Cancel *Condotta Flip* or take -1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). [SUPERSTITION]
- **Name to the Mud:** Whisper a dead captain's name into the latrine trench. Gain +1 Effect when rallying the company this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bannerless One. [SUPERSTITION]

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Ride or Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Dust Cloud* (cover retreat).
- **Cut the Contract (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a *Condotta Rider's Pass* is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Blizzard (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Blizzard Pins*, you pick who finds shelter; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Three-Phase Foes)

- **The Coin-Captain (Mercenary Turncoat)** — *Phases:* Fair Offer → Betrayal Clause → Payday Massacre. *Cracks:* expose his dual contract before the company, pay off his debt to the Condotta Broker, or outbid him for his own loyalty.
- **The Quartermaster-Provost (Logistics Tyrant)** — *Phases:* Supply Freeze → Ration Cuts → Starvation Siege. *Cracks:* steal his secret ledger, rally the men with a shared meal (spend 1 Supplies), or break his control of the supply route.
- **The Singing Wakes (Weapon-Host)** — *Phases:* Whisper → Chorus → Scream. *Cracks:* perform the *Three Silencing Acts* (funeral honours for a fallen blade, bury a broken standard, ring the wind-break bell).

GM Tools

Field Procedures

- **Colours & Countersigns:** Declaring correct countersigns cancels the first **False Orders** SB each night; wrong signs worsen Position on first contact.
- **Payline Drill:** If a scene depicts orderly compensation, clear 1 **Payday**. If pay is “creative,” clear it but mark **Black Mark** – future officers begin one step colder in parley.
- **Scavenge Doctrine:** After battles, gain 1 temporary Gear tag or advance **Supplies** by 1; on a 1–2 on 1d6, spawn “Honour vs. Pragmatism” conflict immediately.

Cross-Regional Use

- **Vhasia:** A *Condotta Rider’s Pass* substitutes for a *Safe-Conduct* on the Pont-du-Tithe once; after use, start a *Parlement Divided* tick.
- **Viterra:** A *Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token* may be notarised as *Ferry Priority*; the notary’s fee is a story.
- **Ubral:** A *Clan-Mother’s War-Braid* counts as a *Guest-Token* in hill-forts; the clans will ask whose side you took.
- **Mistlands:** A *Banner-Captain’s Seal* can be presented to a Bell-Warden as proof of lawful passage; the Warden tests it with a bell. If it rings false, the mist takes a day.
- **Valewood:** A *Field Promotion Warrant* can be offered to a Green Knight as proof of worth; the Knight may challenge you to a trial of paths instead of blades.

Patronage & Power

In the Black Banners, power flows through agreements, coin chests, and the weight of a reputation — but also through the sergeant who knows each man's name, the cook who stretches the rations, the smith who works through the night. A Banner-Captain's authority rests on the number of companies he commands; a Condotta Broker's on the thickness of his roster. Yet loyalty is not bought — it is earned in the mud, at the latrine, across a shared fire.

For the GM: Power in the Black Banners is measured in payday timers, broker's favours, and the length of a duel record — but also in the camp's mood, the quartermaster's ledger, and the stories the veterans tell. Patronage often takes the form of dual contracts, emergency requisitions, or the Bannerless Word — each tied to a specific company, broker, or share. To emphasise the mercenary realism:

- Use the pay and supply timers as visible pressure. Let players negotiate, raid, or pledge future services to clear ticks.
- Enforce **Allegiances in Flux** — every scene, loyalties may shift. The Keeper's SB pool grows when the party breaks an agreement.
- Let **Honour vs. Pragmatism** be a dial the party can slide through their actions. Centre it by a costly act of mercy or a profitable betrayal.
- Track **Black Marks** as a persistent reputation score. Three Black Marks and no condotta broker will write a clear agreement for you.
- Remember the human element: the soldier who shares his last ration, the captain who stands in the line, the surgeon who weeps in private. These are the ties that outlast coin.

In the Black Banners, the camp sings when pay arrives — and falls silent when the coin chest is empty. But the camp also sings when a wounded friend survives, when the supply train arrives, when the snow melts and the road opens. The song is never just about coin.

Final GM Mantra (Black Banners Edition)

The camp sings when pay arrives — and falls silent when the chest is empty. Set **DV low**. Use **Allegiances in Flux** every scene. Let **Payday, Supplies, and Cohesion** be visible. Spend **SB** as false orders, cut supply lines, or camp fever. And remember: in the Black Banners, a broken agreement costs more than a broken blade — but a broken trust costs more than either.

The Linns

Skerries & Storm-Oaths.

“North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are not just traders and raiders; they are keepers of the storm’s oath and the sea’s weight. Their longships fill the whale-road and the river mouths, not for plunder, but for the promise of the tide. They swear oaths to storm and sea – not as words, but as a weight that binds, a clause that the deep remembers. They do not pay in silver; they pay in stories, because a tale well-told is the only treasure that lasts when the gold is gone.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Seal blubber and flatbread – the blubber is chewy, the bread is dense, and both are stored in the same barrel. The barrel is shared with the crew. The crew shares everything. Family is obligation.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To tie a knot. Linn children are given a length of rope at birth. By age five, they can tie the eight sea-knots. The ninth knot is for emergencies – and for funerals. The ninth knot is for when the sea asks for a life.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their breath. Linn sailors chew kelp to sweeten their breath. A stranger whose breath smells of salt has been at sea. A stranger whose breath smells of copper has spoken a false oath. The sea will answer.

What is the most common crime? Oath-breaking – but oath-breaking is a storm. The oath-breaker’s ship will founder. Their children will be born with webbed fingers. The sea is patient. The sea does not forget.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Sea-Queen is not a queen. She is a figurehead – literally. Her body is carved from the keel of a ship that sank in 612 AR. Her voice is a recording. The jarls pretend. The pretending keeps the peace.

Where do people go when they die? To the waves. Bodies are placed in boats and set adrift, weighted with stones carved with their name. If the boat sinks before the horizon, the dead is accepted. If it returns to shore, the dead is cursed. The beaches are littered with their bones.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a storm-oath. Stand on a cliff during a gale and swear your apology to the wind. If the wind carries your words, you are forgiven. If it throws you into the sea, you are not.

What is the most important festival? *The Launching of the Longships (spring thaw). The ships are dragged from their winter shelters and blessed with blood and mead. The ships are named after ancestors. The ancestors are listening. The ancestors approve.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Volva of the Mist is a fraud. She cannot see the future. She reads the weather – pressure, wind, the taste of salt on the air. The sailors know. The sailors do not care. A weather-reader is more useful than a seer.*

0.12 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

Region Diagnostic

Current Hook (one sentence)

The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the frost remembers upon its winds — but the Temple of Light arrives with ink and fire to what has carved.

Core Conflict (one sentence)

Players are caught between the Jarls’ raiding economy, the Sea-Queen’s Temple of Light’s crusade of re-education and assimilation — each do contradict the others.

The One Thing Only This Region Does

Frost-Bound Memory: Oaths are carved in ice that never melts. Every oath inflicts mechanical penalties (Fatigue/Harm) and gives the sea, sending the sea’s attention.

Interactive Mechanics (player-facing)

-  **1 tvíhögg (Double-Cut Fate):** Once per session, cut one thread of fate to redirect another — succeed but mark Frost Mark, or reroll sea/oath rolls but your name is added to hidden ice.
-  **2 Storm-Oaths:** Swear by touching salt water; keeping grants +1 die on sea rolls, breaking inflicts 1 Fatigue (or 1 Harm if sworn during storm).
-  **3 Frost Mark (Weight Timer):** Every favor/gift from Linn creates a 4-segment timer; when full, community demands service (raid, story, labor). Refusal = −1 die on social rolls.
-  **4 Season’s Turn:** GM spends 3 SB to change season; Spring (foraging/healing +1), Summer (combat/sailing +1), Autumn (social/legal +1), Winter (survival Desperate, Frost Mark easier to clear).

Campaign Timers (GM-facing)

- **Temple Pressure [6]** – *Advances when:* players accept Temple aid, ignore shrine offerings, or fail faith tests. *At full:* Bishop demands public oath of loyalty; shrine-devout suffer −1 Position in settlements.
- **Thing Schism [6]** – *Advances when:* jarls convert, feuds go unresolved, or oath-rings are broken. *At full:* The Thing splits; half the clans follow Temple law, half follow frost-law. Civil conflict begins.

- **Winter Debts [8]** – *Advances when:* players accept Frost Marks, take shelter, or break small taboos. *At full:* The Thing convenes; party must defend oaths or be forced into a quest to pay debts.

	Faction	Goal	Method	Why players care
Faction Triad	High Jarls	Unite scattered strands under one raiding oath	Successful raids, wise judgments at Thing-Holm, frost-mark enforcement	Control harbors, access, levy ships, offer raid-truce and oar-shares
	Sea-Queen	Maintain coastal law without drawing blade	Envoy network, seal-bags, oath-sticks branded with queen's mark	Grants harbor marks, escapes writs, audience that bends sea-laws
	Temple of Light Crusade	Convert Linn to Lens of White Flame (re-education & assimilation)	Grain fleets, synod courts, bell-tower consecrations, schoolmasters	Cheap grain, legal alternatives to blood-feuds, protection from "pagan" hazards

The Price

Every gift carries a Frost Mark (weight timer); every oath sworn is carved in ice that never fully melts. Power requires gambling memory (Adar's ravens), accepting storm-marks (Rorg's attention), or submitting to Temple re-education (losing shrine-devotion).

Geography as Constraint

Fjords freeze in winter (longships beached, travel impossible); skerries break navigation requires local pilots); Mistlands and Valewood edges have no need of oaths to claim their due. The Aberderrin Current splits flotillas; contrary swells m...

The Ninth Taboo manifestation

In any longhouse, the ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Thing at eight. Those who blow the ninth see a pale figure (Adar) standing — waiting to collect a weight. Bell-towers ring eight notes; the ninth discovery is fatal.

Current Weaknesses (honest self-assessment)

- Temple crusade needs mechanical teeth beyond "1 die" — add Conversion [6] timer and Synthesis Tokens for blending faiths.
- Rorg/Xhak'thul syncretism needs clearer Patron mechanics — is he Storm Father (Oath of Flame) or Khemesh (Abyss)?

- Frost Mark timer needs clearer clearance conditions per season.

Theme & Atmosphere

High Jarl (Elite): “The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. But the frost — the frost is the witness. It preserves what the tide would wash away. A promise sworn in winter is owed until the ice melts. And the ice never truly melts.”

Net-Wife (Commoner): “The water speaks to those who know how to listen — the way it moves tells you if the fish are running, if the weather’s turning, or if something’s coming that wasn’t invited to the feast. My grandmother taught me to read the frost on the oar-blades. That’s how I know who will live through the winter and who will feed the seals.”

Genre / Mood: Norse coastal saga, oath-driven honor, horror of the unwitnessed death, the tyranny of seasons, the weight of wyrd.

Starting Location: A longship house lined with storm-charms and whale-bone runes, salt wind clawing at the doors. A Net-Wife binds a storm-token into a PC’s palm. “The Whale-Road sings,” she says. “But the Mistlands whistle back. Bring us three keel-lengths of ironwood from the Valewood edge, or the tide will take our boats in the spring. The frost remembers the shelter you took last winter. Pay, or the ice will hold it against you.”

North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whale-road and river mouths. They descend the Ylolka like an axe-blade and cut into southern shores, or slip through the Thin Strip where the Valewood dares not touch salt. Yet even these storm-oath people dread the Mistlands and the Valewood, whose fog and trees have no need of ships or harbors to claim their due.

The Linn measure their lives in seasons, not years. There is a season for raiding (summer, when the seas are open), a season for planting (spring, when the frost breaks), a season for governance (autumn, when the ships are beached and the Thing meets), and a season for survival (winter, when the frost sets its mark). In winter, the fjords freeze, the longships are dragged into sheds, and the people gather around the longhall fires to settle debts, tell sagas, and wait for the sun to return. The winter debt is not a book — it is a set of carved oath-sticks, each notch a promise kept or broken, each knot a story still unfolding. When a Linn says a debt is “written in frost,” they mean it is unchangeable until the ice melts. And the ice, in the high north, never truly melts.

The gods of the Linn are not distant. **Adar**, the All-Father, walks the ridges in a gray cloak, his one eye watching for those who break oaths. He is a manifestation of the Oath of Flame and Light, but the Linn know him as the god of wisdom, death, and binding promises. **Rorg**, the Storm Father, rides the clouds, his hammer cracking the sky. He is a syncretic version of Xhak’tul (in the vein of Thor) — the patron of raiders and sailors, a thunder-god

who laughs in the teeth of the gale. His cult is loud, proud, and dangerous — a Rorg devotee will swear a storm-oath by drinking seawater and shouting at the lightning. The Temple of Light calls him a demon. The Linn call him captain.

What you notice first: The smell of tar and salt fish. The creak of oars from unseen boats. The way everyone — jarl to thrall — touches a knotted cord before speaking of the sea. The oath-sticks hanging from every belt, each mark a weight carried.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn't recognize, it may reach up to correct the debt. Also, never refuse a cup of winter mead — it is a test of your honor and your weight.

Prominent NPCs of Linn

p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumored Quirk
—	Jarl Skjold	High Jarl of the Southern Fjords	Unite the scattered strands under one oath	His beard is braided with silver from every ship he has taken. His oath-stick bears notches from three wars.
—	Volva Hervor	Mist-seer and oath-reader	Read the tides of fate before they turn	She speaks once a year; the rest of the time she listens to the fog. She reads the frost-bound oaths by touch — her fingers are scarred from counting.
—	Astrid	Net-Wife (commoner exemplar)	Keep her village safe from the Hollow and the deep	She ties a knot for every storm she's survived. Her belt has thirty. She is the keeper of the village oath-sticks.
—	Brother Halvard	Missionary of the Temple of Light	Convert the Linn to the Lens of the White Flame	He carries a water-timer to measure the hours of prayer, but the skerries have no hours. His oath-stick is blank — the Linn do not trust him.
—	Gunnhild	Sea-Queen's Hand	Enforce the queen's will without drawing a blade	She never draws her sword. The threat is enough. She carries an oath-stick notched with the names of every jarl who tried to cheat the queen.
—	The Draugr Jarl	Unfinished business (rumored)	A dead jarl whose oath was never fulfilled	Said to rise from the Thing-Holm when the ninth bell tolls. His oath-stick is frozen — the marks are filled with ice.
—	Einar Frost-Tongue	Skald of the Frost Memory	Keep the memory of weights alive through verse	He has never lost a verse duel. His tongue is forked — he can praise and curse in the same breath. His oath-stick is longer than his arm.

Regional Tables

Spades — Places

2. **Kelp-Skerry Gut** — Narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock. *Kelp strands like dead men's hair; row silently or the reef listens.* [TRAVEL] [STEALTH]
3. **Tide-Shed** — Longship houses; tar smoke and gulls for sentries. *Each shed holds a keel's ghost; old crews sleep under the floor planks.* [REPUTATION]
4. **Wave-Gate Reef** — Just off a raiding beach; only locals know the cut. *One wrong turn and the wave breaks over you — twice.* [TRAVEL] [DEATH]
5. **Runestone Causey** — Across tidal flat; names half lost to barnacle. *Touch the stone with your left hand. If it's warm, the ancestors approve.* [LEGEND]
6. **Herring-Stairs** — Drying racks above cliff path; knives flicker like fish. *Workers sing a counting song — eight verses, never nine.* [LABOR]
7. **Winter Hall** — Turf walls, smoke-eye roof, benches crowded with shields. *The fire never goes out. Feed it a story each night or it goes hungry.* [COMMUNITY]
8. **Mistlands Maze** — Reed-channels braid and vanish; navigation by instinct. *The reeds whisper names you've forgotten. Do not answer.* [DEATH] [FEAR]
9. **Boomed Harbor** — Iron rings in whale-bone posts; controlled access. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.* [AUTHORITY]
10. **Aberderrin Headland** — Current rips past wreck timbers in the kelp. *On foggy nights, the drowned signal with lanterns. Never follow.* [DEATH]
- J **Dolmis Waystation** — Low isle with fresh water and old weights. *The well is lined with copper. A single dropped coin returns as a blessing.* [TRAVEL]
- Q **Thing-Holm** — Flat islet ringed with stones for speaking and swearing. *The stones have ears; oaths spoken here echo for three tides. The winter oaths are kept here, frozen in a block of ice that never melts.* [JUSTICE]
- K **High Jarl's Seat** — Above fjord, beacon tower glaring out to sea. *The beacon oil is mixed with whale fat. It burns green when a storm is close, blue when the winter debts are called.* [WEATHER]
- A **Whale-Road Horizon** — Open water where storms are born and names are made. *Here, the sky meets the sea. Here, the dead meet the living.* [LEGEND]

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Net-Wife** — Reads sea like memory, sky like mood; weather-witch in all but name. *She ties a knot for every storm she's survived. Her belt has thirty. She is the keeper of the village oath-sticks.* [COMMUNITY]
3. **Steersman** — Tiller-hand never shakes, even when keel does. *His left ear is scarred — he listened too long to a siren's promise. His oath-stick is notched for every life he's lost.* [REPUTATION]
4. **Shipwright** — Pitch on palms, schedule in teeth; knows every plank's story. *He names each timber after a dead relative. The keel is his grandmother. The ship's burden is carved into the mast.* [CRAFT]
5. **Oar-Master** — Sets beat that decides if home is today or never. *He drums on a hollowed skull. The rhythm is a prayer to Rorg. The oar-crew's debt is marked on his own arm — notches in the bone.* [SOCIAL]
6. **Mist-Pilot** — Ghosts boats through marsh lanes; reed-runner with secret paths. *He never blinks in fog. Some say he traded his blink for safe passage. His memory-cord is knotted, not notched — the knots are spells.* [STEALTH]
7. **Skald** — Verses buy silence, start fights, end them; law in rhyme. *Her tongue is forked — she can praise and curse in the same breath. She is the only one who can reshape a frost-bound oath — by composing a new verse that changes the meaning of a mark.* [JUSTICE] [SOCIAL]
8. **Shield-Band** — Cousins fine with coin, better with cattle. *They sharpen their swords on runestones. The sparks tell fortunes. Their oath-stick is shared — each mark is a blood debt owed to the band.* [COMBAT]
9. **Foster-Son** — Southern coast birth; speaks both laws and subtext. *He wears two brooches — one iron, one bone. Neither is his true allegiance. He carries two oath-sticks — one for the Linn, one for the lowlands.* [POLITICS]
10. **Thing-Speaker** — Makes war into lawsuit, lawsuit into lunch. *He carries a water-timer that runs on meltwater. When it runs out, so does your patience. He interprets the winter debts for those who cannot read ice.* [JUSTICE]
- J **Sea-Queen's Hand** — Envoy with seal-bag and sword-belt; queen's will made manifest. *He never draws his blade. The threat is enough. His oath-stick is branded with the queen's mark — a seal that cannot be forged.* [AUTHORITY]
- Q **Sea-Queen** — Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law. *She lost an eye to a storm — or to a spy. She won't say which. She is the only one who can order the winter debts spoken.* [AUTHORITY]
- K **High Jarl** — First among raids, last to boast; paramount over strands. *His beard is braided with silver from every ship he's taken. His oath-stick is a whale's rib — too long for anyone else to carry.* [REPUTATION]

- A **Volva of Mist** — Oath-reader whose nod stills surf; seer of tides and truth. *She speaks once a year. The rest of the time, she listens to the fog. She reads the frost-bound oaths by touch — her fingers are scarred from counting.* [LEGEND]

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Black Squall** — Drops from clear band; oars or prayers — pick one. [WEATHER] *The wind screams a name. Listen carefully — it might be yours. Rorg is testing your courage.*
 3. **Fogfall** — Sound travels, sight does not; friend and reef trade places. [WEATHER] [FEAR] *You hear oars. Then you don't. Then they're behind you. The drowned are rowing.*
 4. **Boom Lift** — Harbor chain rises; schedules drown in harbor mouth. [AUTHORITY] *The chain's links are inscribed with names of those who carry weight. Each one rattles differently. Your name is on one.*
 5. **Levy Clash** — Viterra's wardens arrive with polite spears. [POLITICS] [COMBAT] *They carry a writ stamped with the queen's seal. The seal is still wet. The winter ice says the queen is owed three ships.*
 6. **Keel-Rot Rumor** — Crews beach mid-voyage; trust in timber fails. [DISASTER] *The rot smells sweet — too sweet. Someone poisoned the tar. The ship's mark is missing.*
 7. **Feud Token** — Raid becomes wedding... or funeral; oath-debt called due. [SOCIAL] [DEBT] *A bronze ring arrives on an arrow. The meaning is clear. The ice shows the mark.*
 8. **Oath Matured** — Verse sworn last winter comes due today. [SOCIAL] [DEBT] *The skald clears her throat. The room goes cold. The ice in the Thing-Holm cracks.*
 9. **Mistlands Miscount** — Channels "move," cargo vanishes without witnesses. [DEATH] *The fog lifts to reveal a different shore. Your charts are now lies. The cargo's mark is blank — someone erased it.*
 10. **Aberderrin Race** — Contrary currents split flotilla; half late, half lost. [WEATHER] *The water churns like a dying man. Something beneath is feeding. The sea remembers a new debt.*
- J **Southron Fire-Pots** — Night-run turns to daylight; surprise ashore. [COMBAT] *Pots shatter on the deck. The fire burns blue — alchemical. Rorg laughs. The raid's memory is now fire-scarred.*
- Q **Thing Injunction** — No sailing till grievance heard (hours? days?). [JUSTICE] *The Thing-Speaker smiles. He has all the time in the world. The winter oath is frozen — no one can leave until it thaws.*

- K **General Muster** — Horns on every headland; all bays become spears. [AUTHORITY] [COMBAT] *The war fleet assembles. Your ship is the smallest. Adar is watching. He counts the oaths.*
- A **Ground-Sea** — Long, blind swell rolls under; steering lies. [WEATHER] [DEATH] *The swell has a rhythm — two short, one long. A signal from below. The drowned are voting.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Harbor-Mark** — Dock without levy in named strand (once). [TRAVEL] *The mark is a notch cut in a bone. Match it to the harbor post. The notch must be cut by the harbor master's own knife.*
 3. **Oar-Share** — Claim two benches on a fast longship for a season. [TRAVEL] *The oars are carved with your name. Row well, or they'll be recarved. The oar itself is the promise.*
 4. **Pilot's Token** — Mist-runner guides through reed-maze safely. [TRAVEL] *The token is a dried eel skin. Keep it dry. The pilot's memory-cord is knotted in the same pattern.*
 5. **Wharf-Right** — Dolmis waystation loading priority; first ashore. [TRAVEL] *The harbormaster frowns but steps aside. Your name is now on a list.*
 6. **Salvage Claim** — Flotsam on reef stretch becomes "inventory." [TRADE] *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim. The promise of the salvage is bound to the tide line.*
 7. **Thing Ruling** — Verdict in your favor that travels with you. [JUSTICE] *The verdict is carved on a whale-rib. Carry it as a shield. The winter ice will not speak for the same dispute twice.*
 8. **Raid-Truce** — Immunity in named bay for one market day. [TRAVEL] [SOCIAL] *A white banner on your mast. No one will attack — openly. The promise of the truce is the banner rope. Cut it, and the truce ends.*
 9. **Foster-Bond** — Guest-kin by jarl's house; hospitality guaranteed. [SOCIAL] *You share a cup with the jarl. The cup is silver. The promise is iron. The winter ice bears a new mark — for both of you.*
 10. **Herring Allotment** — Priority barrels when the run hits; silver in season. [TRADE] *The barrels are sealed with your mark. Break one to test quality. The promise of the allotment is the barrel hoop.*
- J **Escort Writ** — Eight shields and wolf-banner from cape to cape. [TRAVEL] [COMBAT] *The shields are painted with a wolf's head. They die before you do. Their oath is their swords — notched for every oath kept.*

Q **Queen's Audience** — Whisper exits as policy; sea-law bends. [AUTHORITY] *The Queen's hand writes your words on vellum. The ink is her blood. The winter ice will record the audience — but not the words.*

K **High Jarl's Pennon** — Levies open booms and mouths when it flies. [AUTHORITY] *The pennon is torn from a captured ship. Fly it proudly — or else. The promise of the pennon is the ship's mast.*

A **Storm-Oath Clause** — Temporary exception to any sea-law, sealed. [AUTHORITY] [MAGIC] *The clause is whispered, never written. The sea hears and obeys — once. Rorg will remember. The winter ice will not record it — the ice cannot hold a whisper.*

Patronage & Power

Among the Linn, power flows through oaths, kinship, and the spoken word — and through the marks carved in ice. Jarls maintain authority through successful raids and wise judgments, while skalds wield influence through their ability to immortalize deeds in verse — or damn names through satire. The Sea-Queen holds sway over the coastlands, but her rule depends on the respect of the High Jarl and the Thing-speakers who interpret ancient laws. And beneath all of them lies the frost-bound memory — the carved word, not the written one.

For the GM: Power in Linn society is fluid and performance-based. Patronage often takes the form of foster-bonds, oar-shares, or raid-truces — each binding the recipient to service and reputation. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, banners, verses) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival jarls issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the Thing-Holm and harbor gatherings as arenas for social contests, where oaths are sworn and broken.
- Introduce the Frost Mark as a recurring pressure. Every gift from a Linn comes with a weight. Players who ignore their marks may find themselves summoned to the Thing in winter.
- Let the seasons change. A winter scene should feel different from a summer raid. Use the Season's Turn to reinforce the cyclical nature of Linn life.

In Linn society, your word is your bond, and your reputation is your greatest treasure. But the frost-bound memory is patient. It waits for spring.

Temple Crusade Mini-Generators

Temple Pressure Events (d6)

Roll when the Northern Crusade advances or when the GM needs a story beat.

[label=12., wide=0pt]

1. **Grain Fleet Arrives.** Temple ships unload cheap southern grain. Prices drop, but the old shrine offerings are forgotten. *Effect:* +1 tick on **Temple Pressure** timer; +1d on social rolls with hungry villagers for one scene.
2. **Synod Court Opens.** A Thepyrgosi judge hears the first case. Feuds may be settled with penance instead of blood-silver. *Effect:* Shrine-devout characters suffer –1 Position in this settlement until they prove their loyalty.
3. **Bell Tower Consecrated.** A bronze bell rings nine times at dawn. The old shrine bells fall silent. *Effect:* Temple-leaning characters gain +1d on faith actions; every midnight, the GM may spend 1 SB to have the ninth bell attract a hungry ghost.
4. **Schoolmaster Arrives.** Children learn to write Temple script. Old oral traditions are called “superstition.” *Effect:* The next generation will have +1 Temple Devotion; players may attempt a **Synthesis Scene** to save one shrine teaching.
5. **Bishop’s Progress.** A high-ranking cleric tours the coast, consecrating altars. Refusal to host him marks you as an enemy of the Light. *Effect:* Begin a **Bishop’s Favor** [4] timer; if it fills, the bishop demands a public oath of loyalty.
6. **Iconoclasm.** Zealots burn a seastack shrine or break a Thing’s oath-ring. The old patrons are furious. *Effect:* Shrine-devout characters gain a free **Vengeance Oath** String; weather and tide hazards become one step worse for 1d4 days.

Linn Reactions to the Temple (d12)

How a community (or a crew) responds to the crusade’s advance.

[label=12., wide=0pt]

1. **Desperate Acceptance.** “We ate their grain. We owe them.” *Tag:* Grateful–Sullen.
2. **Silent Resistance.** Shrine offerings are left in secret; Temple priests are given cold hearths. *Tag:* Ice–Hospitality.
3. **Open Feud.** A clan declares the Temple an enemy. Raids on granaries begin. *Clock:* **Feud with Temple** [6].
4. **Syncretic Curiosity.** Elders ask the priest to bless a shrine. “Both fires warm the hall.” *Opportunity:* Earn a **Synthesis Token**.
5. **Pragmatic Split.** The jarl converts; half the thing follows, half walks out. *Clock:* **Thing Schism** [6].

6. **Conversion as Revenge.** A family spurned by the old patrons embraces the Temple to spite them. *Tag:* Bitter–Righteous.
7. **Bread & Bells.** The village accepts the Temple but keeps a hidden shrine to Hvítabjörn. *Tag:* Double–Altar.
8. **Heretic Burnings.** Temple zealots execute a shrine-keeper. The hall is now **Contested Ground**.
9. **The Bishop’s Bastard.** A priest’s secret child is now a Linn raider. *String:* Blood–Secret.
10. **Wave-Father’s Answer.** A storm wrecks a Temple grain ship. Shrine-devout see a sign. *Effect:* +2 on a shrine-related roll this session.
11. **Oath-Ring Saved.** A Temple judge rules that the old oath-ring is still lawful – a rare bridge-builder. *Reward:* **Ambassador Status** (one scene of neutral faith ground).
12. **The Silent Bell.** The new tower’s bell cracks on the ninth toll. No one can explain it. *Omen:* GM gains 2 SB for fog- or ghost-related twists.

Temple Missions (d6)

Quests the Temple of Light might offer to a mixed or Temple-leaning crew.

[label=12., wide=0pt]

1. **Recover a Stolen Relic.** A shrine-devout crew has taken a fragment of the True Candle. Find it – by negotiation or force.
2. **Escort the Bishop.** Take a southern prelate through a contested fjord. Protect him from “pagan” ambushes – or arrange one.
3. **Convert a Hall.** A jarl sits on the fence. Persuade him (or his skald) that the Light is good for trade. *Clock:* **Conversion** [6].
4. **Burn the Shrine.** A remote seastack shrine is a navigation hazard and a gathering point for resisters. The Temple offers silver for its destruction.
5. **Rescue a Synod Judge.** He was taken hostage after a biased ruling. Infiltrate the clan’s winter hall and bring him out alive.
6. **Forgive a Blood-Debt.** The Temple wants to end a feud by paying blood-silver from its own coffers. You must convince both sides to accept – a delicate parley.

Faith Tension Scenes (d6)

Quick scene starters for religious conflict.

[label=12., wide=0pt]

1. **The Thinglet at the Hearth.** Shrine-devout and Temple-leaning families argue over a broken betrothal. *Position:* Controlled → Desperate if you take sides openly.
2. **Midnight at the Bell Tower.** Someone has silenced the ninth bell – by stuffing it with wool from a white bear’s pelt. *Complication:* Spiritual Conflict Condition begins.
3. **The Convert’s Shame.** A Temple-leaning Linn begs you to smuggle her family heirloom (a shrine totem) out of the village before the bishop’s agents find it.
4. **Storm over the Synod Court.** Vélki answers a shrine-devout’s prayer with a lightning strike on the Temple granary. *GM:* Spend 2 SB to have a priest accuse the party of witchcraft.
5. **The Wandering Skald.** A singer arrives with a verse that claims the crew has a secret shrine oath. The verse is false – but now everyone believes it.
6. **Dual Oath at Dusk.** A dying warrior asks to swear by both Hrævkn and the Light. The shrine-keeper and the Temple priest each demand you witness only their rite. *Reward:* A **Synthesis Token** if you honor both.

Syncretic Outcomes (d6)

When players successfully blend shrine and Temple practices, roll (or choose) a lasting effect.

[label=12., wide=0pt]

1. **The Shared Cairn.** A new shrine uses a Temple candle to light the old oath-ring. *Effect:* This site is now **Mixed Quarter** permanently; once per session, any character may reroll a failed faith-related roll here.
2. **Witness of Both.** The crew is known as bridge-builders. *Effect:* Gain **Ambassador Status** (convert a faith-based Position penalty into a bonus once per session).
3. **The Ninth Bell Silent.** The village agrees to ring only eight bells, leaving the ninth for the old patrons. *Effect:* Shrine-devout characters no longer suffer –1 Position in this village.
4. **The Skald’s Compromise.** A Temple hymn is set to an old shrine tune. *Effect:* Any Audience tag that includes “Suspicious” downgrades to “Curious” in this region.
5. **Blood-Silver to the Poor.** A feud is settled by paying wergild to the Temple’s poor fund – but the shrine witnesses the payment. *Effect:* The settlement counts as both a **Thing Verdict** and a **Synod Absolution**. The GM may not use this feud as a complication again.

6. **The Unbroken Spiral.** A new rite is born: a white candle and a raven's feather are offered together. *Effect:* The crew gains a permanent **Synthesis Token** that refreshes every season (instead of being one-use).

Local Patrons (Syncretic Names)

- **Adar the All-Father** — Oath of Flame and Light. *The one-eyed god of wisdom, death, and binding oaths. He watches from the ridges. His oath-stick is the frost-bound memory itself.*
- **Rorg the Storm Father** — Syncretic Xhak'thul (Thor-like). *The god of thunder, raiding, and the wild sea. His devotees swear storm-oaths by drinking seawater. He laughs at lightning. The Temple calls him a demon; the Linn call him captain.*
- **The Salted Anchor** — The Sealed Gate. *The harbor that never closes, the oath that never rusts.*
- **The Wave Mother** — Raéyn. *The tide that carries and the storm that answers.*
- **The Drowned Chorus** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel, the weight the sea collects.*
- **The Unwritten Verse** — The Witness. *The memory that survives the drowning.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Draugr Jarl (Unfinished Business):** The Thing-Holm is haunted by a jarl who died before his oath was fulfilled. He rises when a storm-oath is broken, demanding a blood-price paid in stories. The Temple of Light has sent three missionaries to lay him to rest; all three drowned in calm water. His oath-stick is frozen into the ice of the Thing-Holm. If it ever thaws, he will walk again.
- **Adar's Ravens (The Witness):** Adar is said to have two ravens, Memory and Thought, who fly across the world each day and return to whisper in his ear. A Linn skald who prays to Adar may ask one question about a forgotten weight; the GM must answer truthfully, though cryptically. The price is a memory — the skald forgets something unimportant, but it may become important later.
- **Rorg's Hammer (The Xhak'thul):** The Storm Father's hammer is said to be lodged in a cliff on the highest skerry. A character who touches the hammer and survives the lightning may invoke Rorg's wrath once per session: all enemies within Near must test Resolve (DV 4) or be Stunned for one exchange. The cost is that the character is marked by the storm — they will be struck by lightning at the worst possible moment (GM's discretion).
- **The Tide-Washed Covenant (The Hospice of the Salted Anchor):** A gray-robed healer runs a hospice on the edge of the Mistlands, treating wounded raiders

and fog-mad sailors alike. She asks no payment, but she writes every name in a book that never dries. Linn captains leave offerings of fresh water before a voyage; those who refuse find their ship plagued by the drowned. The book is said to be a copy of the frost-bound oaths — but written in salt water, not ice.

- **The Ninth:** In any longhouse, the ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Hollow. The wise stop at eight. Those who blow the ninth are said to see a pale figure standing at the high table — waiting to collect a weight. The figure is Adar, checking his oath-stick.

Linn Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over the gunwale before a voyage. Ignore the first *Black Squall* penalty. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Knot the Oar:** Tie a single knot in your oar's leather grip. Cancel *Keel-Rot Rumor* or take −1 die on your next rowing check (your choice). [SUPERSTITION]
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into the tide. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Sea-Queen. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Drink to the Storm:** Pour a cup of mead into the sea before a raid. Rorg will grant you favorable winds — but he will also expect a share of the plunder. [SUPERSTITION]

Quick Use Notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (rights/tokens/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens** — horns on wind, white horses on swell, verse unfinished until landfall, the ice cracking with memory.

Part III

The Spaces Between

“The Ways Between do not measure miles. They measure choices. A wrong turn might lead to yesterday. A right turn might lead to a version of yourself who made a different decision – and is still alive to regret it.”

— The Edgewalker

Ubral

The Stone Between Spears.

“Ubral is a land of upland mists, stone cairns, and clan oaths held tighter than iron. Caught between the Aelerian mountains and the lowland courts of Viterra, its hills are scarred by old raids and crowned by watch-fires. Law is written not in charters but in cattle, blood-price, and songs. A guest’s word can buy more than a sword, but one broken vow can spark a feud lasting generations.”

— Lady Isolde of the Scar

What do people eat for breakfast? Oatcakes and skyr – the oats are grown in highland clearings, the skyr is cultured in stone crocks buried in the peat. The peat remembers the old kings. The old kings are buried beneath it.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count cattle. Ubral children are taught the eight breeds of the hills. The ninth breed has no colour – it belongs to the cairn-folk. The dead do not pay taxes.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their guest-token. A token given by their last host. A warm token means recently welcomed. A cold token means travelling long. No token means a spy. Spies are given a rope.

What is the most common crime? Cattle raiding – but raiding is a sport. A stolen cow is a stolen child. The return is a negotiation. The negotiation is a feud. The feud is a song.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Lady of Tor is not the ruler. The cairns rule. The cairns vote at each full moon. Their votes are carried by the wind. The wind speaks to the hearth-aunts. The clan obeys.

Where do people go when they die? To the cairns. Their bones are added to the cairns. The cairns grow taller each year. The oldest cairn has no name. It remembers the first clan.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a wergild – payment in cattle. The cattle are driven to the cairn. If they graze peacefully, you are forgiven. If they scatter, you are not. If they refuse to enter the covenant’s shadow, your claim is blood.

What is the most important festival? The Gathering of the Clans (autumn). The clans meet at the Great Cairn. The cattle are counted. The songs are sung. The feuds are settled. The dead are named. The hills remember.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Great Cairn is a prison – the tomb of a Vritann king who tried to conquer Ubral and failed. He was buried alive. His ghost votes with the cairns. He votes for war. The cairns have not yet agreed.

0.13 Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The lowlands write their laws in ink. We carve ours in stone. The ink fades. The stone remembers.*

Lady of Tor (Elite): “The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow. To lead is to understand that the land itself is the true sovereign, and we are merely its stewards. The lowland kings write their claims on parchment. We write ours in cairns. And when the ink fades, as it always does, the cairns will still be here—waiting.”

Hearth-Aunt (Commoner): “Hospitality’s a sacred thing in these hills—break bread at my table and you’re family till the sun sets twice. But cross that trust and the very stones will remember your name. The Viterran tax men learned that. Their bones are under the sheepwalk now. We don’t forget. We don’t forgive. We weigh every slight in cattle and count every insult in winters.”

Genre / Mood: Highland clan honor, misty glens, wergild and blood feuds, exiled dwarves, geometry of grudges, Scottish folk horror.

Starting Location: A Warden’s Cairn at the fog line. Spears planted like grave markers, their shafts wrapped in faded clan ribbons. Hoofbeats echo in the valley below. The Hearth-Aunt offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Wolf Road wakes,” she says. “Viterran tax men are asking which passes you used. The clans are counting your steps. Speak true, or the cairn will add your name to its tally. And mind the Aeler outcast in the smithy—he’s been here forty years and still forgets to duck under doorframes. He counts his breaths in eights. You should too. If you hear a woman washing clothes by the ford at midnight, do not ask her name. She is the *bean-nighe*, and she is washing the shrouds of the dead.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Ubral is a land of knife-edged ridges, mist-veiled glens, dark lochs, and stone cairns that mark the bones of old kings. Caught between the Aelerian mountains to the north and the lowland courts of Viterra to the south, its hills are scarred by centuries of raiding and reprisal. The clans speak a tongue thick with swallowed consonants and older grudges. They measure wealth in cattle, honor in wergild, and time in the generations since a Viterran banner last burned in the high passes. To the east, the gray waters of the Dolmis Sea crash against rocky shores, where fishing villages pay tribute to whichever clan controls the nearest pass—and sometimes to a different one each season.

Exiled Aeler—dwarves who could not abide the Deep Vaults' suffocating tradition—have found refuge here, sharing their cunning with forge and toll-road, and their outcast bitterness with any clan willing to listen. The lowland lords of Viterra claim suzerainty over Ubral; the clans call those claims “ink on wet stone.” Every pass holds a watch-fire, every ford a memory of a battle, every hearth a knife waiting for a guest who stays too long.

The clans do not fight for land. They fight for *honor*—a geometry of obligation that stretches back centuries. An insult is not forgiven; it is *weighed*. A wound is not healed; it is *counted* against a blood-price. Every death opens a new angle in the feud, every reconciliation closes one—but the shape is never forgotten. The Aeler outcasts, with their breath-counters and bell-codes, understand this geometry better than most. They call it *Kon'reh*: the game of exits and obligations, where the ninth move is never made.

The old folk still speak of the *sluagh*—the host of the unforgiven dead that flies through the night sky, snatching souls who have no cairn to call their own. They whisper of the *baobhan sith*, the blood-drinking woman who dances with travellers before draining them dry, and the *each uisge*, the water horse that lures the unwary onto its back and drags them into the loch. The clans leave offerings of iron nails at fords to ward off the kelpies, and they never cut the ninth stalk of heather for fear of waking the *uruisg*, the wild spirit of the glen.

What you notice first: The smell of peat smoke and wet granite. The constant lowing of cattle on distant hills. The way every threshold has a knife hidden nearby—for guests, not against them. The way old men trace patterns in the dirt with sticks, arguing over angles that only they can see.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt. Hospitality is a contract sealed in salt and bread. Refusal is an insult that blood must answer. And never count to nine in a cairn's shadow. The dead are counting with you, and they stop at eight.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

In Ubral, the ninth stone in any cairn is always warm. Touch it, and you will remember an oath you never swore. Those who touch the ninth stone three times are said to become a cairn themselves—silent, still, and waiting for the next hand. The Aeler outcasts say the ninth stone is a door to the Deep Vaults they fled. They do not touch it. They count to eight and leave.

The ninth step on any path that leads to a loch is said to belong to the *each uisge*. Those who step on it hear the sound of hooves beneath the water and feel a cold breath on their neck. If they take a ninth step into the water, the water horse will claim them.

Regional Mood: Cairn, Tor, and the Geometry of Grudges

Here, the past is never past. Every cairn holds a voice, every burn scar on a hillside remembers a raid. Viterra has tried to conquer Ubral a dozen times; each attempt ended with supply lines cut by reivers, passes sealed by Aeler outcast engineers, and lowland knights lost in mist. The Utaran Imperium itself broke its leg on these hills and limped away. Now the clans watch the lowlands with patient eyes, and the exiled Aeler of Khaz-Vurim weigh every traveler's honor on iron scales. A guest here is kin—until they prove otherwise. And kin here will die for you—or kill you over a stolen cow. The Lady of Tor rules by consent of the Council of Cairns, and the Council speaks for the dead as much as the living. Every nine years, a moot is called at Gray Tor to settle the great feud—a dispute between the two oldest clans that no one can remember the origin of, but everyone remembers the blood.

The clans do not write their laws. They *carve* them—into stone, into memory, into the bones of their enemies. A feud is not a quarrel; it is a *balance*, an equation that must be solved in cattle or blood. A clan chief who cannot count the weight of an insult is a chief who will not last the winter. The Aeler outcasts, with their strange obsession for eights and their fear of the ninth breath, have found kindred spirits here. The clans count in eights too—eight cattle for a wound, eight winters for a grudge, eight generations for a blood-feud. The ninth is the Hollow's share.

Along the eastern coast, the sea cliffs drop sheer into the Dolmis. Fisherfolk in black-hulled boats speak of drowned cairns beneath the waves—ancient stones that mark the graves of clans who lost everything to the sea. Some say the Hollow rises from those waters on the ninth wave of the ninth tide. The fisherfolk do not go out on the ninth tide. They tie knots in their nets and wait. In the dark glens, the *bean-sidhe* (banshee) keens when a chieftain is about to die. The clans do not fear her; they listen, for her cry is the only honest herald of what is to come.

The Clans of Ubral (A Highland Primer)

The Great Houses of the Stone			
Clan	Homeland	Feuds (Ancient)	Relationship with Viterra
Mac Tern	Gray Tor, upper Glen Tern	O’Creagh (blood feud)	Defiant; has never paid a lowland tax. Their cairn has nine notches—eight for victories, one waiting.
O’Creagh	Black Broom Bog, eastern fells	Mac Tern, Mac Gowan	Wary; accepts bribes but no gar-risons. Their singers still compose verses about the cattle raid of ’03.
Mac Gowan	Khaz-Vurim Steps, western passes	O’Creagh	Pragmatic; trades iron for lowland silver. Their smiths learned the counting song from Aeler out-casts.
O’Ruarc	Bride’s Causey, southern marches	None active	Collaborator; factor in Valora is a cousin. The other clans call them “the lowland shadow.”
Mac Taggart	Three-Fires Ridge, northern heights	Mac Tern (old)	Neutral; sells beacon service to both sides. Their fires burn in eights—never nine.
O’Cahan	Pass of Ashes, far west	None	Isolationist; speaks to lowlanders only through Aeler out-casts. They keep the old cairns that no one else will tend.

The Mac Tern–O’Creagh feud has outlasted every lowland king. Each has a cairn for every generation lost. No wergild has ever settled it; no marriage has ever bridged it. The Lady of Tor keeps the peace by reminding both that a Viterran judge would hang them all—and that the Hollow would thank her for it.

Faction Timers (Campaign Engines)

- **The Viterran Yoke [6]** – Lowland crown’s creeping control. Advances when a chief accepts a Viterran title, the party enforces lowland law, or a garrison is established. Retreats when a tax collector is sent home empty (or headless) or a claim is exposed as fraud. On full: a Queen’s Justiciar arrives with a circuit court; lowland law becomes default. The cairns fall silent—the dead are watching.
- **Tor’s Hold [6]** – Lady Uria’s personal authority. Advances when she wins a moot, brokers peace, or gains an ally. Retreats when she loses a feud or a client clan defects. On 0: she is deposed; civil war follows. The ninth cairn will have a new stone.
- **Ancestral Grudge [8]** – The dead’s patience. Advances when oaths are broken, wergild unpaid, or cairns defiled. On full: a *cairn-wight* (an undead guardian of the stones) rises and demands blood. The dead do not negotiate. They count.
- **The Forge Weight [6]** – Khaz-Vurim’s economic leverage. Advances when they secure toll contracts, sell iron, or gain a clan’s weight of obligation. On full: they can close a pass to enforce terms. Their iron is cold, but their memory is colder.
- **The Deep Road [8]** – Aeler outcasts’ secret ambition. Advances as they survey, bribe, or blast. On full: construction begins on a dwarf under-way that would destroy several clan cairns. The mountain will remember.
- **Mac Tern’s Revenge [6]** – Advances when Mac Tern suffers an insult or loses cattle. On full: they launch a devastating raid. The raiders count their steps in eights and leave a single white stone at each burned stead—a promise.
- **O’Creagh’s Patience [6]** – Retreats when O’Creagh is wronged. When it hits 0, they strike without warning. Their war-cry is a single word: *Remember*.

Wergild Price Table (Quick Reference)

Blood Prices (in cattle, unless noted)

Insult (spoken)	1 cow
Stolen sheep	3 cows
Broken betrothal	5 cows + a horse
Wounding (by severity)	7–15 cows
Killing a clansman	21 cows + a public apology
Killing a chief	42 cows + a hostage
Breaking an oath sworn on a cairn	9 cows—one for each face of the stone
Killing a guest under your roof	No wergild. Exile or death. The Hollow will collect.

The Hollow's Cairn (Legendary Site)

Hidden in the high mist, a ninth stone circle with no clan markings. The dead do not vote here; they *listen*. Once per arc, a character may climb the cairn and ask one question of the Hollow. The answer is always a weight.

Mechanics: Spirit + Resolve (DV 6). Success: the GM answers truthfully (one sentence). Failure: the character gains the Condition *Marked by the Hollow* (the GM may spend 2 SB to have an Oath-Keeper appear). If the character counts to nine while on the cairn, the Hollow answers without being asked—and takes a memory.

Starting Hooks

- **The Wolf Road wakes:** Viterran tax men are asking which passes you used. The clans are counting your steps. One clan has offered a bounty for the tax men's heads—in cattle, not coin.
- **The Bride-Price Default:** A Mac Tern groom cannot pay the wergild for an O'Creagh bride. The bride has fled to the Pass of Ashes. Retrieve her—or pay her price yourself. The groom has offered his sword. The bride's clan wants his head.
- **The Toll-Master's Burden:** Khaz-Vurim has doubled tolls on the Steps. A clan chief suspects they are skimming to fund the Deep Road. Infiltrate the counting-house and find the hidden reckoning. The toll-master counts in eights. Do not let him reach nine.
- **The Cairn that Weeps:** A shepherd reports that a cairn on Three-Fires Ridge is weeping water that tastes of salt. The dead are agitated. Find out why before the clan blames a rival. The water has a rhythm—eight drips, a pause, eight drips. Something is counting.
- **The Kelpie's Ford:** A child has gone missing near the ford of Loch Dubh. The elders say the *each uisge* has taken her. They offer a fortune in cattle to whoever can retrieve the child—or drive the water horse back to its dark loch.

Faction Turn Cheat Sheet

Between sessions, roll 1d6 for each major faction. Write one sentence of fallout and adjust the relevant timer.

Roll	Progress	Timer Change
1–2	Setback	–1 segment (min 0)
3–4	Stalled	No change
5–6	Advance	+1 segment

Example: Mac Tern raided O’Creagh’s cattle (**Mac Tern’s Revenge** +1). The Viterran factor raised tariffs (**The Viterran Yoke** +1). Khaz-Vurim surveyed a new pass (**The Deep Road** +1). The cairns are restless.

Prominent NPCs of Ubral

p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15	p0.2 p0.25 p0.3 p0.15
Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Lady Uria	Clan-chief of the Gray Tor	Keep the old oaths and resist Viterran encroachment	She lost a hand to a Viterran knight; her iron hook has a built-in bell. It rings when she lies. It has never rung.
Hearth-Aunt Brigid	Keeper of guest-right (commoner exemplar)	Protect her household and settle feuds before blood is spilled	She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to. Her hospitality has ended more feuds than swords.
Councilor Gethin	Elder of the Council of Cairns	Preserve the wergild system and the memory of the dead	He speaks once a year; his sentences take a full season to deliver. He has never spoken a ninth word.
Oath-Singer Liliás	Verse-weaver and feud mediator	Turn vengeance into cattle, not corpses	Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath. Her songs are older than the Viterran crown.
Vent-Prior Orla	Aeler outcast leader of Khaz-Vurim	Build a new under-way through Ubral, linking mountains to lowlands	She carries a bell that rings once for each miner she left behind. She counts her breaths in eights—aloud.
Sister Niamh	Healer of the Cairn-Keepers of the Gray Palm (Temple of Light)	Run a free hospice at Gray Tor without angering the old gods	She asks no payment, but she writes every patient’s name on a slate that never fills. The slate has eight columns.
Bean-Nighe	The Washer at the Ford (spirit omen)	Appear to those about to die, washing their burial shrouds	She has no face—only a hood of grey water. If you ask her name, she will show you your own death.

Names of Ubral

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2	p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Gethin	Uria	ap Cairn	<i>the Gray</i>
Bran	Brigid	ferch Tor	<i>Oath-Sworn</i>
Drystan	Liliás	mac Tern	<i>the Stone-Foot</i>

Eilian Niamh O’Ruarc *Hollow-Tongue*

Padraig Siorcha Mac Gowan *the Unbroken*

Tegid Ailbhe O’Creagh *Ash-Finger*

Cairn Vote (d6)

When a cairn is asked to judge a dispute, roll 1d6:

d6	Outcome	Mechanical Effect
1–2	Dead vote for war	Advance the related Feud or Conflict timer by +2 segment
3–4	Dead are divided	No change, but the GM gains 1 SB (the cairn is watching)
5–6	Dead vote for peace	Retreat the related timer by –1 segment. On a natural 6, also gain a Cairn

Guest-Right Violations (d6)

When a PC breaks guest-right (refuses a cup, insults a host, draws steel at table), roll 1d6:

d6	Consequence
1	The host demands a wergild of 1 Supply immediately.
2	The cairn nearest the hall votes against you—start a Grudge [4] timer.
3	A witness spreads the story. Gain a Black Mark (–1 die on all social rolls in Ubral for one session)
4	The host’s kin challenge you to a duel to first blood (Body+Melee, DV 3). The loser owes a story.
5	The hearth-stone cracks. The hall is now Desperate for all social rolls until you make an offering
6	The Hollow takes notice. GM gains 2 SB to spend on supernatural complications. The host’s famil

0.14 Spades — Places

2.

Sheepwalk Ledge

— Goat path with room for one honest lie at a time. ‘[THRESH-OLD]’ ‘[OATH]’
*The lie must be about an oath you broke. Tell it, and the ledge holds. Refuse, and the path crumbles—start a **Fallen Kin [4]** timer (the ancestor whose oath you broke is watching). The ledge is eight paces long. Do not take a ninth.*
Guest-right cost: If you cross without offering a pinch of salt to the cairn at the far end, the ledge becomes **Desperate** for all navigation rolls.
Blood-price: 1 cow (if the ledge collapses on someone, that is the blood-price).
3.

Warden’s Cairn

— Windy tor; signal-fire basket and dry cache; eyes of the hills. ‘[WATCH]’
The cache holds a single arrow. Light it with the fire, and the message is war. The arrow is fletched with eagle feathers—a clan’s highest oath. The cairn has eight faces. The ninth is hidden.
Guest-right cost: Asking for shelter here requires you to name a weight you still carry. If you refuse, the Warden marks you—start **Suspicion [4]**.
Blood-price: 2 cows (the cost of a false alarm).

4. **Wergild Ford** — Flat stones, deep pools, table rock for counting silver. ‘[LAW]’
‘[TRADE]’ *The table rock is smooth as glass. Blood washes off; lies do not. The water remembers every price ever paid here. The ford has eight crossings. The ninth is the Hollow’s.*
Blood-prices paid here are witnessed by the stones. If you cross without paying a due weight, the water rises—test Body+Athletics (DV 4) or lose 1 Supply (drowned cargo).
5. **Droppers’ Bridge** — Stone span rigged to fall; pins already loosened. ‘[TRAP]’ *The pins are greased with mutton fat. The bridge knows who paid for the grease. Its fall has ended three feuds and started two. There are eight pins. The ninth is a story.*
Crossing cost: Spend 1 Boon or mark 1 Fatigue to notice the loosened pins (Wits+Notice DV 3). On a Miss, the bridge drops—test Body+Athletics or take Harm 1.
6. **Scree-Ladder** — Climbing to a notch; red rags mark safe steps through danger. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The rags are old clan banners. Step where they wave, not where they lie flat. One rag is white—that marks a traitor’s grave. There are eight ladders. The ninth is a fall.*
Guest-right cost: A guide demands a story before showing you the safe route. If you refuse, the ladder becomes **Desperate** for all climbing rolls.
7. **Moot Hollow** — Ring of standing stones; voices carry and won’t quite stop. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[OATH]’ *The stones have ears. Speak a false oath here, and every cairn will know. The dead vote by how the mist moves. There are eight stones. The ninth is the space between.*
Cairn vote: Any oath sworn here is witnessed by the stones. Break it, and the cairns vote against you automatically (see Cairn Vote table).
8. **Reiver’s Gate** — Between boulders; cart-ruts vanish into heather’s memory. ‘[STEALTH]’ *The gate has no lintel. Above it, ravens nest in a skull. The ravens are the clan’s spies. They count in caws—never more than eight.*
Passing cost: The ravens demand a secret. Tell a true secret, and they let you pass unseen. Refuse, and they raise the alarm—start **Watch Patrol [4]**.
9. **Khaz-Vurim Steps** — Dwarf-cut switchbacks with iron mile studs; toll and toil. ‘[TRAVEL]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The studs are cold iron. Touch them, and the mountain knows your weight. Aeler outcasts maintain the toll—they accept stories as often as coin. They count in eights. If you hear a ninth, run.*
Toll: 1 Supply or a story that makes the toll-keeper laugh. If you cannot pay, you are turned back—lose 1 segment of progress.
10. **Gray Tor Fort** — Earthen rampart, timber crown, smoky cook pits. ‘[COMMUNITY]’ *The cook pits have been burning for three hundred years. The ash is deep enough to bury a secret—and more than one Viterran scout. The fort has eight gates. The ninth is a wall.*
Guest-right cost: To enter the fort, you must share a meal. Refusing starts a **Grudge of the Hearth [4]** timer.

J **Black Broom Bog** — Stepping-logs; wrong one drinks you into silence. ‘[DEATH]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *The logs are painted with warding runes. One is unpainted—that one is the quick way. The bog exhales names of the drowned. There are eight logs. The ninth is a whisper.*

Cairn vote: The bog is sacred to the dead. Any violence here triggers a cairn vote. The dead always vote for war (advance the nearest Feud timer by +2).

Q **Bride’s Causey** — Raised road to a valley kirk; ribbons hang like warnings. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The ribbons are from wedding gowns—cut short when the groom fell in a feud. The kirk is neutral ground, but the path is not. The causey has eight spans. The ninth is a promise.*

Guest-right cost: To cross, you must accept a cup of water from the bride’s kin. Refusal is an insult—start **Bride-Price Default** [4].

K **Three-Fires Ridge** — Watchposts that see Viterra and Vhasia both; news travels fast. ‘[WATCH]’ *The fires are layered: birch for peace, pine for raid, oak for invasion. A fourth fire—yew—means the Hollow walks. The watchmen count in eights. The ninth signal is never sent.*

Using the fires: A successful Wits+Survival (DV 3) lets you read the beacon code and learn the state of the passes. On a Miss, you misread the signals—start **False Alarm** [4].

A **Pass of Ashes** — When snow closes here, the upland becomes an island. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The ash is from old sacrifices. The pass remembers every offering. The last sacrifice was a Viterran herald. His voice is still in the wind. The pass has eight turns. The ninth is a cairn.*

Cairn vote: The pass is watched by the ghost of the herald. Any oath sworn here is witnessed by the dead. Break it, and the cairn votes for war automatically.

0.15 Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Aunt** — Holds guest-cup and house’s temper; hospitality as power. *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to. Her hospitality has ended more feuds than swords. She counts her guests in eights. The ninth chair is empty.*

Guest-right cost: She owes a blood-weight to the Mac Tern clan. If you help her pay it (a quest), she gives you a **Guest-Token** (Diamond). Guest-right cost: share a true story of a broken oath. If you refuse, start **Grudge of the Hearth** [4].

3. **Hill Guide** — Thorn-staff and ten quiet shortcuts; the land as a map. *He taps each stone before stepping. The stones talk to him. He learned the tongue from an Aeler outcast who went deaf and learned to listen with his feet. He never takes a ninth step in the same direction.*

Guest-right cost: A cup of tea and a moment of silence. If you speak during his listening, he refuses to guide—start **Lost Ways** [4].

4. **Feud-Broker** — Knows the weight of a life in cattle and coin; peace as trade. *His record is a row of notched sticks. Each notch is a death—or a birth. He has notched both sides of the same feud for forty years. He counts in eights. The ninth notch is a lie.*
Service: He will settle any dispute for a wergild of 3 cows (or 1 Supply). If you pay, gain +1 Position in the next negotiation. If you cheat him, the cairns remember—start **Broker's Grudge** [4].
5. **Reiver Band** — Light on tack, heavy on nerve, laughing in the rain. *They wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles, not names. They raid Viterran supply trains and leave heather sprigs as signatures. They ride in eights. The ninth horse is a ghost.*
Alliance: They will raid a target of your choice—but demand a hostage (a PC becomes a temporary follower of the band). Refusal starts **Reiver Hunt** [4].
6. **Fire Warden** — Braziers speak faster than riders; warning as weapon. *She can light a signal with a single word. The word is a dead man's name. The dead man was a Viterran knight who burned her village. She lights eight beacons. The ninth would call the Hollow.*
Guest-right cost: She demands a name of someone who wronged your family. If you cannot give one, she refuses to share her fire—start **Exposure** [4] (cold).
7. **Wergild Keeper** — Keeps tallies, ends grudges, starts others; law as math. *His reckoning beads are sheep knuckles. He clicks them in his sleep. His grandmother taught him; she learned from an Aeler vent-prior. He counts in eights. The ninth bead is silence.*
Service: He can reckon a blood-weight for 1 Supply. On a success (Wits+Lore DV 3), he finds a hidden wergild that clears 2 segments of a Feud timer. On a Miss, he finds a weight you must settle—tick **Wergild Breach** [4].
8. **Dwarf Warden (Aeler Outcast)** — Khaz-Vurim road; toll first, friendship later. *Her hammer has a chip where she cracked a liar's skull. She never fixed it. She came to the surface for the sky—and stayed for the feuds. She breathes in eights. The ninth is the mountain's.*
Toll: 1 Supply or a story about a betrayal. She is collecting evidence for a case she will never bring. If you lie, she marks you—start **Marked Notice** [3].
9. **Oath-Singer** — Verses bind hands and open gates; word as iron. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath. Her songs are older than the Viterran crown. Each verse has eight lines. The ninth is the silence after.*
Guest-right cost: She asks you to sing a verse of your own people's oath-song. If you cannot, she refuses to witness any oath you make—start **Unwitnessed** [4].
10. **Lowland Factor** — Buying iron blooms, selling trouble; coin as catalyst. *He carries two books. One is for the clans. One is for the tax man. The third book is in his head; it lists every bribe he has ever taken. He counts in eights. The ninth entry is a death.*
Service: He can forge a Viterran tax waiver for 1 Boon. On a Miss, the forgery is discovered—start **Royal Incursion** [4].

J Bride-Carrier — Peaceweaver walking bloodlines with a knife and a smile. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The threat is real. She has walked between warring clans nine times. The ninth was a Viterran lord who wanted a wife. He got a treaty instead. She carries eight ribbons. The ninth is a scar.*

Guest-right cost: She demands a lock of hair from each PC (as a pledge of peace). Refusal starts a **Bride-Price Feud** [4].

Q Lady of Tor — Clan-chief in cloak and mail; her nod is winter or spring. *She lost a hand to a Viterran knight. Her iron hook has a built-in bell. The bell rings when she lies. It has never rung. She holds eight councilors. The ninth is the cairn.*

Guest-right cost: To speak with her, you must first offer a public apology for any wrong your people have done to her clan. If you refuse, she will not hear you—start **Tor’s Silence** [4].

K Council of Cairns — Graybeards and granite wills; they do not hurry. *They have sentenced men to exile. The sentences take a year to deliver. The exile always knows before they speak. There are eight councilors. The ninth is the dead they serve.*

Cairn vote: The Council speaks for the dead. Any request for their judgment triggers a cairn vote (see table). They never accept bribes—only wergild.

A Stone-Speaker — Aeler outcast envoy whose word moves roads and rates. *He carries a tuning fork. Strike it, and the mountain answers. He has not seen his homeland in sixty years. He calls the mist his ceiling now. He counts his breaths in eights. The ninth is the mountain’s answer.*

Guest-right cost: He asks for a memory of your homeland. If you give a true memory, he grants you a **Stone-Clause** (Diamond). If you lie, the mountain remembers—start **Ancestral Grudge** [4].

0.16 Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Upland Mist** — Hear horns but not edges; navigation by sound and instinct. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[STEALTH]’ *The horns are calling a muster. Which clan? You will know when they arrive. The mist smells of wet wool and old iron. The horns sound in eights. The ninth note is a scream.*

Cairn vote: The mist is the breath of the cairns. Any failed roll here ticks **Ancestral Grudge** +1 (the dead are restless).

3. **Feud Rekindled** — Cousin spits on guest-law; knives wake from sleep. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The spit lands at your feet. The insult is now yours to answer. The cousin’s father was killed in a cattle raid thirty years ago. He has been waiting. He counts his grudges in eights. The ninth is you.*

Cairn vote: The nearest cairn is asked to judge. Roll a cairn vote (see table). On a **Clean Success**, the cairn votes for peace (–1 segment on Feud timer). On a **Miss**, it votes for war (+2 segments).

4. **Bridge Dropped** — Pursuers fall... and the route with them; passage becomes peril. ‘[TRAP]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The bridge was cut from the far side. Someone expected you. The cut ropes smell of dwarf-made pitch—a signature of the Aeler outcasts. There were eight ropes. The ninth was cut first.*
Blood-price: If someone falls, their clan will demand a blood-price. Pay 2 Supply or start a **Vendetta** [6].
5. **Black-Rent Demand** — “Privateering on land”; pay or be “escorted.” ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The escort has a noose. Choose your words carefully. The man collecting is a Viterran factor with a royal warrant. The warrant is a forgery. No one will admit it. He demands eight silver. The ninth is your name.*
Guest-right cost: Pay 1 Supply or offer a hostage. Refusal starts **The Viterran Yoke** +1.
6. **Wergild Breach** — Silver short by a head; tempers long by a spear’s length. ‘[LAW]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The bereaved clan has a new widow. She is sharpening a blade. The missing silver was paid in lowland coin—debased, clipped, and worthless. The insult is not the shortfall; it is the contempt. She counts the coins in eights. The ninth is a blade.*
Cairn vote: The widow demands a cairn vote. Roll. On a 1–2, the dead vote for war—advance the related Feud timer by +3.
7. **Snow-Squall** — Seals the notch; tents turn to coffins if you dally. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The snow is tinged gray—ash from the Pass. Someone burned an offering. The offering was a Viterran tax roll. The gods accepted. The snow falls in eights. The ninth flake is a memory.*
Guest-right cost: The only shelter is a cairn. Entering without an offering (1 Supply) angers the dead—start **Ancestral Grudge** +2.
8. **Dwarf Toll Hike** — At the Steps; papers right, purses wrong; law costs coin. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The warden quotes a rate from a book that wasn’t there yesterday. The book was written by an Aeler outcast who lost his sense of humor but not his reckoning. The rate is eight silver. The ninth is a story.*
Toll: Pay double (2 Supply) or offer a story about a broken promise. If you cannot, you are turned back—lose 1 segment of progress.
9. **Cattle Scatter** — Bells ringing downslope; the cover story runs with the herd. ‘[STEALTH]’ ‘[DISASTER]’ *The bells are yours. The herd is not. The real owner is a clan chief with a long memory and three sons with sharp swords. The bells ring in eights. The ninth is a war-cry.*
Blood-price: The chief demands 3 cows (1 Supply) as a fine. If you cannot pay, start a **Cattle Raid Feud** [6].
10. **False Alarm** — Watch-fire beacons ridge to ridge; levies seize the road. ‘[WATCH]’ ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The fire was lit by a child. Or a spy. The levy doesn’t care. The spy is a Viterran agent. The child is his nephew. The beacons burn in eights. The ninth is a lie.*

Cairn vote: The levy will not listen to reason. Roll a cairn vote to see if the dead intervene. On a 5–6, the mist swallows the levy—they disperse.

- J **Bride-Theft** — A wedding becomes a war-party; you are caught between both. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The bride’s veil is on the ground. The groom’s own kin drew first blood. The bride was promised to a neighboring clan. She chose her own groom. Now three clans want her head—and her hand. There are eight guests. The ninth is a ghost.*

Guest-right cost: Whoever you shelter, the other two clans will demand a wergild of 5 cows (2 Supply). Refusal starts a three-way feud.

- Q **Royal Incursion** — Neighbor’s “lawful” arrests in the uplands; flags and chains. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[WEIGHT]’ *The flags are Viterran. The chains are new. The prisoners are children. The crime is not paying a tax that was never law. The clans are calling the muster. The flags have eight stripes. The ninth is blood.*

Cairn vote: The cairns vote on whether to resist. Roll. On 1–2, the dead advise patience—the clans hesitate. On 5–6, they vote for war—advance **The Viterran Yoke** +2.

- K **Clan Muster** — Horns call men from steadings to spears; all traffic stops. ‘[WATCH]’ ‘[COMBAT]’ *The muster stone is black with old blood. The new blood will be red. The last muster was forty years ago, to drive out a Viterran garrison. The garrison’s bones are under the sheepwalk. The horns sound eight times. The ninth is silence.*

Blood-price: To pass through the muster, you must pay a blood-price to the clan’s cairn—1 Supply or a hostage. Refusal means you are conscripted into the war.

- A **Hill-Fall** — Rain liquefies a slope; trail, proof, and bodies slide together. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *The mud is warm. Something underneath is still breathing. The slide exposed a mass grave—clan warriors who fell in a forgotten feud. Their ghosts are counting the blood-price still outstanding. They count in eights. The ninth is you.*

Cairn vote: The ghosts demand payment. Pay 3 Supply (wergild for the dead) or roll a cairn vote. On 1–2, the ghosts attack—treat as a Cap 3 adversary.

0.17 Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Token** — One hearth owes food, bed, and steel at dawn. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The token is a knucklebone from a feast. The host’s name is carved on it. Break it, and the obligation ends. The host will not thank you. There are eight notches on the bone. The ninth is the breaking.*

Blood-price: 3 cows. If you are wronged by the host, you may demand this value in cattle or public apology.

3. **Guide’s Braid** — Lawful passage on named sheepwalks (once). ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The braid is woven from horsehair and a promise. Unravel it to return. The promise was made to a hill guide who died last winter. His ghost still checks the knots. The braid has eight strands. The ninth is a memory.*

Guest-right cost: Using the braid obliges you to leave an offering at the guide's cairn (1 Supply). If you forget, start **Ancestral Grudge** +1.

4. **Ford Remission** — Cross Wergild Ford free for a season; water as ally. '[TRAVEL]' '[WEIGHT]' *The remission is a white stone. Skip it across the ford to pay. The stone was taken from a Viterran courthouse. The law has not found it yet. The stone has eight facets. The ninth is a crack.*

Blood-price: The stone can be used as payment for any wergild of 5 cows or less. Once used, it crumbles.

5. **Feud-Charter** — Two clans sheath blades until the next harvest. '[SOCIAL]' '[OATH]' *The charter is a broken spear. Each clan keeps a half. The spear was used to kill a Viterran tax collector. His family still wants it back. The spear had eight notches. The ninth broke it.*

Cairn vote: The charter is witnessed by the cairns. If either clan breaks it, the cairns vote for war automatically.

6. **Bloom Allotment** — Claim on a week's iron from a hill bloomery. '[TRADE]' *The bloomery is a woman's name. She decides how much you get. She is an Aeler outcast's granddaughter. Her iron is harder than any lowlander's steel. She counts her blooms in eights. The ninth is for the cairn.*

Blood-price: The iron can be traded for 2 Supply or used to forge a weapon (grant +1 die on one melee attack).

7. **Watch-Code** — Today's beacon order from Three-Fires Ridge. '[WATCH]' '[TRAVEL]' *The code is a sequence of smoke puffs. Read it, and the hills will watch for you. The code changes weekly. The fire wardens burn the old codes—the smoke carries the memory. The code has eight signals. The ninth is a warning.*

Guest-right cost: To receive the code, you must share a secret with the fire warden. If you lie, the code is false—start **False Alarm** [4].

8. **Pass-Ring** — Dwarf road priority for one train of carts. '[TRAVEL]' '[AUTHORITY]' *The ring is iron. Wear it on your off hand. The Aeler outcasts who made it stamped their names inside. One name is scratched out—the smith was killed in a feud. The ring still works. The ring has eight runes. The ninth is a scar.*

Blood-price: The ring can be used as a toll waiver for any dwarf road (value 2 Supply). Once used, the ring cracks.

9. **Bride-Escrow** — Hold the bride-gift; both sides must humour you. '[SOCIAL]' '[WEIGHT]' *The purse is a leather bag. The coins inside are from a dead man's hoard. The dead man was a Viterran lord who tried to tax the clans. His ghost asks for his money back. The purse has eight seams. The ninth is a stitch.*

Guest-right cost: The ghost will appear if the purse is opened without a witness. If you fail to provide a witness, start **Haunted** [4].

10. **Shelter Writ** — Gray Tor opens its gates during storm or pursuit. '[SOCIAL]' *The writ is a raven feather. Burn it to claim shelter. The raven was a clan spy. His*

memory still watches the gates. The feather has eight barbs. The ninth is a secret.

Guest-right cost: The writ only works if you swear an oath of non-violence within the fort. Refusal voids the writ.

J Oath-Bracelet — One binding vow ends cleanly, witnessed. ‘[OATH]’ ‘[MAGIC]’
The bracelet is silver. The clasp is a wolf’s head. Bite it to break the oath. The wolf’s head was a seal of a Viterran king. The oath was sworn under duress. The bracelet remembers. The bracelet has eight links. The ninth is the bite.

Cairn vote: Breaking the oath triggers a cairn vote. The dead always vote for the wronged party—advance the related Feud timer by +1 per broken oath.

Q Council Audience — The Cairns hear you alone; precedent sticks like stone. ‘[SOCIAL]’ ‘[LAW]’
The audience is held at midnight. The stones glow when they agree. The last audience exiled a clan chief. He is still walking the passes, looking for a cairn that will forgive him. There are eight councilors. The ninth is the stone.

Guest-right cost: You must leave an offering of silence (no speaking for one hour) before the audience. If you break silence, the cairns refuse to judge.

K Road Commission — Collect tolls on a stretch of pass (for now). ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[TRADE]’
The commission is a wooden staff. Plant it at the toll gate. The staff was carved from a gallows tree. The last toll-keeper was hanged. The staff still creaks. The staff has eight knots. The ninth is a creak.

Blood-price: The commission allows you to demand 1 Supply from any traveller. If you abuse it, the cairns vote against you—start **Ancestral Grudge +1**.

A Stone-Clause — Temporary exception to dwarf toll or law, sealed. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ ‘[OATH]’
The clause is a single rune. Carve it on the toll post, and the mountain will honour it—once. The rune was taught to the clans by an Aeler outcast who wanted to see a Viterran knight pay double. The rune has eight strokes. The ninth is the mountain’s answer.

Guest-right cost: Using the clause obliges you to perform a service for the Aeler outcasts (a quest). Refusal starts **Deep Road +1**.

0.18 Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (oaths/rights/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **stone and spear** motifs—cairns that watch, voices that echo, oaths that cut deeper than steel. The ninth stone is warm. The dead are counting.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Guest-Law:** Breaking hospitality stains a name worse than breaking a sword. Guest-right tokens guarantee shelter, but abuse invites a blood feud. A Viterran lord who broke guest-law at Gray Tor had his name struck from the Council's cairn. His own clan disowned him. The cairn has eight names. His is not among them.
- **Wergild System:** Every injury has a price in cattle or coin. Wergild keepers maintain reckonings that outlive the injured; weights pass to kin. The lowland courts have no equivalent; they imprison the poor and hang the desperate. The clans consider that barbaric. The clans count in eights. The ninth is the Hollow's.
- **Dwarf Toll Roads:** Khaz-Vurim gates charge for passage, but their roads are sure and swift. Pass-rings grant priority, but dwarf law is strict. The Aeler outcasts who run the tolls are exiles—they fled the Deep Vaults because they could not abide the counting. Now they count for the clans, and they are gentle with the weary. They never count to nine.
- **Scottish Folk Horrors (Ubral Bestiary):**
 - **Kelpie / Each Uisge:** A water horse that lures travellers onto its back, then drags them into a loch or river. Appears as a beautiful horse or a shaggy man. Leaves wet hoofprints that steam in moonlight. *Hook:* Offer it a bridle of cold iron, and it will serve you once—then try to drown you.
 - **Bean-Nighe (Washer at the Ford):** A woman washing the shrouds of the dead. Appears at fords at midnight. If you see her, you have one day to live unless you can answer her riddle or distract her. *Hook:* She will trade a death omen for a story about a death you caused.
 - **Baobhan Sith:** A beautiful woman in a green dress who dances with lone travellers, then drinks their blood. She has deer hooves instead of feet. Iron burns her. *Hook:* She offers a dance that grants +1 die to seduction or deception, but marks you as her prey.
 - **Sluagh (Host of the Unforgiven):** A flock of grey, bird-like spirits that fly through the night sky, snatching the souls of those who die without a cairn. They fear the sound of a bell. *Hook:* They may offer to carry a message to the dead for a memory.
 - **Cù Sìth (Fairy Dog):** A great green hound with braided tail, harbinger of death. Three barks mean you will die before sunset; one bark means you will outlive your enemies. *Hook:* It may adopt a character who shows mercy to a wounded animal, granting +1 die to tracking but marking them as “the hound's friend”—and the Hollow's attention follows.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Bone Keeper** — Varnek Karn. *The chronicler of ancestral wergild; the witness to every blood price. He counts in eights. The ninth is the grave.*

- **The Iron Crown** — Mykkiel. *The law of the lowlands, cold and distant; the clans honor it by breaking it. Its scales have eight weights. The ninth is empty.*
- **The Gray Mare** — The Traveler. *The rider who never tires; the path that leads home through the mist. Her hooves fall in eights. The ninth is a whisper.*
- **The Forge Father (Aeler outcast cult)** — The Sealed Gate. *The fire that shapes iron; the exile who builds a new hearth. He counts his breaths. The ninth is the mountain's.*
- **The Cailleach (Winter Hag)** — The Pale Shepherd. *She who brings the frost and the long dark. Her staff is the ninth branch of the world tree.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord run a hospice near the Pass of Ashes, tending to the wounded of both sides of the Great Feud. A renegade Sister has hidden a Hollowed in a cairn, trying to settle a blood-weight by feeding the Hollow memories of Viterran tax collectors. The clans do not know whether to thank her or burn her. The cairn now has eight stones. The ninth is her name.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends appears in the palm of every third corpse pulled from a hill-fall. Take it, and the dead will give you their last breath—but the coin will taste of peat smoke and regret. The coin has eight edges. The ninth is a scar.
- **The Gray Wanderer's Grimoire:** Ubral psions are called “Stone-Listeners.” They press their foreheads to cairns and hear the names of everyone who has touched that stone. The Lady of Tor employs three; they have not spoken aloud in a decade. They count in eights. The ninth name is always theirs.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pass of Ashes is a Class II Anchor—the spirits of Viterran knights who froze to death in a blizzard still march there, looking for a way home. Saikou Ira left a silver mirror at the summit. The mirror shows the knights their own corpses. They have not advanced since. The mirror has eight sides. The ninth is a crack.

Ubral Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Upland Mist* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Guest-Cup:** Tie a single knot in the handle of a drinking cup. Cancel *Feud Rekindled* or take –1 die on your next hospitality roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Ford:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into the Wergild Ford. Gain +1 Effect when claiming redress from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Lady of Tor. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

- **Count the Eighth:** Before entering a cairn's shadow, count your breaths to eight. Stop. If you reach nine, the cairn will count you. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Iron to the Kelpie:** Drop a cold iron nail into a loch before crossing. The water horse will not trouble you for one crossing. '[SUPERSTITION]'

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **clan guards or reiver scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-fires or hill guides**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or feud-kin**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Hill guide or clan chief** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist or bridge collapse**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **reiver band or feud-kin** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **clan warriors, reivers, or dwarf wardens** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes—**feud declared/bridge falls/snow closes pass**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Lady of Tor, Council of Cairns, or Stone-Speaker intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically—**mist thickens/bridge drops/hill falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice—**omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ubral (Stone & Oath):** Cairns shift position, voices echo from empty air, oaths bind mid-speech. The ninth stone glows.
- **Ubral (Hill Law):** Paths reroute without warning, tolls increase mid-journey, guest-rights expire. The eighth cup is the last.
- **Ubral (Feud Culture):** Insults are overheard, weapons appear in sheaths, kin arrive unsummoned. The dead are watching.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Navigation):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Bog Mist*.
- **Cut the Bridge (Presence + Command):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a **Pass-Ring** is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Survival):** On a hit in *Snow-Squall*, you pick who finds shelter; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (Stone & Spear)

- **The Wolf-Road Captain (reiver-king on a piebald mare)** — *Phases:* Ride-Through → Torch the Fold → Laugh in Rain. *Cracks:* present a **Watch-Code** or **Guide's Braid** to reduce his effect; strike a truce with a season's cattle. He counts his victims in eights. The ninth is himself.
- **The Bride-Thief of Black Broom (mask of bog-rush)** — *Phases:* Switch the Bride → Bog Embrace → Nettle Oath. *Cracks:* play a **Bride-Charter** to freeze blades; a **Well-Blessing** nulls one bog move. She has stolen eight brides. The ninth stole her.

- **Stone Warden of Khaz-Vurim (Aeler outcast toll-magistrate)** — *Phases*: Double the Toll → Weigh the Lie → Seal the Switchback. *Cracks*: present two of {**Pass-Ring, Stamped Load-List, Named Sponsor**} to downgrade his authority. He counts in eights. Do not let him reach nine.
- **The Oath-Eater Wight (cairn-bound revenant)** — *Phases*: Take the Word → Cold of Cairn → Bind Witness. *Cracks*: **Oath-Bracelet** or a skald's stanza spoken over bread and blood cancels one move; settle an ancestral wergild. It was betrayed on the ninth oath. It will not forgive.
- **Gray-Tor Hedge-Witch (heather crown, ash staff)** — *Phases*: Weather-Turn → Hag-Stone Sight → Bind the Gate. *Cracks*: gift a **Bloom Allotment** or a winter's salt; a **Council Audience** compels parley. She speaks in eights. The ninth word is a curse.
- **The Each Uisge (Lord of the Loch)** — *Phases*: Beckoning → The Ride → The Drowning. *Cracks*: offer a cold iron bridle, speak its true name (carved on a stone at the bottom of the loch), or sacrifice a horse in your place.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Sheepwalk Ledge Trial** — Speak one honest lie to pass. On success, set Position one step safer for the next border scene; on failure, start *Kin Arrive*. The ledge has eight steps. The ninth is a story.
- **Wergild Ford Weighing** — Cast silver on the table-rock. If paid in full, clear 1 *Feud-Smoke*; if short, *Wergild Breach* enters play. The rock has eight weights. The ninth is a ghost.
- **Pass of Ashes Vigil** — Hold a fire through the night storm. Success grants **Shelter Writ**; a miss summons the *Oath-Eater Wight* at weak strength. The fire must be fed eight times. The ninth feeding is your memory.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Oath Dial (Honor ↔ Cunning)**: Track the party's footing between honor and pragmatism.
 - *Honor High*: +1 Position when invoking guest-right, keeping truce, or paying wergild promptly; first ambush/raid action each session starts one step worse.
 - *Cunning High*: +1 Effect on raids, evasions, and border tricks; first formal parley or oath-bound request each session starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by restoring stolen cattle, hosting an enemy well, or submitting to a cairn ruling. The dial has eight positions. The ninth is a truce.
- **Feud Math (fast settlement)**: Lay three markers: **Blood, Beasts, Blame**.

1. Make a single *Parley/Command/Study* roll per side. On a hit, move one marker to your side; great Effect moves two.
2. Win any two to settle: *Blood* = oath/hostage, *Beasts* = wergild in cattle/coin, *Blame* = public apology/verse.
3. Miss: mark *Feud-Smoke* [4]. At 4, the losing side names a lawful target (bridge, herd, guide). The target has eight days to pay. The ninth is the Hollow's.

- **Guest-Right Procedure:**

- Present a **Guest-Token** (or bread and salt). Host must choose: *Shelter*, *Escort at Dawn*, or *Neutral Meal*.
- Breaking it creates *Blood-Oath* [6] against the violator; any Ubral ally may spend 1 $\diamond$ to tick it twice.
- Abiding it clears 1 tick from *Feud-Smoke* and grants +1d to the next social action in that stading. The oath is witnessed by the hearth. The hearth counts in eights.

- **Watchfire Net (ridge signals):**

- Two timers: *Beat the Beacons* vs *Ridge Aflame* (size by highest rank in your seed).
- Choose a lane each exchange: *Low Fold* (slow, stealth), *Sheepwalk* (tricky, quick), *Road* (fast, obvious).
- Advantage: Low Fold $\triangleright$ Road (conceal), Road $\triangleright$ Sheepwalk (speed), Sheepwalk $\triangleright$ Low Fold (shortcuts).
- *False Alarm (1 SB)*: light or douse a misleading brazier; shift one segment between the two timers. The beacons have eight signals. The ninth is war.

- **Reiver Ride (mounted chase):**

- Track *Remounts* (3): each push for speed trades 1 remount for +1d or +1 Effect. At 0, gain *Blown Mounts* condition.
- *Hag-Stone Cut*: pass a known gap (Sheepwalk Ledge, Droppers' Bridge) to force pursuers to roll or fall behind.
- The reivers ride in eights. The ninth horse is a lie.

- **Khaz-Vurim Protocol (Aeler Outcast Rules):**

- Present any two: **Pass-Ring**, **Stamped Load-List**, **Named Sponsor**. Two = safe passage; one = pay toll + scrutiny; none = delay and search.
- *Stone-Clause* may override one dwarf law once; afterwards start *Marked Notice* [3] with the wardens (prices rise, patience falls).
- *Measured Truth*: you may substitute exact weights/measures for charm or coin to improve Position by one step with dwarves.

- Aeler outcast smiths accept stories as payment for small repairs—the story must be about a betrayal. They are collecting evidence for a case they will never bring. They count their breaths. The ninth is the mountain’s.

- **Bride-Peace Interlude:**

- Play a **Bride-Charter** to suspend violence at a scene. Everyone sheaths—or earns *Song Shame* [4]. When it fills, a skald memorializes the insult (ongoing -1d with that clan).
- The bride has eight ribbons. The ninth is a knife.

- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**

1. *Clear Ridge*: first signal test gains +1d.
2. *Lowing Herd*: +1d to tracking or herding; -1d to stealth near cattle.
3. *Wet Stone*: climbs start one step worse; mending gear is easier (free repair tick).
4. *Old Verse Remembered*: first oath/plea gains +1d if spoken in rhyme.
5. *Border Drums*: Viterra patrols near; papers safer, raiding harsher.
6. *Dwarf Toll Day*: prices firm; any $\diamond$ tied to roads counts double value at the Steps.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Ubral Flavor):**

- 1 SB $\rightarrow$ *Mud and Heather*: footing worsens; next physical action -1d or mark *Winded*.
- 2 SB $\rightarrow$ *Kin Arrive*: add a rival cousin/ally who changes the ask or splits the pot.
- 3+ SB $\rightarrow$ *Cairn Decrees*: a standing stone “speaks” (witnesses recall the law); swap one held $\diamond$ for a lesser right until you make amends. The stone speaks in eights. The ninth word is your name.

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Guest-Faithful*: once/session downgrade a social backlash inside a steading; next time you refuse hospitality, mark *Feud-Smoke* +1.
- *Reiver-Favored*: +1 Effect to seize cattle/contraband on the move; city gates start one step worse Position.
- *Stone-Friend*: +1d with dwarf wardens on roads; any false measure triggers *Marked Notice* +1.

Patronage & Power

In Ubral, power flows through clan bonds, guest-right, and the careful balance of honor and iron. Clan chiefs maintain authority through wergild, moots, and the respect of their people, while the Aeler outcasts of Khaz-Vurim wield influence through their control of mountain passes and forges. Law is personal and passed down through generations, with each oath and weight creating a web of obligation that can last centuries. The Viterran crown claims suzerainty; the clans call that claim “the ink of thieves.”

But older powers stir in the glens and lochs. The *cailleach* watches from the high corries, and the *each uisge* waits beneath the black water. The clans do not fight these spirits; they propitiate them with offerings of iron, salt, and silence. A chief who forgets the old ways may find his cattle drowned and his children cursed.

For the GM: Patronage in Ubral revolves around hospitality, protection, and the resolution of feuds. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this, use the faction timers, let rival clans issue conflicting protections, and remember the Aeler outcasts—they are exiles, not tourists. They will help a clan for a story, but they will never forget a slight. They count in eights. Do not let them reach nine.

In Ubral, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you walk in peace or peril. The lowlands write their laws in ink; Ubral carves them in stone. The ink fades. The stone remembers. And the dead are always counting.

Silkstrand

City of Bridges & Dyewater.

“Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arched bridges, where every crossing is a negotiation and every current carries coin. The silk looms never sleep, the Exchange never closes, and the Archivolt’s notaries seal fates with a drop of wax. The canals are not just water – they are memory. Every bribe, every broken promise, every cargo never declared – the canals remember.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? Rice porridge with dried fish – the rice is from Oshiiran barges, the fish from Zakov fleets. Both are smuggled. Both are delicious. Both are paid for in favours.

What does a child learn before they can walk? To count bridges. The eight bridges of the city: Merchant’s, Weaver’s, Dyer’s, Cooper’s, Pilot’s, Beggar’s, Saint’s, and the ninth – the bridge only there at low tide. The ninth bridge leads to the Sunken Quarter, where promises go to drown.

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? Their ink. Every Silkstrand merchant has a seal-ink stain on their right thumb. Fresh ink means new to the trade. Faded ink means retired. No ink means not a merchant. Not a merchant is not a person.

What is the most common crime? Contract fraud – but fraud is a negotiation. Contracts are written in disappearing ink. The notaries sell the antidote. The antidote is the fee.

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? The Matron is not the ruler. The canals rule. The canals set the prices. The canals decide who drowns. The canals are the city’s memory. The memory is the Matron’s.

Where do people go when they die? To the canals. Bodies are wrapped in silk and sunk in the deep channels. The channels are the city’s archive. The archive is never balanced.

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? You offer a bridge – a toll paid to the Bridge-Lords. The toll is calculated by the wronged party’s estimate of loss. The silver is melted and poured into the canal. The canal remembers the weight.

What is the most important festival? The Dyeing of the Waters (spring). The dyers empty their vats into the canals. The water turns red, blue, green, gold – the year’s fashions. The Matron’s favourite colour is the one that sells best. It is also the colour she dyed her own hair.

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The canals were dug by a Sidhi engineer paid in promises. The promises were broken. The engineer cursed the city. Every ninth drop of water is a tear. She has been crying for nine centuries.

0.19 Silkstrand

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every bridge is a promise. Every canal carries a secret. But the true pacts are sealed in whispers, not wax.*

The Matron (Elite): “In this city, every bridge is an arrangement and every current carries a rumor. The pacts struck in our shadows never quite fade, and the waters remember every handshake. Trust the silk, not the smile. And never mistake a favor for a gift — threads can be pulled from either end.”

Bobbin-Runner (Commoner): “I can cross this city faster than any grown-up, and I know which planks creak and which merchants lie. The bridges remember every step, and the canals carry more secrets than fish. The nobles think they rule, but the Ragman owns the stairs they climb. Stay off the water after midnight — the night-boats don’t carry cargo, they carry whispers between patrons.”

Genre / Mood: Mercantile intrigue, Renaissance urban drama, layered loyalties, high stakes.

Starting Location: Three-Queens Bridge, crowded with market stalls, its stones worn smooth by centuries of footsteps. A Guildmistress with a silver whistle offers a stamped chit. “The Exchange boils today,” she says. “And something in the canals remembers your face. Bring me three bolts of untaxed crimson before the closing bell, or the Archivolt will have your name on a dead seal-keeper’s scroll. And watch your back on the Ropewalk — the Ragman’s bravos are hungry. If you need a patron, ask for the Contarini factor. If you need a knife, ask for the Tide Father’s man. Just know which one you’ll answer to afterwards.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arched bridges — a place where every crossing is a test of trust and every current carries secrets. The silk looms never sleep, the Exchange never closes, and the Archivolt’s clerks bind fates with a drop of wax. Merchants rise and fall with the turn of the market, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and the city’s underworld runs on whispers and borrowed keys.

But trade is the *veneer*. The real power moves through older channels: the client–patron relationships that stitch the city together from the waterline up. The old patrician families — Contarini, Morosini, Dandolo — hold charters signed by emperors who are now dust. The crime lords — the Ragman, the Tide Father, the Silk Mother — hold the alleys, the night-boat landings, and the bonds that leave no mark. The Matron rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron, but she rules because she balances these threads, not because she cuts them.

What you notice first: The clash of water against ancient stone. The constant rumble of cart wheels on bridge planks. The way every handshake lingers a heartbeat too long — as if both parties are checking for hidden blades — and the way every favor is named aloud, so witnesses will know who stands in whose shadow.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a rival while crossing a bridge at night. The water remembers, and the curse you send may come back wrapped around your own throat. But the deeper rule: never accept a favor without speaking its terms. An unspoken kindness is a thread that can be pulled from either end — and the other end is always held by someone who has been playing longer than you.

Regional Mood: Silk, Steel, and Shadow

Here, fortune is written in silk and sealed with a handshake — but the handshake is witnessed, and the witness takes a share. Silkstrand is not lawless; it is *layered*. Above the tide lies the world of guild charters, sealed archives, and the Matron’s velvet justice. Below the bridges, in the weeping arches and the midnight boat lanes, a quieter economy runs on whispers, borrowed keys, and the careful naming of old ties. The old patrician families hold the long view — a promise recalled after twenty years is still a promise. The crime bosses hold the short view — a knife in the ribs settles a score by morning. Every alliance is a knot that can be pulled loose. Every fortune is a thread that can be cut. And every thread has two ends.

The Patrician Families (Old Blood)

The great families of Silkstrand trace their lines to the founders of the republic. They hold the oldest charters, the tallest palazzos, and the longest memories. They do not trade in silk; they trade in *access* — to the Exchange, to the Archivolt, to the Matron’s ear.

p0.25 p0.3 p0.35
Family Patron (if any) Notable Clout

Contarini The Witness (via Archivolt) Control over sealed records; can validate or void any charter

Morosini Maelstraeus (denied, whispered) Merchant banking; holds the markers on half the Exchange

Dandolo The Traveler (publicly) Shipping and canals; controls the flood-stairs and tide charts

Giustinian None (claim neutrality) Arbitration; their word settles disputes without blood

The Underworld Powers (Shadow Patrons)

Beneath the bridges, other powers hold court. They do not sit in palazzos; they sit in warehouses, in the holds of night-boats, in the back rooms of coffee houses. They trade in what cannot be declared.

|p0.25|p0.3|p0.35|

Name Patron (secret) Trade / Clout

The Ragman The Ninth Controls the Ropewalk and the Burdened Arcade; collects broken promises in flesh, not silver

The Tide Father Khemesh Smuggling through the flood-stairs; owns the night-boats; his divers recover what the canals hide

The Silk Mother Inaea (unwitting) Brothel and information network; her weavers knot messages into silk that only she can read

The Bookman Maelstraeus (open secret) Fixes the Exchange books; for a share, any loss can be made to look like profit

Prominent NPCs of Silkstrand

|p0.2|p0.25|p0.3|p0.15|

Name Role/Title Motivation Rumored Quirk

Matrona Lucia The Matron, ruler of Silkstrand Keep the guilds balanced and the treasury full She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences. She keeps a cord with nine knots — one for each family bound to her by old pacts.

Guildmistress Xara Head of the Silk Merchants' Guild Secure the red silk monopoly She can tell your guild by the thread on your cuff; she never forgets a pattern. Her own thread is black — a sign of where her silence lies.

Niccolò Archivolt clerk "Fix" missing entries for a fee His seal is a wolf's head; the teeth are sharp. He has sealed nine charters that were never written. The ninth was his own.

Ravel Night-boat smuggler Move cargo that cannot be named His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax. He works for the Tide Father.

Sister Chiara Healer of the Weavers of Mercy (Temple of Light) Run a hospice near the Salt Gate She asks no payment, but she records every patient's name in a book that seems to never fill. The book has a ninth page that is always blank.

Captain Borso Condottieri watch captain Keep the peace between guilds He wears a mask on feast days; no one has seen his face in seven years. The mask was a gift from the Contarini. He does not know what bond it placed upon him.

Names of Silkstrand

Inspired by the mercantile republics of the southern coast: liquid vowels, soft endings, and surnames that recall a bridge, a canal, or a trade.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Lorenzo	Lucia	da Ponte	<i>the Bridge-Wise</i>
Niccolò	Xara	Canaletti	<i>the Unseen</i>
Borso	Chiara	del Forno	<i>Bobbin-Foot</i>
Marco	Fiammetta	Riva	<i>the Silent</i>
Tommaso	Oria	Selci	<i>Red-Handed</i>
Andrea	Zilia	Molin	<i>Ash-Thread</i>

(Bridge/Canal/Market) Three-Queens Bridge with stacked stalls; Archivolt arcade of clerks; Salt Gate quay with customs.

Spades — Places

2. **Three-Queens Bridge** — Stacked market stalls; cells under arches, reputations made and broken. *The cells are for those who could not settle their standing. The walls are washed with canal water so no one forgets the smell.* [TRADE]
3. **The Archivolt** — Arcaded street of clerks, seals, and quiet knives. *The clerks write in lemon juice. Heat reveals the truth — or a facsimile. The ninth seal is never used. It belongs to the Ragman.* [LAW]
4. **Silk Exchange** — Floor with chalk circles and clappers for opening bids. *The clappers are whale ribs. The bids echo, and sometimes the echo answers. The ninth bid is never recorded — it is the Ragman's portion.* [TRADE]

5. **Salt Gate Quay** — Rope booms, chalk tallies, tired eyes; customs and silver. *The chalk is mixed with ground bone. A false sign writes itself in a dead hand. The ninth sign is always wrong — by design.* [AUTHORITY]
 6. **Palazzo della Matrona** — Ruling seat with private river stairs; velvet and iron. *The Matrona's barge is rowed by those who have repaid their standing in years, not silver. The ninth oar is never used. It is for the Hollow.* [AUTHORITY]
 7. **Spindle Tower** — Creaking windlass-lifts and posted rates; heights and hazards. *The lift operator has a bell. He rings it once for every passenger who crossed without leave. He never rings it nine times.* [LABOR]
 8. **Ropewalk Sheds** — Arrow-straight; bruisers hired by the yard, muscle for hire. *The rope-walkers never look back. They say a rope remembers who pulled it last. The ninth rope in every coil is cut — a tithe to the Ragman.* [LABOR]
 9. **Old Arsenal** — Free Company's barracks now; arms and ambitions stored. *The arsenal's bell rings at odd hours. No one admits ringing it. The ninth ring is a summons. No one has answered it in a generation.* [MILITARY]
 10. **Exchange Coffee House** — Where merchants insure cargo and spread rumors. *The coffee is thick as mud. The policy rates change with the wind. The ninth cup is never poured — it is for the witness no one wants.* [SOCIAL]
- J **Flood-Stairs** — Bronze flood marks, bell rope ready when the Strand runs wild. *The flood marks go up to nine. The ninth step is underwater — always. That step belongs to the Tide Father.* [WEATHER]
- Q **Basilica of Azerin** — Weaver-saint; confraternity rooms hum with vows. *The saint's icon has one eye. The other was traded for the secret of the unbroken thread. The ninth vow whispered here is heard by the Hollow, not the saint.* [FAITH]
- K **Burdened Arcade** — Row of pawn shops and surety houses; promises carved on the pillars. *The pillars are scored with signs. The oldest ones are from three centuries ago. The ninth mark on each pillar is a scar — the Ragman's signature.* [WEIGHT]
- A **The Unwritten Canal** — A buried waterway that appears only in the lowest tides. *It leads to a vault where pacts are kept that were never meant to be spoken. The ninth pact is blank — it awaits a name.* [MYSTERY]
- (**Guild/Factor/Crown**) Bobbin-runner child with feet sure on parapets; foreign factor seeking warehouse and friend at customs; a Contarini factor offering a sealed charter; a Ragman's bravo with a knotted cord around his wrist.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bobbin-Runner** — Child with sure feet on parapets, rumors in pocket. *She ties a knot in her apron string for every secret she carries. The apron is nearly solid knots. The ninth knot is always loose — for the secret she cannot tell.* [STEALTH]
3. **Mulberry Steward** — Counting leaves; desperate for pickers, quick with silver. *His left hand is missing two fingers — lost to a cocoon-rot curse. He calls it a trade. The Silk Mother still holds claim to the ninth.* [LABOR]
4. **Foreign Factor** — Seeking warehouse and friend at customs; connections for sale. *He carries three scrolls. One for the Matron, one for the Archivolt, one for himself. The ninth page of each is blank — for the promise he has not yet spoken.* [TRADE]
5. **Guildmistress** — Silk guilds' hands stained, permits tighter than purse strings. *She can tell your guild by the thread on your cuff. She never forgets a pattern. Her own cuff has a ninth thread — black, a sign of her silent alliance.* [AUTHORITY]
6. **Bridge Bailiff** — Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath; power in position. *He rings a small bell before each announcement. The tone tells you if it's truth or theater. He never rings it nine times.* [LAW]
7. **Archivolt Clerk** — “Fixes” missing entries — for a fee; law as service. *His seal is a wolf's head. He stamps it with a whisper. The ninth seal he stamps each day is never recorded — it is a gift to the Ragman.* [LAW]
8. **Watch Captain** — Condotta to three lords; passwords change with the wind. *He wears a mask on feast days; no one has seen his face in seven years. The mask was a gift from the Contarini. He does not know what bond it placed upon him. The ninth mask in his closet is the Ragman's face.* [MILITARY]
9. **Exchange Caller** — A clap can still a thousand voices; auction master. *He lost his voice to a curse. Now he claps in a language only the bids understand. The ninth clap is silence — the Ragman's answer.* [TRADE]
10. **Covenant Broker** — Writes pledges on cargo, lives, and sometimes conspiracies. *His quill is a stiletto. He has used it as both. The ninth pledge he writes each month is hollow — a tithe to the Bookman.* [FINANCE]
- J **Night-Boat Smuggler** — “Ravel,” silent oar, louder favors; shadows for silver. *His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax. He works for the Tide Father. The ninth passenger he carries each night is not charged — they answer an old summons.* [STEALTH]
- Q **The Matron** — Patient, velvet, iron; the city's thread pulled through her hands. *She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences. Her cord has nine knots — one for each family bound to her by old pacts. The ninth knot is loose. It is for the one who will betray her.* [AUTHORITY]

K **Lame King's Envoy** — Velvet boots; claims certain alleys “protected.” *His cane is hollow. Inside is a letter of marque that expired a decade ago. The ninth alley on his list is the Ragman's court. He does not go there.* [POLITICS]

A **Saint of Warps** — If real: sees curses braided in cloth; holy unraveler. *Her eyes are milk-white. She sees not the cloth, but the threads of promise within. The ninth thread she cuts each day is her own — she does not know why.* [FAITH]

(**Flood/Interdict/Riot**) Flood siren with gates lowering — move crates or kiss them goodbye; quarantine flag at the tannery sealing a district; Loom strike over unpaid wages.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Flood Siren** — Gates lowering; move crates or kiss them goodbye to tide. *The gate-keeper's palm is marked with a bell. Cross it with silver to hurry. The ninth bell is the Tide Father's. He does not hurry.* [WEATHER]

3. **Quarantine Flag** — A district sealed; your cargo implicated. *The flag is brushed with ash and something else — something that smells of graves. The ninth flag raised each year is the Ragman's signal.* [AUTHORITY]

4. **Loom Strike** — Weavers idle over wage disputes; streets fill with idle frames. *The striking weavers wear red threads around their wrists. They will not speak first. The ninth weaver in the picket line wears black — the Silk Mother's thread.* [LABOR]

5. **Seal Counterfeit** — Discovered at Archivolt; all charters frozen. *The forged seal is warm. The real one is cold. Touch both to know which is which. The ninth seal in the Archivolt is the Ragman's. It is never cold.* [LAW]

6. **Bridge Riot** — A dropped stall blocks lanes; tempers boil faster than kettle steam. *The riot started over a missed bell-ring. Or a stolen bolt. Or a look. The ninth stone thrown always hits a Ragman's bravo. He does not forget.* [SOCIAL]

7. **Condottieri Flip** — Colors change; watchwords shift, escorts vanish. *The captain's new banner is stitched with thread from his old captain's shroud. The ninth thread is from a banner that never fell — the Ragman's.* [MILITARY]

8. **Pledge Fraud** — A warehouse burns; the pledge is a forgery. *The broker has fled. His scrolls are full of ships that never sailed. The ninth page of each scroll is blank — for the ship that will sink tonight.* [FINANCE]

9. **Coin Clipping** — Light silver floods the market; the Exchange locks its doors. *The clippings were melted into a statue of the Matron. She is not amused. The ninth coin in every bag is a clipping — the Ragman's tithe.* [TRADE]

10. **Salt-Tax Doubled** — At Salt Gate; boats stack three deep, gifts flow. *The tax collector wears a mask. Beneath it, his face is a salt-caked skull. The ninth boat in line is never taxed — it belongs to the Tide Father.* [AUTHORITY]

J Duel Challenge — Booked on Three-Queens Bridge; you're named as seconds. *The challenge is written on silk. Burn it to refuse — and lose face forever. The ninth duel of the season is always fought over a Ragman's thread.* [SOCIAL]

Q Exchange Corner — Rivals hoard raw silk; prices go vertical. *The cornering merchant has a book bound in human skin. The names inside are his competitors. The ninth name is his own — a reminder.* [TRADE]

K Saint's Procession — Closes half the wards; ignore at peril, faith walks the streets. *The icon weeps oil. The faithful collect it in silver cups. The ninth cup is never filled — it is for the saint's tears that have not yet fallen.* [FAITH]

A Curse Awakened — In canals: no route reaches the address you seek. *The water is still. Your reflection is gone. You are still here — for now. The ninth reflection in the canal is the Ragman's. He is not reflected. He is behind you.* [DEATH]

(Permit/Seat/Escort) Bridge token for peak-hour cart crossing free; Exchange floor pass; Matron's seal for a single charter.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bridge Token** — One peak-hour cart crossing free; traffic as currency. *The token is a bronze coin with a hole in the center. The hole is the toll. The ninth token minted each year is the Ragman's. He does not use it.* [TRAVEL]

3. **Exchange Pass** — Day pass to trade without sponsor; freedom in paper. *The pass is stamped with a spider. The spider's legs are the signatures of three guilds. The ninth leg is missing — it belongs to the Ragman.* [TRADE]

4. **Watergate Priority** — Skip one flood closure when it matters; tide waits for none. *The priority token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the gate-keeper spits but stands aside. The ninth token is the Tide Father's. He never waits.* [TRAVEL]

5. **Sealed Indulgence** — Retrofit a missing entry; past deals stand. *The indulgence is written in lemon juice. Heat it to see the terms. The ninth indulgence is blank — it awaits a name and a reckoning.* [LAW]

6. **Warehouse Seal** — From Matron's office; rivals legally shut out. *The seal is a brass bell. Ring it once to claim the space. The ninth seal is the Ragman's. He does not ring it. He knocks.* [AUTHORITY]

7. **Ropewalk Trust** — Hire crews before you have silver; muscle on promise. *The trust is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each promise claimed. The ninth knot is the Ragman's. Cutting it costs more than silver.* [LABOR]

8. **Arsenal Key** — One night's issue for retinue; arms in trusted hands. *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist. The ninth key is the Ragman's. He has the fist.* [MILITARY]

9. **Pledge of Surety (Blank)** — Insure one cargo against any loss; the pledge pays in silver. *The pledge is a prayer. The prayer is a pact. The pact is a wager. The ninth pledge is the Bookman's. He always wins.* [FINANCE]
10. **Condotta Rider** — City watch escorts through any ward, once. *The rider's horse has iron shoes. The sparks tell him who to watch. The ninth rider is the Ragman's. He rides alone.* [MILITARY]
- J **Matron's Audience** — Private whisper becomes policy; velvet commands. *The Matron's ear is a bell. Speak into it, and the city listens — once. The ninth audience is never granted. The Matron does not explain why.* [AUTHORITY]
- Q **Toll-Farm Share** — On Three-Queens stalls for a season; profit in vendors. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your portion. The ninth share is the Ragman's. He does not break it. He collects.* [FINANCE]
- K **Golden Thread** — Temporary charter to set tolls on a named canal. *The thread is real gold. It will not break — but it will stretch. The ninth thread is the Tide Father's. He sets tolls in silence.* [AUTHORITY]
- A **The Unwritten Bond** — A blank parchment signed by a dead seal-keeper. Fill it in. *The seal-keeper's ghost will enforce it. The ghost has a sense of humor. The ninth bond is blank — it awaits a name that has never been written. The Ragman keeps it.* [MAGIC]

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (permits, passes, seals) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **silk and water** motifs — threads that bind, currents that remember, bargains that stain the hand. Also echo the ninth: a missing step, an unwritten charter, a silence where a name should be.

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **The Measure of a Favor (Patron–Client Bond):** In Silkstrand, favors are the true measure of standing. Each favor has a **measure** — a sense of what it cost to grant and what it will cost to call in. Favors are remembered not in scrolls but in **threads** — a red thread tied around the wrist of the client, a black thread around the wrist of the patron. When the favor is answered, the threads are cut. A character may start with 1d3 favor threads (minor promises owed or owed to them). The GM

may award threads for significant aid. A thread can be spent to gain +1 Position on a social roll with the patron's faction, or to demand a minor service (safe passage, a night's shelter, a warning). Holding more than nine threads is dangerous — the ninth thread is always the Hollow's.

- **Minor Favor (1 thread):** A night's shelter, a message delivered, a blind eye turned.
 - **Significant Favor (3 threads):** An introduction to a patron, an altered record, a small stake.
 - **Major Favor (6 threads):** A change in policy, a life spared, a charter voided.
 - **Unpayable Measure (9 threads):** The Ragman's favor. You do not want to carry this. The ninth thread is never cut.
- **Patron–Client Mini-Generator (d6):** When the party seeks a patron or encounters a client relationship, roll to determine the nature of the bond.
 1. **Blood Bond:** The patron and client share a family tie — or a family feud. The promise is old, deep, and bitter.
 2. **Silk Bond:** The patron holds the client's bond in the form of a silk charter. The terms are written, but the reckoning is not.
 3. **Shadow Bond:** The patron is a crime lord (the Ragman, the Tide Father, the Silk Mother). The client owes a service that cannot be named aloud.
 4. **Stone Bond:** The patron is a patrician (Contarini, Morosini, Dandolo). The client holds a charter or a seal. The promise is public but the measure is private.
 5. **Bridge Bond:** The patron and client met on a bridge at night. The favor was sworn without witnesses. Only the water remembers.
 6. **Ninth Bond:** The patron is the Hollow. The client does not know they are bound. The ninth thread is already tied.
 - **Duel Etiquette:** Duels fought on bridges draw crowds eager to wager on blood. Refusing stains a name worse than losing. The winner may claim the loser's bridge token (if any) as a trophy. A duel may also be fought to settle a favor's measure — the loser's bond is transferred to the winner's patron.
 - **Canal Omens:** Canals run strange colors at dawn; red foretells riots, blue brings calm, black means a curse has awakened. A successful Wits + Lore test (DV 3) allows a character to interpret the omen and gain +1 die on the next roll to avoid or exploit the coming event. Green water means the Hollow is near.
 - **Matron's Seal:** Any charter bearing her seal is law — but the Matron is known to rescind seals without warning, leaving promises tangled. A seal may be challenged by producing an older Matron's seal; the older one always holds. The ninth seal is the Matron's own — she has never used it.

- **Exchange Volatility Timer [6]:** Tracks market instability. Each time a major cargo is seized, a trade route is cut, or a merchant falters, tick the timer. At 3: prices of all goods increase by 1 Supply. At 6: a panic hits — the Exchange closes for 1d3 days, and all standing agreements are voided unless witnessed by the Matron. The ninth time this timer fills in a decade, the Ragman collects.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Saint of Accounts** — The Witness. *Every transaction is a prayer. Every signature is a confession.*
 - **The Unbroken Seal** — Mykkiel. *Charters are sacred. To break one is to break the city.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The canal's hunger; the pull of a promise never kept.*
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *The light that guides lost ships — and the lost.*
 - **The Ragman** — The Ninth. *The unspoken promise. The thread that is never cut.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Lazarus of the Unwritten Accord (The Witness):** The Archivolt clerks keep a sealed archive of *unwritten pacts* — promises that were never stamped. The Order of the Witness claims that reading even one of these binds the reader to fulfil it. The Matron has never opened the archive. The Red Clerk has, and his seal now weeps blood. The ninth pact in the archive is blank — it awaits the Ragman's name.
- **Saint Fina of the Silken Veil (Isoka):** The Basilica of Azerin has a side chapel dedicated to the *Shedding Saint*, whose mosaic shows a silkworm breaking its cocoon. Pilgrims who leave a confession there wake the next morning having forgotten one sin — but also one kindness they received. The Guildmistress permits the chapel because the offerings keep the silk guilds wealthy. The ninth confession each day is heard by the Hollow, not the saint.
- **The Weavers of Mercy (The Silk-Shrouded):** A hospice near the Salt Gate is run by gray-robed healers who ask no payment. They are tolerated because they treat wounded condottieri for free, but the Black Purse faction suspects they also ease burdens — scrolls left near their doors have been found blank. The Order's rule: "You do not pay back. You pay forward. But woe to the one who strikes a healer." The ninth bed in the hospice is always empty — it is for the Ragman, should he ever need mercy.
- **The Scroll of Unbroken Promises (The Syndicate Seal):** A small but influential order of clerks based in the Archivolt. They adjudicate disputes over charters, cargo claims, and bridge tolls. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they

accept no bribes — only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three shipments are impounded. The ninth judgment each year is never delivered — it is the Ragman's veto.

- **The Ninth:** In any Silkstrand scene, the ninth bridge crossed in a day leads somewhere unexpected. The wise stop at eight and take a boat. Those who cross the ninth are said to hear a faint laugh from the water — and their pacts are never quite fulfilled. The ninth bridge is the Ragman's. He built it. He did not pay.

Silkstrand Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Toss a crust into the water before crossing a new bridge. Ignore the first *Bridge Riot* penalty. [SUPERSTITION]
- **Knot the Thread:** Tie a single knot in a scrap of silk. Cancel *Seal Counterfeit* or take -1 die on your next negotiation (your choice). [SUPERSTITION]
- **Name to the Water:** Whisper a client's name into the canal at dawn. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Bond* to the Archivolt. [SUPERSTITION]
- **The Ninth Thread:** If you hold nine favor threads, cut one immediately. The ninth thread is the Ragman's. He will find you. [SUPERSTITION]

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city watch** or **rival merchants**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds** or **bridge traffic**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **customs**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Bridge bailiff** or **guildmaster** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement** or **flood**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival merchant** or **hired bravo** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **condottieri**, **smugglers**, or **guild enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes — **flood hits**/**charter voided**/**duel declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1**/**Harm 1**/**Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Matron**, **Watch Captain**, **Guildmistress**, or **Ragman** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically — **flood rises**/**bridge collapses**/**procession blocks streets**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice — **omen appears**/**blessing lost**/**curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Silkstrand (Bridges & Trade):** Bridge planks shift underfoot, agreements restructure mid-speech, silver changes hands without touch.
- **Silkstrand (Canals):** Water levels rise without warning, gondolas block routes, a sudden fog hides a rival's approach.
- **Silkstrand (Duel Culture):** Challenges are issued mid-conversation, seconds appear from the crowd, honor prices rise with each breath.
- **Silkstrand (The Ninth):** A bridge appears where none was before. A charter's ninth clause writes itself. A thread tightens around your wrist. The Ragman is watching.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Wits + Stealth):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Fog Bank*.
- **Cut the Bridge (Presence + Sway):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a bridge token is in your possession, +1 die.
- **Weather the Flood (Resolve + Athletics):** On a hit in *Flood Siren*, you pick who keeps their footing; on a miss, the GM does.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Ragman (Lord of Unspoken Pacts)** — *Phases*: Polite Reception → Forgotten Promise → The Ninth Thread. *Cracks*: burn a favor thread in public; settle a bond with a story, not silver; cut the ninth thread — but it will grow back.
- **Archivolt Agent (collector of “missing entries”)** — *Phases*: Quiet Inserts → Scroll Hunts → Bridge Vetoes. *Cracks*: win a duel for precedent; expose a hidden altar; break his pen with the Matron’s Seal.
- **The Tide Father’s Enforcer (a living pledge)** — *Phases*: Grace Period → Due Date → Reclamation. *Cracks*: pay in stories; find the original bound party; renegotiate the bond under a neutral bridge — the ninth bridge, which does not exist.

Patronage & Power

In Silkstrand, power flows through commerce, connections, and the careful weaving of influence — but the loom belongs to the patrons, not the merchants. The Matron maintains control through a web of guilds, factors, and condottieri, each bound by charters and customs that shift like the tides. The old patrician families hold the long view — a promise recalled after twenty years is still a promise. The crime lords hold the short view — a knife in the ribs settles a score by morning.

For the GM: Patronage in Silkstrand revolves around access — to bridges, to warehouses, to the Exchange floor itself — but access is granted through trust, not purchased with silver. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence, but each such reward carries a thread — a promise owed to the patron who granted it. To emphasize the layered client–patron dynamic:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, tokens, charters) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided — and that carry a thread of promise to a specific patron (a Contarini seal, a Ragman’s knot, a Matron’s ribbon).
- Let rival patrons (Contarini vs. Ragman, Morosini vs. Tide Father) issue conflicting charters, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more — and whose measure they are willing to carry.
- Use the bridges, markets, and Exchange as arenas for social contests, where reputation and connections determine success — and where a well-timed favor can turn the tide.
- Track **favor threads** as a tangible resource. Holding threads is power; holding too many is danger. The ninth thread is always the Hollow’s.

In Silkstrand, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rise or drown. But your bond is also a thread, and every thread has two ends. One end is in your hand. The other is held by someone who has been playing longer than you.

Midh-Akhaz

The Violet Gate.

“Midh-Akhaz is not a city. It is a gap in the world where trade is the only law. No walls, no gates – just the smell of horse sweat, cedar smoke, and the copper tang of coin paid in blood. The grass grows tall to conceal the fallen, not to honor them. Ecktorian emissaries call it ‘the Brink’ – the edge where coin buys survival. Caravan guards call it home – a temporary respite from the weight of the road. Thieves call it paradise – a place where the only law is the weight of a knife in the belt.”

— Aeler Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? *Curd cheese and flatbread – the cheese is from Ykrul herds, the bread baked in dung-fire embers. The poor dip it in salt; the rich dip it in honey stolen from a border hive.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To count horses. The eight gaits of a healthy mount. The ninth gait – the death-sprint – is never taught. It is discovered when the rider’s life depends on it.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their braids. Ykrul warriors braid with clan colours. Vilikari traders wear oiled braids with silver beads. A stranger whose braids are loose has just fought. A stranger with no braids is a slave or a ghost. Neither stays long.*

What is the most common crime? *Grass-right forgery. The Oasis Compact issues branded sticks for grazing rights. A clever carver can duplicate the brand. The penalty is exile into the tall grass at dusk. The grass has no court of appeals.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Khatun is not the only ruler. The Silver Stall stable master knows where every stolen horse sleeps. The Dust Market auctioneer knows the price of every sin. The Iron Well keeper knows the name of everyone who will die before the next grass moon. They meet once a season. The grass records it.*

Where do people go when they die? *To the grass. Bodies are left beyond the caravan rings. The grass grows tall and green where a body falls. A patch of deep violet means the dead were not properly mourned. Locals avoid those patches.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a blood-price on the Coin-Weigh Tribunal’s scales. If the scale tips in your favour, you are forgiven. If it balances, you owe a story – a true story that makes the wronged party weep. If it does not, you owe a finger.*

What is the most important festival? *The Grass Moon (autumn equinox). The violet seed-heads glow under moonlight. The tribes ride in a great circle, singing the names of the dead. At midnight, the Khatun pours water onto the earth. If it steams, the Hollow is walking. No one sleeps.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The Oasis Compact's original seal was stolen by a Vilikari factor who wanted to control water rights. The factor still lives in the Foreign Quarter under a false name. The seal is hidden in a hollow horse skull buried under the Grass Ring. The skull belonged to the Khatun's favourite stallion. The stallion did not die of old age.*

0.20 Midh Ahkaz — “The Violet Gate”

Quick Reference **Tagline:** Coin talks. Grass walks. Blood settles the rest.
 Khatun of the Ring (Elite):

The Ways Between

Spiritways & Veilways.

“The Ways Between do not measure miles. They measure choices. A wrong turn might lead to yesterday. A right turn might lead to a version of yourself who made a different decision – and is still alive to regret it. The mist does not hide landmarks. It hides destinations.”

— The Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? *Nothing. There is no breakfast in the Ways Between. No morning, no hunger, only the walking. The walking is sustenance.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To forget. Children born in the Ways Between do not learn. They remember the path they took to be born – eight turns, then the ninth turn is the birth. The birth is a choice. The child does not know they chose.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their direction. A stranger walking toward you may be coming from your future. A stranger walking away may be going to your past. A stranger walking beside you may be yourself from a timeline where you did not turn left. Do not ask.*

What is the most common crime? *Stealing – but stealing is a paradox. A thief steals a memory from a version of you that no longer exists. The memory never belonged to you. You cannot miss it. You will miss it anyway.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The Ways Between are not between anything. They are the only thing that exists. The solid ground you remember – cities, roads, hearths – is the dream. The Ways are the waking. The waking is the walking. The walking never ends.*

Where do people go when they die? *Deeper. The Ways have no surface, no bottom. The dead walk deeper. The deeper they walk, the less they remember. When they remember nothing, they become the path. The path is the walking. The walking is the dead.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You cannot. Apologies require memory. Memory requires a self. The Ways erase both. The only apology is to stop walking. Stopping is not an option.*

What is the most important festival? *There are no festivals. There is only the moment between heartbeats when you realise you have been walking for nine years and you do not remember why. That moment is the festival. Celebrate it by taking the next step.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? The Wayfinder is not a person. It is the road itself, dreaming of a traveller who will finally reach the end. The end does not exist. The road knows this. The road dreams anyway.

0.21 The Ways Between — Obishaal, the Realm of Dreams and Death

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every dream is a door. Every door is a judgment. The dead dream forever; the living borrow their sleep.*

The Wayfinder (Elite): “I exist only in the moment of choice, the breath between one path and another. Obishaal is not a place—it is a *state*. To guide here is to understand that every dream leads somewhere, but only the virtuous know which somewhere is worth the waking.”

Lost Pilgrim (Commoner): “The dead don’t leave. They just change addresses. Obishaal is their new neighborhood, and the scales are balanced with virtue. If you’re lucky, you’ll only visit. If you’re not... you’ll find yourself climbing stairs that never end, and every landing offers a bargain you can’t refuse.”

Genre / Mood: Dream-death metaphysical, virtue-based ascent, temptation and fall, folk-surrealism.

Starting Location: A crossroad shrine of black glass stones, where travelers meet their reflections coming the other way. The shrine is silent except for the soft hum of the stones. A Backwards Pilgrim stands at the crossroads, facing the direction you came from. “The Thirteenth Stone speaks,” they say. “But the path chooses who arrives. What did you bury on the road here? The stones can smell it. And in Obishaal, every buried thing dreams of waking.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ways Between is a transit way, the eternal crossroads through Obishaal, the element of Dreams and Death, the eighth element after Fire, Life, Air, Fortune, Earth, Fate, Water, Dreams/Death. It is the realm where the settled dead go not to oblivion but to an *ideal afterlife*—a dream that reflects the life they lived. A farmer dreams of endless harvest; a warrior dreams of eternal battle; a merchant dreams of scales that never tip. These dreams are real, and they are paradise or prisons.

The living may enter the Ways through thresholds of sleep, near-death, or deliberate ritual. Once inside, they find a landscape that shifts with their own psyche—but also with the weight of their choices. **To ascend** through the layers of Obishaal, a traveler must demonstrate *virtue*: honesty, courage, mercy, self-sacrifice. **To fall** is to yield to *vice*: greed, cowardice, cruelty, despair. Each layer is a test, and each test is a dream that tempts you to fail.

At the very bottom, pressed into the silt of the deepest dream, lies **Ikasha**, She Who Sleeps. Her sisters Inaea and Isoka imprisoned her there eons ago, for Ikasha dreamed of summoning and confronting the Clockwork Monad—a confrontation that, in their judgment, would unmake reality. Now Ikasha dreams fitfully, and her nightmares seep upward, infecting the layers above. Sometimes a traveler who falls far enough can hear her voice, offering escape in exchange for service—a service that would free her.

Between the layers drift the dead who have not yet found their final dream. They are the *Unsettled*, and they will trade memories, secrets, and virtues for a chance to ascend—or to pull you down with them.

What you notice first: The air tastes of copper and old keys. Your footsteps echo half a beat too late. The waystones are warm—and they pulse like hearts.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a question asked by a reflection. The answer will bind you to the path you did not choose.

Regional Mood: The Dream That Remembers

Here, the dream is not a thing—it is a witness. It remembers every promise made at a deathbed, every lie told to a dying ear, every virtue you failed to keep. Obishaal does not forgive, but it does not forget either. It offers passage in exchange for truth. The longer you stay, the more the dream learns about you. By the time you reach your destination, you may find that the destination knows you better than you know yourself. Some travelers never leave. They become dream-echoes, their faces pressed into the glass of a forgotten dream, their names still warm on the lips of the next pilgrim.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

On any path in the Ways Between, the ninth step you take in a straight line will land on a threshold you did not see. The wise take eight steps, then pause to look around. In Obishaal, the ninth step is always a dream of falling. Those who fall hear a voice ask, “What did you owe?” Answering costs a memory; silence costs a name.

Thin Places — Where the Veil Wears Thin

Not every threshold is a door. Some are a *crack*—a place where the world forgot to finish its seam. The Pereshi call them *breath-holes*, where the mountain’s exhalation smells of yesterday. The Tulkani knot a thread and leave it untied, marking where the Hollow’s attention wanders. The Aeler do not name them at all. They simply count to eight and leave the ninth breath unspoken.

A **thin place** is a location where the boundary between the waking world and the Ways Between is unusually permeable. Crossing is not a matter of ritual or intent—it is a matter of *being in the wrong place at the wrong angle*. A wrong step. A miscounted breath. A name spoken at the wrong hour.

When Does a Thin Place Open?

The GM may declare a thin place when:

- A character rolls a **critical failure** (all 1s) on a navigation or survival test in a liminal region (Valewood, Mistlands, high passes, deep mines, ancient ruins).
- The party camps at a **crossroads, bridge, or ford** during a new moon, an eclipse, or the ninth hour.
- A character **breaks a taboo** (pours the ninth cup, takes the ninth step, speaks the ninth name) in a region where the Hollow is strong.
- The GM spends **3+ Story Beats** to introduce a supernatural complication, and the fiction supports a threshold crossing.
- A player **willingly seeks** a thin place (rare—most who seek them never return unchanged).

Signs of a Thin Place (d6)

Roll or choose when the party enters an area that might be thin:

1. **Echoes answer wrong.** Your voice returns half a heartbeat later, or in a different pitch. Sometimes the echo speaks words you did not say.
2. **Shadows drift.** Your shadow moves when you stand still. Cast by a light source that isn’t there.
3. **The ninth step appears.** A stair, a bridge plank, a stone—where no ninth should exist. Step on it, and the ground shifts.
4. **Bells ring without clappers.** A distant chime, a temple bell, a levee alarm. The sound comes from a direction you cannot find.
5. **The air tastes of copper and old keys.** The same taste Saikou Ira describes before every exorcism. The same taste the Aeler name *breath of the deep*.

6. **A door stands where no door stood.** Grey wood, warm handle, no frame. It does not open for those who knock. It opens for those who do not.

Accidental Crossing (Mechanics)

When a character is in a thin place and the conditions align, the GM may call for a **Spirit + Resolve test** (DV 4–6, depending on the thinness). On a failure, the character crosses into the Ways Between—not by choice, but by *accident*.

- **Partial success** ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$): The character feels the pull. They may choose to step back (mark 1 Fatigue) or let themselves cross (gain 1 Boon, but enter the Ways).
- **Miss** (0 successes): The character crosses involuntarily. They arrive in a random location in the Ways Between (roll on the table in §0.21).
- **Critical failure** (all 1s): The character crosses—and something crosses *with* them. A Oath-Keeper, a Counting Wraith, or worse.

Once crossed, the character must navigate the Ways Between using the standard travel procedures (Chapter 46). They cannot simply “turn back”—the threshold that opened may close behind them. Finding the way home requires a *balance*: a story, a memory, or a name offered to the road.

Known Thin Places (By Spades Draw)

The following locations are known thin places, keyed to the *Spades* (place) draws of various regional generators. A GM who draws one of these cards while the party is in that region may declare the area thin, triggering the possibility of an accidental crossing.

p0.18 p0.32 p0.40 Known Thin Places by Region and Spades Rank

Region	Spades	Entry (Place)	Thin Place Hazard / Hook
Aeler	10 (Reliquary Arcade)	<i>The Bell-Crypts</i> .	Bells ring without clappers. A ninth tone pulls listeners into a dream-echo of the mountain's first collapse.
Mistlands	Q (Witchlight Bridge)	<i>The Ninth Plank</i> .	Step where the plank is missing, and you step into the fog of Obishaal. The Hollow Bride sometimes waits on the far side.
Ykrul	A (Sky Steppe)	<i>The Star-Road Scar</i> .	Where the grass grows in spirals. Crossing at dusk may lead to the Long Mile of Temptation.
Vilikari	A (Foedus Stone)	<i>The Crack of the Ninth Clause</i> .	Touch the stone's newest crack, and you may hear the Oath-Keeper's question before you answer.
Linn	K (High Jarl's Seat)	<i>The Beacon That Remembers</i> .	When the beacon burns green, the dead can see you. When it burns blue, they can touch you.
Thepyrgos	A (The Unfinished Stair)	<i>The Ninth Flight</i> .	Climb where no stair should be,

and you climb through the fossil stairs of Obishaal.

Acasia A (The Pale Causeway) *The Causeway of Broken Promises*. Every milestone is a broken oath. Walk it at dusk, and the Walking Scale may find you.

Vhasia K (Sun Palace, Lence) *The Hall of Shattered Mirrors*. Mirrors show not your face, but a reflection of the path you refused. Step through, and you enter the Crossroads of the Ninth Choice.

Viterra A (Highway Stone) *The Queen's Milestone*. The stone is cracked. The crack is a door. Those who peer inside see the Bone Corridor of Unfinished Business.

Valewood A (Valeheart Spire) *The Spire's Shadow*. When the spire phases, its shadow becomes a stair. Climb it, and you enter the Stone Circle of Forgotten Villages.

Aelinnel A (The Green Gate) *The Gate That Expects Change*. If you cannot pay the toll in truths, the gate may open to the Memory Tunnel of the Dying instead of the forest.

Aelaerem A (Hollow Field) *The Field of Uncounted Steps*. Step nine times in a straight line, and the Hollow Field becomes the Mist-Ford of First Doubt.

Zakov A (Serpent's Spine) *The Reef That Sings*. The harmonic hum is the song of the Deep Drake. Follow it, and you may find the Pressure's lair—or the Thirteenth Stone.

Tulkani A (Ikasha's Dreaming Place) *The Dreamer's Threshold*. A cave that smells of honey and rust. Entering it is already a crossing. The Wayfinder waits inside.

Fhara A (The First Well) *The Well of Forgotten Names*. Drink from it, and you may wake in the Waystation of the Virtuous, your name already spent.

Sidhi A (The Sealed Coast) *The Coast of Unmarked Graves*. The drowned walk here. If you answer a drowned sailor's question, you follow them into the Promise Bridge of the Unsettled.

Pereshi A (The First Keystone) *The Stone That Asks*. Touch it, and the mountain asks a question. Answer poorly, and you climb the Fossil Stairs of Ascension.

Kuvani K (Khagan's Felt Throne) *The Throne of Tails*. The saddle has no stirrups. Sit in it, and the Long Mile of Temptation begins beneath you.

Ashaan A (Ikasha's Sleeping Chamber) *The Sealed Door*. The stone is warm. The lock is a whisper. Those who listen too long cross into the deepest layer—and may never wake.

Ngomebe A (The First City) *The City That Never Stopped*. A walking city seen only on the horizon. Step onto its shadow, and you step into the Spiral Path of Recursion.

Taharka A (The King's Tomb) *The Tomb of the Unnamed*. The keystone is a door. The door leads to the Threshold Arch of Virtue. The arch judges.

Sekogo A (The Ukwe's Root-Chamber) *The Root That Whispers*. Sit on the throne of roots, and the tree asks one question. If you cannot answer, you fall into the Bone Corridor.

Lethai-ar (Crimson Valley) A (The First Bridge) *The Invisible Strand*. Only those who have witnessed nine true oaths can see it. Cross it, and you walk the Promise Bridge of the Unsettled.

Theona A (Lookout Cliff) *The Cliff of Nine Views*. From here you can see the Green Host riding—and sometimes the Fossil Stairs rising beside them.

Oshiira A (The Ledger Vault) *The Vault of Unpaid Scales*. The records are warm. Read the ninth page, and the Thirteenth Stone speaks to you.

Black River (Thepyrgos–Viterra border) (Special) *The Ferryman's Slip*. The river is a threshold. Bryn's boat is not the only one. On moonless nights, the dead row themselves. A coin in the water may buy a crossing—or sell your name.

Denizens of the Ways Between (Expanded)

The following creatures may appear in the Ways Between, drawn from the bestiaries and expansions. They are not random encounters—they are *judges*. Each has a hunger, a weakness, and a price.

p0.20 p0.20 p0.20 p0.30 Denizens of the Ways Between

Creature	Source	Hunger	Price to Banish
Counting Wraith	<i>Witnessed Prey</i>	Errors (ninth step, ninth breath)	A correct count of eight
Oath-Keeper	<i>Witnessed Prey</i>	Unpaid scales	Payment of the original weight
Trow	<i>Witnessed Prey</i>	Absences, omissions	A memory freely given
Neighbor	<i>Witnessed Prey</i>	Broken taboos, attention	A never-told truth (or silence)
Poltergeist (Class IV)	<i>Saikou Ira's Compendium</i>	Rage, unfinished business	A witnessed apology
Deep Drake (Pressure)	<i>Witnessed Prey / Saikou Ira</i>	Attention, the ninth breath	A memory of sunlight (or a copper bell)
Scale Lich	<i>Witnessed Prey (appendix)</i>	Unbalanced judgments	A true name carved in quartz
The Hollow Bride	<i>The Hearth Balance</i>	Hospitality broken, the ninth cup	An apology witnessed
The Walking Scale	<i>The Salt Balance</i>	Broken promises	A story never told
The Keeper of the Seventh Exhalation	<i>The Wandering Balance</i>	The seventh sneeze	A name offered freely

Accidental Crossing Destination (d6)

When a character crosses into the Ways Between accidentally, roll to determine where they emerge:

1. **The Mist-Ford of First Doubt** (Class III Procession site). Water runs uphill. Footsteps echo backwards. The dead march here at midnight.
2. **The Bone Corridor of Unfinished Business** (Anchor graveyard). Shadows walk the walls but never touch the floor. A Poltergeist may be forming.
3. **The Crossroads of the Ninth Choice** (Threshold nexus). All four paths lead to the same destination—but different *yesterdays*. A Trow sits at the center, smoking.
4. **The Promise Bridge of the Unsettled** (Oath-Keeper territory). Cross with a vow, and the bridge remembers. The toll is a story you have never told.

5. **The Long Mile of Temptation** (Vice’s testing ground). The road stretches differently for each traveler. A Walking Scale appears at the halfway mark.
6. **The Thirteenth Stone (Ikasha’s Seal)**. The path ends at a warm stone. The stone whispers. Beneath it, She Who Sleeps dreams of freedom. A Deep Drake may be coiled nearby.

GM Guidance: Thin Places as Pressure, Not Punishment

Thin places are not traps. They are *complications*. A party that accidentally crosses into the Ways Between should not feel that they have “failed.” They have simply entered a different kind of scene—one where negotiation matters more than steel.

- **Offer a way out.** The Ways Between always offer a path home. The path may demand a toll (a memory, a story, a name), but it exists.
- **Use the travel rules.** Treat the Ways Between as a leg of a journey. Draw cards. Set timers. The destination is “home” or “the next threshold.”
- **Let players use their bonds.** A character who calls on a bond while lost in the Ways may hear a familiar voice—or see a familiar face—guiding them. The road remembers who weighs what.
- **The ninth is always watching.** In any scene set in the Ways Between, the ninth card drawn (or the ninth roll made) triggers a manifestation of the Hollow. Not a fight—a *question*. The players must answer truthfully, or the road takes a memory.

Set down by the Grey Wanderer, after a night spent in a thin place near the Black River. The fire went out three times. The shadows did not. The ninth bell rang once—and then was silent.

The Ways Between are not a dungeon. They are a conversation. Speak carefully. The road listens.

Spades — Places (Dream Layers)

2. **Mist-Ford of First Doubt** — Water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards through time. ‘[THRESHOLD]’ *The ford shows you wading through your own past. Do not look down at the water.*
3. **Bone Corridor of Unfinished Business** — Shadows walk the walls but never touch the floor; light as memory. ‘[DEATH]’ *The bones are from those who chose vice and fell. They shift when you blink.*
4. **Threshold Arch of Virtue** — Shows a reflection as someone you might have been; the past as a mirror. ‘[TRUTH]’ *The reflection has a scar you never got. It asks how you avoided it.*

5. **Spiral Path of Recursion** — Ascends but returns to the same stone marker; the journey as meditation. '[MAGIC]' *Each loop, the stone moves closer to the center. Or you do.*
 6. **Promise Bridge of the Unsettled** — Cross with a vow and it remembers your weight; an oath as a toll. '[OATH]' *The bridge's planks are old letters. Read one, and you may owe the writer.*
 7. **Crossroads of the Ninth Choice** — All four paths lead to the same destination, but different tomorrows. '[THRESHOLD]' *The center stone is warm. A coin placed there will vanish—or be accepted.*
 8. **Stone Circle of Forgotten Villages** — Marks where a village used to be; the houses are now constellations. '[DEATH]' *The stars are too close. You can touch them. They crumble like ash.*
 9. **Memory Tunnel of the Dying** — Hear the thoughts of those who passed here; the past as an echo. '[MEMORY]' *The thoughts are in a language you almost understand. One word is your name.*
 10. **Fossil Stairs of Ascension** — Each step is an eye that watches your ascent; the climb as scrutiny. '[FEAR]' *The eyes belong to those who fell here. They blink in sequence.*
- J **Waystation of the Virtuous** — The keeper trades in unfinished conversations; words as currency. '[SOCIAL]' *The keeper has no face. It wears the faces of those who paused too long.*
- Q **Junction of Vice and Virtue** — Paths physically collide; you must choose which reality to follow. '[THRESHOLD]' *The collision sounds like breaking glass. The glass reforms into a door.*
- K **Long Mile of Temptation** — The road stretches differently for each traveler; distance as perception. '[MAGIC]' *You are the only one walking. The others are already at the end.*
- A **The Thirteenth Stone — Ikasha's Seal** — Where the path reveals its true destination; truth as revelation. '[TRUTH]' *The stone whispers. The whisper is a promise you made to yourself and broke. Beneath it, the stone is warm—and dreaming.*

(Wayfarer/Spirit/Dream-walker) Lost pilgrim who thinks they're going home but forgot where; toll-taker accepting payment in forgotten memories.

Hearts — Travelers & Guides

2. **Lost Pilgrim** — Thinks they're going home but forgot where; destination as a memory. '[TRAVEL]' *Their pack is full of stones. Each stone is a forgotten promise.*

3. **Toll-Taker (Virtue Assessor)** — Accepts payment in virtues you didn't know you had. '[SOCIAL]' *Their scales weigh truth and echo. A balanced scale means you pass—for now.*
 4. **Wayward Guide** — Directions technically correct, morally questionable. '[TRAVEL]' *They point with a broken compass. The needle spins, but the path is true.*
 5. **Dream-Merchant** — Carries a sack of nightmares and one perfect dream for sale. '[MAGIC]' *The perfect dream is their own. They are selling it because they cannot wake up.*
 6. **Child-Ghost of Unfinished Life** — Knows shortcuts but charges in riddles; wisdom as a puzzle. '[DEATH]' *The riddles have no answer—only a choice. Choose wrong, and you become a child.*
 7. **Wounded Walker (Vice-Bound)** — Bleeding metaphor; their pain grows thorns along the path. '[FEAR]' *The thorns have faces. Each face is someone they failed to save.*
 8. **Map-Merchant of Impossible Dreams** — Selling maps to places that don't exist yet; the future as a commodity. '[TRUTH]' *The maps change as you watch. The destination is always one page ahead.*
 9. **Guide-Dog (Ancestral Spirit)** — Made of shadow and starlight; follows those who walk with purpose. '[SPIRIT]' *It never barks. It whines when you are about to make a mistake.*
 10. **Backwards Pilgrim (Dream-Echo)** — Moving through time; their steps erase what just happened. '[MEMORY]' *They are walking toward their birth. Every step, they forget something.*
- J **Soul-Ferryman** — Carries the luggage of the living; a burden as a service. '[DEATH]' *The luggage is full of things you never said. The ferryman knows them all.*
- Q **Road's Child (Dream-Kin)** — Born where paths crossed, raised by waymarks; navigation as instinct. '[TRAVEL]' *They have no navel. They were never born—they simply began.*
- K **Dead-Road Keeper** — Ensures proper passage for those who should not walk. '[DEATH]' *Their lantern burns a cold blue. The flame does not flicker.*
- A **The Wayfinder (Dream Avatar)** — Exists only in the moment a choice is made; a decision as an entity. '[LEGEND]' *They are every guide you ever needed. They are also every road you refused.*

(Veil-Thin/Dream-Bleed/Wayward) Path loops back to show your funeral preparations; reality thins—you see the dreams of sleeping travelers; Ikasha's nightmare bleeds into the upper layers.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Funeral Loop** — The path shows your funeral preparations; death as a destination. '[DEATH]' '[FEAR]' *The mourners are people you have not met yet. They seem to know you well.*
3. **Reality Thins (Ikasha's Dream Bleed)** — You see the dreams of sleeping travelers; the boundary as a veil. '[MAGIC]' *A dreamer mutters your name. They are dreaming of a choice you will make tomorrow.*
4. **Waymark Lies (Vice's Test)** — Points the wrong way; trust leads to places that never were. '[TRUTH]' *The waymark has a crack. Through the crack, you see a path you should have taken.*
5. **Dream-Bleed** — Waking memories become someone else's nightmares. '[MEMORY]' '[FEAR]' *You remember a childhood fear that was not yours. It still terrifies you.*
6. **Toll Demanded (Virtue Payment)** — Currency you did not know you carried; payment as a revelation. '[SOCIAL]' '[WEIGHT]' *The toll is a secret you told a dead person. They are now standing behind you.*
7. **Path Split (Virtue vs. Vice)** — Each version of you remembers differently; identity as a choice. '[MAGIC]' *One you is smiling. One you is weeping. One you is already walking away.*
8. **Gravity Shifts (Guilt's Weight)** — Emotional weight grows physically heavy; a burden as physics. '[WEATHER]' *Your pack feels heavier. Inside is a regret you forgot you carried.*
9. **Time-Sickness (Dream Chronology)** — You arrive before you left; paradox shadows follow. '[MAGIC]' *Your past self waves at you. Do not wave back.*
10. **Truth Payment (Ikasha's Price)** — The road remembers your lies and demands truth as payment. '[TRUTH]' '[WEIGHT]' *The lie is carved on a stone. The stone is warm. It knows your temperature.*
- J **Crossroads Judgment (Virtue Audit)** — The path you chose judges the ones you did not; decision as karma. '[TRUTH]' '[SOCIAL]' *A ghost of the road not taken asks why. You have one sentence to answer.*
- Q **Memory-Thief (Unsettled Dead)** — A rest stop keeper pays in counterfeit recollections. '[MEMORY]' '[SOCIAL]' *The memory is almost right. The color of the sky is wrong.*
- K **Forbidden Path (Ikasha's Descent)** — Opens only for those already lost; loss as a key. '[DEATH]' *The path smells of old tears. You taste salt on your lips.*

- A **Convergence (Ikasha's Waking)** — All travelers arrive together, none recall how; arrival as a mystery. '[MAGIC]' '[LEGEND]' *You recognize everyone. You have never seen any of them before. The air tastes of honey and rust. Ikasha is dreaming of you.*

(**True Name/Safe Passage/Waywisdom**) Waymark that always points toward your next important choice; a token of passage that the road recognizes as belonging.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Choice Compass (Virtue's Needle)** — Always points toward your next important choice. '[TRAVEL]' *The needle is a splinter of the Thirteenth Stone. It hums when you are near a decision.*
 3. **Passage Token (Dream-Marked)** — The road recognizes you as one who belongs. '[SOCIAL]' *The token is a braid of your own hair. You do not remember cutting it.*
 4. **Dream-Catcher** — Filters nightmares from your rest; sleep as a sanctuary. '[MAGIC]' *The catcher is woven from old promises. It smells of lavender and regret.*
 5. **Truth-Compass (Ikasha's Fragment)** — Points to what you most need to know, not what you want. '[TRUTH]' *The compass has no needle. The housing spins until you speak a truth.*
 6. **Memory-Anchor** — Keeps you from losing yourself on deeper paths. '[MEMORY]' *The anchor is a river stone. Your name is carved on it in a language you have never seen.*
 7. **Safe Haven (Virtue's Rest)** — A guaranteed rest stop without complication. '[TRAVEL]' *The haven is a dry arch. The arch is a doorframe with no door.*
 8. **Guide-Light (Virtue's Beacon)** — Burns the color of your truest intention; purpose as a beacon. '[SOCIAL]' *The light is blue. Blue means you are honest. Red means you are not.*
 9. **Path-Cutter (Dream Shears)** — Cuts distance through metaphor, not space. '[MAGIC]' *The cutter is a pair of shears. Cut a memory, and the road between here and there vanishes.*
 10. **Scale-Clearing (Virtue's Mercy)** — The road forgives one weight you thought you carried. '[WEIGHT]' *The weight was owed to a dead person. They are no longer dead on this path.*
- J **Crossroads Boon** — Choose among three paths, each exactly where you need to be. '[LEGEND]' *The paths are labeled: Regret, Forgive, Forget. Choose carefully.*
- Q **Way-Wisdom (Dream-Logic)** — Understand the language of paths and signs for one journey. '[TRAVEL]' *The waystones whisper. They are complaining about the last traveler. It was you.*

- K Grace Passage (Virtue's Shield)** — Walk safely through any dangerous crossing for one night. '[TRAVEL]' *The grace is a bell. Ring it, and the road will pretend not to see you.*
- A Road's Name (Ikasha's True Name)** — Call the path by its true name and command its nature. '[LEGEND]' *The name is a single syllable. Speaking it will change the road—and you.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (true names/safe passages/waywisdom) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **dream-road** motifs—reflections that lie, paths that judge, destinations that choose the traveler. Also, the presence of an Ace hints that Ikasha's dream is particularly close.

Additional Features

- **Dream-Logic Navigation:** Any Ace introduces a metaphysical requirement (a sacrifice, a taboo, an exchange) that must be satisfied to pass. Name it at the table; the road will enforce it.
- **Reflection Points:** Face cards (J, Q, K) show alternate selves or unlived choices. Treat them as temporary NPCs or scene tags that can help, hinder, or tempt.
- **Memory Currency:** Diamonds may be traded for knowledge or safe passage as if they were memories. Describe the memory paid; the path (or its keeper) pays in kind.
- **Virtue and Vice Timers:** Each character in Obishaal tracks a small personal **Virtue** [3] and **Vice** [3] timer. Virtue advances when they act with honesty, courage, mercy, or self-sacrifice. Vice advances when they act with greed, cowardice, cruelty, or despair. When one timer fills, the character **ascends** (Virtue) to a higher layer of Obishaal or **falls** (Vice) to a lower one. Ascension offers a boon; falling offers a temptation (a cursed gift from the layer's vice-spirit). The timers reset after each layer transition. Reaching the bottom (Vice filled in the deepest layer) allows Ikasha to speak directly to the character.
- **Ikasha's Whisper (Patron Intervention):** When a character falls to the lowest layer (or deliberately seeks her out), they may hear Ikasha's voice. She offers a *Fragment of Freedom*: +2 dice to any roll involving escape, secrecy, or breaking bonds, but each use marks 1 **Obligation to Ikasha** and advances a **Waking Dream** [6] timer.

When that timer fills, Ikasha uses the character as a vessel to attempt an escape—a campaign-level event.

• **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**

- **The Unnamed Guide** — The Traveler. *The road that appears only when you are lost.*
- **The Mirror Listener** — The Witness. *The reflection that tells you what you need to hear, never what you want.*
- **The Threshold Child** — The Sealed Gate. *The one who was never born, who guards the places where paths end.*
- **The Echo King** — The Ninth. *The voice that answers when you speak to the empty road.*
- **The Dreamer Below** — Ikasha (imprisoned). *She who sleeps and dreams of waking. Her whispers are bargains; her freedom is a promise.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord know the Ways Between as the Cord’s shadow. A lost Hollowed wanders here, its thread trailing into the mist. Follow it, and you may find a Sister who cut herself free—and who now tends Ikasha’s dream.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Ira’s silver mirror shows the Ways Between as a tangled knot of unfulfilled balances. He has walked three paths here. He will not speak of the fourth, where he glimpsed Ikasha’s face.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at every crossroads. Pick it up, and the road will offer you a shortcut—but the coin will reappear in your pocket at the next junction, heavier. In Obishaal, the coin is warm and pulses like a heartbeat.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Psions call the Ways Between “the Stair.” They climb it in their dreams, trading memories for glimpses of paths not yet walked. Some never wake. The Grey Wanderer claims that the Stair is Ikasha’s spine.

Ways Between Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stones:** Crumble a crust at the base of a waystone. Ignore the first *Waymark Lies* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Knot the Path:** Tie a single knot in a piece of string and hang it from a milestone. Cancel *Path Split* or take — — 1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Crossroads:** Whisper a dead traveler’s name into the center stone. Gain +1 Effect when bargaining with a Toll-Taker this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Wayfinder. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **path keepers or wayward spirits**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **travelers or memory echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or reflection points**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable path alignment**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Toll-taker or wayward guide** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path shift or reality thinning**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **memory-thief or forbidden path entity** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wayward spirits, path entities, or alternate selves** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **path loops/time shifts/reality fractures**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: The Wayfinder, Dead-Road Keeper, or Road's Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **reality thins/paths converge/time loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Obishaal (Dream-Logic):** Paths rearrange without warning, reflections speak unbidden, destinations shift mid-journey. A character may hear Ikasha's whisper as a free omen (the GM may spend 1 SB to make it a false omen).
- **Obishaal (Memory Currency):** Memories become tangible, forgotten knowledge resurfaces, past and present blur. Trading a memory here may also tick the *Virtue* or *Vice* timer depending on the memory's nature.
- **Obishaal (Virtue and Vice):** Decisions echo forward, alternate selves appear, paths judge moral weight. The GM may spend SB to force a character to test a virtue (e.g., "Resist the temptation to lie") or to offer a vice that ticks their Vice timer.

Path-Moves & Procedures (Optional Depth)

Weighing of Steps (Travel Move) When the company enters a liminal path (Mist-Ford, Bone Corridor, etc.), choose one:

- **Pay the Toll:** Each PC names a small truth or a fond memory (GM: 1 SB banked, +1 Position on navigation).
- **Refuse the Toll:** +1d on Speed, but start a **Way-Scale** [4] timer.
- **Bargain the Toll:** Trade a *Diamond* reward as if it were a memory (see Memory Exchange below); cancel one imminent *Club* card in this scene.

When **Way-Scale** fills, trigger *Crossroads Judgment* at the next junction.

Reflection Duel (Social/Moral Test) When confronted by an alternate self or *Reflection Point*, state what that self wants from you and roll your best social action.

- **Success:** Gain a *Guide-Light* tag for the scene and clear 1 tick from **Paths Decide**.
- **Mixed:** Trade places for one exchange or take a **Condition: Disoriented**.
- **Miss:** The reflection walks away with one of your *Diamonds* (GM picks the most narratively apt).

	Memory Offered	Buys You
Memory Exchange (Rates & Risks)	A childhood smell, a forgotten nickname	+1 Position on one crossing
	A first failure or small betrayal	Cancel one minor Complication
	A true fear you have never spoken	<i>Guide-Light</i> or <i>Way-Cord</i> -like effect
	The details of a kept promise	<i>Safe Passage</i> for the party
	The meaning behind a scar	Convert one <i>Club</i> into <i>Trace</i> only
	A perfect day (all details)	Treat the next <i>Heart</i> face as an ally

Exchange Rule: If you pay the same *kind* of memory twice in a journey, start **Hollowing** [4]. When it fills, you gain the *Backwards Pilgrim* tag until you reclaim what was lost.

Way-Keys & Taboos (d6)

1. **Speak Last:** Only the final word said at a gate is true; others are “practice.” First speakers take — — 1d on their next test.
2. **Step Odd:** Crossings require an odd number of steps; even counts loop you back one scene.
3. **Name Nothing:** True names wake *Name-Theft*; use titles or lose a *Diamond*.
4. **Wet Iron:** A drop of water on iron cancels one glamour once per scene.
5. **Back Gift:** Leave something behind to go forward; refuse and tick **Way-Scale**.
6. **Answer Bent:** Answer a waystone’s question with a metaphor, not a fact, or trigger *Truth Payment*.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Archivist of Unmade Roads (cloak stitched from surveyor’s cords)** — *Phases:* Receipts of Refusal → Stay of Journey → Unfiled Options. *Cracks:* a **Choice Compass** reveals the true path; a **Scale-Clearing** voids his claim.
- **The Toll-Matriarch Beneath the Bridge (many hands, one voice like wet stone)** — *Phases:* Truth Payment → Scale-Clearing → Forbidden Path. *Cracks:* a **Passage Token** marks you as belonging; a **Road’s Name** commands her to stand aside.
- **The Wayfinder’s Shadow (your silhouette, two steps ahead)** — *Phases:* Crossroads Judgment → Guide-Light → Haste Mark. *Cracks:* a **Memory-Anchor** keeps you grounded; a **Grace Passage** slips past its gaze.

- **Ikasha's Nightmare (Dream-Eater)** — Appears only in the deepest layer. *Phases:* Whispers → Temptation → Consumption. *Cracks:* a **Virtue** filled timer can be spent to reject the nightmare; a memory of true self-sacrifice (cost 1 permanent Bond) banishes it entirely.

Encounter Seeds (quick hooks)

- **The Promise Bridge's Receipt:** An old vow you never spoke was logged here. To cross, define when you would have sworn it—and to whom.
- **Thirteenth Stone Auction:** The stone sells three possible endings. Each bidder is you from a different failure.
- **Bone Corridor Choir:** Shadows sing a name wrong by one letter. Correct it and gain *Truth-Compass*; ignore it and start **Name-Theft**.
- **Ikasha's Finger Bone:** A character finds a bone that pulses with dream-light. If they hold it while sleeping, they can speak to Ikasha directly—but each time, the **Waking Dream** timer ticks.

Extensions (Plug-in)

Choice Dial (Resolve ↔ Drift) Track the party's footing between firm intent and wandering.

- *Resolve High:* +1 Position on *Path Split* tests; the first *Dream-Bleed* each session hits harder (start at 2).
- *Drift High:* +1 Effect when bargaining with way-entities; the first *Truth Payment* each session costs a cherished *detail*.
- Center the Dial by naming aloud the next choice *and* why you might refuse it; clear 1 tick from **Way-Scale**.

Counter-Seal (once/scene, if justified) Break a single metaphysical instruction (taboo, key, or omen) by presenting a memory in symbol form (a token, a letter, a sketch). Gain +1d on that crossing; the GM banks 1 SB as a *Marked Consequence* to spend when reflections return.

Start-of-Scene Murmurs (1d6)

1. *Second Sunrise:* light arrives twice; your first missed navigation roll becomes a mixed success.
2. *Name Draft:* the air steals a syllable; your next lie sounds true once.
3. *Echo Scale:* your footprints owe a step—skip a square or tick **Way-Scale** +1.

4. *Pale Bell*: time hiccups; the first *Club* can be delayed until the end of the scene.
5. *Traveler's Chorus*: distant voices agree with you; +1d on appeals to path entities.
6. *Hollow Weather*: rain that does not wet; conditions look dire but impose no penalties this scene.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Obishaal Flavor)

- 1 SB → *Footprint Vote*: your tracks choose a different direction; increase DV by 1 on any roll that relies on following a trail.
- 2 SB → *Echo of Refusal*: a choice you avoided manifests as a minor obstacle (a locked gate, a forgotten toll). If the choice involved a vice, also tick the Vice timer of the character who refused.
- 3+ SB → *Threshold Cracks*: the path fractures; gain a temporary **Path-Cutter** effect but start **Convergence** [4] (all travelers you have met will arrive together at the next junction). Additionally, Ikasha's dream seeps through the cracks; each character hears a single word of her voice.

Cross-Regional Conversions (Using Diamonds Across the Map)

- *Valewood*: **Road's Name** may count as a *Valeheart Clause* once if spoken under leaves; doing so creates **Court Tithe** [2].
- *Mistlands*: **Grace Passage** functions as *Pall Indulgence* over one levee crown at night; ring a bell afterward or start **Witchlight Count**.
- *Vhasia*: **Way-Wisdom** can be presented as "pilgrim right" to bypass one *Interdict* barrier; begin a **Parlement Divided** tick.
- *Viterra*: **Passage Token** can be notarized into a temporary *Ferry Priority*; on use, advance **Border-Lace**.
- *Ubral*: **Memory-Anchor** counts as a *Guest-Token* at one hearth if you recount a family road-tale.
- *Silkstrand*: **Path-Cutter** doubles as a night-boat route once; spend 1 favor with a smuggler or trigger *Seal Counterfeit*.
- *Linn*: **Choice Compass** acts as a *Pilot's Token* in a reed-maze if you pay a name to the water.
- *Theona*: **Crossroads Boon** allows counting "eight-and-one" to cross an *Uncounted Bridge* safely once.

Patronage & Power

In Obishaal, power flows through understanding the metaphysical nature of dreams, the ability to navigate virtue and vice, and the careful management of one's weight before the scales. The true authorities are those who know the True Names of dream-layers, can mediate between the living and the Unsettled, and understand the currency of virtue.

For the GM: Patronage in Obishaal revolves around guidance, safe passage, and the ability to navigate moral tests. Rewards often take the form of dream-tokens, fragments of Ikasha's memory, or knowledge of a layer's True Name. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (compasses, anchors, bells) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided by the dream itself.
- Let rival guides (Virtue vs. Vice) issue conflicting directions, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the crossroads, waystations, and dream-layers as arenas for moral contests, where a single act of mercy can ascend you—and a single act of cruelty can damn you.

In Obishaal, your virtue is your power, and your power determines whether you wake or sleep forever.

The Wilds

Roads, Ruins, and Weather.

“Between towns and treaties, the land breathes with patience. Old roads keep the step of armies in their dust; cairns hold the names that no page can contain. Law here is not written in books but in the marks we leave and the debts we owe to the earth – not in coin, but in the weight of a story. To travel is not to conquer the land, but to ask its leave, and the land answers not with silver but with the memory of our passage. The hollows are not holes in the world; they are the lungs of the earth, breathing deep and slow. They do not judge; they do not give. They simply are, and in their being, they teach us to be.”

— The Bravo of Silkstrand

What do people eat for breakfast? *Whatever they found – berries, roots, a rabbit snared at dawn. The wilds provide. The wilds also take. The taking is breakfast for something else.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To read the sky. Wilds children are taught the eight winds by taste. The ninth wind has no direction – it is the land’s own breath. The land’s breath is a warning.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their pack. Heavy pack means travelling long. Light pack means just started. No pack means a fool or a ghost. The wilds eat fools. Ghosts eat the wilds.*

What is the most common crime? *Forgetting – but forgetting is a survival strategy. The wilds are full of things that want to be forgotten. A traveller who forgets them may pass safely. A traveller who remembers must pay a toll – a story. The memory is the trap.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The wilds are not empty. They are full of watchers – spirits, beasts, old things with no names. They do not interfere. They wait. They remember every footprint.*

Where do people go when they die? *Into the land. The dead are left where they fell. The land absorbs them. The land’s memory grows longer. The dead become the land’s memory. The memory is the wilds.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You leave an offering – a coin, a button, a lock of hair. If the offering is gone by morning, you are forgiven. If it remains, you are not. If it has been moved, the land is testing you. The test is the walk. The walk is the apology.*

What is the most important festival? *The Turning of the Leaves (autumn). The wilds change colour – red is anger, gold is warning, brown is patience, green is forgetfulness. This year the leaves are red. The land is angry. Do not ask why.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The wilds have a heart. A stone buried beneath the oldest oak. The stone is warm and beating. If it stops, the wilds die. Nothing left to remember. Nothing left to wait.*

0.22 The Wilds — “Roads, Ruins, and Weather”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *The land walks when you don’t watch it, and the roads remember who bled on them.*

Claimant Chief (Elite): “These lands answer not to charters but to those who can read their signs and respect their moods. Authority here is earned one campfire at a time, by proving you understand the difference between claiming and belonging.”

Forager Child (Commoner): “The wilds don’t need your roads or your rules – they got their own ways of keeping score. Follow the cairns if you want to live, and always leave something behind to thank the land for letting you pass. Every hill hides a secret, and every hollow breathes.”

Genre / Mood: Hexcrawl wanderlust, ruin-haunted silence, weather as character.

Starting Location: A shelter hollow carved into a fallen giant’s ribcage, moss glowing faintly under starlight. A Forager Child offers a route-song: “The Bad Ground shifts, and the weather walks behind it. Sing with me, or walk alone.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between towns and treaties lies the patience of the land. Old roads remember armies; cairns remember names no book keeps. In the Wilds, law thins to trail-marks and favors, and the weather keeps its own counsel. This is the country of the hexcrawl: a patchwork of hidden valleys, forgotten ruins, beast lairs, and the bones of failed settlements. No single authority rules here—instead, the land itself is the measure, and every crossing writes a new line. Walk soft, read the wind, bargain with whatever still listens, and keep one eye on the horizon. The next hex may hold water, treasure, or teeth.

What you notice first: The silence after a bird stops singing. The way a cairn seems to have shifted since you passed it last. The smell of rain on dry stone, even when the sky is clear.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sleep in a hollow that has soot on the ceiling without adding your own to the fire. The land knows the difference between a guest and a thief.

Regional Mood: The Land That Watches

Here, the wilds are not empty—they are patient. Every ridge has been climbed by someone who never came down; every spring has been drunk from by a hundred generations of the lost. The land remembers every footstep, every campfire, every promise whispered into the wind. It does not judge, but it does not forget. Power in the wilds is not given by crowns or charters—it is earned by reading the weather, by leaving the right offering at the right

cairn, by knowing when to move and when to wait. Those who rush are swallowed; those who listen are guided. The wilds are not a destination. They are the conversation between the map and the untamed.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

In any Wilds scene, the ninth cairn you pass in a day will be warm to the touch. Leave an offering—a pinch of salt, a copper coin, a single word spoken to the wind—or the path will forget you. Those who forget to pay find that the next crossing leads back to the same cairn, and the cairn has grown a new stone. The stone has their name on it.

The Unfinished Map

The Wilds are not a route—they are a grid of secrets. Each day's march opens a new page. Some hexes are empty: water, fuel, a safe place to sleep. Others hold lairs, ruins, shrines, or the remnants of old wars. The GM should key a handful of interesting places in advance, then let the cards populate the space between. Draw a card for each new leg; let the suit and rank whisper what you find. The land does not repeat itself, but it echoes.

(Crossing/Lookout/Old Road) Crossing point with ford/ice-span/stepping logs/dune saddle/reef shelf; lookout knoll with wind-carved marker; old road trace with cairns half-eaten by terrain.

Spades — Places (Hex Terrain)

2. **Crossing Point** — Ford, ice-span, stepping logs, dune saddle, reef shelf. *The crossing has a price: a stone, a story, or a moment of silence. The water hums when it's satisfied.*
3. **Lookout Knoll** — Tor, cliff, dune, ridge with wind-carved marker. *From here, you can see three hexes in clear weather—and one that shouldn't exist, flickering like a heat-shaped lie.*
4. **Old Road** — Trace with cairns and switchbacks half-eaten by terrain. *The cobbles are worn smooth by ghosts. They whisper directions at dusk. The directions are always true, but never complete.*
5. **Shelter Hollow** — Overhang, cave, root cellar; soot says “used lately.” *The soot is layered in thin, greasy rings. Someone has been coming here for a very long time. The hollow smells of wet fur and old secrets.*
6. **Water Source** — Spring, seep, fog net, snow pan, guarded by thorns or stone. *The water tastes of iron and old bargains. Drink deep, but leave a coin—copper for a safe draw, silver for a question answered.*

7. **Windbreak** — Rock ribs, lee of pines, reed-wall berm. *The windbreak smells of woodsmoke and wool. Someone camped here last night. Their fire is still warm.*
 8. **Ruined Outpost** — Watchstack, wayside shrine, marker pile. *The ruin's flagstones are warm, as if a great beast sleeps beneath them. The air tastes of rust and thyme.*
 9. **Bad Ground** — Sinkhole, bog crust, crevasse, loess slump. *The ground breathes—a slow, deep inhalation that lifts your heels. Step lightly or it will swallow you.*
 10. **Gate Gully** — Pinch point between bluffs, dunes, or ice hummocks. *The gully has a name carved in the rock. The name changes every season. Carve yours, and you may never leave.*
- J **Boundary Row** — Totems, standing stones, prayer flags bent by weather. *The flags are faded. The last prayer was for rain—and it still hasn't come. The totems have grown moss in the shape of faces.*
- Q **Worksite** — Abandoned mine, quarry, logging camp, salt pan. *The tools are scattered, but none are rusted. Whoever left did not plan to return—or has not yet finished.*
- K **Signal Height** — Old fire-pit or mirror stand; smoke stains linger. *Light the fire, and someone will answer. Whether they are friend or foe is your risk. The smoke always smells of your childhood.*
- A **Trail Nexus** — Migratory, pack, or contraband paths knot here. *Three trails meet, but only two are on any map. The third belongs to the dead. Their footprints point the wrong way.*

(**Guide/Warden/Caravan**) Forager child with truer maps than yours; guide with three routes and one price (changes daily).

Hearts — People & Factions (Hex Denizens)

2. **Forager Child** — Goat-herd or berry-picker with truer maps than yours. *Their map is drawn on a scrap of bark. It shows a path that disappears at a standing stone. The stone is not on any other map.*
3. **Guide** — Three routes and one price (changes daily); navigation as negotiation. *Their price is never coin. It is a favor, a secret, or a night's watch. They will not tell you which until you arrive.*
4. **Warden Patrol** — Local badges, local laws, local patience; order as familiarity. *Their badge is a chipped sunburst. They serve a crown that no longer exists. The crown does not pay them. The land does.*

5. **Caravan Crew** — Drovers, porters, yarn-post hands trading speed for coin. *They know every shortcut and every ambush. They will share both—for a price. Their silence is purchased in stories.*
6. **Pilgrims** — Bound for a tucked-away shrine or stone; faith as a destination. *Their shrine has no name. The stone there is warm, and it answers questions poorly. It prefers to ask them.*
7. **Poachers** — Know every snare and shortcut; survival as expertise. *They wear the teeth of game wardens as necklaces. The game wardens are still alive. They are saving for a full set.*
8. **Hermit-Healer** — Dogs, geese, and opinions about weather; wisdom as isolation. *Their poultices smell of grave-moss. They work anyway. The dogs do not bark at strangers—they judge them.*
9. **Prospectors** — Salt, amber, iron, fungus; chasing rumors and glint. *Their claim is marked with a knot of red thread. Cross it, and they will shoot. The thread glows when a stranger's foot touches it.*
10. **War-Band** — Reavers or “escorts,” depending on your purse; violence as commerce. *Their banner is a painted skull. The paint is from a dead comrade's blood. They add a finger bone to the standard after every contract.*
- J **Monster-Hunter** — Rite-keeper wearing yesterday's trophies; death as livelihood. *Their trophy is still warm. The monster's mate is close behind. They are not running—they are leading.*
- Q **Quartermaster** — Ledgers first, hospitality second; supply as authority. *Their measure is written in a code only they understand. The code is their life story. The margins are full of regrets.*
- K **Claimant Chief** — Papers and spears to match; legitimacy as force. *Their papers are stained with water and blood. Both are still wet. The water came from a spring they poisoned. The blood from the spring's keeper.*
- A **The Stranger** — Spirit-touched nomad or emissary; rules bend near them. *They have no shadow. The ground does not remember their footprints. Their voice echoes twice—once for them, once for the land.*

Additional Denizens of the Wilds

Not every soul in the wilds is a wanderer. Some have built fragile refuges, while others have been broken by war, exile, or the land itself.

14. **Isolated Town (Palings)** — A handful of families eking out a living behind a thorn hedge. *The gate is a wagon axle lashed upright. They trade hides for salt and ask no questions. Their children have never seen a paved road. '[COMMUNITY]'*

15. **Refugee Train** — A column of worn carts and quieter people fleeing a war or a curse. *Their leader carries a charter from a lord who is now dead. They will trade stories for passage and bury their dead without markers.* '[SORROW]'
 16. **Deserter Camp** — Soldiers who threw down their colours, now living by stealth. *They still drill at dawn and keep a sharp watch. Their loyalty is to each other, not to any flag. They may know the location of an abandoned fort.* '[STEALTH]'
 17. **Beastman Hunting Band** — Feral-looking folk with antler charms and pelts stitched to skin. *They do not speak Utaran. They communicate in growls and hand signs. They are not savages—they are the land's first children, and they remember when the roads were deer paths.* '[SPIRIT]'
 18. **Lost Tribe (Cairn-Folk)** — Descendants of a settlement that fell off every map. *They wear the teeth of their ancestors and tattoo their lineage on their faces. They believe the Hollow is a sleeping god and that the party are its messengers. They are wrong—or are they?* '[MYSTERY]'
 19. **Rootless Mercenaries** — A dozen sell-swords between contracts, nursing old wounds. *Their captain lost an eye to a mushroom spore. They will fight for coin, but they will also fight for a hot meal. They know the location of a forgotten cache of arms.* '[COMBAT]'
 20. **Anchorite in a Dead Tower** — A holy woman who has not spoken in twenty years. *She writes prophecies on the walls with charcoal. The prophecies are always about the next storm or the next stranger to arrive. She will not look at you if your shadow is wrong.* '[FAITH]'
 21. **Feral Children** — Orphaned by a raid or a plague, raised by wolves or worse. *They know every hidden spring and every game trail. They will not come close, but they will watch. Leave them a piece of bread, and they may leave you a knapped arrowhead—or a warning.* '[SURVIVAL]'
 22. **Cult of the Unburied** — Grave-tenders who believe the dead should not be left to the land. *They carry iron shovels and speak in hushed tones. They burn the bodies of the fallen they find, lest the Hollow take them. They may be willing to burn your dead as well—for a story.* '[RITUAL]'
- J **Exiled Scholar** — A academic who fled a city after proving the wrong theorem. *He carries a single book—his own—and will trade a chapter for a night's shelter. The book contains a map to a ruin that does not appear on any official chart.* '[KNOWLEDGE]'
- Q **The Grey Singer** — A blind woman who wanders the wilds humming. *Her songs calm territorial beasts and call down birds. She is looking for a melody she heard in a dream. If you help her find it, she will teach you a verse that quells a storm.* '[MYSTIC]'

K Bandit King's Lookout — A scout for a large robber band, hiding in a hollow tree. *He has a whistle that can summon a dozen riders. He is not cruel—just hungry. A bag of salt or a true story will buy his silence and his guidance around the ambush.* '[STEALTH]'

A The Hollow's Own — A figure dressed in grey rags, walking the same path every dusk. *They have no face—only a smooth expanse where features should be. They do not attack. They point. The direction they point is the direction the Hollow will walk next.* '[DEATH]'

(Weather/Doubleback/Prowlers) Weather turn with heat snap/cold snap/fog/dust; doubleback with tracks that loop; prowlers shadow with wolves/jackals/ghouls.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (Hex Hazards)

2. **Weather Turn** — Heat snap, cold snap, fog, dust; plans sag like wet leather. *The wind changes direction three times in an hour. Someone is watching. The air tastes of a season that hasn't come yet.*
3. **Doubleback** — Tracks loop; the navigator swears the land moved underfoot. *Your own footprints face you. They were made yesterday—or tomorrow. The toes point toward a future you have not chosen.*
4. **Prowlers Shadow** — Wolves, jackals, ghouls, seals, ravens by night; hunt as a company. *Their eyes reflect no light. Their teeth do. They are patient. They have been following since the last hex. You are only now noticing.*
5. **Route Blocked** — Deadfall, rockfall, dune shift, ice heave; the path as an obstacle. *The blockage was placed. The toolmarks are fresh. Whoever cleared this path did not want you to follow—or wanted you to take the other way.*
6. **Quarantine Sign** — Camp fever; wardens sniff your packs for death. *The sign is a ribbon tied in a figure-eight. Do not cross it. The ribbon is damp. It was tied recently. The wardens are still nearby.*
7. **Territorial Beast** — Charge, stampede, or swarm; your choice of which is wrong. *The beast's lair is nearby. You can smell it—old blood and older musk. The ground is warm. You are standing on its pantry.*
8. **Elemental Front** — Grassfire, peat-burn, canopy flare, blowing spindrift. *The fire moves against the wind. The wind is lying. The smoke writes a word in a language you almost understand. It is a warning.*
9. **Paper vs Spear** — Jurisdiction fight in the wilds stalls your day; law as argument. *Two officials, one road. Both have seals. Neither will show them. The seals are warm. They have been used recently—on death warrants.*

10. **Supply Pinch** — Water, fuel, or feed low; pick what starves first. *Your canteen is full. The water is from a source that dried up last year. You do not remember filling it. Someone did.*
- J **Pursuit** — Hunters or avengers follow; signs say “close.” *The tracks are one hour old. They are gaining. The hunters do not need to sleep. They have not slept for three days. Neither have you.*
- Q **Bad Omen** — Will-lights, taboo day, saint bells silent; locals refuse to move. *The omen is written in bird droppings on a milestone. It is still accurate. The birds are watching. They are waiting for you to ignore it.*
- K **General Alarm** — Levy, muster, evacuation; all tracks become checkpoints. *The alarm horn is cracked. It sounds like a scream. The scream is a name. The name is yours.*
- A **Catastrophe** — Flood, whiteout, sandstorm, lahar; timers jump like frightened deer. *The catastrophe has a name. The land remembers it. The land is shouting it now. The sound is the same as a heartbeat. Yours.*

Expanded Travel Hazards (from expansions)

For GMs who want even more variety, add these entries to the *Clubs* table (either replace six existing entries or expand the table to d18 by renumbering).

14. **Bell-Line Failure (Mistlands)** — A ward-bell cracks. Wraiths cross the levee. *Test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or gain the MARKED BY MIST condition (the next spirit encounter starts at Desperate Position).* ‘[DEATH]’
15. **Star-Road Phasing (Valewood)** — An ancient Lethai road flickers in and out of reality. *Navigation DV +2. On a failure, the party emerges in a different hex entirely (GM chooses).* ‘[MAGIC]’
16. **Spirit-Dust Storm (Ashaan)** — Red sand from the Red Desert carries whispering spirits. *All actions Desperate for the scene. On any 1, a bound spirit breaks free and attacks (Cap 2).* ‘[SPIRIT]’
17. **Ninth Night (Tulkani Circle)** — The party has camped too long. The Hollow walks. *An Oath-Keeper appears at midnight. It asks for a story, a memory, or a promise. Refusal deepens the land’s watchfulness.* ‘[ATTENTION]’
18. **Well-Spirit Honored (Fhara)** — A dry well suddenly flows, but the water carries minerals. *The spirit asks for respect—an offering of dates or a true story. Granted, the water stays sweet; refused, it turns bitter for the next leg.* ‘[SPIRIT]’
19. **Toll Shift (Silkstrand/Brass Coast)** — A gatekeeper changes the crossing terms. *All passage costs +1 Measure until the next landmark. Diplomacy requires a successful Presence + Sway (DV 4).* ‘[AUTHORITY]’

(**Cache/Pass/Favor**) Cache token for hidden food or fuel stash; right-of-way pass recognized by a named trail; warden's favor with an escort letter.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (Hex Discoveries)

2. **Cache Token** — Key to a hidden food or fuel stash (once); preparation as power. *The token is a knucklebone. The stash is marked with a cairn that has one stone missing. The missing stone is the token.*
 3. **Right-of-Pass** — Recognized marker for a named trail or crossing. *The marker is a notch carved in a milestone. The notch is shaped like a bird. The bird is an owl. The owl watches at dusk.*
 4. **Warden's Favor** — Escort letter; "they're with us" as a shield. *The letter is stamped with a bell. The bell's clapper is missing. The absence of sound is the signature.*
 5. **Weather Window** — Good forecast and a narrow gate to use it. *The window is a single hour at dawn. The birds will tell you when. They will stop singing. That is the signal.*
 6. **Water Deed** — Lawful draw at a scarce source; necessity as a right. *The deed is a clay cup. Break it, and the spring will flow—once. The cup's shards can be traded for another deed. There are nine shards.*
 7. **Route Song** — A map scrap that actually works; knowledge as navigation. *The song has eight verses. The ninth is humming. The humming is the sound of the road itself. It changes with the weather.*
 8. **Remount Hire** — Fresh legs or hulls waiting at a post; speed as a service. *The remounts have no names. They answer to whistles and bribes. They remember every rider. They do not forgive cruelty.*
 9. **Truce Cord** — Taboo exemption at a site (one scene); peace as a thread. *The cord is braided from wool and ash. Burn it to invoke the truce. The ash must be from the same fire that warmed the truce.*
 10. **Toll Waiver** — A ferry, bridge, or reef gate honors this chit; passage as paper. *The chit is a dried leaf. The toll-keeper will not touch it. They will nod and wave you through. They will not speak.*
- J **Favor Owed** — Locals owe you (or you owe them); trade for labor or insight. *The favor is carved on a tally stick. Break it when the favor is done. The stick will not burn. It will only splinter.*
- Q **Private Audience** — A keeper, shrine-warden, or spirit of the place hears you alone. *The audience is held at midnight. The spirit wears your face. It asks only one question. You will answer truthfully.*

K Road Commission — Temporary authority over a stretch of wilds. *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the land will listen—once. The whistle is carved from a bone that was never alive.*

A Earth's Exception — One temporary rule-bend (cross during a storm, pass uncounted, beasts ignore you). *The exception is a secret. The land will forget it as soon as you use it. You will remember it every night for a year.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Timer (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (cache/pass/favor) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, add a lingering omen of the land (a smell on the wind, a sound that carries too far, tracks that shift) that you can echo in later scenes.

Travel at a Glance (Fast & Loose)

A journey through the Wilds is a series of choices, not a checklist. Before each leg (a day, a stretch of road, a single hex), the party picks two priorities from **Speed**, **Stealth**, **Safety**, **Survey**. Those become your edge; the others become vulnerabilities. The GM then frames a single roll based on the terrain and the weather's mood (see *Weather Whims*, below). Success means you find what you sought; a mixed result trades progress for a cost; a miss throws a complication from the *Clubs* table onto the path.

Weather Whims (d6, one per leg)

1. *Glass-clear* – long sight, easy navigation. +1 to Survey actions.
2. *Low fog* – stealth advantage, speed suffers. +1 to Stealth, –1 to Speed.
3. *Trickle rain* – tracks wash, cold bites. First navigation or tracking roll at –1 die.
4. *Dry cold / heat* – resources drain faster. Mark +1 supply strain at end of leg.
5. *Shifting wind* – smoke and scent lie. Reroll one die on a weather-related check, but the GM may bank 1 SB.
6. *Omen sky* (aurora, sun-dog, three moons) – the land is listening. The GM may ask one player to answer a single question about the party's future.

Making Camp When you stop, choose one *boon* and accept one *risk*:

- **Boon:** heal a piece of gear; clear 1 Fatigue; scout tomorrow’s weather; share a story with a road spirit (gain a *Truce Cord*).
- **Risk:** thin shelter (next weather hits harder); smoky fire (attracts prowlers); exposed approach (ambush more likely); hungry neighbors (locals or beasts appear).

A road spirit’s favour requires a small offering—a pinch of salt, a dropped coin, a whispered truth. Be polite.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Cord use certain shelter hollows as waystations. A renegade Sister has hidden a Hollowed in a ruined outpost; the child has not moved in weeks.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Old Roads are Class II Anchor sites—ghosts of imperial surveyors still measure the miles. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin at every milestone.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at the bottom of every spring. Take it, and the water will never run dry—but the spring will remember your face.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Wilds psions are called “Stone-Listeners.” They hear the memory of old trails. Claimant chiefs pay well for their services—and dispose of those who hear too much.

Wilderness Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at a boundary stone. Ignore the first *Bad Ground* penalty.
- **Knot the Trail:** Tie a single knot in a piece of grass at a crossing. Cancel *Doubleback* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Spring:** Whisper a dead traveler’s name into a water source. Gain +1 Effect when foraging this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the land.

Weather Omens (d10) — New Mini-Generator

When the sky speaks in signs, roll to interpret its warning or promise.

|p1.5cm|p10cm|

gray!20 d10 Omen Meaning

1 Three crows fly west—the next storm will carry voices from the past.

2 Moonring broken at midnight—the weather will shift twice before dawn.

3 Wind carries iron scent on clear air—storm approaches from the direction of old battlefields.

4 Stars vanish in pattern—the land is holding its breath; the next step decides fate.

5 Sun dogs flank the rising sun—blessing on journeys begun before noon.

6 Fog forms perfect circles—what is lost will return, but changed.

7 Lightning strikes twice in same spot—the Hollow marks this place for attention.

8 Rain falls upward for three breaths—a reversal is coming; prepare to give what you take.

9 Wind dies completely at noon—the land sleeps; move swiftly or become part of its dream.

10 Aurora pulses with your heartbeat—the sky knows your name and your burden.

Ruin Findings (d8) — New Mini-Generator

When you explore a forgotten structure, roll to discover what echoes remain.

|p1.5cm|p10cm|

gray!20 **d8 Discovery**

1 A mosaic floor depicting a migration no map remembers—follow the tiles to find a hidden valley.

2 Wind whistles through broken arches in a tune that feels like home—hum it to gain +1 Effect on the next social roll.

3 Stone faces weep clear liquid that tastes of the first rain of spring—drink to clear 1 Fatigue.

4 A single tile is warm to the touch—press it to reveal a compartment holding a perfectly preserved seed.

5 Shadows move opposite the light—stand in their intersection to become invisible for one exchange.

6 Carvings show hands exchanging not goods but breaths—press your palm to the wall to share a memory.

7 The air hums at a frequency that makes teeth ache—sing against it to gain +1 die on the next magical roll.

8 A doorway frame is grown over with living stone—walk through it to leave one burden behind.

Trail Signs (d6) — New Mini-Generator

When you pause to read the land's subtle messages, roll to interpret what the way is telling you.

p1.5cm gray!20	p10cm d6 Sign Meaning
1	Pebbles point not to the path but to a patch of edible mushrooms—the land offers sustenance if you look aside.
2	Grass grows in perfect spirals around a stone—walk the spiral three times to find your bearings if lost.
3	A single feather lies across the trail—it belongs to a bird that nests only in places of perfect safety.
4	Moss grows thickest on the north face of rocks—but here it thrives on the south; the land is confused or changed.
5	Twigs are arranged in a pattern that matches your boot tread—something has been watching your steps.
6	Water in a puddle holds a perfect reflection... of a place you've never been.

Patronage & Power

In the Wilds, power flows through knowledge of the land, the ability to navigate without formal authority, and the careful cultivation of local relationships. True authority comes from understanding weather patterns, reading tracks, and maintaining the favor of both human inhabitants and the spirits of place. Those who can provide safe passage, find water in dry times, or mediate between conflicting claims hold the most influence.

For the GM: Patronage in the Wilds revolves around practical knowledge, local customs, and the ability to provide essential services like navigation, shelter, and supply. Rewards often take the form of tokens, passes, and local knowledge that can be leveraged into greater safety and efficiency. To emphasise the hexcrawl feel:

- Key 6–10 interesting hexes before the session, then use the generator to fill the rest.
- Let the party discover new routes, short cuts, and hidden lairs through successful scouting or lucky finds.
- Use the *Roads Move*, *Weather Wakes*, and *Local Resentment* timers (from the hexcrawl procedures) to create a living, reactive wilderness—or simply let the cards speak.
- Offer Diamonds as “exploration rewards” that unlock new options (a cache token, a safe passage, a local ally).

In the Wilds, your skill is your standing, and your standing determines whether you survive or perish.

Terrain Stock (d20)

Roll or choose a striking detail to dress a hex.

1. Fresh ash on an old fire ring; prints circle *around* it.
2. Boundary totems toppled but re-stack themselves if watched politely.
3. Broken wagon with salt-vein crystals growing through spokes.
4. Singing culvert; echo names the boldest listener wrongly.
5. Weather bell hung in a pine; tolling swaps rain and wind.
6. Cairn with a copper coin balanced on edge; don't breathe hard.
7. Fence of antlers pointing uphill; follow and skip one *Bad Ground*.
8. Mummified pack-beast wearing a courier's braid; letter hums.

9. Pebble mosaic of an old levy call; stepping it summons wardens.
10. Fossil rib arch; shelter under it and dream of tomorrow's route.
11. Abandoned hunter's cache; choice of food or rumor, not both.
12. Mirror-puddle; shows last night's sky whatever the hour.
13. Rope bridge made of prayer knots; one is freshly cut.
14. Scare-stakes dressed in saltcloth; something big respects them.
15. Stone with bite-marks; taste iron and remember a shortcut.
16. Old road mile-post defaced into a saint; offerings still fresh.
17. Thistle patch buzzing with coin-flies; feed them copper for safe passage.
18. Fallen giant's footprint now a pond; frogs chant a route-song.
19. Soot writing on cliff: *Storm at Second Bell*. It's right.
20. Hollow tree full of carved names; the newest is yours.

Lair Seeds (One-Page Crawls)

d12 quick lair hooks. Each can be a single session's focus.

1. **Fen Clockworks** — Bog-gears turn under peat; each tooth a drowned oath.
2. **Dry River Gallery** — Petroglyphs re-arrange at dusk; wrong reading summons bramble knights.
3. **Ice-Well Vault** — Stairs drilled through permafrost; breath blooms frost-runes that answer questions badly.
4. **Sunken Forum** — Pillars knee-deep in silt; rust moths nest in the rostrum.
5. **Pilgrim Kilns** — Charcoal mounds hike on stilt roots at night; a hermit-healer bargains weather for charcoal.
6. **Hanging Salt Chapel** — White stalactites ring like bells; grave-eels coil in the font.
7. **Thorn Maze Mill** — Waterwheel turns without water; phase panthers pace the sluice.
8. **Brewer's Hollow** — Barrels of wind; decant a gale or drink a calm.
9. **Antler Archive** — Tally carved on horn; theft awakens the cairn-wights' accountant.
10. **Black Lantern Mines** — Lantern-eyes nest like bats; light buys silence, darkness buys passage.

11. **Stormbone Spire** — Vertebrae tower; earth-sharks circle beneath like sharks in sand.
12. **Amber Orchard** — Trees fossilised mid-sway; trapped thunderflies grant *Weather Window* when freed.

Wilderness Bestiary

A palette of strange creatures, each with *signs* (what you notice before it sees you) and a *hook* (how to engage or avoid).

- **Earth-Sharks** — Burrow beneath loess and tundra; dorsal ridges like plowshares. *Signs*: furrows that breathe; pebbles rattle. *Hook*: lure with drumbeats or goat bells.
- **Phase Panthers** — Shadow-striped cats that step between gusts. *Signs*: pawprints offset from themselves. *Hook*: mirrored water or bell-silver disrupts the blink.
- **Rust Moths** — Swarms that taste iron memory. *Signs*: lacework mail; pitted nails. *Hook*: feed them old keys; they ignore fresh steel.
- **Lichen-Bears** — Moss-matted ursines with rock-teeth. *Signs*: clawed bark with green scabs. *Hook*: smoke of juniper calms; salt enrages.
- **Wind Drakes** — Rib-thin sky-serpents that ride fronts. *Signs*: shed vanes; feathers like glass. *Hook*: whistle back the storm to ground them.
- **Ooze-Remnants** — Alchemical slough from an old field lab. *Signs*: boot-holes rounded smooth. *Hook*: wood ash firms them; vinegar makes them sprint.
- **Fell Harts** — Antlered shades that herd the living toward cliffs. *Signs*: hoofprints that don't compress soil. *Hook*: speak a hunter's apology while walking backward.
- **Cairn-Wights** — Stone-stack custodians; patient as frost. *Signs*: pebbles rearranged around your fire. *Hook*: rebuild the stack correctly; they serve until dawn.
- **Thundertusks** — Boars that store lightning in tusk-veins. *Signs*: fused sand beads; singed roots. *Hook*: ground your spear; throw shadow to draw the strike.
- **Lantern-Eyes** — Floating orbs of watchlight rumor; jealous of secrets. *Signs*: daylight in ravines at midnight. *Hook*: offer a whispered truth; they part like reeds.
- **Grave-Eels** — Burrow through barrow loam; taste names. *Signs*: sinking turf over old wars. *Hook*: sing lineage or throw false names to mislead.
- **Bramble Knights** — Empty helms grown through with thorn; patrol old borders. *Signs*: briar in boot-grease. *Hook*: present a hedge-blessing; they escort instead of impale.

Strange Finds (d10)

When you discover a hidden cache or an ancient hoard, roll or pick:

1. **Route-stones** that warm near true north.
2. **Weather-bell clapper** that tolls only for lightning.
3. **Trail-right knot** dyed in berry law; locals honour it once.
4. **Salt-vein pick** that cuts oozes like cloth.
5. **Glass feather**; break to call a wind drake for one pass.
6. **Tally leaf** waterproofed with eel-fat; ink never runs, words drift.
7. **Thorn sigil** that bramble knights read as parley.
8. **Coin-fly cocoon**; hatch it for one honest guide to the nearest water.
9. **Bone flute** that calls earth-sharks to circle elsewhere.
10. **Lantern-eye husk**; squeeze for daylight the length of a camp prayer.

Omens & Signs

The land speaks. Use these when the party pauses or when the GM needs a portent.

Sky Signs (d8)

1. sun-dog
2. mare's tails
3. anvil cloud faces the wrong way
4. silent birds
5. far thunder without storm
6. moon with halo
7. ash scent on clear air
8. stars "shiver"

Ground Signs (d8)

1. cairn with new pebble
2. boot prints that end at rock

3. butchered game left neat
4. snapped twig at head height
5. ash under wet moss
6. ward-knot cut
7. trail beads on shrub
8. a single coin on a stone

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or local hunters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **prowlers or caravan guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or claimants**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource timer**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Guide or warden patrol** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or route blockage**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **war-band or territorial beast** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wardens, war-bands, or prowlers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **weather turns/catastrophe strikes/quarantine declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front timer by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Claimant chief, quartermaster, or The Stranger** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **weather shifts/blockage clears/catastrophe hits**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Wilds (Weather):** Conditions shift without warning, storms arrive early, calm turns to chaos.
- **Wilds (Navigation):** Trails reroute mid-journey, landmarks disappear, guides demand additional payment.
- **Wilds (Local Customs):** Spirits demand tribute, territorial beasts become aggressive, local laws change with the terrain.

Fast reskin palette

Forest swap dunes→deadfall, spindrift→canopy flare, prowlers→boar/wolves; water = spring/stream.

Desert swap bog→salt pan, fog→dust, shelter = overhang/wadi; water = seep/fog net.

Tundra/Ice swap dune shift→ice heave, fire→spindrift, boats→sleds; prowlers = bears/wolves.

Coast/Isles crossings = reef shelves, prowlers = seals/raiders, alarms = harbor booms; fuel = driftwood.

Swamp/Fen crossings = corduroy/log causeways, bad ground = peat crust, prowlers = gators/leeches.

Highlands crossings = cols and scree traverses, alarms = beacon chains, prowlers = cats/eagles.

Dungeons

Living Infrastructure.

“Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with rusted lungs and dream in currents of forgotten speech. The walls do not forget a step; the air holds the echoes of words we wish we had not spoken. Dungeons are not broken things – they are machines that have learned to live. Their lungs are the vents that sigh, their veins the pipes that throb, their jaws the doors that yield without touch. Some were forged by hand; others grew like mold in the dark. They are not ancient; they are patient, and they remember every flaw in the design as if it were a feature.”

— The Edgewalker

What do people eat for breakfast? *Fungus bread and cave water – the fungus grows on the walls, the water drips from the ceiling. Both taste of stone. Both are all there is.*

What does a child learn before they can walk? *To count footsteps. The eight sounds of the deep: Drip, Creak, Groan, Whisper, Scrape, Echo, Silence, and the ninth – the dungeon’s own heartbeat. The heartbeat is a door opening. The door is always behind you.*

What is the first thing you notice about a stranger? *Their shadow. Dungeon shadows are long, even in bright light. A shadow too short means they have been here too long. A shadow that moves independently means they have been touched by the deep. No shadow means they are not a stranger – they are the dungeon’s guest. The dungeon never lets guests leave.*

What is the most common crime? *Map-making – but map-making is heresy. The dungeon changes its corridors when it feels watched. A map that is accurate at dawn is a lie by dusk. The punishment is to walk the lie until it becomes true.*

What does no one talk about but everyone knows? *The dungeon is not a place. It is a creature that dreamed itself into stone. The corridors are its veins. The chambers are its organs. The prisoners are its thoughts. The thoughts are not its own.*

Where do people go when they die? *Into the walls. Bones are ground into mortar and used to patch the cracks. The cracks always reappear. The dead are never finished being used.*

How do you apologize for a serious wrong? *You offer a memory – a true one, witnessed by the dungeon itself. The memory is added to the walls. The walls whisper it back when you sleep. The apology never ends.*

What is the most important feature? *The Turning of the Keys (whenever the dungeon decides). Locks change, prisoners move, corridors rearrange. There is no date, no warning, no end. It is happening now. You did not notice. That is the point.*

What is the secret that could destroy a powerful person? *The dungeon's architect is still alive, sealed in the lowest chamber. The dungeon does not want to be alone. The architect is its only friend. The architect has not spoken in nine centuries. The dungeon does not need words.*

0.23 Dungeons — Living Infrastructure

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. The walls remember every footfall; the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations.*

The Dungeon’s Architect (Elite): “I am a Scholar-Prisoner. The walls here have a memory like old parchment—they remember every scream, every spell, every drop of blood spilled on the stones. And sometimes, when the air’s just right, they whisper it back to you. The dungeon listens. The question is whether it learns. I have been here for nine years. I have heard it learning. It started with single words. Then sentences. Now it speaks in paragraphs. Last week, it finished my thoughts before I did.”

Cavern-Crawler (Commoner): “Dungeons are not ruins—they are systems. Ventilation shafts that breathe, water channels that pulse, doors that open and close without any hand to move them. The Aeler built many of them; the Covenant sealed others; the Sidhi mined a few; and some were never built at all. They grew. Like fungus in the dark. Like a story told too many times. Like a debt that compounds.”

Genre / Mood: Survival horror underground, infrastructure as adversary, eco-horror, forgotten machinery.

System Type: Portable overlay — apply to any dungeon, ruin, or deep place. Not a fixed geography.

Theme & Atmosphere

Dungeons are not empty holes. They are *living infrastructure*—semi-sentient systems that remember, learn, and hunger. Their corridors shift when you aren't looking. Their doors open to places you did not intend. Their air tastes of copper, old keys, and the breath of something that has been waiting a very long time.

Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs. The Aeler built many of them as overflow vaults and under-roads; the Covenant sealed others to contain what should not walk; the Sidhi mined a few and left behind ghost-workings. Some were never built at all. They grew from pressure, from forgotten oaths, from the weight of unresolved debts. A dungeon is not a place. It is a process. Like a fungus in the dark. Like a story told too many times. Like a curse that compounds.

When you enter a dungeon, you are not entering a room. You are entering a *system*—and systems have rules. Air must be counted. Light must be rationed. Noise is the first enemy. Attention is the last. The dungeon learns your patterns and adapts. It offers shortcuts to the desperate and dead ends to the confident. It remembers your name after you leave.

What you notice first: The air tastes of copper and old keys. Your footsteps echo half a beat too late. The walls are warm—and they pulse like hearts.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ignore a door that opens when you're not looking. The dungeon is offering you a choice. Refuse, and the next door may not open at all. Accept, and the door may lead to a room that was always there, waiting for someone to finally walk through. The room has been waiting for nine thousand years. It is not tired of waiting.

The Ninth Taboo Manifestation

In any dungeon, the ninth door you open (counting only doors that required conscious choice) will lead to a room that is *not on your map*. The room is always warm. Something inside knows your name. If you enter, you may find treasure—or become part of the dungeon's memory. The wise open eight doors, then backtrack.

Quickstart (Two Minutes)

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1. **Choose a Dungeon Type:** Keystone Vault (Aeler), Sealed Catacomb (Covenant), Pressure Grotto (Mazereth), Spore Warren (Mycotheres), or Raw Vein (wild).
2. **Track Four Things:** Air [6], Light [6], Noise [4], Attention [6] (choose: Drake Notice, Cult Patrol, or Vein Unrest).
3. **Intent Dial (per room/zone):** Stealth / Speed / Survey / Communion (parley with place-spirits).

4. **Diamonds to Carry:** keystone courtesy, bell-wire, toll-chalk, web token, shed-skin writ, pressure map, reed charm.
5. **Etiquette on Entry:** Step on stone; speak under beam; ring once. (Grants Position +1 in first scene if observed.)

Names of Dungeon Denizens

Dungeon dwellers rarely use surnames. Epithets are earned from the living stone.

p0.25 p0.25 p0.2 p0.2			
First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Clan/Origin	Epithets
Korr	Svala	Deepforged	<i>the Unseeing</i>
Thrain	Harken	Ironbound	<i>the Candle-Eater</i>
Grimm	Lira	Root-Touched	<i>the Silent</i>
Veth	Myrin	Spore-Kin	<i>the Soot-Scarred</i>
Rurik	Tamsin	Pressure-Born	<i>the Echo-Thief</i>
Cael	Nix	Hollow-Kin	<i>the Last Step</i>

Spades — Places (Dungeon Zones)

Room, Corridor, Threshold, Heart

2. **Air-Sealed Chamber** — A room with no obvious vent; the air is still, warm, and tastes of iron. '[SURVIVAL]' *Testing Air each scene; on a miss, start Suffocation [4].*
3. **Whispering Gallery** — A long corridor where every sound echoes nine times. '[STEALTH]' *Any roll that produces noise ticks Noise +1; on a miss, the echo speaks a name.*
4. **Flooded Vault** — A submerged antechamber; pressure doors block the way. '[TRAVEL]' *Crossing requires a Body+Athletics test (DV 4) or lose 1 Light (wet lamp).*
5. **Clockwork Junction** — Gears turn in the walls; brass conduits hum. '[MAGIC]' *A successful Tinkering test (DV 3) can shift one segment of any dungeon timer. On a 1, start Anomaly [4].*
6. **Spore Garden** — Bioluminescent fungi carpet the floor; soft light, softer danger. '[HEAL]' *Forage DV 2 (glow-spores, medicinal moss). On a miss, inhale spores → Weariness +1.*
7. **Bell-Line Corridor** — Ropes of copper bells hang from the ceiling; any movement rings them. '[STEALTH]' *Stealth rolls start Desperate. A successful Tinkering test (DV 4) silences them for one scene.*

8. **Keystone Arch** — A stone doorway carved with ancient Aeler runes. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Present a Keystone Courtesy or spend 1 Boon to open it without rolling.*
9. **Mirror Hall** — Walls of polished obsidian show reflections that move independently. ‘[TRUTH]’ *Any lie spoken here is answered by a reflection that speaks the truth—at cost of 1 Fatigue to the liar.*
10. **Pressure Vent** — A narrow shaft with rhythmic blasts of hot air. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Crossing requires timing (Wits+Survival DV 4). On a miss, take Harm 1 (burn).*
- J **Hoard Chamber** — A cavern of treasure, but every coin is warm and whispers. ‘[WEIGHT]’ *Taking anything starts Hoard’s Attention [4]; on fill, a guardian awakens.*
- Q **Ossuary Forge** — Bones and scrap metal are smelted into crude tools. ‘[CRAFT]’ *Can produce one Relic tag (e.g., BLEED, WARD) at cost of 1 Obligation (the dead remember).*
- K **Observatory of Scars** — A domed chamber with sky-windows showing past wars, not current skies. ‘[DIVINE]’ *Once per delve, ask the GM one question about the dungeon’s history; the answer is true but cryptic.*
- A **The Heart** — The core of the dungeon: a beating crystal, a sleeping dragon, a coven of cultists, or a ticking machine. ‘[LEGEND]’ *The boss lives here. Entering triggers the final phase.*

Hearts — People & Factions (Dungeon Denizens)

2. **Cavern-Crawler** — A grimy survivor with a lamp and a longer list of scars. ‘[SURVIVAL]’ *Knows one shortcut (reduce Distance by 1) but demands a share of the first Diamond found.*
3. **Pressure Guild (Mazereth)** — A deep tunneler who counts breaths like coin. ‘[TRADE]’ *Offers a Pressure Map (Diamond) for 1 Supply or a story about a collapse.*
4. **Aeler Under-Mason** — A dwarf with a tuning fork and a level. ‘[CRAFT]’ *Can stabilize one collapsing zone per delve at cost of 1 Fatigue.*
5. **Lethai-ar Silk-Warden** — A masked elf whose web-token grants passage through disputed corridors. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *Will escort the party past one hazard if they swear an oath witnessed by her.*
6. **Spore-Speaker** — A mycothe priest who communes with fungal networks. ‘[MAGIC]’ *Can clear 1 segment of Air or Light in exchange for a memory (erase a minor fact).*
7. **Drake-Touched Thrall** — A cultist with scales growing from their arms. ‘[FEAR]’ *Offers a Drake’s Whistle (summon a minor drake for one scene) at cost of starting Attention +1.*

8. **Iron Avenger** — An Aeler feud-keeper hunting a fugitive in the deep. '[COMBAT]' *Will fight beside you against a common enemy, but will demand a blood-price afterward.*
9. **Fossil Juror** — A sentient skeleton bound to judge intruders. '[JUSTICE]' *Will not attack; instead, asks a riddle. Answer correctly to pass; fail and it demands a geas.*
10. **Hoard-Wyrd** — A ghost bonded to a specific treasure. '[DEATH]' *It will let you take the item if you promise to return it after one use—or suffer a curse.*
- J **Ember Imp** — A small, sharp-toothed creature that trades heat for secrets. '[TRICK]' *Will light your lamp for 1 Fatigue, but will also steal a small item when you aren't looking.*
- Q **Herald Gargoyle** — A stone sentinel that enforces the dungeon's etiquette. '[AUTHORITY]' *Demands a tithe (a story, a breath, a name) before allowing passage.*
- K **Worm-Bound Knight** — A fallen knight bound by a geas to a sleeping dragon. '[OATH]' *Will aid in a single combat if you promise to break their oath afterward.*
- A **The Dungeon's Voice** — A whisper from the walls, speaking in your own voice. '[MYSTERY]' *It offers a shortcut or a treasure in exchange for a promise. Breaking it costs a memory.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats (Dungeon Hazards)

Environment, Attention, Betrayal, Unstable

2. **Micro-Collapse** — A ceiling cracks; stone dust fills the air. '[DISASTER]' *Each PC tests Body+Athletics (DV 3) or takes Harm 1. Tick Noise +1.*
3. **Lantern Sputter** — Your light source gasses or gutters. '[LIGHT]' *Reduce Light by 1. On a miss, the lamp goes out entirely—start Stumble in Dark [4] timer.*
4. **Pocket Gas** — A burst of foul air from a crack. '[AIR]' *Tick Air +1. Anyone in the scene who fails a Endurance test (DV 3) marks 1 Fatigue.*
5. **Echo-Lure** — The dungeon mimics a voice you know, calling from a side passage. '[TRAP]' *Whoever follows must test Wits+Resolve (DV 4) or be separated from the party for 1 scene.*
6. **Leech Bloom** — A patch of carnivorous fungi awakens. '[COMBAT]' *Cap 2 adversary; if ignored, ticks Supplies -1 (they eat rations).*
7. **Silk Strand Snaps** — A Lethai-ar web bridge collapses. '[TRAVEL]' *Distance -1; anyone on the bridge tests Body+Athletics or takes Harm 1.*
8. **Oath-Magnet** — A spoken promise in this zone becomes magically binding. '[OATH]' *Any vow made here ticks a Promise Timer [4] that tightens on a lie.*

9. **Drake Whisper** — A distant roar echoes; the dungeon's attention sharpens. '[ATTENTION]' *Tick Attention +1; on a miss, also mark Fatigue (fear).*
10. **Patrol Net Tightens** — Sentinels or cultists adjust their routes. '[AUTHORITY]' *Next Stealth roll starts at Desperate Position.*
- J **Lose the Bell-Wire** — Your guide-rope is cut; you are lost. '[TRAVEL]' *Distance +2 segments; all navigation rolls suffer -1 die until you find a landmark.*
- Q **Task Loop** — The party repeats the same corridor; time loops. '[MAGIC]' *Tick Weariness +1; on a miss, a character forgets why they came (lose one Clue).*
- K **Autonomous Spasm** — A clockwork mechanism runs wild. '[DISASTER]' *A random piece of gear becomes Compromised; on a critical, it explodes (Harm 1 to wielder).*
- A **Convergence** — The dungeon's Attention fills. The boss manifests immediately. '[BOSS]' *Treat as a Major Turn (4+ SB); roll on the Boss Seed table.*

Diamonds — Treasures & Discoveries

Each Diamond is a physical object with a cost and a story.

2. **Pressure Map** — A leather chart marked with safe routes. '[TRAVEL]' *DV -1 to navigate collapses or gas pockets for one delve.*
3. **Bell-Wire Spool** — A coil of copper wire that rings when taut. '[STEALTH]' *Lay a witness line; convert one False Order/Echo Lure into a Confusion only.*
4. **Keystone Courtesy** — A carved stone token. '[AUTHORITY]' *Once per leg, raise or lower a portcullis "by the book" without a roll—if you can name the builder.*
5. **Web-Token** — A silk charm from a Lethai-ar warden. '[SOCIAL]' *Enter parley with any faction in the dungeon from a position of safety once.*
6. **Shed-Skin Writ** — A parchment signed in Isoka's rite. '[LAW]' *Voids one coercive clause (contract, geas, oath) at the cost of 1 Obligation (a future favour).*
7. **Reed-Charm (under-river)** — A water-resistant talisman. '[TRAVEL]' *Treat one blackwater reach as neutral terrain for a crossing.*
8. **Cinder Pearl** — A drake's tooth still warm. '[MAGIC]' *Add IGNITE to one small action (e.g., light a torch, spark a fuse) once.*
9. **Gleam Reed** — A phosphorescent stem. '[LIGHT]' *Remove one Root/Slow effect; also restores 1 Light segment.*
10. **Cold Scale** — A frost-wyrm scale. '[WARD]' *Ignore one chill or terror effect for a scene; then crumbles.*

J Proof-Mote — A floating mote of amber light. ‘[TRUTH]’ *Ask the GM: “What here is misfiled?” The answer is a clue about a hidden treasure or trap.*

Q Scale Draught — A vial of diluted wyrm blood. ‘[FEAR]’ *Resist fear in a tribunal or horror scene; after use, tick Attention +1 (the wyrm notices).*

K Rime Crown — A circlet of frost-shaped bone. ‘[WARD] [COLD]’ *Once per session, gain COLD and WARD for a scene; then mark 1 Fatigue.*

A The Egg That Will Not Hatch — A cold, glass-smooth egg containing an idea. ‘[LEGEND]’ *Whisper a question; the egg answers in dreams. It will only hatch when someone dies willingly for it.*

Dungeon Mechanics (Visible Tracks)

Every delve tracks four resources. Keep them visible.

- **Air [6]** – Stale pockets, smoke, gas leaks. When Air ≥ 4 , all physical actions start -1 Position unless you have a bellows or mask.
- **Light [6]** – Lamps, glow-silk, bioluminescence. At Light = 0, all actions are Desperate; wandering monsters find you automatically.
- **Noise [4]** – Clatter, echoes, spells. When Noise = 4, a patrol or predator arrives (GM chooses).
- **Attention [6]** – The dungeon’s focus. When Attention = 6, the boss manifests or a catastrophic trap triggers. Reset to 0 after.

Intent Dial (per zone) Choose one before entering a new zone:

- **Stealth** – Low Noise, slower. $+1$ Position to Hide Sign, but Distance advances slower.
- **Speed** – Tick Noise to push distance; invites mishaps.
- **Survey** – Read the stone/web/flow. On a hit, reduce Air or Light by 1.
- **Communion** – Parley with place-spirits. Risky boons (a clue, a shortcut) but may tick Attention.

Three-Timer Rule At most three active timers in a scene. The GM selects which of Air/Light/Noise/Attention are active. Long-term timers (Hoard’s Attention, Promise Timer) are tracked between sessions.

Boss Seeds (Three-Phase Foes)

Roll d6 or choose a boss that fits the dungeon's heart.

1. **The Hoard-Wyrm (Crystalline Drake)** – *Phases*: Greed's Gleam → Scale Horde → Awaken the Hoard. *Cracks*: feed it a cursed treasure, speak a true regret, or shatter its heart-crystal with a memory of generosity.
2. **The Unburnt Cult (Isoka Fanatics)** – *Phases*: Shedding Rite → Trial of Venom → The Fiery Dawn. *Cracks*: refuse the cup three times, expose a false priest, or force a Bowl (fairness) before a Fang (verdict).
3. **The Deep Drake (Pressure Below)** – *Phases*: Whisper → Knock → Invitation → Collection. *Cracks*: offer a memory of sunlight, speak a true regret, or allow a willing sacrifice to walk into the deep in your place.
4. **The Iron Avenger (Aeler Feud-Keeper)** – *Phases*: Blood Ledger → Toll Demanded → Reckoning. *Cracks*: pay the wergild in public works, expose a false claimant, or complete the feud with a duel of witnesses (not blades).
5. **The Mycothe Sovereign (Spore Lord)** – *Phases*: Bloom → Court of Mold → The Great Reseeding. *Cracks*: burn the central mycelium, negotiate a spore-truce (sacrifice 1 Supply of ash), or sing a counting song it has never heard.
6. **The Hollow Architect (Ghost of a Forgotten Builder)** – *Phases*: Redraw the Map → Collapse the Approach → The Unfinished Stair. *Cracks*: finish its blueprint (Craft test DV 5), return a stolen keystone, or convince it that the empire is truly dead.

Loot Generator (Hoard Strata)

When the party defeats the boss or cracks a major vault, roll on these tables to build a hoard. Use the same strata as the Dragon's Lair supplement.

Stratum A: Coin & Commodity (d12)

1. Scales of electrum stamped with extinct dynasties.
2. River-pearls that hum in rain. [WATER]
3. Salt-bricks worth a city's winter.
4. Demon-minted coppers—warm to touch. [BLIGHT]
5. Glass coins: spend with a lie, shatter on truth.
6. Star-iron beads (forge-grade). [RELIC]
7. Amber lumps with insects that whisper routes.

8. Scrip of a fallen bank; redeemable with the right story.
9. Temple tithes bound with blue twine (oath-sealed).
10. Trade bars etched with river-depth marks (pilot's tools).
11. Coral crowns; brittle but potent at sea. [COMMAND]
12. Black spice; anesthetic or poison by dose.

Stratum B: Art & Relic (d12)

1. Masks of the Seven Winds (sing for WIND once/scene).
2. Tapestry that updates current wars nightly.
3. Bone flutes that call extinct birds.
4. Chalice that refuses poisoned liquid.
5. Crown of Oaths: swearing while wearing binds magically. [BIND]
6. Twin mirrors: speak into one, echo from the other at midnight.
7. Zodiac astrolabe; points to eclipses. [DIVINE]
8. Ember harp; strings ignite when lies are told nearby.
9. Saint's gauntlet; unburnt by any fire.
10. Library sigil-stamp; seals are obeyed by lesser courts.
11. Fossil codex; pages of shale can be read once each.
12. Lantern with bottled dawn (3 uses). [LIGHT]

Stratum C: Names, Oaths, Intangibles (d12)

1. A king's true name in a lead vial.
2. A bridge's right-of-way (you collect the toll).
3. Seven unspent apologies; each removes one curse.
4. A ship's luck bound in twine; cut to claim it.
5. The deed to a moonlit crossroads.
6. A treaty's missing clause; add it to rewrite borders.
7. The last lullaby of a nation; sing to calm armies.

8. A festival's first toast; begin it to unite feuds.
9. Weather's favor over one valley for a year.
10. The memory of a siege ladder; place it to open a gate.
11. A duel's outcome, never fought; declare to bind fate.
12. The debt of a cathedral to its mason's bloodline.

Stratum D: Cursed Complications (d10)

1. Taking coins awakens a Hoard-Wyrd.
2. The art objects are witnesses; they may testify in court.
3. Removing any crown asserts a claim; rivals appear.
4. Intangibles are tracked by Herald Gargoyles.
5. A rival dragon has a lien on half the hoard.
6. Curse of Counting: must tally treasure nightly or suffer Fatigue +1.
7. Hoard Scent: predators pursue the bearer.
8. Echo of Theft: the original owners dream of you.
9. Oath-Magnet: you attract sworn duels.
10. Tide-Tithe: waters reclaim 10% during each full moon.

Quick Hoard Build

1. Pick 1–2 from A, 1–2 from B, 1 from C, 1 from D.
2. Assign 1–2 TAGS as properties (e.g., WARD, COMMAND, LIGHT).
3. State a *Hoard Law*: who may touch what (breaking it triggers a Lair Move or Attention tick).

Dungeon Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Door:** Crumble a crust at a sealed threshold. Ignore the first *Micro-Collapse* penalty. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Knot the Bell-Wire:** Tie a single knot in a guide rope. Cancel *Echo-Lure* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice). '[SUPERSTITION]'

- **Name to the Wall:** Whisper a dead explorer's name into a crack. Gain +1 Effect when negotiating with the dungeon's Voice this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Architect. '[SUPERSTITION]'
- **Salt to the Threshold:** Leave a pinch of salt at a door you do not wish to open again. The door will not open from either side for one day. '[SUPERSTITION]'

SB Menu (Dungeons)

Minor (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** A patrol or warden notices you.
- **Noise:** Your footsteps echo; a nearby denizen stirs.
- **Trace:** Scratched stone or spent lamp oil marks your route.
- **Delay:** A door jams, a ladder breaks—lose time.
- **Air Strain:** Tick Air +1 (stale pocket).

Moderate (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** A sentinel sounds a chime; Attention +1.
- **Position Lost:** A floor collapses or a wall seals; you are separated.
- **Foe Appears:** A minor drake, a fossil juror, or a cultist squad arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A lamp sputters (Light -1) or a weapon snags.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A keystone door now requires a test to open.

Serious (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** A warband of Iron Avengers or a Hoard-Wyrd appears.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A bell-wire snaps, a pressure map tears.
- **Major Twist:** The dungeon shifts—a corridor loops, a new path opens.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a campaign timer (e.g., Hoard's Attention, Manifestation).
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1** or **Harm 1** from gas or fall.

Major (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared seal activates (Harm 2, Area).
- **Authority Arrival:** The Dungeon's Voice, a Herald Gargoyle, or the boss interrupts.
- **Scene Shift:** A collapse seals the exit; the Heart chamber opens prematurely.
- **Patron Omen:** A draconic echo or a Lethai-ar omen appears.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The dungeon reveals a forgotten truth—a secret door, a hidden geas, a broken oath.

Cross-Regional Use

- **Aeler Holds:** A **Keystone Courtesy** can open sealed vaults; using it ticks **Ancestral Grudge** if the builder's lineage is insulted.
- **Mistlands:** A **Bell-Wire Spool** can be used to rehang a broken bell-line; start **Witchlight Count** after.
- **Ykrul Steppe:** A **Cold Scale** counts as a *Salt Allotment* in a kurgan negotiation; the dead will demand a story.
- **Sihai:** A **Proof-Mote** may be accepted as a *Silence Token* in a Censorate audit; the auditor will ask where you found it.
- **Valewood:** A **Rime Crown** can be offered to the Alder King as a winter tithe; he will ask for a memory of fire in return.

Patronage & Power

In a dungeon, power flows through breath, light, and the careful management of the dungeon's attention. The true authorities are those who understand its systems—the Aeler under-masons who know keystone law, the Lethai-ar silk-wardens who read web-law, the Mazereth pressure guilders who count every exhalation. But the dungeon itself is the final patron. It offers shortcuts, treasures, and secrets—always at a price. Accept a shortcut, and it may close behind you. Take a treasure, and the Hoard's Attention ticks. Speak a true name, and the dungeon learns your voice.

For the GM:

- Use the four tracks (Air, Light, Noise, Attention) as visible pressure. Let players buy relief with Strings or etiquette, not just dice.
- Enforce the **Intent Dial** each zone; switching intent costs a scene or a tick of Noise.
- Offer one **Diamond** that could solve the current scene—but only if the party accepts a future Price (a geas, a curse, an obligation to a faction).
- Spend SB as environment first (collapse, sputter, echo) before monsters. The dark should be the first antagonist, the denizens the second, the boss the third.
- Use the **Boss Seeds** as capstones for major delves. A boss is not a random encounter; it is the dungeon's answer to the party's intrusion.

The under realms are not a pit to be cleared but a commons to be negotiated. Where lights are counted and breaths are tallied, procedure is mercy—and every crossing is a promise that must hold under weight.

The Memory Closes

“The road is south. The ink is fresh. The lamp is borrowed.”

— Silkstrand Bravo

“The sea does not forgive, but it does forget – if you give it a story worth remembering.”

— Lady Isolde

“The ledger is closed. The knife is still sharp. Your name is next.”

— Aeler Edgewalker

“The road is a memory. Every oasis is a story, every broken wheel a lesson. The Tulkani tie knots to remember who shared what. The Fhara weigh water before they weigh silver. The Pereshi recite verses to keep the bridges open. And the Sidhi keep lighthouse lamps burning for the dead who still have not reached the shore.”

— Dusana of the Raven Road, at a caravanserai whose name she refused to give

The night air was just shy of frost, and the Three-Mugs Inn smelled of spiced ale, damp wool, and the faint promise of gossip that had been sitting on the bar for a week. The fire crackled low, casting a wavering amber glow over the handful of patrons who pretended not to be listening to each other’s stories.

A soft creak announced the door’s opening. In stepped a woman whose scarred cheek caught the firelight like a fresh-drawn blade. She brushed snow from her cloak, set her sword-hand on the hilt of a well-worn blade, and surveyed the room with the practiced eye of someone who had counted the stones of every bridge she’d crossed.

“Evening,” she said, voice low but carrying. “I’m Isolde of the Scar. Does anyone know if the road north of the Belworth still has that... unsettling gap where the stones whisper?”

A ripple of laughter rose from the corner where a lanky figure leaned back, a grin playing at the corners of his mouth. His cloak was patched with bright dyed patches, and a dagger dangled from his belt like an after-thought. He tipped an imaginary hat.

“Name’s... well, I don’t really need one, but you can call me Bravo. I’ve been tracing the canals of Silkstrand all day—turns out the ninth bridge only appears when the tide’s feeling generous. You looking for a shortcut, or just a story to trade for a mug?”

From the shadows near the hearth emerged a third figure, tall and gaunt, whose breath seemed to fog the air even as the fire licked his boots. He carried no weapon, only a small brass bell that hung from his neck, silent for now. His eyes were the color of stone-wet after a storm, and he spoke in a tone that made the crackling fire sound like a distant rumble.

“Aeler,” he said, the name barely more than a whisper. “I’ve been walking the old tunnels beneath the Aeler holds. The stone remembers every footfall, and it’s been. . . restless lately. If you’re looking for a place that won’t collapse under the weight of your expectations, I know a few shafts that still hold.”

The trio fell into an uneasy silence, each measuring the other not with suspicion but with the quiet respect of strangers who have walked too many roads to be surprised by another traveler’s tale.

Isolde glanced at the bravo’s dagger, then at the bell at the Aeler’s throat. “You both carry. . . reminders.”

Bravo chuckled, tapping the hilt of his blade. “A reminder that I still owe someone a drink.”

Aeler lifted the bell just enough for it to give a faint, reluctant chime. “And a reminder that some debts are measured in breath, not coin.”

The innkeeper, a stout woman with a flour-dusted apron, slid three mugs across the bar without a word. The ale was dark, frothy, and smelled faintly of rosemary—exactly the sort of thing that made a warrior think of home, a rogue think of a clever bargain, and a stone-walker think of the weight of a promise kept.

They clinked mugs, the sound a brief, bright note against the low hum of the tavern. No grand quest was sworn, no ancient prophecy whispered. They simply sat, drank, and let the night settle into the familiar rhythm of strangers who, for a moment, shared the same fire, the same stale bread, and the same unspoken understanding that the road ahead would be just as muddy, just as bright, and just as full of stories as the one they’d just left behind.

When the moon rose high enough to silver the snow outside, each rose, tucked their respective token—sword, dagger, bell—back into their packs, and slipped back into the night. They did not exchange names again; they did not need to. The Three-Mugs Inn would remember them only as the three who came in, shared a drink, and left without making a fuss—exactly the sort of uneventful, perfectly ordinary encounter that makes a tavern worth its name.